

German Grammar Reference Book
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299 grammar rules

9 categories

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How to Use This Book

This grammar reference is automatically generated from your DeutschOps lessons with Stefanie, enriched with web-verified rules from authoritative German grammar sources (Duden, Dartmouth, GermanVeryEasy). It updates automatically after every lesson you process.

Complete Rule	Full grammar with conjugation/declension tables
Examples	Sentences from your actual lessons + verified sources
Common Mistakes	Errors Italian speakers typically make — read carefully
Exceptions	Special cases and irregular patterns to memorize
Source verified	Rule confirmed with authoritative web sources
From lesson only	Rule extracted from transcript, not yet web-verified

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Word order in statements, W-questions, and yes/no questions (Wortstellung in Aussagen, W-Fragen und Ja/Nein-Fragen)

■ From lesson

German word order places the conjugated verb in position 2 in statements and W-questions, and in position 1 in yes/no questions. Position 1 can be occupied by different elements like the subject, an adverb, or a question word.

COMPLETE RULE

W-questions: Position 1 = W-word (Woher, Wo), Position 2 = verb (kommen, wohnst), then subject (Sie, du). Statements/Answers: Position 1 = subject (Ich), Position 2 = verb (komme, wohne), then additional information. Yes/No questions: Position 1 = verb (Kommen, Wohnst), Position 2 = subject (Sie, du), then additional information. Answers to yes/no questions start with Nein/Ja, then normal statement word order.

EXAMPLES

- *Woher kommen Sie? - Ich komme aus Marokko.*
- *Wo wohnst du? - Ich wohne in Tübingen.*
- *Kommen Sie aus Tunesien? - Nein. Ich komme aus Marokko.*
- *Wohnst du in Stuttgart? - Nein. Ich wohne in Tübingen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Putting the verb in position 1 in statements (incorrect: *Komme ich aus Marokko). Not inverting verb and subject in questions. Forgetting that the verb must always be in position 2 in statements and W-questions.

Konnektoren 'aber', 'oder', 'und'

■ From lesson

Conjunctions 'aber' (but), 'oder' (or), and 'und' (and) connect sentences or clauses. They occupy position 0, meaning the verb remains in position 2 of the second clause.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 0 (connector) + Position 1 (subject) + Position 2 (verb). The connector does not count as position 1.

EXAMPLES

- *Das ist die normale Kleinfamilie, aber sie ist heute nicht mehr die Regel.*
- *Man bekommt Kinder, aber man heiratet nicht immer.*
- *Meine Mutter ist nicht verheiratet und sie erzieht meinen Bruder und mich allein.*
- *Sie heiraten noch einmal oder sie leben ohne Trauschein.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Placing the verb in position 3 instead of position 2 after the conjunction

Wortstellung Subjekt

■ From lesson

Word order: The subject stands in position 1 or after the verb

COMPLETE RULE

Das Subjekt steht auf Position 1 oder nach dem Verb. In statements, the subject can be in first position (before verb) or in third position (after verb in second position).

EXAMPLES

- *Am Sonntag ist das Brunnenstüberl geöffnet.*
- *Das Brunnenstüberl ist am Sonntag geöffnet.*
- *Das Wetter war leider nicht so gut.*
- *Leider war das Wetter nicht so gut.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Placing the verb in wrong position when starting sentence with time or place expressions

Lokale Angaben - Wo?

■ From lesson

Local expressions answering 'Where?' use prepositions with dative case. Common verbs are stehen (to stand), sitzen (to sit), liegen (to lie), hängen (to hang). The definite article changes to dative form after the preposition.

COMPLETE RULE

Wo ist/liegt das Buch? Das Buch ist/liegt: auf/unter/an + dem Tisch (Maskulinum) | neben/in + dem Sofa (Neutrum) | vor/hinter + der Kommode (Femininum) | über/zwischen +

den Regalen (Plural). Note: dem = der+dem contraction for masculine/neuter dative.

EXAMPLES

→ *Wo ist das Buch? Das Buch ist auf dem Tisch.*

→ *Das Buch liegt neben dem Sofa.*

→ *Das Buch ist vor der Kommode.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using accusative instead of dative, forgetting article changes (der→dem, das→dem, die→der)

Imperativsätze - Regelmäßige Verben (informell Sg.)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with regular verbs in informal singular form. The imperative is formed by removing the -st ending from the du form.

COMPLETE RULE

Informal singular: du kommst → Komm! | du redest → Rede! | du wartest → Warte! | du öffnest → Öffne! | du entschuldigst → Entschuldige! | du lächelst → Lächle! | du passt auf → Pass auf!

EXAMPLES

→ *Komm!*

→ *Rede!*

→ *Warte!*

→ *Öffne!*

→ *Entschuldige!*

→ *Lächle!*

→ *Pass auf!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Don't forget to drop the -st ending from the du form

Imperativsätze - Regelmäßige Verben (informell Pl.)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with regular verbs in informal plural form. The imperative is formed by using the ihr form with exclamation mark.

COMPLETE RULE

Informal plural: ihr kommt → Kommt! | ihr redet → Redet! | ihr wartet → Wartet! |
ihr öffnet → Öffnet! | ihr entschuldigt → Entschuldigt! | ihr lächelt → Lächelt! |
ihr passt auf → Passt auf!

EXAMPLES

→ *Kommt!*

→ *Redet!*

→ *Wartet!*

→ *Öffnet!*

→ *Entschuldigt!*

→ *Lächelt!*

→ *Passt auf!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

The ihr form is used unchanged as imperative

Imperativsätze - Regelmäßige Verben (formell)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with regular verbs in formal form. The imperative uses the Sie form with inverted word order.

COMPLETE RULE

Formal: Sie kommen → Kommen Sie! | Sie reden → Reden Sie! | Sie warten → Warten Sie!
| Sie öffnen → Öffnen Sie! | Sie entschuldigen → Entschuldigen Sie! | Sie lächeln →
Lächeln Sie! | Sie passen auf → Passen Sie auf!

EXAMPLES

→ *Kommen Sie!*

→ *Reden Sie!*

→ *Warten Sie!*

→ *Öffnen Sie!*

→ *Entschuldigen Sie!*

→ *Lächeln Sie!*

→ *Passen Sie auf!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Don't forget to invert the word order and keep Sie

Imperativsätze - haben und sein (informell Pl.)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with the verbs haben and sein in informal plural form.

COMPLETE RULE

Informal plural irregular: ihr habt → **Habt keine Angst!** | ihr seid → **Seid vorsichtig!**

EXAMPLES

→ *Habt keine Angst!*

→ *Seid vorsichtig!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Remember that seid is the imperative, not seit

Imperativsätze - haben und sein (formell)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with the verbs haben and sein in formal form.

COMPLETE RULE

Formal irregular: Sie haben → **Haben Sie keine Angst!** | Sie sind → **Seien Sie vorsichtig!**

EXAMPLES

→ *Haben Sie keine Angst!*

→ *Seien Sie vorsichtig!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Note that sein uses Seien Sie, not Sind Sie

Nebensätze mit weil und dass

■ From lesson

Subordinate clauses with 'weil' (because) and 'dass' (that). In spoken German, sometimes two main clauses are connected with 'weil', e.g. 'Bernhard möchte in Köln studieren, weil ... (pause) ... er hat dort keine Sprachprobleme.' Before subordinate clauses with 'dass', there are often connecting verbs like 'glauben' (believe), 'wissen' (know), etc.

COMPLETE RULE

Hauptsatz + weil/dass + Mittelfeld + Verb am Ende. Examples: 'Bernhard möchte in Köln studieren, weil er dort keine Sprachprobleme hat.' 'Ich möchte im Ausland studieren, weil Auslandserfahrung wichtig ist.' 'Bernhard hofft, dass er im Alltag alles versteht.' 'Wir finden, dass Köln eine schöne Stadt ist.'

EXAMPLES

- *Bernhard möchte in Köln studieren, weil er dort keine Sprachprobleme hat.*
- *Ich möchte im Ausland studieren, weil Auslandserfahrung wichtig ist.*
- *Bernhard hofft, dass er im Alltag alles versteht.*
- *Wir finden, dass Köln eine schöne Stadt ist.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to put the verb at the end of subordinate clauses

Reflexivpronomen und reflexive Verben

■ From lesson

Reflexive pronouns refer to the accusative or dative complement in the sentence. Reflexive verb with accusative complement, e.g.: sich erholen → Ich hoffe, dass ich mich bald erhole. Reflexive verb with dative complement, e.g.: sich anschauen → Ich will mir alle Bilder anschauen. Reflexive pronouns have the same word order as personal pronouns, e.g.: Ich habe mir ein Buch gekauft. Ich habe es mir gekauft.

COMPLETE RULE

Reflexive pronouns Akkusativ: mich, dich, sich, uns, euch, sich. Reflexive pronouns Dativ: mir, dir, sich, uns, euch, sich. Personal pronouns Akkusativ: mich, dich, ihn/sie/es, uns, euch, sie/Sie. Personal pronouns Dativ: mir, dir, ihm/ihm/ihr, uns, euch, ihnen/Ihnen.

EXAMPLES

- *sich erholen → Ich hoffe, dass ich mich bald erhole.*
- *sich anschauen → Ich will mir alle Bilder anschauen.*

→ *Ich habe mir ein Buch gekauft.*

→ *Ich habe es mir gekauft.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing reflexive pronouns with personal pronouns, especially in the third person

Konditionale Nebensätze mit wenn

■ From lesson

Conditional clauses with 'wenn' (if). The subordinate clause can come before or after the main clause. When the subordinate clause comes first, the main clause begins with the verb.

COMPLETE RULE

Hauptsatz + Nebensatz: Main clause, wenn + subordinate clause (verb at end). |
Nebensatz + Hauptsatz: Wenn + subordinate clause (verb at end), verb + main clause.

EXAMPLES

→ *Rui bekommt Zinsen, wenn er Geld auf einem Sparkonto hat.*

→ *Wenn Rui Geld anlegen will, kann er es auf ein Sparkonto einzahlen.*

→ *Die EC-Karte kostet nichts, wenn Rui nur Online-Banking macht.*

→ *Wenn er nur Online-Banking macht, kostet die EC-Karte nichts.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to put the verb at the end of the wenn-clause. Forgetting to invert subject and verb in the main clause when the wenn-clause comes first

Temporale Nebensätze mit als

■ From lesson

Temporal subordinate clauses with 'als' (when) refer to a single point or period in the past. The subordinate clause can come before or after the main clause. When the subordinate clause comes first, the main clause begins with the verb.

COMPLETE RULE

Hauptsatz + Nebensatz: Main clause, als + subordinate clause (verb at end). |
Nebensatz + Hauptsatz: Als + subordinate clause (verb at end), verb + main clause.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ruis Portemonnaie war weg, als er an der Kasse zahlen wollte.*

→ *Als er an der Kasse zahlen wollte, war Ruis Portemonnaie weg.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'als' (single past event) with 'wenn' (repeated past events or present/future conditions).

Forgetting verb-final position in the als-clause

Nebensätze mit 'seit(dem)' und 'bis'

■ From lesson

Subordinate clauses with 'seit(dem)' (since) and 'bis' (until) describe temporal relationships. When 'seit(dem)' or 'bis' introduce a subordinate clause, the verb moves to the end of that clause.

COMPLETE RULE

Main clause + seit(dem)/bis + subordinate clause (verb at end). OR: Seit(dem)/bis + subordinate clause (verb at end) + main clause. Examples: 'Beate hat dauernd Schmerzen, seit(dem) sie an ihrer Masterarbeit arbeitet.' OR 'Seit(dem) Beate so viel arbeitet, hat sie dauernd Schmerzen.'

EXAMPLES

→ *Beate hat dauernd Schmerzen, seit(dem) sie an ihrer Masterarbeit arbeitet.*

→ *Seit(dem) Beate so viel arbeitet, hat sie dauernd Schmerzen.*

→ *Es dauert noch 2 Wochen, bis Beate zu Dr. Rosmann gehen kann.*

→ *Bis Beate zu Dr. Rosmann gehen kann, dauert es noch 2 Wochen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to move the verb to the end of the subordinate clause

Gründe formulieren: Kausale Verbindungsadverbien 'darum', 'deshalb', 'deswegen', 'daher'

■ From lesson

Causal connective adverbs 'darum', 'deshalb', 'deswegen', and 'daher' all mean 'therefore/that's why' and are used to express reasons or consequences. They connect two main clauses and can be used interchangeably. After these adverbs, the verb comes immediately (Position 2).

COMPLETE RULE

Main clause with 'weil' subordinate clause can be transformed into two main clauses connected by 'darum/deshalb/deswegen/daher'. Structure: Sentence 1 (reason). + darum/deshalb/deswegen/daher + VERB + subject + rest of sentence.

EXAMPLES

→ *Weil ich Sport machen soll, gehe ich jeden zweiten Tag walken.* → *Ich soll Sport machen, darum/deshalb/deswegen gehe ich jeden zweiten Tag walken.*

→ *Ich habe Urlaub genommen, weil ich mich ausruhen soll.* → *Ich soll mich ausruhen, darum/deshalb/deswegen habe ich Urlaub genommen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting that the verb must come in position 2 after these adverbs (inverted word order)

Orts- und Zeitangaben im Satz (Place and time expressions in sentences)

■ From lesson

Position of place and time expressions in German sentences. Position 1 can be subject or other elements. Position 2 is the conjugated verb. Mittelfeld (middle field) contains most information. Time expressions usually come before place expressions in the Mittelfeld.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 1: Subject or other sentence element | Position 2: Conjugated verb | Mittelfeld: Time and place expressions (time usually before place) | Satzende: Sentence ending (past participle, separable prefix, etc.). Note: Im Mittelfeld stehen Zeitangaben meistens vor Ortsangaben.

EXAMPLES

→ *Jörg ist diese Woche schon fünfmal im Kino gewesen.*

→ *Jörg und Michael sind nach dem Frühstück sofort ins Museum gegangen.*

→ *Sie waren fast zwei Stunden im Museum.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Students often place time and place expressions in the wrong order or position.

Infinitivsätze

■ From lesson

Infinitive clauses are formed with 'zu' + infinitive. Both parts stand at the end of the sentence.

COMPLETE RULE

Infinitive clauses are formed with 'zu' + infinitive. Both parts stand at the end of the sentence. Example: *Irina hätte Lust, das Hafenfest zu besuchen.* Infinitive clauses often follow expressions like 'Lust haben', 'vorhaben', 'es gut/schlecht ... finden', 'es lieben', 'es ist ... + adjective'. With verbs with separable prefix, 'zu' goes between prefix and verb stem. In passive sentences, 'zu' goes between past participle and 'werden'.

EXAMPLES

- *Irina hätte Lust, das Hafenfest zu besuchen.*
- *Eleni findet es gut, ins Theater zu gehen.*
- *Irinas Bruder hat vor, ins Musical zu gehen.*
- *Antonia liebt es, auf einem Schiff mitzufahren.*
- *Es ist am schlimmsten, angerempelt zu werden.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to place 'zu' between the prefix and verb stem in separable verbs

Indefinitpronomen und -adverbien mit 'irgend-'

■ From lesson

Indefinite pronouns and adverbs with 'irgend-' emphasize that something is indefinite/uncertain. 'irgend-' can come before question words (wann → irgendwann, wie → irgendwie, wo → irgendwo), before indefinite article words (ein → irgendeiner), or before indefinite pronouns (jemand → irgendjemand, wer/wen/wem → irgendwer/irgendwen/irgendwem, etwas → irgendetwas, colloquially: was → irgendwas)

COMPLETE RULE

irgend- strengthens the meaning of: something is indefinite. *irgend-* can stand before question words: e.g. wann → irgendwann, wie → irgendwie, wo → irgendwo. *irgend-* can stand before indefinite article words: ein → irgendein. *irgend-* can stand before indefinite pronouns, e.g. jemand → irgendjemand, wer/wen/wem → irgendwer/irgendwen/irgendwem, etwas → irgendetwas (colloquially: was → irgendwas)

EXAMPLES

- *wann → irgendwann*
- *wie → irgendwie*
- *wo → irgendwo*
- *ein → irgendein*
- *jemand → irgendjemand*
- *wer/wen/wem → irgendwer/irgendwen/irgendwem*

→ etwas → irgendetwas

→ was → irgendwas

n-Wörter

■ From lesson

Some adverbs can be combined with 'n-': nirgendwo = nirgends, nirgendwohin, nirgendwoher

COMPLETE RULE

Einige Adverbien kann man mit 'n-' verneinen: nirgendwo = nirgends, nirgendwohin, nirgendwoher

EXAMPLES

→ nirgendwo = nirgends

→ nirgendwohin

→ nirgendwoher

Kausale Verbindungen: Präposition 'wegen' + Genitiv

■ From lesson

The preposition 'wegen' (because of) takes the genitive case and is used to state reasons

COMPLETE RULE

Präposition 'wegen' + Genitiv: Wegen der Kombination aus Theorie und Praxis wäre ein Studium an einer FH sicher interessant.

EXAMPLES

→ *Wegen der Kombination aus Theorie und Praxis wäre ein Studium an einer FH sicher interessant.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

In colloquial speech, 'wegen' is also used with dative

Kausale Verbindungen: Verbindungsadverb 'nämlich'

■ From lesson

The connecting adverb 'nämlich' (namely, because) is used to give reasons and appears in the middle field of the sentence

COMPLETE RULE

Verbindungsadverb 'nämlich': *Ich muss ein Auslandssemester machen. Ich habe nämlich vor, später für eine internationale Organisation zu arbeiten.*

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich muss ein Auslandssemester machen. Ich habe nämlich vor, später für eine internationale Organisation zu arbeiten.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Learners may place 'nämlich' at the beginning of the sentence instead of in the middle field

Nebensatz: damit

■ From lesson

The subordinate conjunction 'damit' (so that/in order that) introduces a purpose clause. It is used when the subject of the main clause and subordinate clause are different. The verb in the subordinate clause goes to the end.

COMPLETE RULE

damit + subject + ... + verb at end. Used when subjects differ between clauses. Otherwise use um ... zu + infinitive.

EXAMPLES

→ *Man sollte sich zuerst schriftlich bei den Landwirten melden, damit diese ihre zukünftigen Helfer vorher kennen lernen.*

→ *Damit die Landwirte ihre zukünftigen Helfer vorher kennen lernen, sollte man sich zuerst schriftlich bei diesen melden.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using 'damit' when subjects are the same (should use 'um ... zu' instead)

Nebensatz: um ... zu + Infinitiv

■ From lesson

The construction 'um ... zu + infinitive' (in order to) is used to express purpose when the subject is the same in both the main and subordinate clause. Most commonly used.

COMPLETE RULE

um + ... + zu + infinitive. Subject must be the same in both clauses.

EXAMPLES

→ *Man arbeitet als WWOOFer, um praktische Erfahrung im Bio-Landbau zu sammeln.*

→ *Um praktische Erfahrung im Bio-Landbau zu sammeln, arbeitet man als WWOOFer.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using 'um...zu' when subjects are different (should use 'damit' instead)

Kausale Konnektoren - Causal connectors (weil, da, denn, daher/darum/deshalb/deswegen)

■ From lesson

Causal connectors introduce reasons: weil and da introduce subordinate clauses (reason in secondary clause). denn introduces main clauses (Hauptsatz, reason is in Position 0). daher/darum/deshalb/deswegen introduce reasons in main clauses (reason stated before, position before or after verb).

COMPLETE RULE

weil, da = because (subordinate clause connector, verb at end). denn = because (main clause connector, verb in Position 2, reason in Position 0 Hauptsatz). daher/darum/deshalb/deswegen = therefore, that's why (reason stated in main clause before, can be Position 0 or after verb).

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Confusing verb position with weil (verb at end) vs. denn (verb Position 2). Using denn instead of daher/darum/deshalb/deswegen when referring to previously stated reason.

Verhältnisse ausdrücken - je ... desto / umso

■ From lesson

The construction 'je ... desto/umso' expresses proportional relationships (the more ... the more). The first clause (Nebensatz) starts with 'je' and has the verb at the end. The second clause (Hauptsatz) starts with 'desto' or 'umso' in Position 1, followed by the verb in Position 2.

COMPLETE RULE

1. Satz (Nebensatz): Position 1 = je + comparative, Satzende = verb. 2. Satz (Hauptsatz): Position 1 = desto/umso + comparative, Position 2 = verb, then rest of sentence.

EXAMPLES

→ *Je weiter oben eine Person steht, desto besser sind ihre Chancen.*

→ *Je mehr Stimmen ein Partei erhält, umso mehr Sitze bekommt sie.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to put the verb at the end in the je-clause, or not putting the verb in Position 2 in the desto/umso-clause

'Lassen' constructions (having something done)

■ Web verified

The verb 'lassen' means 'to let/allow' but commonly expresses causative meaning 'to have something done by someone else' (similar to Italian 'farsi fare qualcosa'): 'Ich lasse mir die Haare schneiden' (I have my hair cut). Structure: lassen (conjugated) + reflexive pronoun (when action affects oneself) + object + infinitive. Used when you don't do something yourself but have it done by another person.

COMPLETE RULE

CONJUGATION (Present Tense - Irregular/Strong Verb):

ich lasse / du lässt / er-sie-es lässt / wir lassen / ihr lasst / sie lassen

PRINCIPLE PAST: *ließ*

PAST PARTICIPLE: *gelassen* (normal) OR *lassen* (with infinitive - double infinitive construction)

AUXILIARY VERB: *haben*

CAUSATIVE CONSTRUCTION (having sth done TO oneself):

Subject + *lassen* (conjugated) + REFLEXIVE PRONOUN (*mir/dir/sich/uns/euch/sich*) + object (accusative) + INFINITIVE

Example: 'Ich lasse mir die Haare schneiden'

CAUSATIVE CONSTRUCTION (having sth done to object/thing):

Subject + *lassen* (conjugated) + object (accusative) + INFINITIVE

Example: 'Ich lasse mein Auto reparieren'

PERFEKT TENSE (double infinitive):

Subject + *haben* (conjugated) + object + INFINITIVE + *lassen* (infinitive)

Example: 'Ich habe mir die Haare schneiden lassen'

KEY DISTINCTION:

- WITH reflexive pronoun (*mir/sich*): action affects the person

'Er lässt sich die Haare schneiden' (He has his hair cut)

- WITHOUT reflexive: action affects a thing

'Er lässt sein Auto reparieren' (He has his car repaired)

EXAMPLES

→ Ich lasse mir die Haare schneiden. (I'm having my hair cut / I get my hair cut)

→ Ich lasse mein Motorrad reparieren. (I'm having my motorcycle repaired)

→ Hast du ein Dach bauen lassen? (Did you have a roof built?)

→ Sie lässt sich operieren. (She is having surgery / She's getting an operation)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: (1) OMITTING REFLEXIVE PRONOUN: Saying 'Ich lasse die Haare schneiden' instead of 'Ich lasse mir die Haare schneiden' - forgetting that in German the reflexive pronoun (mir/dir/sich) is required when the action affects oneself, unlike Italian 'mi faccio tagliare i capelli' where 'mi' is more flexible. (2) WRONG WORD ORDER: Placing infinitive before object. (3) PERFEKT CONSTRUCTION: Using past participle 'gelassen' instead of infinitive 'lassen' in double infinitive construction. (4) ARTICLE USAGE: Using 'meine Haare' instead of 'die Haare' - German uses definite article with body parts.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The verb 'lassen' has multiple meanings beyond causative: (1) 'to leave/let be': 'Lass mich in Ruhe' (Leave me alone), (2) 'to allow': 'Lass uns gehen' (Let us go), (3) reflexive passive substitute 'sich lassen' means 'can be done': 'Das lässt sich leicht erklären' (That can be easily explained). In Perfekt without accompanying infinitive, use 'gelassen': 'Ich habe mein Auto in der Garage gelassen' (I left my car in the garage).

Asking Questions - W-Fragen

■ From lesson

Question words (W-words) begin information questions, followed by verb in second position

COMPLETE RULE

Common question words: wer (who), was (what), wo (where), wohin (where to), woher (where from), wann (when), wie (how), warum (why), welche (which). Verb comes directly after question word

EXAMPLES

→ Wie heißt du?

→ Wo wohnst du?

→ Woher kommst du?

→ Was machst du?

→ *Wann arbeitest du?*

→ *Warum lernst du Deutsch?*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using wrong question word or incorrect word order

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

None

beim + noun (contraction)

■ Web verified

'Beim' (bei + dem) is used with nominalized verbs to express 'while doing X' or 'during X'. German nominalizes infinitives by capitalizing them and treating them as neuter nouns. This construction replaces a full 'während' clause with a more concise prepositional phrase. Always takes dative case.

COMPLETE RULE

STRUCTURE: beim + nominalized infinitive

NOMINALIZATION OF VERBS:

1. Take infinitive: *kochen*
2. Capitalize it: *Kochen*
3. It becomes neuter noun: *das Kochen*
4. Use with 'beim' (bei + dem): *beim Kochen*

CONTRACTION RULES:

bei + dem = beim (mandatory contraction with definite article)

MEANING: 'while/during doing X', 'in the process of X'

RELATIONSHIP TO OTHER FORMS:

- Most concise: *'Beim Kochen höre ich Musik'*
- More formal: *'Während ich koche, höre ich Musik'*
- With reference: *'Ich koche. Dabei höre ich Musik'*

COMMON NOMINALIZED VERBS:

- *das Kochen* (cooking)
- *das Sprechen* (speaking)
- *das Essen* (eating)
- *das Lesen* (reading)

- das Schreiben (writing)
- das Verlassen (leaving): 'Beim Verlassen des Bahnhofs...'

AFTER THESE PREPOSITIONS: *beim, zum, vor dem, nach dem, für das, mit dem*

EXAMPLES

- *Beim Kochen höre ich immer Musik. (While cooking, I always listen to music.)*
- *Beim Sprechen hat er gelacht. (While speaking, he laughed.)*
- *Beim Verlassen des Bahnhofs sah ich einen Mann. (While leaving the station, I saw a man.)*
- *Beim Essen sollte man nicht reden. (One shouldn't talk while eating.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' MISTAKES:

- 1. Not capitalizing the nominalized verb: ■ 'beim kochen' → ■ 'beim Kochen'
- 2. Using wrong article/case: ■ 'bei das Kochen' → ■ 'beim Kochen' (dative)
- 3. Trying to conjugate the nominalized verb: ■ 'beim koche' → ■ 'beim Kochen' (infinitive form only)
- 4. Confusing with gerund usage (Italian 'sto cucinando'):** German uses present tense for continuous action, nicht nominalized form
- 5. Forgetting that nominalized infinitives are NEUTER:** always 'das Kochen' not *die/der Kochen
 - 6. Using 'beim' with non-action nouns: ■ 'beim Haus' → ■ 'bei dem Haus' (beim only for nominalized VERBS or established noun phrases)
- 7. Not understanding it replaces 'während' clause:** 'Beim Kochen...' = 'Während ich koche...'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

NOT ALL NOUNS: 'Beim' contraction is primarily used with nominalized verbs (action nouns). For regular nouns, use 'bei dem' if article is needed:

- ✓ 'beim Kochen' (nominalized verb)
- 'bei dem Haus' NOT 'beim Haus' (regular noun)
- BUT 'beim Frühstück' (established noun phrase for meal)

ESTABLISHED PHRASES: Some non-verbal nouns use 'beim':

- beim Frühstück (at breakfast)
- beim Mittagessen (at lunch)
- beim Abendessen (at dinner)

These are established time expressions.

WITH OBJECTS: Nominalized verbs can take genitive objects: 'beim Verlassen des Bahnhofs' (while leaving the station)

NO PLURAL: Nominalized infinitives have no plural form: always 'das Kochen' never *'die Kochen'

Comparative Adverbs and Negation

■ Web verified

For expressing 'less often' or 'less + adjective', German uses 'nicht so + adjective/adverb' rather than a comparative form with weniger. The comparative of oft is öfter, and the superlative is am häufigsten (preferred) or am öftesten (grammatically correct but less common). When comparing quantities with numbers and groups, no declination is used on the number itself.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPARISON PATTERNS:

1. **EQUALITY** (as...as): so + ADJECTIVE/ADVERB + wie

Die Maus ist so groß wie die Ratte. (The mouse is as big as the rat.)

Er läuft so schnell wie ich. (He runs as fast as I do.)

2. **INEQUALITY** (less...than): nicht so + ADJECTIVE/ADVERB + wie (NOT weniger!)

Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe. (The mouse is not as big as the giraffe.)

Er ruft nicht so oft an wie früher. (He doesn't call as often as before.)

WRONG: *Er ruft weniger oft an. ✗*

RIGHT: *Er ruft nicht so oft an. ✓*

3. **COMPARATIVE** (more...than): ADJECTIVE/ADVERB + -er + als

Die Giraffe ist größer als die Maus. (The giraffe is bigger than the mouse.)

Er läuft schneller als ich. (He runs faster than I do.)

COMPARATIVE OF OFT (often):

Positive: oft

Comparative: öfter (preferred) or häufiger (more formal/literary)

Superlative: am häufigsten (preferred, sounds natural) or am öftesten (correct but awkward)

Example: *Ich gehe öfter ins Kino als früher. (I go to the cinema more often than before.)*

Example: *Sie besucht ihre Großeltern am häufigsten. (She visits her grandparents most often.)*

WENIG vs WENIGER:

wenig = little, few (quantity)

weniger = less, fewer (comparative of wenig)

am wenigsten = least (superlative)

Weniger is ONLY used for quantities, NOT for comparisons of degree:

- *Ich habe weniger Geld als du. ✓ (quantity - I have less money than you)*

- *Die Maus ist weniger groß als die Giraffe. ✗ WRONG*

- *Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe. ✓ CORRECT*

NUMBERS WITH GROUPS (no declination on numbers):

zwei von ihnen (two of them) - NOT zweien

drei von allen (three of all) - NOT dreien

vier von uns (four of us) - NOT vieren

But: einer von ihnen (one of them) - einer IS declined

keiner von allen (none of all) - keiner IS declined

GROSS vs HOCH for height:

- For people/animals: groß (tall, big)

Der Mann ist groß. (The man is tall.)

- For buildings/objects: hoch (high)

Das Gebäude ist hoch. (The building is high.)

- Comparative: größer (taller), höher (higher)

- Superlative: am größten, am höchsten

EXAMPLES

→ **Er ruft nicht so oft an wie früher, aber er schreibt öfter E-Mails.** (He doesn't call as often as before, but he writes emails more often)

using nicht so + oft for less, öfter for more)

→ **Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe, aber sie ist schneller.** (The mouse is not as big as the giraffe, but it is faster - comparison using nicht so...wie)

→ **Drei von ihnen sind sehr groß, aber keiner von allen hat eine Brille.** (Three of them are very tall, but none of all has glasses - no declination on drei)

→ **Sie besucht ihre Großeltern am häufigsten von allen Enkelkindern.** (She visits her grandparents most often of all grandchildren)

superlative am häufigsten preferred over am öftesten)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers say 'weniger oft' (influenced by Italian 'meno spesso') instead of 'nicht so oft'. They use weniger for qualitative comparisons: 'Das Auto ist weniger schnell' instead of 'Das Auto ist nicht so schnell'. They may use 'wie' for inequality: 'nicht so groß wie' is correct, but they might forget 'nicht so' and just say 'kleiner als' (smaller than) which changes the meaning. Italian speakers might decline numbers with von: 'zweien von ihnen' instead of 'zwei von ihnen'. They confuse groß and hoch for height, using 'hoch' for people ('Der Mann ist hoch' instead of 'Der Mann ist groß').

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Wenig/weniger/am wenigsten DOES use weniger as comparative, but only for quantities: 'Ich habe weniger Zeit' (I have less time). For qualitative comparisons, always use 'nicht so...wie'. The adverb oft has two acceptable comparative forms (öfter/häufiger), but häufiger is more formal/written, öfter more colloquial. The superlative am öftesten exists but sounds unnatural; am häufigsten is strongly preferred. With mehr (more), you CAN say 'mehr oft' but it's redundant - just use öfter. Cardinal numbers zwei, drei, vier, etc. never decline with von, but einer/keiner/welche do decline. Groß is used for people's height even though Italian uses 'alto' (high/tall) - this is a false friend.

Conditional subordinate clauses with ob

■ Web verified

The subordinating conjunction 'ob' means 'if/whether' and introduces indirect questions or expresses doubt/uncertainty. In subordinate clauses with 'ob', the conjugated verb must move to the end of the clause. A comma separates the main clause from the subordinate clause.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: Main clause + comma + ob + subject + other elements + conjugated verb

Word order in subordinate clause with 'ob':

1. Conjunction 'ob' comes first
2. Subject follows
3. Middle field elements (objects, adverbs, etc.)
4. Verb goes to the end

Usage contexts:

- Indirect yes/no questions: *Er fragt, ob du kommst.*
- Expressing doubt/uncertainty: *Ich weiß nicht, ob es regnet.*
- Conditional requests: *Ich frage mich, ob du mir helfen könntest.*

Note: 'ob' differs from 'wenn' (if in conditional sentences). Use 'ob' for whether/doubt, 'wenn' for conditions/when.

EXAMPLES

- *Er könnte ihn fragen, ob er einen besseren Preis machen könnte.* (He could ask him if/whether he could make a better price.)
- *Ich frage, ob du Zeit hast.* (I'm asking whether you have time.)
- *Er wollte wissen, ob es morgen regnet.* (He wanted to know if/whether it will rain tomorrow.)
- *Kannst du mir sagen, ob der Zug pünktlich ist?* (Can you tell me whether the train is on time?)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often struggle with verb-final word order in subordinate clauses because Italian subordinate clauses maintain the same SVO (Subject-Verb-Object) order as main clauses. Common errors include:

- 1. Placing the verb in second position instead of clause-final: **Ich frage, ob du hast Zeit* instead of *Ich frage, ob du Zeit hast*
- 2. Confusing 'ob' with 'se' in Italian - while 'se' means both 'if' (condition) and 'if/whether' (doubt), German separates these: 'wenn' for conditions, 'ob' for doubt
- 3. Forgetting the comma before 'ob'
 - 4. Using 'wenn' instead of 'ob' for indirect questions: **Er fragt, wenn ich komme* instead of *Er fragt, ob ich komme*

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In V1-conditionals (verb-first conditionals), 'ob' can be omitted and the finite verb moves to first position: 'Ist er nicht bereit zu kommen, bedauern wir es.' (If he's not willing to come, we regret it.) This is more formal. With 'falls' (in case), the structure is similar but emphasizes possibility rather than doubt.

Coordinating conjunctions without inversion (denn, und, aber, oder)

■ From lesson

These conjunctions connect two main clauses without changing word order. The verb stays in second position in both clauses

COMPLETE RULE

denn (because), und (and), aber (but), oder (or) - no inversion after these conjunctions

EXAMPLES

- *Ich muss die Bank anrufen, denn ich brauche eine Information*
- *Ich habe keine Zeit, denn ich muss früh aufstehen und Yoga machen*
- *Ich tanze gern Salsa, aber ich tanze lieber Bachata*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'denn' with 'weil' which requires verb-final position

dabei (adverb/conjunction)

■ Web verified

'Dabei' is a pronominal adverb (da + bei) meaning 'in doing so', 'meanwhile', 'at the same time', 'thereby', or 'in the process'. It refers back to an action or situation already mentioned. As a Konjunkionaladverb, it connects sentences while occupying position 1 or 3, causing the subject to move.

COMPLETE RULE

STRUCTURE: da- (pronominal element 'at that/it') + bei (preposition 'at/with/during')

FUNCTIONS:

1. *Pronominal adverb replacing 'bei + noun': 'beim Kochen' → 'dabei'*
- *'Er hat mir beim Kochen zugesehen' → 'Er hat mir dabei zugesehen' (He watched me cooking/doing that)*

2. Konjunkionaladverb (sentence connector):

- Position 1: 'Ich koche gerne. Dabei höre ich Musik.' (I like to cook. Meanwhile/While doing so, I listen to music)
- Position 3: 'Ich koche gerne. Ich höre dabei Musik.' (I like to cook. I listen to music meanwhile)

3. Can introduce subordinate clauses:

- 'Ich helfe ihm dabei, den Speicher aufzuräumen' (I'm helping him clean up the attic)

WORD ORDER: When 'dabei' is in position 1, verb takes position 2, subject position 3 (inversion).

EXAMPLES

- Ich koche gerne. Dabei höre ich Musik. (I like to cook. Meanwhile/While doing so, I listen to music.)
- Meine Tochter hat geheiratet, und dabei hat er gelacht. (My daughter got married, and during that/meanwhile he laughed.)
- Ich helfe dir dabei, die Wohnung zu putzen. (I'll help you clean the apartment.)
- Er liest ein Buch. Dabei trinkt er Tee. (He's reading a book. Meanwhile/While doing so, he drinks tea.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' MISTAKES:

1. Translating literally from Italian 'intanto' without understanding the pronominal reference - dabei MUST refer to something already mentioned

- 2. Using 'dabei' without establishing what action it refers to: ■ 'Dabei höre ich Musik' (with no prior context) → ■ 'Ich koche. Dabei höre ich Musik'

3. Confusing with 'da' (there/because) - 'dabei' is specifically 'at/with that action'

- 4. Using for people instead of actions: ■ 'bei ihm' → 'dabei' (dabei refers to actions/things, not people)

5. Incorrect word order: forgetting inversion when dabei starts the sentence

6. Mixing up with 'daneben' (next to that), 'danach' (after that), 'davor' (before that)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

COLLOQUIAL MEANING: 'Dabei' can also mean 'although/yet' in spoken German: 'Ich bin müde, dabei habe ich viel geschlafen' (I'm tired, although I slept a lot).

NOT FOR PEOPLE: Cannot replace 'bei + person'. Use the full prepositional phrase: 'bei meiner Mutter' ≠ 'dabei'.

DA-COMPOUND RESTRICTIONS: Only works with prepositions that can form da-compounds. Primary prepositions like 'bei, mit, für' work; secondary prepositions like 'während, wegen' form separate words (währenddessen, deswegen).

Dative verb 'gehören' (to belong to)

The verb 'gehören' means 'to belong to' and requires dative case: 'Die Tasche gehört mir' (The bag belongs to me). The possessed item is the nominative subject, the owner is in dative. Word order can be inverted for emphasis: 'Mir gehört die Tasche' (To me belongs the bag = The bag is mine). Can also use with preposition 'zu' + dative to mean 'to be part of'.

COMPLETE RULE

CONJUGATION (Present Tense - Regular Verb):

ich gehöre / du gehörst / er-sie-es gehört / wir gehören / ihr gehört / sie gehören

PRINCIPLE PAST: gehörte

PAST PARTICIPLE: gehört (with 'haben')

AUXILIARY VERB: haben

STRUCTURE 1 (possession): [Item - NOMINATIVE] + gehört/gehören + [Owner - DATIVE]

Example: 'Das Buch gehört mir'

STRUCTURE 2 (with 'zu' - membership/belonging to group): gehören + zu + [Group/Category - DATIVE]

Example: 'Er gehört zu unserer Familie'

EMPHATIC WORD ORDER: [Owner - DATIVE] + gehört/gehören + [Item - NOMINATIVE]

Example: 'Mir gehört das ganze Erbe'

EXAMPLES

→ *Die Tasche gehört mir. (The bag belongs to me / The bag is mine)*

→ *Mir gehört die Tasche. (To me belongs the bag - emphatic: The bag is MINE)*

→ *Das Schiff gehört nicht mir. (The ship doesn't belong to me / The ship is not mine)*

→ *Das gehört mir. (That belongs to me / That's mine)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: (1) **REVERSED ROLES**: Saying 'Ich gehöre das Auto' (I belong to the car) instead of 'Das Auto gehört mir' (The car belongs to me) - confusing who owns what. (2) **USING ACCUSATIVE**: 'Das Haus gehört mich' instead of 'Das Haus gehört mir'. (3) **CONFUSION WITH 'ZU GEHÖREN'**: Not distinguishing between 'gehören' (belong to/ownership) and 'gehören zu' (be part of/member of). Italian 'appartenere a' works differently structurally.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When used with 'zu' + dative, 'gehören' means 'to be part of/belong to a group': 'Er gehört zu dieser Familie' (He belongs to this family). In the meaning 'to belong somewhere/be in the right place', it takes preposition 'in' + accusative: 'Die Schuhe gehören in den Schuhschrank' (The shoes belong in the shoe closet). With 'sich gehören', it means 'to be proper/appropriate': 'Das gehört sich nicht' (That's not proper).

Dative verb 'schmecken' (to taste good)

■ Web verified

The verb 'schmecken' (to taste) is used exclusively for food and drinks with dative case structure: 'Die Pizza schmeckt mir' (The pizza tastes good to me). The food/drink is the nominative subject, the person experiencing the taste is in dative. The word 'gut' is optional - 'schmeckt mir' alone already means 'tastes good to me', while 'schmeckt mir nicht' means 'doesn't taste good to me'.

COMPLETE RULE

CONJUGATION (Present Tense - Regular Verb):

ich schmecke / du schmeckst / er-sie-es schmeckt / wir schmecken / ihr schmeckt / sie schmecken

PRINCIPLE PAST: *schmeckte*

PAST PARTICIPLE: *geschmeckt* (with 'haben')

AUXILIARY VERB: *haben*

STRUCTURE: [Food/Drink - NOMINATIVE] + *schmeckt/schmecken* + [Person - DATIVE] + (optional: *gut/nicht/schlecht*)

DATIVE PRONOUNS: *mir, dir, ihm, ihr, uns, euch, ihnen, Ihnen*

VERB AGREEMENT: *Agrees with the food/drink (nominative subject)*

Singular: *'Der Kaffee schmeckt mir'*

Plural: *'Die Äpfel schmecken mir'*

EXAMPLES

→ *Das Eis schmeckt mir sehr gut.* (The ice cream tastes very good to me / I really like the ice cream)

→ *Die Äpfel schmecken dem Mann.* (The apples taste good to the man / The man likes the apples)

→ *Der Kaffee schmeckt mir nicht.* (The coffee doesn't taste good to me / I don't like the coffee)

→ *Pizza schmeckt ihr nicht.* (She doesn't like the taste of pizza / Pizza doesn't taste good to her)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers make the same reversal error as with 'gefallen': (1) INCORRECT SUBJECT: Saying 'Ich schmecke die Schokolade' (I am tasty to the chocolate) instead of 'Die Schokolade schmeckt mir' (The chocolate tastes good to me). This happens because Italian 'mi piace' construction differs structurally. (2) USING ACCUSATIVE: Saying 'Das Eis schmeckt mich' instead of 'Das Eis schmeckt mir'. (3) WRONG USAGE: Using 'schmecken' for non-food items - it's exclusively for food and beverages.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In figurative/metaphorical usage, 'schmecken' can sometimes mean 'to detect/notice a taste': 'Ich schmecke Knoblauch darin' (I taste/detect garlic in it) - here it takes accusative. However, in standard usage meaning 'to like the taste', it always takes dative. The verb can also be used transitively in

culinary contexts: 'mit Salz schmecken' (to season with salt).

Deshalb and deswegen as causal connectors

■ Web verified

Deshalb and deswegen both mean 'that's why' or 'therefore' and introduce a consequence or result. They are conjunctive adverbs (Konjunkionaladverbien) that start a new main clause and require inversion, with the verb immediately following them in position 2. They must be preceded by a period or semicolon, never a comma.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: [Reason Clause]. Deshalb/Deswegen + [VERB] + [Subject] + [Rest]

Synonyms (interchangeable):

- deshalb (most common, neutral)
- deswegen (equally common, neutral)
- daher (slightly more formal)
- darum (more colloquial)
- folglich (formal, written language)

Word Order Rules:

1. Occupies Position 1 in the sentence
2. Verb must come in Position 2 (immediately after)
3. Subject follows verb (inversion)
4. Cannot be preceded by a comma - requires period or semicolon

Alternative constructions:

- weil + subordinate clause (verb at end): Ich bleibe zu Hause, weil ich krank bin
- denn + main clause (no inversion): Ich bleibe zu Hause, denn ich bin krank

EXAMPLES

→ Ich bin krank. Deshalb bleibe ich zu Hause. (I'm sick. Therefore I'm staying home.)

→ Die Kirche ist 500 Meter entfernt. Deswegen höre ich den Lärm nicht. (The church is 500 meters away. That's why I don't hear the noise.)

→ Sie möchte in Berlin arbeiten. Daher lernt sie Deutsch. (She wants to work in Berlin. That's why she's learning German.)

→ Wir haben keine Zeit. Darum können wir nicht kommen. (We have no time. That's why we can't come.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

- 1. Using a comma before *deshalb/deswegen* instead of a period (influenced by Italian conjunctions)
2. Forgetting inversion - placing subject before verb
3. Confusing *deshalb* with 'weil' and mixing up word order
4. Placing *deshalb* in the middle of a sentence without proper structure
5. Not recognizing that *deshalb* introduces the RESULT, not the cause (opposite structure from subordinating conjunctions)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. Alternative position: Can be placed in middle of sentence but loses position 1 emphasis: 'Ich bin krank, ich bleibe *deshalb* zu Hause' (less common)
2. With also: 'Also' can mean 'therefore' but is more flexible and doesn't always signal pure cause-effect
3. Formal alternatives: 'folglich', 'demnach', 'infolgedessen' follow same rules but are formal/written
4. Spoken German: Sometimes native speakers use comma + *deshalb* informally, but this is grammatically incorrect

Directional particles: *hin* (away from speaker) vs. *her* (toward speaker)

■ Web verified

The particles '*hin*' (away from speaker) and '*her*' (toward speaker) combine with prepositions and verbs to show direction relative to the speaker's position. '*hinauf*' = up there (away from speaker), '*herauf*' = up here (toward speaker). '*hinein/herein*' = in there/in here.

COMPLETE RULE

Hin indicates movement away from the speaker's position toward a destination; *her* indicates movement from a point of origin toward the speaker. These combine with directional adverbs: *hinauf/herauf* (up), *hinunter/herunter* (down), *hinein/herein* (in), *hinaus/heraus* (out), *hinüber/herüber* (over/across). Full combinations with verbs: *hingehen* (to go there), *herkommen* (to come here), *hinaufgehen* (to go up there), *heraufkommen* (to come up here), *hineingehen* (to go in there), *hereinkommen* (to come in here). In spoken German, *hin/her* can be split from the verb: 'Wo gehst du *hin*?' instead of 'Wohin gehst du?'

EXAMPLES

- *Geh hinein!* (Go in there - away from speaker, e.g., speaker is outside telling child to go inside)
- *Komm herein!* (Come in here - toward speaker, e.g., speaker is inside inviting someone in)
- *Ich klettere nicht hinauf.* (I don't climb up there
movement away from speaker's current position)
- *Komm herauf!* (Come up here - movement toward speaker who is at higher position)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may confuse hin/her because Italian doesn't have this speaker-perspective distinction for directional movement. Common error: Using 'herauf' when describing someone else going up away from you (should be 'hinauf'). Error example: '*Komm hinauf!' when you're upstairs calling someone (should be 'Komm herauf!' because movement is toward you). Another mistake: Omitting hin/her entirely when required: '*Komm!' instead of 'Komm her!' Italian speakers accustomed to 'vieni qui' may not realize 'her' is needed.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In colloquial German, especially in southern regions, the distinction is often ignored and shortened forms are used: 'rein' (in), 'raus' (out), 'rauf' (up), 'runter' (down), 'rüber' (over). These forms don't indicate hin/her direction clearly. Example: 'Komm rein!' is acceptable for 'Komm herein!' in spoken German.

Embedded relative clauses can be moved to end

■ Web verified

Relative clauses in German can appear immediately after the noun they modify (embedded mid-sentence) or moved to the end of the main clause for clarity and smoother flow. The placement affects sentence rhythm but not meaning. Relative clauses are always separated by commas, and the verb in the relative clause always goes to the end.

COMPLETE RULE

Relative Clause Position:

EMBEDDED (mid-sentence): Insert relative clause immediately after the noun it modifies.

Example: Der Mann, der dort steht, ist mein Onkel.

(The man, who stands there, is my uncle.)

END POSITION: Move relative clause to sentence end when main clause is interrupted.

Example: Ich habe jemanden getroffen, den ich kenne.

(I met someone whom I know.)

Both: 'Ich habe jemanden, den ich kenne, getroffen' AND 'Ich habe jemanden getroffen, den ich kenne' are grammatically correct.

Rules:

- Relative clause must follow the noun it modifies (cannot precede it)
- Always use commas to separate relative clauses
- Verb in relative clause goes to END (subordinate clause word order)
- Relative pronoun agrees in gender/number with antecedent, but case depends on function within relative clause

EXAMPLES

- *Jeder, der Fußball gerne schaut, spielt auch gerne Fußball. (Everyone who likes watching soccer also likes playing soccer.)*
- *Ich habe jemanden getroffen, den ich kenne. (I met someone whom I know.)*
- *Das Buch, das ich lese, ist sehr interessant. (The book that I am reading is very interesting.)*
- *Der Junge, den ich gestern getroffen habe, spielt Fußball. (The boy whom I met yesterday plays soccer.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may struggle with German relative clause positioning because Italian relative clauses (with 'che', 'cui') typically appear immediately after the antecedent and are less flexible in placement. They might create awkward embedded structures when end-position would be clearer. Italian speakers frequently forget to move the verb to the end of the relative clause, maintaining SVO order as in Italian: saying 'der Mann, der ist groß' instead of 'der Mann, der groß ist'. They may omit commas around relative clauses since Italian punctuation rules differ. Italian allows omitting relative pronouns in some contexts, but German never does.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The relative pronoun can NEVER be omitted in German (unlike English 'the book I read'). When prepositions are involved, they must precede the relative pronoun: 'mit dem', 'für die' (not split). Relative clauses ALWAYS require comma separation. End-position is preferred when the relative clause is long or complex, to avoid confusing embedded structures. The verb-final position in relative clauses is absolute - no exceptions, even in casual speech.

Expressing Likes - gern/lieber

■ From lesson

Add 'gern' after a verb to express liking that activity. Use 'lieber' to express preference

COMPLETE RULE

gern(e) = gladly/with pleasure, placed after the verb. *lieber* = more gladly/preferably, used for comparisons. Pattern: *Ich mache X gern, aber ich mache Y lieber*

EXAMPLES

- *Ich tanze gern Salsa (I like dancing salsa)*
- *Ich tanze lieber Bachata (I prefer dancing bachata)*
- *Hörst du gern Musik? Ja, aber ich höre lieber Podcasts*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using mögen instead of gern with activities

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Both gern and gerne are correct

Expressing likes with 'gern'

■ From lesson

To express liking an activity, use verb + gern(e). To express preference, use verb + lieber

COMPLETE RULE

gern = like doing something; lieber = prefer doing something; 'gerne' and 'gern' are interchangeable

EXAMPLES

→ ***Ich trinke gern(e) Wein***

I like drinking wine

→ ***Ich tanze gern Salsa, aber ich tanze lieber Bachata***

I like dancing salsa, but I prefer dancing bachata

→ ***Ich höre gern Popmusik, aber ich höre lieber Rockmusik***

I like pop music but prefer rock music

Finalsätze with damit

■ Web verified

Use 'damit' (so that) to express purpose when the subject changes between main and subordinate clauses, or when you need to specify a different subject explicitly. 'Damit' is a subordinating conjunction that sends the conjugated verb to the end of the clause. This structure is mandatory when subjects differ and answers the same questions as um...zu: Wozu?, Wofür?, Zu welchem Zweck?

COMPLETE RULE

STRUCTURE: Main Clause + comma + damit + Subject + (Objects/Adverbs) + Conjugated Verb (at end).

COMPLETE PATTERN:

- Main clause: Normal V2 word order
- Comma separates clauses
- 'damit' introduces subordinate clause
- Explicit subject in subordinate clause (required if different from main clause)
- Conjugated verb goes to END of subordinate clause

- All other elements (objects, adverbs) come before the verb

VERB CONJUGATION: The verb in the *damit*-clause is fully conjugated to match its subject:

- ich kann → *damit ich kann*

- er fährt → *damit er fährt*

- sie arbeiten → *damit sie arbeiten*

WORD ORDER IN DAMIT-CLAUSE:

Subject + (Time) + (Manner) + (Place) + (Objects) + Conjugated Verb

CLAUSE POSITION: The *damit*-clause can come before or after the main clause:

- AFTER: *Ich lerne Deutsch, damit ich in Deutschland arbeiten kann.*

- BEFORE: *Damit ich in Deutschland arbeiten kann, lerne ich Deutsch.* (Note: main clause then has inverted word order with verb first after comma)

EXAMPLES

→ *Sie gibt ihm das Fahrrad, damit er schneller fahren kann.* (She gives him the bike so that he can go faster.)

→ *Ich lerne Deutsch, damit ich in Deutschland arbeiten kann.* (I learn German so that I can work in Germany.)

→ *Er spricht langsam, damit wir ihn besser verstehen können.* (He speaks slowly so that we can understand him better.)

→ *Wir rufen sie an, damit sie Bescheid weiß.* (We call her so that she knows what's happening.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' ERRORS:

■ 1. VERB POSITION ERROR: Italian subordinate clauses with 'perché' maintain normal word order. Italian speakers often forget to move the verb to the end: **'damit ich kann arbeiten'* instead of *'damit ich arbeiten kann'*.

2. USING 'damit' FOR SAME SUBJECT: Italian frequently uses 'perché + subjunctive' even with identical subjects, leading to overuse of *damit*: **'Ich lerne, damit ich spreche'* when *'um zu sprechen'* is more natural.

■ 3. OMITTING THE SUBJECT: Italian allows subject omission in subordinate clauses. German requires explicit subject: **'Ich gebe ihm Geld, damit kann essen'* instead of *'damit er essen kann'*.

4. CONFUSION WITH 'dafür': Italian speakers may confuse 'damit' (conjunction) with 'dafür' (pronominal adverb meaning 'for that').

5. SUBJUNCTIVE INTERFERENCE: Italian uses subjunctive mood in purpose clauses (*perché + congiuntivo*), but German *damit* takes indicative mood, not *Konjunktiv*.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. SAME SUBJECT CHOICE: When subject is identical in both clauses, 'damit' is grammatically correct but 'um...zu' is generally preferred: Both are correct: 'Ich lerne, damit ich bestehe' / 'Ich lerne, um zu bestehen' (but second is more natural).

2. STYLISTIC CHOICE: In formal writing or when emphasizing the separate subject even when identical, damit may be used.

3. DAMIT AS PRONOMINAL ADVERB: 'damit' also functions as pronominal adverb (da + mit = 'with that/it'). Context determines function: 'Ich arbeite damit' (with that/it - pronominal) vs. 'Ich arbeite, damit du zufrieden bist' (so that - conjunction).

4. NEGATIVE PURPOSE: For negative purposes (so that...not), use 'damit...nicht': 'Ich schließe die Tür, damit es nicht kalt wird' (I close the door so that it doesn't get cold).

Finalsätze with um...zu

■ Web verified

Final clauses (Finalsätze) express purpose or goal. Use 'um...zu + infinitive' when the subject is the same in both clauses. The structure is: main clause + comma + um + (objects/adverbs) + zu + infinitive. The infinitive always goes at the end. This answers questions like Wozu? (For what purpose?), Wofür? (What for?), Zu welchem Zweck? (For what purpose?).

COMPLETE RULE

STRUCTURE: Subject + Verb + Object, um + (Additional Elements) + zu + Infinitive.

COMPLETE PATTERN:

- Main clause: Normal word order (V2)
- Comma separates clauses
- 'um' introduces purpose clause
- All objects, adverbs come before 'zu + infinitive'
- Infinitive is always at the end

WITH SEPARABLE VERBS: The 'zu' goes between prefix and verb stem:

- aufstehen → um aufzustehen
- einkaufen → um einzukaufen
- anzurufen → um anzurufen

WITH MODAL VERBS: zu goes after main infinitive and before modal:

- um Deutsch lernen zu können (in order to be able to learn German)

SUBJECT RULE: Only use um...zu when the subject performing both actions is identical or clearly understood from context.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich muss zur Bank gehen, um ein Konto zu eröffnen. (I must go to the bank in order to open an account.)*

→ *Sie spart Geld, um sich ein neues Auto zu kaufen. (She saves money in order to buy herself a new car.)*

→ *Wir lernen Deutsch, um in Deutschland zu arbeiten. (We learn German in order to work in Germany.)*

→ *Er steht früh auf, um den Zug nicht zu verpassen. (He gets up early in order not to miss the train.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' ERRORS:

- 1. OMITTING 'um': Italian uses 'per + infinitive' directly (per imparare = to learn), so Italian speakers often forget 'um' and say *'Ich gehe nach Deutschland, Deutsch zu lernen' instead of 'Ich gehe nach Deutschland, um Deutsch zu lernen'.
- 2. WRONG WORD ORDER: Italian places the infinitive immediately after 'per', but German requires all other elements before 'zu + infinitive'. Italian speakers may incorrectly say *'um zu lernen Deutsch' instead of 'um Deutsch zu lernen'.
- 3. USING 'damit' UNNECESSARILY: Italian often uses 'perché + subjunctive' for same-subject purposes, leading speakers to overuse 'damit' when 'um...zu' is clearer: *'Ich lerne, damit ich Deutsch spreche' instead of 'Ich lerne, um Deutsch zu sprechen' (when subject is same).
- 4. SEPARABLE VERB CONFUSION: Not inserting 'zu' correctly: *'um auf zu stehen' instead of 'um aufzustehen'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. When subjects are **DIFFERENT** between clauses, you **MUST** use 'damit' instead: 'Sie gibt ihm das Fahrrad, damit er schneller fahren kann' (NOT *um er schneller zu fahren).
2. With **SAME** subject, both 'um...zu' and 'damit' are possible, but 'um...zu' is preferred as more concise and natural.
3. **VERBS WITHOUT 'zu'**: Modal verbs, perception verbs (sehen, hören), lassen, gehen, bleiben take bare infinitive, so cannot be used with um...zu structure directly.
4. When the infinitive clause is **VERY COMPLEX** or contains multiple verbs, 'damit' may be clearer even with same subject.

gerade in Nebensätzen (subordinate clauses)

■ Web verified

When using 'gerade' (right now, currently) in a subordinate clause introduced by 'weil', the word order is: subordinating conjunction + subject + gerade + rest of verb phrase, with the conjugated verb at the end.

COMPLETE RULE

German subordinate clauses (Nebensätze) introduced by a subordinating conjunction such as *weil*, *dass*, *wenn*, *ob*, *obwohl*, etc. send the conjugated (finite) verb to the very end of the clause. Word order pattern for *weil*-clauses containing 'gerade':

weil + subject + (time/gerade) + object(s)/other adverbials + non-finite verb parts + conjugated verb (end)

This follows the general TeKaMoLo principle (Temporal-Kausal-Modal-Lokal) for ordering middle-field elements, with 'gerade' functioning as a temporal adverb placed early in the clause, directly after the subject (and after any pronoun objects), but before the rest of the verb phrase (objects, separable prefixes, or infinitives), with the conjugated verb pushed to the final position.

Structure: Hauptsatz, *weil* + Subjekt + gerade + (Objekt/e) + Verb (finit, am Ende).

Example structure: 'Ich habe keine Zeit, weil ich gerade meine Wohnung putze.' -> *weil* (conj.) + *ich* (subj.) + *gerade* (adv.) + *meine Wohnung* (obj.) + *putze* (finite verb, end).

This mirrors the general subordinate-clause rule: a subordinating conjunction kicks the conjugated verb to the end of its clause, and the word order within the clause otherwise remains similar to a main clause (subject, objects, adverbials), just without the verb in second position.

EXAMPLES

→ Ich habe keine Zeit, weil ich gerade meine Wohnung putze.

→ Sie sind im Flugzeug, weil sie gerade in den Urlaub fahren.

→ Er geht nicht ans Telefon, weil er gerade duscht.

→ Wir können nicht sprechen, weil wir gerade das Abendessen kochen.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Kevin tended to place 'gerade' incorrectly or overcomplicate the sentence structure instead of using this simple pattern. Italian speakers commonly struggle with this rule because Italian subordinate clauses (e.g., 'perché sto pulendo la mia casa proprio ora') keep the verb in second position, right after the subject, with adverbs like 'proprio ora'/'adesso' typically placed at the end or beginning of the clause, never forcing the verb to the clause-final position. This leads Italian learners to build sentences like '*weil ich putze gerade meine Wohnung' (keeping the verb in 'normal' second position, as in a main clause) instead of correctly moving 'putze' to the end: 'weil ich gerade meine Wohnung putze.' A second frequent error is forgetting the comma before 'weil', since Italian 'perché' does not obligatorily require comma separation in the same systematic way. Italian speakers may also over-complicate the sentence by trying to front 'gerade' at the very start of the clause (as they might with 'proprio ora' in Italian), producing incorrect orders such as '*weil gerade ich meine Wohnung putze.'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The coordinating conjunction 'denn' (also meaning 'because') does NOT trigger verb-final word order — unlike 'weil', a clause with 'denn' keeps normal main-clause (verb-second) word order, so 'gerade' in a *denn*-clause behaves like in any main clause: 'Ich habe keine Zeit, denn ich putze gerade meine Wohnung.' In colloquial spoken German, some native speakers use 'weil' informally with main-clause (verb-second) word order ('weil ich putze gerade...'), but this is considered non-standard and should be avoided in formal or written German. When a modal verb or Perfekt tense is involved, 'gerade' still occupies the same early position in the middle field, while it is the auxiliary/modal verb (not the participle or infinitive) that moves to the clause-final position.

glauben + Dative

■ Web verified

The verb glauben (to believe) requires the dative case when you believe a person (what they say) - meaning to trust their words. Use 'glauben an + accusative' when believing in something as a concept, having faith in something, or believing in someone's abilities.

COMPLETE RULE

GLAUBEN CASE PATTERNS:

1. glauben + DATIVE PERSON = to believe someone/what they say (to trust their statement)

Ich glaube ihm. (I believe him.)

Ich glaube der Frau. (I believe the woman.)

Ich glaube dir, dass du recht hast. (I believe you that you are right.)

Pattern: SUBJECT + glauben + DATIVE PERSON (+ optional dass-clause)

Like Italian: credere A qualcuno

2. glauben + an + ACCUSATIVE = to believe in something/someone (to have faith)

Ich glaube an Gott. (I believe in God.)

Ich glaube an dich. (I believe in you - your abilities.)

Ich glaube an die Demokratie. (I believe in democracy.)

Pattern: SUBJECT + glauben + an + ACCUSATIVE OBJECT

Like Italian: credere IN qualcosa/qualcuno

3. glauben + ACCUSATIVE THING = to believe something (to think something is true)

Ich glaube das nicht. (I don't believe that.)

Glaubst du diese Geschichte? (Do you believe this story?)

CONJUGATION (Present):

ich glaube, du glaubst, er/sie/es glaubt, wir glauben, ihr glaubt, sie/Sie glauben

OTHER DATIVE VERBS (similar pattern):

- vertrauen + Dative (to trust someone)

- helfen + Dative (to help someone)

- danken + Dative (to thank someone)

- antworten + Dative (to answer someone)

- folgen + Dative (to follow someone)

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich glaube ihm, dass er heute müde ist. (dative person)**

I believe him that he is tired today, I trust what he says)

→ **Ich glaube dir, aber meine Mutter glaubt dir nicht. (dative person)**

I believe you, but my mother doesn't believe you)

→ **Ich glaube an Gott und an die Liebe. (an + accusative for faith/concepts)**

I believe in God and in love)

→ **Ich glaube an dich! Du schaffst das! (an + accusative for believing in abilities)**

I believe in you! You can do it!)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use accusative instead of dative when believing a person directly (saying 'Ich glaube ihn' instead of 'Ich glaube ihm'), influenced by Italian 'lo credo'. They confuse 'glauben + dative person' with 'glauben an + accusative' - using dative for faith/belief in concepts ('Ich glaube Gott' instead of 'Ich glaube an Gott'). Italian speakers may forget the preposition 'an' entirely when expressing faith. They might overgeneralize and use dative with all belief contexts instead of recognizing the three distinct patterns.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When glauben means 'to think/suppose' rather than 'to believe someone', it doesn't take dative: 'Ich glaube, es regnet' (I think it's raining - no case marking, just dass-clause or statement). Glauben can take accusative for things/statements you believe: 'Ich glaube die Geschichte nicht' (I don't believe the story). In religious contexts, 'an' is required: 'glauben an Gott' (never 'glauben Gott'). The dative is only used for believing a person's words, not for believing in a person's character or abilities (which requires 'an').

Indefinite pronouns as masculine (jemand, niemand)

■ Web verified

The pronouns 'jemand' (someone) and 'niemand' (nobody) refer to unspecified persons and decline with masculine endings in written German: nominative jemand/niemand, accusative jemanden/niemanden, dative jemandem/niemandem, genitive jemandes/niemandes. They are singular, have no gender, and take third-person singular verbs. In colloquial speech, endings are often dropped.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete declension table:

NOMINATIVE: jemand / niemand

ACCUSATIVE: jemanden / niemanden (colloquial: jemand / niemand)

DATIVE: jemandem / niemandem (colloquial: jemand / niemand)

GENITIVE: jemandes / niemandes (rarely used; von + dative preferred)

Note: When followed by 'anders' or nominalized adjectives, pronouns usually remain uninflected. Nominalized adjectives after *jemand/niemand* take neuter endings: *jemand Interessantes* (someone interesting).

EXAMPLES

- *Jemand hat an der Tür geklopft.* (Someone knocked on the door.)
- *Ich habe jemanden Interessanten kennengelernt.* (I met someone interesting yesterday.)
- *Sie hat mit niemandem darüber gesprochen.* (She didn't talk to anyone about it.)
- *Niemand weiß, wohin sie gegangen ist.* (No one knows where she went.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may omit case endings entirely, as Italian pronouns 'qualcuno' and 'nessuno' are invariable. They might also incorrectly assign grammatical gender based on the referent's biological gender, whereas *jemand/niemand* always use masculine forms regardless of the person's gender. Additionally, Italian speakers may forget that these pronouns require third-person singular verb conjugation. In genitive constructions, they may attempt direct translations instead of using the preferred 'von + dative' structure common in spoken German.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In colloquial/spoken German, case endings are frequently dropped: '*Ich habe jemand getroffen*' is common and understood informally. In writing and exams, full forms are expected. When followed by 'anders' or nominalized adjectives, *jemand/niemand* typically remain uninflected. Genitive forms (*jemandes/niemandes*) are rare; speakers prefer 'von + dative' construction instead.

Indirect questions with 'ob'

■ From lesson

When transforming a yes/no question into an indirect question, use 'ob' (whether/if) to introduce the subordinate clause. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the clause. Common sentence starters include '*Ich frage mich, ob...*', '*Ich weiß nicht, ob...*', '*Ich überlege, ob...*', and '*Ich möchte wissen, ob...*'

COMPLETE RULE

Direct yes/no questions become subordinate clauses introduced by 'ob'. The word order changes to: conjunction + subject + other elements + conjugated verb (at the end).

EXAMPLES

- *Hast du morgen Zeit?* → *Ich frage mich, ob du morgen Zeit hast.*
- *Ist der Supermarkt sonntags geöffnet?* → *Ich weiß nicht, ob der Supermarkt sonntags geöffnet ist.*
- *Soll ich ihm schreiben?* → *Ich überlege, ob ich ihm schreiben soll.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Students often forget to move the verb to the end position or confuse 'ob' with 'wenn' (which is used for conditional sentences, not indirect questions).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Modal verbs like 'sollen' remain conjugated and move to the end, while the main verb stays in infinitive form before it.

Indirect Questions with Question Words

■ Web verified

Indirect questions are subordinate clauses that report a question without asking it directly. The question word (wo, wer, wem, wann, wie lange, warum, wie, etc.) introduces the subordinate clause, and the conjugated verb moves to the end. These are used with introductory phrases like 'Ich weiß nicht...', 'Ich frage mich...', 'Er fragt...', 'Kannst du mir sagen...', 'Ich möchte wissen...', or 'Sie möchte wissen...'. The key difference from relative clauses is that indirect questions always contain an unanswered question. For yes/no questions without a question word, use 'ob' (whether/if) to introduce the indirect question.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: Main clause + comma + question word (wo, wer, wem, wen, wann, wie, wie lange, warum, wohin, woher, etc.) + subject + other elements + conjugated verb at end. For yes/no questions: Main clause + comma + ob + subject + other elements + verb at end. Common introductory phrases: Ich weiß nicht..., Ich frage mich..., Er fragt..., Sie möchte wissen..., Kannst du mir sagen..., Ich verstehe nicht..., Ich sage dir nicht..., Ich möchte wissen... Punctuation: Use a period if the main clause is a statement; use a question mark if the main clause is also a question (e.g., 'Kannst du mir sagen, wann der Zug abfährt?').

EXAMPLES

- *Ich weiß nicht, wo er wohnt. (I don't know where he lives.)*
- *Kannst du mir sagen, wann der Zug abfährt? (Can you tell me when the train departs?)*
- *Er fragt, ob sie morgen kommt. (He asks if she is coming tomorrow.)*
- *Ich verstehe nicht, warum sie nicht angerufen hat. (I don't understand why she didn't call.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often confuse indirect questions with relative clauses. Indirect questions always contain an unanswered question and require introductory phrases like 'Ich weiß nicht', whereas relative clauses describe or identify a noun. Another common mistake is incorrect comma placement - always separate the main clause from the subordinate clause with a comma. Italian speakers may also forget to move the verb to the end position in the subordinate clause, as Italian word order is more flexible. They may incorrectly place a question mark when the main clause is a statement rather than a

question.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When the verb is understood from context, it may be omitted in colloquial speech. In subordinate clauses, both the question word and the conjugated verb remain at the end. Modal verbs follow the same pattern: the conjugated modal comes after the infinitive at the end (e.g., 'Ich weiß nicht, ob ich morgen arbeiten muss'). With perfect tense, the auxiliary verb and past participle both go to the end (e.g., 'Ich weiß nicht, wer die Wohnung geputzt hat').

Infinitive constructions with zu

■ Web verified

Many German verbs require 'zu + infinitive' to complete their meaning, forming infinitive clauses (Infinitivsätze). The 'zu' stands directly before the infinitive at the end of the clause. These are subordinate clauses without their own explicit subject; the subject is understood from the main clause. Common verbs include: versuchen (to try), vergessen (to forget), schaffen (to manage), vorhaben (to plan), hoffen (to hope), beginnen/anfangen (to begin), and many others.

COMPLETE RULE

VERBS REQUIRING ZU + INFINITIVE (extensive list):

1. INTENTION/PLAN VERBS:

- *versuchen (to try), vorhaben (to plan), planen (to plan), sich bemühen (to endeavor), daran denken (to think of/remember), beabsichtigen (to intend)*

2. BEGINNING/ENDING VERBS:

- *anfangen (to begin), beginnen (to begin), aufhören (to stop), stoppen (to stop)*

3. FORGETTING/REMEMBERING:

- *vergessen (to forget), (nicht) vergessen (not to forget)*

4. OPINION/BELIEF VERBS:

- *glauben (to believe), denken (to think), meinen (to think/believe), hoffen (to hope), erwarten (to expect), vermuten (to suppose)*

5. DECISION/AGREEMENT VERBS:

- *beschließen (to decide), sich entscheiden (to decide), vereinbaren (to agree), abmachen (to arrange), versprechen (to promise)*

6. MODAL/POSSIBILITY EXPRESSIONS:

- *scheinen (to seem), drohen (to threaten), wagen (to dare), sich trauen (to dare), gelingen (to succeed), schaffen (to manage)*

7. REJECTION/REFUSAL:

- sich weigern (to refuse), ablehnen (to decline), vermeiden (to avoid)

8. WARNING/FORBIDDING:

- warnen vor (to warn), verbieten (to forbid)

9. EMOTION VERBS:

- sich freuen (to look forward to/be happy), Spaß haben (to have fun)

STRUCTURE:

Main clause + comma + (objects/adverbs) + zu + infinitive

WITH SEPARABLE VERBS: 'zu' goes BETWEEN prefix and verb stem:

- anrufen → anzurufen: Ich vergesse oft, dich anzurufen.
- aufstehen → aufzustehen: Es ist schwer, früh aufzustehen.
- einkaufen → einzukaufen: Ich habe vergessen, einzukaufen.

WITH MODAL VERBS in infinitive clause: zu goes after the main infinitive, before the modal:

- Ich hoffe, bald anfangen zu können. (I hope to be able to start soon.)

ADJECTIVE + zu + INFINITIVE (after 'sein'):

- Es ist wichtig, pünktlich zu sein.
- Es ist schwer, Deutsch zu lernen.
- Es ist schön, hier zu sein.

NOUN + zu + INFINITIVE:

- die Absicht, ... zu ... (the intention to...)
- die Möglichkeit, ... zu ... (the possibility to...)
- der Versuch, ... zu ... (the attempt to...)

EXAMPLES

- Ich schaffe es nicht, zur Bank zu gehen. (I don't manage to go to the bank.)
- Sie vergisst immer, ihre Hausaufgaben zu machen. (She always forgets to do her homework.)
- Wir versuchen, pünktlich zu sein. (We try to be on time.)
- Es ist wichtig, viel Wasser zu trinken. (It is important to drink a lot of water.) [impersonal expression with sein + adjective]

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' ERRORS:

- 1. OMITTING 'zu': Italian uses bare infinitive after many verbs (cercare di fare = try to do, but 'di' is not directly before verb). Italian speakers often forget 'zu': *'Ich versuche gehen' instead of 'Ich versuche zu gehen'.

2. WRONG POSITION OF 'zu': Italian structure 'cercare di + infinitive' has 'di' immediately before verb. In German, other elements can separate: Italian 'cerco di studiare' → German 'Ich versuche zu studieren' (simple) BUT 'Ich versuche jeden Tag Deutsch zu lernen' (NOT *zu Deutsch jeden Tag lernen).

■ **3. SEPARABLE VERB ERRORS:** Italian has no separable verbs. Italian speakers write 'zu' separately: *'zu anrufen' or *'anrufen zu' instead of 'anzurufen'.

4. USING 'zu' WITH MODAL VERBS: Italian uses 'potere' + infinitive (bare). German modal verbs DON'T take 'zu': *'Ich muss zu gehen' (WRONG) → 'Ich muss gehen' (CORRECT). But: 'Ich hoffe, gehen zu können' (zu before modal is correct in infinitive clause).

5. CONFUSION WITH 'per' (purpose): Italian 'per + infinitive' (purpose) → German 'um...zu' (NOT just 'zu'): Italian 'studio per imparare' → German 'Ich lerne, um zu verstehen' (NOT *Ich lerne zu verstehen).

6. OVERUSING SUBORDINATE CLAUSES: Italian often uses 'che + subjunctive' where German prefers 'zu + infinitive': Italian 'Spero che io possa venire' → German prefers 'Ich hoffe, kommen zu können' over 'Ich hoffe, dass ich kommen kann'.

7. DOUBLE INFINITIVES: With auxiliary verbs in infinitive clause, Italian speakers may incorrectly structure: Understanding 'Ich habe vergessen zu kommen' (correct) vs. confusing it with *'Ich habe zu vergessen kommen'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS - VERBS THAT DON'T TAKE 'zu':

1. MODAL VERBS (take bare infinitive):

- können, müssen, dürfen, sollen, wollen, mögen/möchten
- Ich kann schwimmen. (NOT *zu schwimmen)

2. PERCEPTION VERBS:

- sehen (to see), hören (to hear), fühlen (to feel), spüren (to sense)
- Ich sehe ihn kommen. (I see him coming.) [no zu]

3. LASSEN (to let/have something done):

- Ich lasse das Auto reparieren. (I have the car repaired.) [no zu]

4. MOTION VERBS + activity:

- gehen, fahren, kommen (+ activity verb)
- Ich gehe schwimmen. (I go swimming.) [no zu]
- Wir fahren einkaufen. (We drive shopping.) [no zu]

5. BLEIBEN (to stay/remain):

- Er bleibt sitzen. (He remains seated.) [no zu]

6. WERDEN (future auxiliary):

- Ich werde gehen. (I will go.) [no zu]

7. LERNEN, HELFEN, LEHREN - OPTIONAL:

- Can take zu or not, especially when short:
- Das Kind lernt schwimmen. (short, no zu common)

- Das Kind lernt, richtig zu schwimmen. (longer, zu common)
- Ich helfe dir tragen. / Ich helfe dir, das zu tragen.

8. BRAUCHEN + nicht/nur:

- When brauchen means 'need not' with 'nicht' or 'nur', zu is optional but common:
- Du brauchst nicht (zu) kommen. (You don't need to come.)
- Modern usage prefers 'zu': Du brauchst nicht zu kommen.

9. HABEN/SEIN in set expressions:

- Das ist zu machen. (That can be done.) [zu expresses possibility/necessity, different meaning]
- Ich habe viel zu tun. (I have a lot to do.) [set expression]

Infinitive with zu after certain verbs (vergessen, versuchen)

■ Web verified

Many German verbs require an infinitive clause with 'zu' to complete their meaning. These verbs introduce a subordinate infinitive clause that describes an action related to the main verb. The structure is similar to English 'to + verb' constructions. The infinitive with zu always goes to the end of the clause, and the clauses are separated by a comma when the infinitive clause contains additional elements.

COMPLETE RULE

Common verbs requiring zu + infinitive:

MEMORY & THOUGHT:

- vergessen (to forget)
- sich erinnern (to remember)
- denken (to think)
- glauben (to believe)

ATTEMPT & EFFORT:

- versuchen (to try)
- probieren (to try/test)
- sich bemühen (to make an effort)

BEGINNING & ENDING:

- anfangen/beginnen (to begin/start)
- aufhören (to stop)

DECISION & PLANNING:

- beschließen (to decide)
- entscheiden (to decide)

- *vorhaben* (to plan/intend)
- *planen* (to plan)

EMOTION:

- *sich freuen* (to be happy/look forward to)
- *hoffen* (to hope)
- *fürchten* (to fear)

PERMISSION & REQUEST:

- *erlauben* (to allow)
- *verbieten* (to forbid)
- *bitten* (to ask/request)

OTHERS:

- *versprechen* (to promise)
- *scheinen* (to seem)
- *helfen* (to help - can use with or without zu)
- *lernen* (to learn - can use with or without zu)
- *lehren* (to teach - can use with or without zu)

Structure: [Subject] + [conjugated verb] + , + [additional elements] + zu + [infinitive]

Conjugation remains normal for the main verb; only the second verb stays in infinitive form.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich vergesse immer, Wasser zu trinken.* (I always forget to drink water.)
- *Ich versuche, immer den Bus zu nehmen.* (I try to always take the bus.)
- *Wir haben beschlossen, unsere Ferien in Deutschland zu verbringen.* (We decided to spend our vacation in Germany.)
- *Er fängt an, Deutsch zu lernen.* (He is starting to learn German.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers' typical errors:

- 1. OMITTING 'ZU': Incorrect: *Ich versuche Deutsch lernen. Correct: Ich versuche, Deutsch zu lernen. (Italian uses bare infinitive: 'Provo a imparare' but German requires 'zu')
- 2. USING 'A' OR 'DI': Incorrect: *Ich versuche a Deutsch zu lernen. Correct: Ich versuche, Deutsch zu lernen. (Transferring Italian prepositions 'a' or 'di' before infinitive)
- 3. WRONG POSITION OF 'ZU': Incorrect: *Ich versuche zu immer pünktlich sein. Correct: Ich versuche, immer pünktlich zu sein. ('zu' must come immediately before the infinitive)
- 4. MISSING COMMA: Incorrect: *Ich vergesse immer Wasser zu trinken. Correct: Ich vergesse immer, Wasser zu trinken. (Extended infinitive clauses need comma)
- 5. WITH MODAL VERBS: Incorrect: *Ich versuche, zu können schwimmen. Correct: Ich versuche zu schwimmen OR Ich will schwimmen können. (Modal verbs don't take 'zu')

■ 6. REFLEXIVE VERB ERRORS: Incorrect: *Ich freue zu lernen mich. Correct: Ich freue mich, zu lernen. (Reflexive pronoun stays in main clause)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. HELFEN, LERNEN, LEHREN: These three verbs can take infinitive with OR without 'zu'. With objects/adverbs, 'zu' is preferred:

- Ich lerne schwimmen (short, no zu)
- Ich lerne, gut zu schwimmen (extended, with zu)

2. BRAUCHEN (to need): Uses 'zu' in negation or questions, meaning 'don't have to': Du brauchst nicht zu kommen (You don't have to come)

3. PERCEPTION VERBS (sehen, hören, fühlen): Take bare infinitive WITHOUT zu: Ich sehe ihn kommen (NOT *zu kommen)

4. LASSEN (to let/have done): Takes bare infinitive: Ich lasse das Auto reparieren

5. BLEIBEN + STEHEN/SITZEN/LIEGEN: No zu required: Er bleibt sitzen

6. GEHEN + INFINITIVE (activities): No zu: Ich gehe schwimmen

Infinitive with zu after haben + noun (Zeit, Lust, Angst)

■ Web verified

When the verb 'haben' is combined with certain nouns (Zeit, Lust, Angst, Möglichkeit, Gelegenheit, Recht, etc.), it triggers an infinitive clause with 'zu' to express having time, desire, fear, opportunity, or right to do something. This construction creates a two-part predicate where the noun specifies what you 'have' and the infinitive clause describes the action.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: [Subject] + haben + [noun] + , + zu + [infinitive]

Common nouns used with haben + zu + infinitive:

1. Zeit (time)

- Ich habe Zeit, ... (I have time to...)
- keine Zeit (no time)
- genug Zeit (enough time)
- wenig Zeit (little time)

2. Lust (desire/feel like)

- Ich habe Lust, ... (I feel like...)
- keine Lust (don't feel like)
- große Lust (great desire)

3. Angst (fear)

- Ich habe Angst, ... (I'm afraid to...)
- keine Angst (no fear)
- große Angst (great fear)
- 4. Möglichkeit (possibility/opportunity)
 - die Möglichkeit haben (to have the opportunity)
- 5. Gelegenheit (opportunity/occasion)
 - die Gelegenheit haben (to have the occasion)
- 6. Recht (right)
 - das Recht haben (to have the right)
- 7. Grund (reason)
 - einen Grund haben (to have a reason)
- 8. Pflicht (duty/obligation)
 - die Pflicht haben (to have the duty)

Conjugation of haben:

Present: ich habe, du hast, er/sie/es hat, wir haben, ihr habt, sie/Sie haben

Past (Präteritum): ich hatte, du hattest, er/sie/es hatte, wir hatten, ihr hattet, sie/Sie hatten

Perfect: ich habe gehabt, du hast gehabt, etc.

EXAMPLES

- Ich habe keine Lust, Deutsch zu lernen. (I don't feel like learning German.)
- Ich habe Angst, im Meer zu schwimmen. (I'm afraid to swim in the sea.)
- Ich habe keine Zeit, Urlaub zu machen. (I have no time to take vacation.)
- Wir haben die Möglichkeit, nach Berlin zu fahren. (We have the opportunity to go to Berlin.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers typically make these mistakes:

- 1. OMITTING 'ZU': Incorrect: *Ich habe keine Zeit Urlaub machen. Correct: Ich habe keine Zeit, Urlaub zu machen. (Italian 'Non ho tempo di fare' uses 'di', not zu construction)
- 2. USING 'VON' OR 'FÜR': Incorrect: *Ich habe Lust von/für tanzen. Correct: Ich habe Lust zu tanzen. (Transferring Italian 'di' as German 'von/für')
- 3. WRONG WORD ORDER: Incorrect: *Ich habe zu machen keine Lust Hausaufgaben. Correct: Ich habe keine Lust, Hausaufgaben zu machen. (Infinitive must go to end)

4. CONFUSING 'ANGST HABEN' WITH 'FÜRCHTEN': Both work but structure differs:

- Ich habe Angst, im Meer zu schwimmen.
- Ich fürchte, im Meer zu schwimmen. (less common)

Italian 'avere paura di' → German 'Angst haben...zu'

■ 5. ARTICLE ERRORS: Incorrect: *Ich habe eine Zeit. Correct: Ich habe Zeit. (Time is used without article in this construction, unlike Italian 'ho del tempo')

■ 6. USING INFINITIVE ALONE: Incorrect: *Ich habe schwimmen Angst. Correct: Ich habe Angst zu schwimmen. OR Ich habe Angst, im Meer zu schwimmen.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. WITHOUT INFINITIVE CLAUSE: These nouns can be used without infinitive when context is clear:

- Ich habe Zeit. (I have time - no specific action mentioned)
- Hast du Lust? (Do you feel like it?)

2. ALTERNATIVE WITH 'AUF': With some nouns, 'Lust auf + noun' is used instead:

- Ich habe Lust auf Eis. (I feel like ice cream - noun object)
- Ich habe Lust, Eis zu essen. (I feel like eating ice cream - infinitive)

3. 'HABEN' AS MODAL-LIKE: In construction 'haben + zu + infinitive' (without noun), it means 'must/have to':

- Ich habe viel zu tun. (I have a lot to do/must do)
- This is different from 'haben + noun + zu + infinitive'

4. WITH DATIVE: Some constructions use dative:

- Ich habe keine Zeit für dich. (not infinitive construction)
- Ich habe dir zu helfen. (archaic, means 'I have to help you')

Infinitive with zu: es ist + adjective + zu + infinitive

■ Web verified

This construction is used to make general, impersonal statements about what is important, nice, necessary, difficult, etc. The structure follows the pattern: es ist + adjective + comma + zu + infinitive. The infinitive clause describes or explains the evaluation expressed by the adjective. This is equivalent to English 'it is + adjective + to + verb'.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: *Es ist + [adjective] + , + [objects/adverbs] + zu + [infinitive]*

Common adjectives used:

- wichtig (important)
- schön (nice/beautiful)
- schwer/schwierig (difficult/hard)
- leicht (easy)
- möglich (possible)
- unmöglich (impossible)

- gesund (healthy)
- verboten (forbidden)
- nötig/notwendig (necessary)
- interessant (interesting)

Word Order Rules:

1. The infinitive with 'zu' always goes to the end of the clause
2. A comma separates the main clause from the infinitive clause
3. Objects and adverbs come before 'zu + infinitive'
4. With separable verbs, 'zu' goes between the prefix and stem: aufzustehen, einzukaufen

Examples with structure breakdown:

Es ist wichtig, pünktlich zu sein.

[main clause] + [comma] + [adverb] + zu + [infinitive]

Es ist nicht leicht, eine neue Sprache zu lernen.

[main clause with negation] + [comma] + [object phrase] + zu + [infinitive]

EXAMPLES

- Es ist wichtig, viel Wasser zu trinken. (It is important to drink a lot of water.)
- Es ist billiger, den Regionalzug zu nehmen. (It is cheaper to take the regional train.)
- Es ist schön, ins Fitnessstudio zu gehen. (It is nice to go to the gym.)
- Es ist schwierig, jeden Tag früh aufzustehen. (It is difficult to get up early every day.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often make these errors:

- 1. OMITTING THE COMMA: Incorrect: *Es ist wichtig pünktlich zu sein. Correct: Es ist wichtig, pünktlich zu sein. (Italian doesn't always require comma separation)
- 2. OMITTING 'ZU': Incorrect: *Es ist wichtig Deutsch lernen. Correct: Es ist wichtig, Deutsch zu lernen. (Influenced by Italian infinitive constructions like 'È importante imparare')
- 3. WRONG WORD ORDER: Incorrect: *Es ist zu lernen wichtig Deutsch. Correct: Es ist wichtig, Deutsch zu lernen. (Italian word order differs)
- 4. USING SUBJUNCTIVE INSTEAD: Incorrect: *È importante che impari... → *Es ist wichtig, dass ich lerne... when a simple infinitive would work: Es ist wichtig zu lernen.
- 5. WITH SEPARABLE VERBS: Incorrect: *Es ist schwer, zu aufstehen früh. Correct: Es ist schwer, früh aufzustehen. (zu must go inside the separable verb)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. NO 'ZU' AFTER MODAL VERBS: Modal verbs (können, müssen, wollen, dürfen, sollen, mögen) take bare infinitive without 'zu': Ich muss lernen (NOT *zu lernen)

2. NO 'ZU' AFTER: bleiben (to stay), gehen (motion), lassen (to let), sehen (to see), hören (to hear), fühlen (to feel)

3. NO 'ZU' WITH 'WERDEN' (future): Ich werde lernen (NOT *zu lernen)

4. OPTIONAL COMMA: When the infinitive clause is very short (just zu + verb with no other elements), the comma may be omitted, though using it is safer: Es ist wichtig(,) zu lernen.

5. VERBS THAT CHANGE MEANING: Some verbs like 'drohen' and 'versprechen' change meaning when used with infinitive + zu vs. as modal verbs.

Negation - nicht (verbs and adjectives)

■ From lesson

Use 'nicht' to negate verbs and adjectives. Position: after conjugated verb or before the element being negated

COMPLETE RULE

'nicht' comes after the conjugated verb in simple sentences, or before specific elements being negated (adjectives, separable prefixes, infinitives)

EXAMPLES

- Ich spiele nicht Tennis
- Ich komme nicht
- Ich bin nicht traurig
- Ich kann nicht lange schlafen

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Placing nicht at the beginning of the sentence or in wrong position

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Position varies depending on sentence structure

Negation with 'nicht' (verbs and adjectives)

■ From lesson

'nicht' is used to negate verbs and adjectives, and always comes after the verb

COMPLETE RULE

'nicht' always comes after the conjugated verb in simple sentences

EXAMPLES

- *Ich spiele nicht gern Tennis*
- *Ich komme nicht*
- *Ich bin nicht wütend / traurig*
- *Ich wandere nicht gern*

Negation with kein vs. nicht

■ Web verified

'Kein' negates nouns (nominal phrases) and replaces indefinite articles or no article. 'Nicht' negates entire sentences, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, or nouns with definite articles.

COMPLETE RULE

'Kein' declension follows 'ein-word' pattern (same endings as 'ein'): Nominative: kein/keine/kein/keine (m/f/n/pl); Accusative: keinen/keine/kein/keine; Dative: keinem/keiner/keinem/keinen; Genitive: keines/keiner/keines/keiner. Use 'kein' to negate: indefinite nouns (with ein/eine), plural nouns without article, uncountable nouns. Use 'nicht': to negate verbs, adjectives, adverbs, nouns with definite articles (der/die/das), proper names, possessive pronouns. Position of 'nicht': before unconjugated verb or at end of sentence for verb negation; directly before the element being negated for specific element negation.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich habe keine Zeit. (I have no time / I don't have time*
indefinite noun)
- *Es gibt keinen großen Rabatt. (There's no big discount - indefinite noun with adjective)*
- *Das ist nicht gut. (That's not good - negating adjective)*
- *Ich kenne nicht den Mann, sondern die Frau. (I don't know the man, but the woman*
definite article)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using 'nicht' instead of 'kein' for indefinite nouns (e.g., 'Ich habe nicht Zeit' instead of 'Ich habe keine Zeit'). Using 'kein' with definite articles (incorrect: 'kein der Mann'). Italian speakers may struggle with this distinction as Italian uses 'non' more universally. Incorrect word order with 'nicht'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

With double indefinite elements in negation focus, only one is marked negative in standard German: 'Ich glaube, dass Otto niemandem etwas gesagt hat' (not 'niemandem nichts'). In questions and exclamations, 'nicht' can appear without actual negating force (empty negation): 'Wolltest du nicht

noch...?' After verbs expressing prevention (verhindern, vermeiden), subordinate clauses are not negated again.

Prepositional adverbs (da + preposition)

■ Web verified

Pronominal adverbs (Pronominaladverbien) are formed by combining 'da' (there) with a preposition to refer back to things, ideas, or situations (NOT people or animals). They replace prepositional phrases with pronouns. When the preposition starts with a vowel, add 'r' for euphony (darüber, darauf). For people, always use preposition + personal pronoun (mit ihm, für sie).

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE LIST OF DA-COMPOUNDS:

WITH CONSONANT PREPOSITIONS:

- *damit* (with that/it) ← *da* + *mit*
- *dafür* (for that/it) ← *da* + *für*
- *dagegen* (against that/it) ← *da* + *gegen*
- *danach* (after that/it) ← *da* + *nach*
- *daneben* (beside that/it) ← *da* + *neben*
- *durch* → *dadurch* (through that/it)
- *hinter* → *dahinter* (behind that/it)
- *von* → *davon* (of/from that/it)
- *vor* → *davor* (before/in front of that/it)
- *zu* → *dazu* (to that/it)
- *zwischen* → *dazwischen* (between that/it)

WITH VOWEL PREPOSITIONS (add 'r'):

- *an* → *daran* (on/at that/it)
- *auf* → *darauf* (on/upon that/it)
- *aus* → *daraus* (out of that/it)
- *ein* → *darein* (into that/it)
- *in* → *darin* (in that/it)
- *über* → *darüber* (about/over that/it)
- *um* → *darum* (around that/it)
- *unter* → *darunter* (under/among that/it)

QUESTION FORMS (wo- compounds): Replace 'da' with 'wo':

- *womit*, *wofür*, *woran*, *worauf*, *worüber*, *worum*, etc.
- Used to ask questions about things with prepositions

USAGE RULES:

1. THINGS/IDEAS: Use da-compounds
2. PEOPLE/ANIMALS: Use preposition + pronoun (mit ihm, für sie)
3. SUBORDINATE CLAUSES: Da-compound can anticipate a following clause: 'Ich freue mich darauf, dass du kommst' (I'm looking forward to you coming)

EXAMPLES

→ Ich spreche über das Problem. → Ich spreche darüber. (I'm talking about the problem. → I'm talking about it.)

→ Er wartet auf die Antwort. → Er wartet darauf. (He waits for the answer. → He waits for it.)

→ Sie interessiert sich für Kunst. → Sie interessiert sich dafür. (She's interested in art. → She's interested in it.)

→ Wir denken an die Prüfung. → Wir denken daran. BUT: Wir denken an unseren Lehrer. → Wir denken an ihn. (We think about the exam. → We think about it. BUT: We think about our teacher. → We think about him.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' ERRORS:

■ 1. USING FOR PEOPLE: Italian doesn't have this distinction, so speakers incorrectly use da-compounds for people: *Ich spreche damit' when referring to 'mit dem Mann' instead of 'mit ihm'.
RULE: damit = with IT (thing), mit ihm = with HIM (person).

■ 2. FORGETTING THE 'R': Italian speakers forget epenthetic 'r' before vowels: *daauf' instead of 'darauf', *daüber' instead of 'darüber'.

3. LITERAL TRANSLATION: Italian translates prepositions directly (parlare DI qualcosa = sprechen VON/ÜBER etwas). Confusion arises because Italian uses 'di' while German may use different preposition: Italian 'parlare di' → German 'sprechen über' → 'darüber sprechen' (not *davon).

4. OMITTING DA-COMPOUND BEFORE CLAUSES: Italian doesn't require anticipatory pronoun before clauses. German often needs it: *Ich freue mich, dass du kommst' (incomplete) → 'Ich freue mich darauf, dass du kommst'.

5. WRONG PREPOSITION CHOICE: Since German verbs govern specific prepositions differently from Italian: warten AUF (not *für) → darauf warten; sich interessieren FÜR → dafür interessieren.

6. CONFUSING DAMIT (conjunction vs. pronominal): 'damit' as 'with that/it' vs. 'damit' as 'so that'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. PREPOSITIONS WITHOUT DA-COMPOUNDS:

- außer (except) - no compound
- gegenüber (opposite) - rare compound
- seit (since) - no compound with da-
- während (during) - no compound

2. OBSOLETE FORMS:

- darob (thereof) - archaic
- darohne (without that) - obsolete
- darab (therefrom) - obsolete

3. HIER-COMPOUNDS: Similar forms exist with 'hier' (here) instead of 'da': hiermit (herewith), hierfür (for this), hieran (on this) - used mainly in formal/written German.

4. COLLOQUIAL SPLIT: In spoken German, da-compounds can split: 'Da habe ich nicht mit gerechnet' instead of 'Damit habe ich nicht gerechnet' (I didn't reckon with that).

5. PERSONAL REFERENCE: Some contexts allow da-compounds for people in collective/abstract sense: 'die Regierung und was damit verbunden ist' (the government and what's connected with it).

6. VERBS THAT REJECT DA-COMPOUNDS: Some verbs with prepositions cannot use da-compounds and must use full clauses: *'Ich bin mir darüber sicher' is less common than 'Ich bin mir sicher, dass...'

Prepositional adverbs (da- + preposition)

■ Web verified

Prepositional adverbs (Pronominaladverbien) combine 'da' or 'wo' with prepositions to replace prepositional phrases referring to things/ideas (not people): 'darauf' (on/about that), 'darüber' (about that), 'damit' (with that), 'davon' (of/from that). Question forms use 'wo-': 'worauf' (on what), 'worüber' (about what), 'womit' (with what). When preposition starts with vowel, add '-r-': 'daran', 'woran'. Only for things/concepts, never for people.

COMPLETE RULE

FORMATION RULES:

STATEMENTS (referring to things already mentioned):

da + preposition = darauf, dabei, damit, danach, dafür, dagegen

When preposition starts with VOWEL: da + r + preposition = daran, darauf, darüber, darum, daraus, darein

QUESTIONS (asking about things):

wo + preposition = wobei, womit, wonach, wofür, wogegen

When preposition starts with VOWEL: wo + r + preposition = woran, worauf, worüber, worum, woraus, worein

COMMON COMBINATIONS:

- an: daran, woran (on/at that/what)
- auf: darauf, worauf (on/about that/what)
- aus: daraus, woraus (from/out of that/what)

- bei: dabei, wobei (at/with that/what)
- durch: dadurch, wodurch (through that/what)
- für: dafür, wofür (for that/what)
- gegen: dagegen, wogegen (against that/what)
- in: darin/darein, worin (in that/what)
- mit: damit, womit (with that/what)
- nach: danach, wonach (after/according to that/what)
- über: darüber, worüber (about/over that/what)
- um: darum, worum (about/around that/what)
- unter: darunter, worunter (under/among that/what)
- von: davon, wovon (of/from that/what)
- vor: davor, wovor (before/in front of that/what)
- zu: dazu, wozu (to/for that/what)

USAGE RULE: Use ONLY for things/ideas/concepts, NEVER for people

For PEOPLE: use preposition + personal pronoun

Things: 'Ich denke darüber nach' (I think about it)

People: 'Ich denke an ihn' (I think about him)

EXAMPLES

→ Worauf freust du dich? - Ich freue mich darauf. (What are you looking forward to? - I'm looking forward to it/that)

→ **Worüber hast du gesprochen?**

Ich habe darüber gesprochen. (What did you talk about? - I talked about it/that)

→ Womit fährst du? - Mit meinem Motorrad. (What are you traveling with? - With my motorcycle)

→ Ich denke oft daran. (I often think about it/that)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers make these errors: (1) USING WITH PEOPLE: Saying 'Ich spreche darüber' when referring to a person instead of 'Ich spreche über ihn/sie' - Italian doesn't have this restriction. (2) FORGETTING THE 'R': Saying 'daüber' or 'woauf' instead of 'darüber', 'worauf' when preposition starts with vowel. (3) USING PREPOSITION + DAS: Saying 'über das' instead of 'darüber' when referring back to something already mentioned - sounds unnatural. (4) WRONG PREPOSITION: Choosing wrong preposition based on Italian equivalents - 'sich freuen über' (be happy about) vs Italian 'essere contento di' leads to confusion.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some prepositional adverbs have idiomatic meanings: 'dabei sein' (to be present/participating), 'dafür sein' (to be in favor), 'dagegen sein' (to be against). The adverbs with 'hier-' (hieran, hiermit, hierbei) exist but are used mainly in formal/written German. Some verbs require specific prepositional adverbs: 'es kommt darauf an' (it depends on), 'rechnen mit/damit' (to expect/count on). When referring to entire clauses, use prepositional adverb before comma: 'Ich freue mich darauf, dass du kommst' (I'm looking

forward to you coming).

Prepositional verbs with fixed prepositions

■ Web verified

Many German verbs require specific prepositions that must be learned together with the verb. The preposition determines the case of the following noun (dative or accusative). Examples include: *sich freuen auf* + accusative (look forward to), *träumen von* + dative (dream of/about), *leiden an* + dative (suffer from illness), *leiden unter* + dative (suffer from external factors), *sich beschwerten über* + accusative (complain about), *reagieren auf* + accusative (react to), *teilnehmen an* + dative (participate in), *sich unterhalten mit* + dative *über* + accusative (talk with someone about something), *sich verlieben in* + accusative (fall in love with), *sich vorbereiten auf* + accusative (prepare for).

COMPLETE RULE

PREPOSITIONAL VERBS COMPLETE SYSTEM:

WITH ACCUSATIVE (ACC):

- *sich freuen auf* + ACC = look forward to
- *warten auf* + ACC = wait for
- *sich vorbereiten auf* + ACC = prepare for
- *reagieren auf* + ACC = react to
- *antworten auf* + ACC = answer/respond to
- *sich verlieben in* + ACC = fall in love with
- *sich beschwerten über* + ACC = complain about
- *sich ärgern über* + ACC = be annoyed about
- *sich freuen über* + ACC = be happy about
- *denken an* + ACC = think of/about
- *sich erinnern an* + ACC = remember
- *glauben an* + ACC = believe in

WITH DATIVE (DAT):

- *träumen von* + DAT = dream of/about
- *erzählen von* + DAT = tell about
- *abhängen von* + DAT = depend on
- *leiden an* + DAT = suffer from (illness)
- *leiden unter* + DAT = suffer from (conditions)
- *teilnehmen an* + DAT = participate in
- *sich unterhalten mit* + DAT = converse with
- *sprechen mit* + DAT = speak with

- *beginnen mit + DAT = begin with*
- *aufhören mit + DAT = stop doing*

DOUBLE PREPOSITION VERBS:

- *sich unterhalten mit + DAT über + ACC = talk with someone about something*
- *sprechen mit + DAT über + ACC = speak with someone about something*

CASE RULES:

- Always accusative: *für, durch, gegen, ohne, um, an* (in most prepositional verbs)
- Always dative: *aus, bei, mit, nach, von, zu*
- Context-dependent: *an, auf, in, über, unter* (usually accusative with prepositional verbs)

EXAMPLES

- *Ich freue mich sehr auf die Sommerferien. (I'm really looking forward to the summer holidays.)* - *auf* + accusative
- *Sie träumt jede Nacht von ihrem Heimatland. (She dreams every night of her homeland.)*
von + dative
- *Er leidet seit Jahren an Diabetes. (He has suffered from diabetes for years.)*
an + dative for illness
- *Die Studenten nehmen an dem Seminar teil. (The students are participating in the seminar.)* - *an* + dative

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER ERRORS:

- 1. **WRONG PREPOSITION TRANSFER:** Using Italian preposition logic. **Ich warte für dich* instead of *Ich warte auf dich* (I wait for you). Italian: *'aspetto per te'* uses 'per' (for).
- 2. **WRONG CASE AFTER PREPOSITION:** **Ich träume von meinem Freund* (correct) vs **Ich träume von mein Freund* (wrong). Italians struggle with case endings since Italian prepositions don't govern case.
- 3. **OMITTING REFLEXIVE PRONOUN:** **Ich freue auf den Urlaub* instead of *Ich freue mich auf den Urlaub*. Italian: *'Mi rallegro'* requires reflexive, but word order differs.
- 4. **CONFUSING SIMILAR VERBS:** *'sich freuen auf'* (look forward to) vs *'sich freuen über'* (be happy about). Italian uses same verb *'rallegrarsi di'* for both concepts.
- 5. **ADDING UNNECESSARY ARTICLES:** **Ich leide an der Krebs* instead of *Ich leide an Krebs*. Italian often requires articles where German doesn't with abstract nouns.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. VERBS WITH MULTIPLE PREPOSITIONS:

- *denken an + ACC* (think of) vs *denken über + ACC* (think about/have opinion)
- *sich freuen auf + ACC* (look forward to) vs *sich freuen über + ACC* (be happy about)
- *leiden an + DAT* (illness) vs *leiden unter + DAT* (conditions/suffering)

2. PREPOSITION CAN BE OMITTED:

- suchen (search for) vs suchen nach + DAT (search for something abstract)
- antworten + DAT (answer someone) vs antworten auf + ACC (answer/respond to something)

3. REGIONAL VARIATIONS: Some Swiss and Austrian German speakers use different prepositions: 'sich erinnern an' (German) vs 'sich erinnern + genitive' (Swiss formal)

4. VERBS CHANGING MEANING: Same verb + different preposition = different meaning must be memorized separately

Purpose clauses with um...zu

■ Web verified

Used to express purpose or intention ('in order to'). The structure connects a main clause with an infinitive construction. The subject must be the same in both clauses.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: Main clause + comma + um + (other sentence elements) + infinitive verb + zu (inserted between separable prefix and verb if applicable). If subjects differ, use 'damit' + subordinate clause instead. The infinitive with 'zu' is placed at the end. In written language, 'um' can sometimes be omitted without changing meaning, but 'um...zu' is standard. For separable verbs: 'zu' splits the prefix from the verb stem (e.g., wegzulaufen).

EXAMPLES

- Ich gehe nach Monza, um ein Autorennen zu sehen. (I'm going to Monza [in order] to see a car race.)
- Er lernt Deutsch, um in Deutschland zu arbeiten. (He's learning German [in order] to work in Germany.)
- Sie spart Geld, um ein Auto zu kaufen. (She's saving money [in order] to buy a car.)
- Wir sprangen ins Wasser, um uns abzukühlen. (We jumped in the water [in order] to cool down.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often incorrectly use 'für + zu + infinitive' (influenced by Italian 'per + infinitare') instead of 'um...zu'. Another error is forgetting the comma before 'um' or using 'um...zu' when subjects differ (should use 'damit' instead). Confusing word order by placing 'zu' incorrectly.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When the infinitive group is used attributively (as an attribute to a preceding word), only 'zu' is used, not 'um...zu': 'Die Aussicht, eine Woche auszuspinnen' (the prospect of relaxing for a week). With modal verb meaning, no 'um' is used. 'Ohne...zu' expresses 'without + gerund'.

Reflexive pronoun with kaufen

■ Web verified

When buying something for oneself, German uses reflexive pronoun in DATIVE case: 'Ich kaufe mir ein Motorrad' (I buy myself a motorcycle). The reflexive dative pronoun indicates the action benefits the subject. This occurs when the verb already has an accusative object (the thing bought), so the reflexive becomes dative.

COMPLETE RULE

REFLEXIVE PRONOUNS - Accusative: *mich, dich, sich, uns, euch, sich*. Dative: *mir, dir, sich, uns, euch, sich*. **RULE:** Normally reflexive pronouns are accusative (*ich wasche mich*). **BUT** when the verb already has an accusative object, the reflexive pronoun becomes DATIVE. **Structure:** Subject + Verb + DATIVE reflexive + ACCUSATIVE object. Common dative reflexive verbs: *sich (dat.) etwas (acc.) kaufen* (to buy oneself something), *sich (dat.) die Hände waschen* (to wash one's hands), *sich (dat.) die Zähne putzen* (to brush one's teeth), *sich (dat.) etwas vorstellen* (to imagine something), *sich (dat.) die Haare kämmen* (to comb one's hair), *sich (dat.) etwas anziehen* (to put something on). The dative reflexive shows the action is done to/for the subject's benefit.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich habe mir ein Motorrad gekauft. (I bought myself a motorcycle)*
- *Ich wasche mir die Hände. (I wash my hands)*
literally: I wash to-myself the hands)
- *Sie kämmt sich die Haare. (She combs her hair)*
- *Kannst du dir das vorstellen? (Can you imagine that? - to yourself)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers struggle with this because Italian doesn't distinguish accusative/dative reflexive pronouns (both use 'mi, ti, si, ci, vi, si'). Common errors: (1) Using accusative instead of dative: *'Ich kaufe mich ein Auto' instead of 'Ich kaufe mir ein Auto'. (2) Omitting the reflexive entirely: *'Ich kaufe ein Auto' (grammatically correct but changes meaning - doesn't emphasize 'for myself'). (3) With body parts, forgetting dative reflexive: *'Ich wasche die Hände' instead of 'Ich wasche mir die Hände'. (4) Confusion about when to use dative: if there's no accusative object, use accusative reflexive (Ich wasche mich).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some reflexive verbs **ALWAYS** require dative even though there's no visible accusative object: *sich (dat.) etwas einbilden* (to imagine falsely), *sich (dat.) etwas vornehmen* (to resolve to do something), *sich (dat.) etwas vorstellen* (to imagine). These are true dative reflexive verbs. Note: The distinction matters only for 'ich' (mich/mir) and 'du' (dich/dir); all other persons use 'sich' for both cases.

Reflexive verb: sich Sorgen machen

■ Web verified

To express worry or concern, German uses the fixed expression 'sich Sorgen machen' (literally: to make oneself worries). The noun 'Sorgen' is ALWAYS plural in this construction. Structure: subject + reflexive pronoun (dative: mir/dir/sich/uns/euch/sich) + Sorgen machen. While 'sich sorgen (um)' exists, 'sich Sorgen machen' is far more common and natural in everyday German.

COMPLETE RULE

Full conjugation: ich mache mir Sorgen, du machst dir Sorgen, er/sie/es macht sich Sorgen, wir machen uns Sorgen, ihr macht euch Sorgen, sie/Sie machen sich Sorgen. The reflexive pronoun is in DATIVE case. Optional: add 'um + accusative' to specify what you worry about (sich Sorgen machen um etwas/jemanden).

EXAMPLES

- *Ich mache mir große Sorgen um Torsten. (I'm deeply worried about Torsten.)*
- *Der Junge macht sich Sorgen. (The boy is worried.)*
- *Machst du dir Sorgen? (Are you worried?)*
- *Mach dir keine Sorgen! (Don't worry!)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use singular 'Sorge' instead of plural 'Sorgen' (influenced by Italian 'preoccupazione'); using accusative reflexive pronouns instead of dative (*sich Sorgen machen instead of mir/dir/sich Sorgen machen); trying to use 'sich sorgen' which is less common and sounds more formal/literary; forgetting the reflexive pronoun entirely

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The verb 'sich sorgen (um)' exists and means the same thing, but is less commonly used and sounds more formal or literary. Example: 'sich um jemanden sorgen' (to worry about someone). Both are grammatically correct, but 'sich Sorgen machen' is strongly preferred in spoken and everyday German.

Reflexive verbs with dative prepositions: sich streiten (mit), wütend sein (auf + Akkusativ)

■ Web verified

Reflexive verbs in German require a reflexive pronoun (mich, dich, sich, uns, euch) that refers back to the subject. The verb 'sich streiten' (to argue) is a reciprocal reflexive verb used in plural forms meaning 'to argue with each other.' When combined with prepositions, the preposition determines the case of the following object. The adjective 'wütend sein' (to be angry) uses 'auf + Akkusativ' when directing anger at a person, and 'über + Akkusativ' when angry about a thing or situation.

COMPLETE RULE

REFLEXIVE PRONOUNS:

Accusative: *mich, dich, sich, uns, euch, sich*

Dative: *mir, dir, sich, uns, euch, sich*

SICH STREITEN (to argue) - Reciprocal use:

Present: *ich streite mich, du streitest dich, er/sie/es streitet sich, wir streiten uns, ihr streitet euch, sie streiten sich*

Perfect: *ich habe mich gestritten, du hast dich gestritten, etc.*

Preposition: *sich streiten mit + Dativ (to argue with someone)*

Example: *Sie streitet sich mit ihrer Schwester.*

WÜTEND SEIN (to be angry) - Adjective with prepositions:

wütend sein auf + Akkusativ (angry at a person): Er ist wütend auf seinen Kollegen.

wütend sein über + Akkusativ (angry about something): Sie ist wütend über die Verspätung.

Note: The reflexive pronoun 'sich' in 3rd person (singular and plural) remains the same in both Accusative and Dative cases.

EXAMPLES

→ *Die zwei Männer streiten sich über Politik. (The two men are arguing about politics.)*

→ *Ich streite mich oft mit meinem Bruder. (I often argue with my brother.)*

→ *Er ist sehr wütend auf seinen Chef. (He is very angry at his boss.)*

→ *Sie ist wütend über die Entscheidung. (She is angry about the decision.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: 1) Forgetting the reflexive pronoun entirely, as many German reflexive verbs are not reflexive in Italian (e.g., 'litigare' vs 'sich streiten'). Italian: 'Loro litigano' → Incorrect German: **'Sie streiten'* → Correct: *'Sie streiten sich.'* 2) Using the wrong preposition because Italian uses different prepositions: Italian 'arrabbiato con qualcuno' uses 'con' (with), but German uses 'auf' (on). Incorrect: **'wütend mit dem Mann'* → Correct: *'wütend auf den Mann.'* 3) Using the wrong case after the preposition - Italian speakers may default to Dative when Accusative is required. Incorrect: **'wütend auf dem Mann'* → Correct: *'wütend auf den Mann'* (Akkusativ). 4) In compound tenses, Italian reflexive verbs always use 'essere' as auxiliary, while German reflexive verbs use 'haben': Italian 'si sono arrabbiati' → German 'sie haben sich gestritten' (NOT **sie sind sich gestritten*).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some reflexive verbs can take the reflexive pronoun in either Accusative or Dative depending on whether there is an additional Accusative object in the sentence. Example: 'sich waschen' (Akk.) → 'Ich wasche mich,' but 'sich die Hände waschen' (Dat.) → 'Ich wasche mir die Hände.' However, 'sich streiten' is always Accusative because it doesn't take a direct object. The adjective 'böse' can also mean angry and uses the same construction: 'böse auf + Akkusativ.'

Reflexive verbs with prepositions

■ Web verified

Many German verbs that require prepositions are also reflexive. The reflexive pronoun (mich, dich, sich, uns, euch, sich) comes after the conjugated verb and before the preposition. Common patterns: sich freuen auf/über, sich erinnern an, sich interessieren für, sich ärgern über, sich gewöhnen an.

COMPLETE RULE

REFLEXIVE PRONOUNS:

Accusative: mich, dich, sich, uns, euch, sich

Dative: mir, dir, sich, uns, euch, sich

(Only ich/du forms differ between accusative/dative)

WORD ORDER:

1. Main clause: Subject + verb + reflexive pronoun + preposition + object

Ich interessiere mich für Musik.

2. Question: Verb + subject + reflexive pronoun + preposition + object

Interessierst du dich für Kunst?

3. Subordinate clause: Subject + reflexive pronoun + preposition + object + verb

..., weil ich mich für Geschichte interessiere.

COMMON REFLEXIVE VERBS + PREPOSITIONS (ACCUSATIVE):

- *sich freuen auf/über (look forward to/be happy about)*
- *sich interessieren für (be interested in)*
- *sich erinnern an (remember)*
- *sich kümmern um (take care of)*
- *sich ärgern über (be annoyed about)*
- *sich gewöhnen an (get used to)*
- *sich konzentrieren auf (concentrate on)*
- *sich verlieben in (fall in love with)*
- *sich entscheiden für (decide on)*
- *sich beschweren über (complain about)*

COMMON REFLEXIVE VERBS + PREPOSITIONS (DATIVE):

- *sich vorstellen (+ Dat object, not preposition - special case)*

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich interessiere mich sehr für klassische Musik. (I'm very interested in classical music.)*

→ *Erinnerst du dich an das Wort? (Do you remember the word?)*

→ *Sie haben sich an die neue Umgebung gewöhnt. (They got used to the new environment.)*

→ *Wir freuen uns riesig auf den Urlaub. (We're really looking forward to the vacation.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers typically make these errors:

- **1. FORGETTING REFLEXIVE PRONOUN:** Italian verbs like 'interessarsi' are reflexive, but speakers forget German 'sich' (*Ich interessiere für Musik instead of mich für Musik). English equivalents aren't reflexive, compounding confusion.
- **2. WRONG PREPOSITION:** Italian uses different prepositions (*sich interessieren in/di instead of FÜR, *sich erinnern di instead of AN)
- **3. WRONG PRONOUN POSITION:** Placing reflexive pronoun after preposition (*Ich interessiere für mich instead of mich für)
- 4. CONFUSING ACCUSATIVE/DATIVE:** Most reflexive verbs with prepositions use accusative reflexive pronouns, but Italian speakers may use dative by analogy with Italian indirect objects
- **5. FORGETTING 'SICH' IN INFINITIVE:** Writing just 'freuen' instead of 'sich freuen' when noting vocabulary

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

- 1. With da-/wo-compounds for things:** Wofür interessierst du dich? - Ich interessiere mich dafür.
- 2. Separable reflexive verbs:** prefix goes to end: 'sich umschauen' → Ich schaue mich um.
- 3. With modal verbs:** reflexive pronoun comes after modal: Ich muss mich daran erinnern.
- 4. Some verbs can be reflexive OR non-reflexive with different meanings:** erinnern (remind someone) vs. sich erinnern (remember)
- 5. When object is pronoun, word order changes:** Ich interessiere mich dafür (thing) vs. Interessierst du dich für ihn? (person)
- 6. A few take dative reflexive when another accusative object is present:** Ich stelle mir das vor (I imagine that)

Regular verb conjugation

■ From lesson

Regular verbs in German follow a predictable pattern: take the infinitive stem (remove -en) and add personal endings: -e, -st, -t, -en, -t, -en

COMPLETE RULE

For verbs with stems ending in -t or -d (like arbeiten), add an extra -e- before the ending for smoother pronunciation: du arbeitest, er arbeitet

EXAMPLES

→ *arbeiten: ich arbeite, du arbeitest, er arbeitet*

→ *spielen: ich spiele, du spielst, er spielt*

→ *kaufen: ich kaufe, du kaufst, er kauft*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting the extra -e- in verbs like *warten*: *Er wartt* → *Er wartet*

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular verbs like *sein*, *haben*, and modal verbs have different conjugation patterns

Relative clauses review with indefinite pronouns

■ Web verified

Indefinite pronouns (*jemand*, *niemand*, *etwas*, *nichts*, *alles*) can serve as antecedents for relative clauses. With *alles/nichts/etwas*, use relative pronoun 'was' (not *der/die/das*). With *jemand/niemand*, use 'der/die' forms. Relative pronouns must agree in gender, number, and case. Verb goes to end of relative clause; comma separates clauses.

COMPLETE RULE

RELATIVE PRONOUNS TABLE: Masculine: *der* (nom.), *den* (acc.), *dem* (dat.), *dessen* (gen.). Feminine: *die* (nom.), *die* (acc.), *der* (dat.), *deren* (gen.). Neuter: *das* (nom.), *das* (acc.), *dem* (dat.), *dessen* (gen.). Plural (all genders): *die* (nom.), *die* (acc.), *denen* (dat.), *deren* (gen.). **SPECIAL RELATIVE PRONOUN 'WAS':** Used after: *alles* (all/everything), *nichts* (nothing), *etwas* (something), *viel/vieles* (much), *das* (the thing/that which), and after entire clauses. **STRUCTURE:** Antecedent + comma + relative pronoun + middle field + verb (end). **INDEFINITE PRONOUNS:** *jemand/niemand* (someone/no one - declinable, refers to people, use 'der' forms), *etwas/nichts* (something/nothing - invariable, use 'was'), *alles* (everything - use 'was'), *jeder* (everyone - fully declinable). The relative pronoun's case depends on its function **WITHIN** the relative clause, not the main clause.

EXAMPLES

→ *Gibt es jemanden, der hier Chinesisch spricht?* (Is there someone who speaks Chinese here?)

→ *Alles, was du sagst, ist falsch.* (Everything that you say is wrong)

→ *Niemand, dem ich vertraue, würde das tun.* (No one whom I trust would do that)

→ *Ich brauche etwas, was mir hilft.* (I need something that helps me)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers struggle with: (1) Using 'der/die/das' after indefinite pronouns instead of 'was': *'Alles, das ich sage' instead of 'Alles, was ich sage' (Everything that I say). (2) Verb placement: *'Der Mann, der hier spricht Chinesisch' instead of 'Der Mann, der hier Chinesisch spricht' (forgetting verb-final). (3) Missing comma: *'Jemand der hilft' instead of 'Jemand, der hilft'. (4) Wrong case: choosing case based on main clause instead of relative clause function. (5) With *jemand/niemand*,

forgetting these can take optional case endings: 'jemand(em)' in dative.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

After *alles*, *nichts*, *etwas*, and neuter demonstratives (*das*, *dasjenige*, *dasselbe*), **MUST** use 'was' as relative pronoun, never 'das'. After superlatives used as nouns (*das Beste*, *das Schönste*), also use 'was'. When referring to an entire preceding clause, use 'was': 'Er kam zu spät, was mich ärgerte' (He came late, which annoyed me). With *jemand/niemand*, the endings in dative/accusative are optional: 'jemand, den/dem ich kenne' or 'jemand, dem/dem ich kenne'. The relative pronoun 'welcher' exists but is rarely used, mostly to avoid repetition of 'der'.

Relative clauses with 'in dem'

■ Web verified

'In dem' (in which, in that, when) introduces relative clauses referring to a moment, situation, or enclosed space. The relative pronoun must agree in gender and number with its antecedent, while its case is determined by its grammatical function within the relative clause. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the relative clause. Preposition + relative pronoun combinations are common when the verb in the relative clause requires that preposition.

COMPLETE RULE

STRUCTURE: Main clause + comma + [preposition + relative pronoun] + middle field + VERB(end).
Relative pronouns: Masculine: *der* (nom), *den* (acc), *dem* (dat), *dessen* (gen). Feminine: *die* (nom), *die* (acc), *der* (dat), *deren* (gen). Neuter: *das* (nom), *das* (acc), *dem* (dat), *dessen* (gen). Plural: *die* (nom), *die* (acc), *denen* (dat), *deren* (gen). **WITH PREPOSITIONS:** The preposition governs the case of the relative pronoun: 'in dem Moment' (in+dat), 'mit der' (mit+dat), 'für den' (für+acc). Common patterns: 'in dem' (in which/when - dative masculine/neuter), 'in der' (in which/when - dative feminine), 'mit dem' (with which - dative masc/neut), 'von dem' (of which - dative). **VERB POSITION:** Conjugated verb ALWAYS at the end of relative clause.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe sie in dem Moment getroffen, in dem sie gehen mussten.* (I met them at the moment in which they had to leave)

→ *Der Kunde, mit dem ich gerade gesprochen habe, ist Deutscher.* (The client with whom I just spoke is German)

→ *Das Haus, in dem ich wohne, ist sehr alt.* (The house in which I live is very old)

→ *Der Tag, an dem wir uns kennengelernt haben, war schön.* (The day on which we met was beautiful)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often forget to move the verb to the end of the relative clause, keeping English/Italian word order: *'in dem Moment, in dem sie mussten gehen' (incorrect) instead of 'in dem

sie gehen mussten'. Case errors: using wrong case for relative pronoun based on antecedent instead of function: *'der Moment, in das sie...' (incorrect - should be 'in dem' because 'in' takes dative). Omitting preposition when German verb requires it: *'der Moment, den ich wartete' instead of 'auf den ich wartete' (waiting FOR). Confusing 'das' (relative pronoun) with 'dass' (conjunction).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some relative clauses can be introduced by 'wo' (where) instead of a prepositional phrase, especially with places: 'das Haus, wo ich wohne' (more colloquial) vs. 'das Haus, in dem ich wohne' (more formal). Genitive relative pronouns 'dessen/deren' do not change and are not used with prepositions - they directly modify a noun: 'der Mann, dessen Auto...' (the man whose car...). In very formal German, 'welcher/welche/welches' can replace 'der/die/das' as relative pronouns.

Relative clauses with 'was'

■ Web verified

'Was' is used as a relative pronoun when referring to indefinite pronouns (alles, etwas, nichts), neuter superlatives (das Beste, das Schönste), or entire clauses. It introduces a subordinate clause, so the conjugated verb moves to the end. Example: 'alles, was er hat' = 'everything that he has'.

COMPLETE RULE

WHEN TO USE 'WAS' AS RELATIVE PRONOUN:

1. After indefinite pronouns in neuter: *alles, nichts, etwas, vieles, wenig, manches, allerlei*
2. After neuter superlatives: *das Beste, das Schönste, das Größte*
3. After demonstrative pronouns: *das, dasjenige, dasselbe*
4. After substantivized adjectives/participles (when expressing something general/indefinite)
5. When referring to an entire clause

FORM: 'was' is invariable (does not change for gender, number, or case in standard usage)

Nominative/Accusative: *was*

Genitive: *wessen* (rare)

With prepositions: use *wo*-compounds (*wofür, worauf, etc.*)

WORD ORDER: The conjugated verb goes to the end of the relative clause.

EXAMPLES

- *Alles, was er sagt, ist wahr. (Everything that he says is true.)*
- *Das ist das Beste, was ich je gesehen habe. (That is the best thing that I have ever seen.)*
- *Er hat nichts, was wichtig ist. (He has nothing that is important.)*
- *Das, was du mir erzählt hast, glaube ich nicht. (What you told me, I don't believe.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. Using 'che' thinking pattern - forgetting that 'was' is specifically for indefinite/neuter contexts, not all relative clauses
 - 2. Using 'das' instead of 'was' after alles, nichts, etwas (Italian: tutto che → German: alles, was NOT alles, das)
3. Not moving the verb to the end of the clause (Italian word order influence)
4. Trying to decline 'was' like Italian relative pronouns
5. Omitting the relative pronoun (possible in Italian: 'tutto quello ho' but German requires: 'alles, was ich habe')

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTION: After 'etwas', both 'was' and 'das' are acceptable to avoid repetition: 'etwas, was/das du wissen solltest'. In regional dialects (Westfälisch, Nordniederdeutsch, Obersächsisch), 'was' may be used more broadly than in standard German.

Relative clauses with relative pronouns (Relativsätze)

■ Web verified

Relative clauses provide additional information about a noun in the main sentence. The relative pronoun (der/die/das/dem/den/denen) agrees in gender and number with the noun it refers to, but its case depends on its function within the relative clause. The conjugated verb always goes to the end of the relative clause, and the clause is set off by commas.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete Declension Table of Relative Pronouns:

Masculine: Nominative: der, Accusative: den, Dative: dem, Genitive: dessen

Feminine: Nominative: die, Accusative: die, Dative: der, Genitive: deren

Neuter: Nominative: das, Accusative: das, Dative: dem, Genitive: dessen

Plural (all genders): Nominative: die, Accusative: die, Dative: denen, Genitive: deren

Key Rules:

1. Gender and number: Match the antecedent (noun being referred to)
2. Case: Determined by function in the relative clause (subject = nominative, direct object = accusative, indirect object = dative)
3. Word order: Verb always at the end of relative clause
4. Punctuation: Always separated by commas
5. With prepositions: Preposition + relative pronoun at start of clause; case determined by preposition
6. Alternative form: welcher/welche/welches (used to avoid repetition; no genitive forms)

EXAMPLES

- *Das Paar, das ein Problem mit dem Dach hat, wohnt im vierten Stock.* (nominative - das is subject of relative clause)
- *Der Mann, den ich gestern getroffen habe, ist mein Lehrer.* (accusative - den is direct object)
- *Die Frau, der ich das Geschenk gegeben habe, ist sehr nett.* (dative - der is indirect object)
- *Das sind die Freunde, mit denen ich viel Zeit verbringe.* (dative plural with preposition - denen after mit)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

- 1. Using the wrong case by basing it on the main clause instead of the relative clause function
- 2. **Forgetting to place the verb at the end of the relative clause (Italian keeps normal word order)**
- 3. Using 'den' instead of 'denen' for dative plural
- 4. **Omitting the relative pronoun (possible in English and Italian but never in German)**
- 5. **Separating the relative clause too far from its antecedent**
- 6. **Confusing relative pronouns with demonstrative pronouns**

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

- 1. **Genitive forms: dessen (masculine/neuter) and deren (feminine/plural) indicate possession**
- 2. **With prepositions: The preposition determines the case (in dem, mit denen, an die, über den)**
- 3. **Referring to entire clauses: Use 'was' instead of der/die/das (Er hat bestanden, was mich freut)**
- 4. **Referring to places: Can use 'wo' instead of preposition + relative pronoun (Das Restaurant, wo wir gegessen haben)**
- 5. **Two-way prepositions in fixed verb combinations keep their required case regardless of motion/location**

Relative pronouns with prepositions in relative clauses

■ Web verified

When a relative clause contains a verb with a required preposition or expresses a prepositional relationship, the preposition must appear directly before the relative pronoun at the beginning of the relative clause. The preposition determines the case of the relative pronoun. For plural dative, the special form 'denen' (not 'den') must be used.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: [Main clause] + [noun], [Preposition] + [Relative Pronoun in required case] + [rest of clause] + [verb at end].

Case determination:

- Accusative prepositions (für, durch, gegen, ohne, um): always accusative
- Dative prepositions (aus, bei, mit, nach, von, zu): always dative
- Two-way prepositions (an, auf, in, über, unter, etc.): case determined by verb combination or context

Special Dative Plural Form:

- **MUST** use 'denen' (not 'den') for dative plural
- Die Leute, mit denen ich arbeite (NOT mit den)

Preposition placement:

- Comes directly before relative pronoun
- Cannot be separated or moved to end of clause
- Modern standard: in dem ich wohne (NOT dem ich wohne in)

With fixed verb-preposition combinations:

- The preposition from the verb combination must appear: sprechen über → über den/die/das
- Case is determined by the preposition, not by the verb's usual object case

EXAMPLES

→ Es gibt ein Büro, in dem man Steuern bezahlen kann. (There's an office in which one can pay taxes
- in + dative)

→ **Wo wohnen die Leute, mit denen ich gestern gefeiert habe?** (Where do the people live with whom I celebrated yesterday?)

mit + dative plural = denen)

→ **Das ist die Frau, für die ich das Geschenk gekauft habe.** (That's the woman for whom I bought the gift)

für + accusative)

→ Das Restaurant, über das wir gesprochen haben, ist sehr gut. (The restaurant we talked about is very good - sprechen über + accusative)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

- 1. Using 'den' instead of 'denen' for dative plural (most common error)
2. Placing the preposition at the end of the clause (English/Italian influence)
3. Separating the preposition from the relative pronoun
4. Using the wrong case after two-way prepositions
5. Forgetting the preposition when the verb requires it in German but not in Italian
6. Confusing the preposition required by the verb with spatial prepositions

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. Genitive prepositions are rare: Das Auto, wegen dessen ich zu spät kam (The car because of which I was late)
2. Alternative with 'wo': For places, can use 'wo' instead of preposition + pronoun: Das Haus, wo ich wohne (instead of in dem)
3. Referring to entire clauses: Use wo(r) + preposition: Er kam zu spät, worüber ich mich geärgert habe
4. When preposition doesn't relate to relative pronoun: Keep normal position: Die Frau, die in dem Geschäft ein Eis kauft (in relates to Geschäft, not to relative pronoun)
5. Fixed verb combinations override logical preposition choice: denken an (not über) even when English is 'about'

Reporting with 'dass'

■ Web verified

When reporting what someone says or knows (not a question), use 'dass' to introduce the subordinate clause. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the clause. The 'dass' clause expresses relative certainty and is used for reporting feelings, opinions, judgments, thoughts, knowledge, and indirect speech. A comma always separates the main clause from the 'dass' clause.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE:

1. **STRUCTURE:** Main clause + comma + dass + subject + other elements (time, manner, place) + conjugated verb
2. **VERB POSITION:** The conjugated verb ALWAYS goes to the final position in the dass-clause
3. **WITH MODAL VERBS:** Infinitive precedes modal verb at end
Example: Ich weiß, dass er Deutsch lernen will.
4. **WITH PERFECT TENSE:** Past participle precedes auxiliary verb
Example: Sie sagt, dass sie in Berlin gewohnt hat.
5. **COMMA RULE:** A comma is mandatory before 'dass' - never optional in German
6. **WORD ORDER WITHIN CLAUSE:** Subject + Time + Cause + Manner + Place + Verb (TeKaMoLo)
7. **NEGATION:** 'nicht' typically goes before the verb at the end
Example: Ich weiß, dass er nicht kommt.
8. **WHEN DASS-CLAUSE COMES FIRST:** Entire subordinate clause = position 1, main verb immediately follows comma
Example: Dass er kommt, weiß ich.
9. **CANNOT BE OMITTED:** Unlike English 'that', German 'dass' can never be dropped
10. **SPELLING:** Always 'dass' (double 's') as conjunction, NOT 'das' (article/pronoun)

EXAMPLES

- *Ich weiß, dass mein Freund bald kommt. (I know that my friend is coming soon.)*
- *Er sagt, dass er zu Hause bleibt. (He says that he is staying at home.)*
- *Sie glaubt, dass das Wetter morgen schön wird. (She believes that the weather will be nice tomorrow.)*
- *Der Lehrer erklärt, dass wir die Hausaufgaben machen müssen. (The teacher explains that we must do the homework.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. KEEPING MAIN CLAUSE WORD ORDER: Italian keeps standard word order in subordinate clauses. Germans send verb to end.

■ **WRONG:** Ich weiß, dass er kommt bald.

■ **CORRECT:** Ich weiß, dass er bald kommt.

(Italian influence: 'So che viene presto' - verb stays in middle)

2. FORGETTING THE COMMA: Italian uses fewer commas than German.

■ **WRONG:** Ich denke dass er recht hat.

■ **CORRECT:** Ich denke, dass er recht hat.

3. OMITTING 'DASS': Italian speakers may drop 'che' in speech, but German 'dass' is always required.

■ **WRONG:** Ich hoffe, er kommt.

■ **CORRECT:** Ich hoffe, dass er kommt.

4. CONFUSING 'DASS' AND 'DAS': Italians confuse these homophones.

■ **WRONG:** Ich weiß, das er kommt. (das = article)

■ **CORRECT:** Ich weiß, dass er kommt. (dass = conjunction)

5. WRONG MODAL VERB POSITION: Placing conjugated modal before infinitive.

■ **WRONG:** Ich weiß, dass er will Deutsch lernen.

■ **CORRECT:** Ich weiß, dass er Deutsch lernen will.

6. WRONG INVERSION AFTER FRONT-PLACED DASS-CLAUSE:

■ **WRONG:** Dass er kommt, ich weiß.

■ **CORRECT:** Dass er kommt, weiß ich.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. PERFECT TENSE WITH MODAL VERBS: Conjugated auxiliary 'haben' goes BEFORE two infinitives (very irregular)

Example: Ich weiß, dass er hat kommen können. (Though most Germans use simple past to avoid this)

2. VERBS 'LASSEN', 'SEHEN', 'HÖREN': Same exception as modal verbs with perfect tense

Example: Ich weiß, dass er das Auto hat reparieren lassen.

3. ELLIPTICAL CONSTRUCTIONS: 'dass' can sometimes be dropped in colloquial speech after certain verbs like 'annehmen', but this is informal

4. REPORTED SPEECH ALTERNATIVE: Konjunktiv I can replace dass-clauses in formal reported speech

Example: Er sagt, er komme morgen. (instead of: Er sagt, dass er morgen kommt.)

5. INFORMAL SPOKEN GERMAN: Some native speakers use main clause order after 'dass' in casual speech, but this is considered INCORRECT in writing and formal contexts

6. 'OB' INSTEAD OF 'DASS': When expressing uncertainty (whether/if), use 'ob' not 'dass'

Example: Ich weiß nicht, ob er kommt. (I don't know if/whether he's coming.)

7. DASS-CLAUSES AS COMPLEMENTS: Often replace accusative objects and make no sense without the main clause

Example: Er glaubt das. → Er glaubt, dass es wahr ist.

schauen vs. anschauen - with/without object

■ Web verified

The verb 'schauen' means 'to look' without requiring a specific object (intransitive). When you want to 'look at' something specific, use 'anschauen' with the accusative object. The reflexive 'sich anschauen' (dative reflexive) emphasizes you're watching/looking at something for yourself.

COMPLETE RULE

Conjugation patterns:

schauen: ich schaue, du schaust, er schaut - intransitive, no object required

anschauen: ich schaue...an, du schaust...an (separable) - requires accusative object

sich anschauen: ich schaue mir...an, du schaust dir...an - dative reflexive + accusative object

Regional variation:

- Northern Germany: 'gucken/angucken' more common (colloquial)

- Southern Germany/Austria: 'schauen/anschauen' preferred

- Standard/Formal: 'sehen/ansetzen' most formal

Structure: *schauen* (no object) vs. *anschauen* (+ accusative) vs. *sich* (dative) *anschauen* (+ accusative)

EXAMPLES

→ *Schau!* (Look! - no object, imperative)

→ *Ich schaue aus dem Fenster.* (I look out the window

direction, no direct object)

→ *Ich schaue den Eiffelturm an. (I look at the Eiffel Tower*

accusative object with prefix)

→ *Ich schaue mir den Film an. (I watch the film for myself*

dative reflexive 'mir' + accusative 'den Film')

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers use 'schauen' with a direct object like 'guardare qualcosa' → 'Ich schaue den Film' (incorrect or regional only). Standard German requires: 'Ich schaue den Film an' or 'Ich schaue mir den Film an'. Also forgetting 'an' separates: 'Ich schaue den Film an' NOT 'Ich anschau den Film'. Confusing with 'ansehen' (more formal) vs 'anschauen' (more casual).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'Schauen' can take objects in Southern German dialects without 'an', but this is non-standard. In Standard German, always use 'anschauen' or 'ansehen' for specific objects. With people, 'ansehen' (to look at someone, make eye contact) is preferred over 'anschauen' (implies longer, evaluative looking). For TV/movies, both work but 'sich ansehen' is most common: 'Wir sehen uns einen Film an'.

sich entschuldigen bei jemandem

■ Web verified

The reflexive verb 'sich entschuldigen' (to apologize) requires the preposition 'bei' followed by the dative case to indicate the person to whom you are apologizing. The structure is: sich entschuldigen bei + Dativ.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete conjugation with 'bei + Dativ':

PRÄSENS:

ich entschuldige mich bei dir/ihm/ihr

du entschuldigst dich bei mir/ihm/ihr

er/sie/es entschuldigt sich bei mir/dir/uns

wir entschuldigen uns bei euch/ihnen

ihr entschuldigt euch bei uns/ihnen

sie entschuldigen sich bei mir/dir/uns

PRÄTERITUM:

ich entschuldigte mich bei dir/ihm/ihr

du entschuldigtest dich bei mir/ihm/ihr

er/sie/es entschuldigte sich bei mir/dir/uns

wir entschuldigten uns bei euch/ihnen

ihr entschuldigtet euch bei uns/ihnen
sie entschuldigten sich bei mir/dir/uns

PERFEKT:

ich habe mich bei dir/ihm/ihr entschuldigt
du hast dich bei mir/ihm/ihr entschuldigt
er/sie/es hat sich bei mir/dir/uns entschuldigt
wir haben uns bei euch/ihnen entschuldigt
ihr habt euch bei uns/ihnen entschuldigt
sie haben sich bei mir/dir/uns entschuldigt

Alternative with 'für' or 'wegen': *sich entschuldigen für etwas* (for something) / *wegen etwas* (because of something)

Example: *Ich entschuldige mich bei dir für meinen Fehler.* (I apologize to you for my mistake.)

EXAMPLES

- *Ich entschuldige mich bei Ihnen für die Verspätung.* (I apologize to you for the delay.)
- *Sie hat sich bei mir entschuldigt.* (She apologized to me.)
- *Wir müssen uns bei dem Lehrer entschuldigen.* (We have to apologize to the teacher.)
- *Er entschuldigt sich bei seinen Eltern wegen seines Verhaltens.* (He apologizes to his parents for his behavior.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may omit 'bei' or confuse it with other prepositions because Italian uses 'scusarsi con qualcuno' (con = with). They might say 'Ich entschuldige mich dir' instead of 'Ich entschuldige mich bei dir', or use the wrong case after 'bei'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When you're excusing someone else (not yourself), 'entschuldigen' is not reflexive: 'Ich entschuldige meinen Sohn' (I excuse my son). Also, the polite request 'Entschuldigung!' (Excuse me!) or 'Entschuldigen Sie!' does not require 'bei'.

Subordinate clause with 'indem' (by doing)

■ Web verified

'Indem' is a subordinating conjunction meaning 'by doing' or 'while doing' (instrumental/simultaneous). It introduces a subordinate clause explaining how an action is performed. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the clause.

COMPLETE RULE

FUNCTION: 'indem' introduces an instrumental subordinate clause (shows means/method)

Meaning: 'by doing', 'in that', 'by means of'

STRUCTURE:

Main clause, indem + subject + (other elements) + VERB.

OR

Indem + subject + (other elements) + VERB, VERB + subject + (rest of main clause).

WORD ORDER:

- 'indem' = position 0 (introduces clause)
- Subject follows
- Conjugated verb goes to END of subordinate clause
- Comma separates clauses

TYPICAL USE: Explaining method/means by which something is accomplished

EXAMPLES

→ *Sie helfen Nico, indem sie eine Annonce im Radio machen. (They help Nico by making an announcement on the radio.)*

→ *Er lernt Deutsch, indem er Videos schaut. (He learns German by watching videos.)*

→ *Du kannst Geld sparen, indem du weniger kaufst. (You can save money by buying less.)*

→ *Er hat viel Geld sparen können, indem er einen Teil der Arbeit selbst gemacht hat. (He was able to save a lot of money by doing part of the work himself.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. **Confusing 'indem' with 'in dem' (in which - relative clause with preposition)**
2. **Not moving verb to end (Italian: 'facendo questo' vs German: 'indem man das macht')**
 - 3. Using gerund construction from Italian instead of indem-clause
4. **Forgetting the comma before 'indem'**
5. **Confusing with 'während' (while - temporal) - 'indem' is about HOW, not WHEN**
 - 6. Word order: placing verb in position 2 instead of at the end

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTION: In older or literary German, 'indem' can also mean 'while' (temporal), but this usage is becoming archaic. Modern German prefers 'während' for temporal simultaneity. With modal verbs in subordinate clause, the conjugated modal goes to the end: 'indem er es machen kann' (by being able to do it).

Subordinate clause with 'sodass' (so that, with the result that)

■ Web verified

'Sodass' (or 'so dass') is a subordinating conjunction that introduces a consecutive clause (Konsekutivsatz) expressing the result or consequence of the action in the main clause. As with all subordinate clauses in German, the conjugated verb moves to the end of the clause. The main clause and subordinate clause are separated by a comma. An alternative form 'so...dass' can be used to emphasize the intensity or degree of the action leading to the consequence.

COMPLETE RULE

STRUCTURE: Main Clause + comma + sodass + Subject + Other Elements + Conjugated Verb (at end)

CONJUGATED VERB POSITION:

- In main clause: Position 2 (standard German word order)
- In subordinate clause with 'sodass': Final position

VARIATIONS:

1. 'sodass' (one word) - standard form introducing direct consequence
2. 'so...dass' - emphasizes degree/intensity in main clause

Structure: Main clause with 'so' + adjective/adverb, dass + subordinate clause

EXAMPLE CONJUGATION:

Present: Es regnet stark, sodass wir nicht ausgehen können.

Perfect: Er hat alles gegessen, sodass nichts übrig geblieben ist.

With modal: Sie arbeitet so viel, sodass sie keine Freizeit haben kann.

ALTERNATIVE EXPRESSIONS (consecutive adverbs - require different word order):

also, daher, darum, deswegen, deshalb, folglich, infolgedessen

These keep Position 2 for the verb: 'Es regnete. Deshalb blieben wir zu Hause.'

EXAMPLES

→ *Der Mann hat alles gegessen, sodass es nichts für den anderen gibt. (The man ate everything, so that there is nothing for the other.)*

→ *Es regnet stark, sodass wir nicht segeln können. (It's raining heavily, so that we cannot sail.)*

→ *Sie hat so laut geschrien, dass alle aufgewacht sind. (She screamed so loudly that everyone woke up.)*

→ *Ich habe den Bus verpasst, sodass ich zu spät zur Arbeit gekommen bin. (I missed the bus, so that I arrived late to work.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: 1) Forgetting to move the verb to the end position because Italian subordinate clauses maintain standard SVO order. Italian: 'Ha mangiato tutto, così non c'è niente per l'altro' (verb 'è' stays in position 2) → Incorrect German: *'Er hat alles gegessen, sodass es gibt nichts für den anderen' → Correct: 'Er hat alles gegessen, sodass es nichts für den anderen gibt.'

2) Confusing 'sodass' (consequence) with 'damit' (purpose). Italian uses 'così che' for both, but German distinguishes them. 3) Omitting the comma before 'sodass' - Italian punctuation rules differ from German. 4) Using incorrect word order when 'sodass' begins the sentence (rare but possible): the entire subordinate clause becomes Position 1, so the main verb must be Position 2. Example: 'Sodass wir pünktlich ankommen, müssen wir jetzt losfahren.' 5) Using 'so dass' as two words vs 'sodass' - both are correct, but 'sodass' is more modern and preferred.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When 'so...dass' construction is used with an adjective, the 'so' must precede the adjective in the main clause. However, this is NOT possible if there's already an adverb before the adjective. The main clause must precede the consecutive clause in standard usage; reversing the order changes the meaning from consequence to cause (making it a causal clause). 'Sodass' cannot be used with past subjunctive mood (Konjunktiv II) to express hypothetical consequences; use 'sodass...würde' construction instead.

Subordinate clause word order

■ Web verified

In German subordinate clauses (Nebensätze), the conjugated verb always moves to the final position of the clause. Subordinate clauses are dependent clauses that cannot stand alone and are introduced by subordinating conjunctions (such as dass, weil, wenn, ob, obwohl, als, bevor, nachdem, während, damit) or relative pronouns. The entire subordinate clause must be separated from the main clause by a comma. When a subordinate clause begins a sentence, it counts as position 1, so the main clause verb must come immediately after the comma (verb-comma-verb pattern).

COMPLETE RULE

Complete Structure: Subordinating conjunction + Subject + Middle field elements (objects, adverbs following TeKaMoLo order: Temporal-Kausal-Modal-Lokal) + non-conjugated verbs (infinitives/participles) + conjugated verb.

Common Subordinating Conjunctions:

- dass (that)
- weil (because)
- wenn (if/when - present/future)
- als (when - single past event)
- ob (whether/if)
- obwohl (although)
- damit (so that)
- bevor (before)
- nachdem (after)
- während (while)
- seit/seitdem (since)

Verb Position Rules:

1. Simple tenses: Conjugated verb goes to the end
2. Compound tenses (Perfect, Pluperfect): Auxiliary verb (haben/sein) goes to the very end, with participle before it
3. Modal verbs: Infinitive comes before conjugated modal verb at the end
4. Separable verbs: Prefix stays attached to verb stem (not separated) in subordinate clauses
5. Multiple verbs: Conjugated verb always last, other verb forms precede it

Word Order when Subordinate Clause Comes First:

When the subordinate clause begins the sentence, the main clause shows inverted word order (verb before subject) because the entire subordinate clause occupies position 1.

Pattern: [Subordinate clause with verb at end], [VERB] [subject] [rest of main clause].

Example: Weil ich krank bin, bleibe ich zu Hause.

Comma Rules:

- A comma ALWAYS separates main and subordinate clauses (mandatory in German)
- Comma placement is never optional with dass, weil, wenn, etc.
- When subordinate clause is embedded within main clause, use two commas

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich weiß nicht, ob der Zug um 10 Uhr abfährt. (I don't know if the train departs at 10 o'clock.)**

Simple present tense with separable verb, showing conjunction + subject + time expression + verb at end with prefix attached.

→ **Er sagt, dass er gestern das Buch gelesen hat. (He says that he read the book yesterday.)**

Perfect tense showing: conjunction + subject + time + object + participle + auxiliary at very end.

→ **Weil ich morgen früh arbeiten muss, gehe ich heute früh ins Bett. (Because I have to work early tomorrow, I'm going to bed early today.)**

Modal verb construction with subordinate clause first, demonstrating verb-comma-verb pattern and infinitive before modal at end.

→ **Sie hat mir erzählt, dass sie nicht zur Party kommen konnte, weil sie ihrer Mutter helfen musste. (She told me that she couldn't come to the party because she had to help her mother.)**

Multiple subordinate clauses showing nested structure with modal verbs and dative object.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these mistakes with German subordinate clauses:

- **1. FORGETTING TO MOVE VERB TO END:** Italian maintains SVO order even in dependent clauses, so Italian speakers often keep the verb in second position (e.g., *Ich weiß, dass er ist krank* instead of *Ich weiß, dass er krank ist*).
- **2. WRONG WORD ORDER AFTER FRONT-PLACED SUBORDINATE CLAUSE:** Italian speakers fail to invert subject and verb in the main clause when it follows a subordinate clause (e.g., *Wenn ich Zeit habe, ich gehe ins Kino* instead of *Wenn ich Zeit habe, gehe ich ins Kino*).

3. CONFUSING COORDINATING AND SUBORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS: Using *weil* (subordinating) and *denn* (coordinating) interchangeably. With *denn*, verb stays in position 2; with *weil*, verb goes to end.

■ **4. INCORRECT VERB ORDER IN COMPOUND TENSES:** Placing conjugated auxiliary before participle/infinitive (e.g., **weil ich habe das Buch gelesen** instead of **weil ich das Buch gelesen habe**).

5. MISSING COMMAS: Italian comma rules differ, so speakers often omit the mandatory comma separating clauses.

■ **6. SEPARATING PREFIX VERBS IN SUBORDINATE CLAUSES:** Italian speakers may separate prefixes (e.g., **dass er das Fenster auf macht** instead of **dass er das Fenster aufmacht**).

■ **7. USING ENGLISH/ITALIAN STRUCTURE:** Applying native language word order instead of German subordinate clause structure, especially in longer, complex sentences.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. DOUBLE INFINITIVE EXCEPTION (Ersatzinfinitiv): When modal verbs (*können, müssen, wollen, sollen, dürfen, mögen*) or verbs *lassen, sehen, hören* are used in perfect or pluperfect tense with another infinitive, the auxiliary *haben* goes **BEFORE** both infinitives instead of at the very end. Example: **Ich weiß, dass er das hat machen müssen** (not **dass er das machen müssen hat**). This exception is why Germans prefer simple past tense with modals.

2. INFORMAL SPOKEN GERMAN: In casual spoken German, some native speakers use main clause word order after *weil*, but this is considered incorrect in formal German and writing.

3. CONDITIONAL CLAUSES WITHOUT WENN: Conditional subordinate clauses can be formed without *wenn* by placing the verb in position 1: **Habe ich Zeit, komme ich vorbei** (If I have time, I'll come by).

4. INFINITIVE CLAUSES WITH ZU: Infinitive constructions with *zu* (*um...zu, ohne...zu, anstatt...zu*) follow different rules - the infinitive with *zu* goes to the end, but there's no conjugated verb.

5. RELATIVE CLAUSES: Follow the same verb-final rule but use relative pronouns (*der, die, das*) instead of conjunctions, and the relative pronoun's case depends on its function within the relative clause.

6. INDIRECT QUESTIONS: Question words (*wer, was, wann, wo, wie, warum*) introduce subordinate clauses with verb-final position: **Ich weiß nicht, wann der Zug ankommt.**

Subordinate clauses with 'dass' (reported speech)

■ From lesson

'Dass' (that) introduces subordinate clauses for reported speech or statements. The verb goes to the end

COMPLETE RULE

Use 'dass' to report what someone says or thinks. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the subordinate clause

EXAMPLES

→ **Er sagt, dass er morgen kommt**

He says that he's coming tomorrow

→ **Ich glaube, dass das eine gute Idee ist**

I believe that's a good idea

Subordinate clauses with 'ob' (indirect questions)

■ From lesson

'Ob' introduces indirect yes/no questions (meaning 'whether' or 'if'). The verb goes to the end of the subordinate clause

COMPLETE RULE

Use 'ob' for indirect yes/no questions. In subordinate clauses, the conjugated verb moves to the end

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich weiß nicht, ob es morgen regnet**

I don't know if/whether it will rain tomorrow

→ **Er fragt, ob du Zeit hast**

He asks if/whether you have time

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'ob' with 'wenn' - 'wenn' is for conditions, 'ob' is for indirect questions

Subordinate clauses with 'wenn' (conditional)

■ From lesson

'Wenn' introduces conditional clauses (if/when). The verb goes to the end of the subordinate clause

COMPLETE RULE

Use 'wenn' for conditional sentences (if) or repeated events (whenever). Verb goes to end of subordinate clause

EXAMPLES

→ **Wenn es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause**

If/When it rains, I stay at home

→ **Wenn ich bei der Kreuzung bin, gehe ich nach links**

When I'm at the crossing, I go left

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using 'wenn' for indirect questions instead of 'ob'

Subordinate Clauses with dass

■ From lesson

The conjunction 'dass' introduces subordinate clauses where the verb moves to the end

COMPLETE RULE

dass (that) is used to report what someone says or thinks. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the subordinate clause. Main clause + dass + ... + verb

EXAMPLES

- *Er sagt, dass er morgen kommt*
- *Ich denke, dass das eine gute Idee ist*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Not moving the verb to the end of the clause

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In subordinate clauses with modal verbs, infinitive comes last, then modal verb

Subordinate Clauses with ob

■ From lesson

The conjunction 'ob' introduces indirect yes/no questions, with verb at the end

COMPLETE RULE

ob (whether/if) is used for indirect yes/no questions. It does NOT mean 'if' in conditional sentences (use 'wenn'). Verb goes to end of clause

EXAMPLES

- *Ich frage, ob er morgen kommt*
- *Ich weiß nicht, ob es bald regnet*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using 'wenn' for indirect questions instead of 'ob'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

None

Subordinate clauses with relative pronouns

■ Web verified

Relative clauses in German use pronouns (der/die/das) that agree with the gender and number of the noun they refer to. The case of the relative pronoun depends on its function within the relative clause. The conjugated verb moves to the end of the subordinate clause.

COMPLETE RULE

Relative Pronoun Declension Table:

Masculine: Nom: der, Acc: den, Dat: dem, Gen: dessen

Feminine: Nom: die, Acc: die, Dat: der, Gen: deren

Neuter: Nom: das, Acc: das, Dat: dem, Gen: dessen

Plural: Nom: die, Acc: die, Dat: denen, Gen: deren

The relative pronoun gender/number matches its antecedent. The case depends on the relative pronoun's grammatical function in the relative clause (subject=nominative, direct object=accusative, indirect object=dative, possession=genitive). Verb position: conjugated verb goes to the end of the relative clause.

EXAMPLES

- *Die Hose, die gelbe Streifen hat, gefällt mir.*
- *Der Mann, den ich gestern gesehen habe, ist mein Lehrer.*
- *Das Haus, das ich kaufen will, ist teuer.*
- *Die Frau, deren Auto rot ist, wohnt hier.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may omit the relative pronoun (possible in Italian but never in German). They may use 'che' patterns from Italian, failing to decline the pronoun for case. Italian uses 'che' for all genders/numbers as subject or object, while German requires correct gender agreement and case declension. Italian speakers may forget to move the verb to the end of the relative clause since Italian relative clauses follow standard word order.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The pronouns 'welcher/welche/welches' can also be used as relative pronouns (mostly in written German to avoid repetition). 'Was' is used when the antecedent is an indefinite pronoun (alles, nichts, etwas) or a superlative used as a noun. 'Wo' is used when the antecedent is a place.

Subordinate Clauses with wenn

■ From lesson

The conjunction 'wenn' introduces conditional clauses (if) or temporal clauses (when/whenever), with verb at end

COMPLETE RULE

wenn means 'if' (condition) or 'when/whenever' (time). The verb in the wenn-clause goes to the end. If wenn-clause comes first, main clause begins with verb (inversion)

EXAMPLES

- *Wenn es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause*
- *Wenn ich bei der Kreuzung bin, gehe ich nach links*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing wenn with ob, or not using inversion in main clause

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

None

Superlative without nouns: am + [adjective]sten

■ Web verified

When a superlative stands alone without a following noun (predicative or adverbial use), use the invariable construction 'am + adjective + -sten'. This form never changes regardless of gender, case, or number. The 'am' is a contraction of 'an dem' and literally means 'at the most'.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: am + adjective + -(e)sten (invariable)

This form is used:

1. After sein/werden/bleiben (predicative): *Der Berg ist am höchsten*
2. To modify verbs (adverbial): *Er läuft am schnellsten*

3. In questions: Welches Auto ist am billigsten?

The form NEVER changes - it's always 'am [adjective]sten' regardless of subject.

Add -esten (not -sten) after: -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -x, -z

Example: interessant → am interessantesten

EXAMPLES

→ Von allen Bergen ist der Mount Everest am höchsten. (Of all mountains, Mount Everest is the highest.)

→ Welches Buch ist am interessantesten? (Which book is the most interesting?)

→ Im Winter sind die Tage am kürzesten. (In winter, the days are the shortest.)

→ Maria läuft am schnellsten von allen. (Maria runs the fastest of all.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may:

1. Try to decline the am-form (influenced by Italian adjective agreement: 'più alto/alta/alti/alte')
2. Omit 'am' entirely, using only the adjective with -sten
3. Use the attributive form (der/die/das + adjective + -ste) when am-form is needed
4. Confuse with Italian 'il più + adjective' construction and try to add articles

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular forms: gut→am besten (not *am gutsten), viel→am meisten (not *am vielsten), gern→am liebsten, hoch→am höchsten (drops -c-), nah→am nächsten. Cannot be used attributively before nouns - must use der/die/das + -ste form instead.

Superlative: am + -sten vs. article + -ste + noun

■ Web verified

German has two superlative forms: PREDICATIVE (after verbs): 'am + adjective-sten' when no noun follows (Das Haus ist am größten); ATTRIBUTIVE (before nouns): 'article + adjective-ste + ending + noun' (Das ist das größte Haus). The choice depends on whether the superlative modifies a noun directly.

COMPLETE RULE

SUPERLATIVE FORMATION:

1. PREDICATIVE SUPERLATIVE (after verbs, no noun):

Structure: am + ADJECTIVE + -(e)sten

- groß → am größten (biggest)

- schön → am schönsten (most beautiful)

- intelligent → am intelligentesten (most intelligent)
- Add -e- when adjective ends in: -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -z, -x

Examples:

- Dieses Haus ist am größten. (This house is the biggest.)
- Das Meer ist am schönsten. (The sea is the most beautiful.)

2. ATTRIBUTIVE SUPERLATIVE (before nouns):

Structure: ARTICLE + ADJECTIVE + -st + ADJECTIVE ENDING + NOUN

- der größte Berg (the biggest mountain)
- das schönste Meer (the most beautiful sea)
- die intelligenteste Studentin (the most intelligent student)

Examples:

- Das ist das größte Haus. (That is the biggest house.)
- Das ist das schönste Meer. (That is the most beautiful sea.)

3. UMLAUT RULES (same as comparative):

Monosyllabic adjectives with a, o, u often add umlaut:

- alt → ältest- (oldest)
- groß → größt- (biggest)
- jung → jüngst- (youngest)
- lang → längst- (longest)

4. IRREGULAR SUPERLATIVES:

- gut → am besten / der/die/das beste (best)
- viel → am meisten / der/die/das meiste (most)
- gern → am liebsten / der/die/das liebste (most liked)
- hoch → am höchsten / der/die/das höchste (highest)
- nah → am nächsten / der/die/das nächste (nearest)

EXAMPLES

- Dieses Haus ist am größten. (This house is the biggest.)
- Das ist das schönste Meer. (That is the most beautiful sea.)
- Die Adria ist nicht das schönste Meer. (The Adriatic is not the most beautiful sea.)
- Er läuft am schnellsten. (He runs the fastest.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' COMMON ERRORS:

1. USING 'PIÙ' CONSTRUCTION: Italians try to use 'mehr' (more) or 'meist' (most) before adjectives like Italian 'più'

- Das ist das mehr schöne Meer (Italian: il più bel mare)

■ ✓ Das ist das schönste Meer

2. OMITTING 'AM' IN PREDICATIVE FORM:

■ Dieses Haus ist größten

■ ✓ Dieses Haus ist am größten

3. FORGETTING ADJECTIVE ENDINGS in attributive use:

■ Das ist das schönst Meer (missing -e)

■ ✓ Das ist das schönste Meer

4. CONFUSING THE TWO FORMS:

■ Das Haus ist das größte (wrong: article + adjective without 'am' after verb)

■ ✓ Das Haus ist am größten (predicative)

OR: Das ist das größte Haus (attributive with noun)

5. WRONG WORD ORDER: Placing superlative incorrectly

■ Ist am größten das Haus

■ ✓ Das Haus ist am größten

6. USING -issimo ENDING: Italian speakers might try an absolute superlative like 'bellissimo'

■ Das ist ein schönstesimo Meer (no such form exists)

■ ✓ Das ist das allerschönste Meer (the very most beautiful sea)

■ ✓ Das ist ein sehr schönes Meer (a very beautiful sea)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. SOME ADJECTIVES DON'T TAKE UMLAUT despite being monosyllabic:

- bunt → am buntesten (not: büntesten)
- falsch → am falschesten (not: fälschesten)
- flach, froh, klar, rasch, roh, schlank, stolz, toll, voll, zart

2. ADJECTIVES ENDING IN -el, -en, -er may drop the -e:

- dunkel → am dunkelsten (or: düinkelsten)
- teuer → am teuersten (not: teurersten - drops -e)

3. ABSOLUTE SUPERLATIVE (no comparison): Use 'aller-' prefix or 'aufs' + superlative:

- Das ist das allerbeste Buch! (That's the very best book!)
- Sie singt aufs Schönste. (She sings in the most beautiful way.)

4. 'MEIST-' as superlative of 'viel' can be used before adjectives for 'most':

- das am meisten verkaufte Buch (the most sold book)
- This is the ONLY case where you use 'meist' before another adjective

5. ELATIVE (intensified positive): Adjective + -st without comparison:

- höflichst (most politely - as a courtesy)
- bestens (very well, excellently)

um + accusative for asking/requesting

■ Web verified

The preposition 'um' with accusative case is used with verbs of asking/requesting to express asking FOR something: 'bitten um' (to ask for, request), 'fragen um' (to ask for - though 'fragen nach' is more common for inquiring about). Structure: jemanden um etwas bitten/fragen (to ask someone for something). Very common expressions: 'um Hilfe bitten' (ask for help), 'um Erlaubnis fragen' (ask for permission). Note: 'fragen nach' means 'to inquire about' while 'fragen um' means 'to ask for/request'.

COMPLETE RULE

um + accusative: um den Weg (for directions), um Hilfe (for help), um einen Gefallen (for a favor), um Erlaubnis (for permission). Main verbs: bitten um + accusative (to ask for, request), fragen um + accusative (to ask for - archaic/formal), kümmern um (to care for). Modern German prefers 'nach dem Weg fragen' (ask for directions) over 'um den Weg fragen'.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich bitte dich um einen Gefallen. (I'm asking you for a favor.)*
- *Er bittet um Hilfe. (He asks for help.)*
- *Sie fragte ihn um Rat. (She asked him for advice.)*
- *Jemanden um den Weg fragen. (To ask someone for directions - though 'nach dem Weg fragen' is more common.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers confuse 'fragen nach' (inquire about) with 'fragen um' (request/ask for) - using wrong preposition; using dative after um (*um dem Weg fragen); translating Italian 'chiedere di' with 'fragen nach' when 'fragen um/bitten um' is needed; forgetting that 'um' in this context requires accusative; using 'für' instead of 'um' with bitten

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'fragen' more commonly uses 'nach + dative' to mean 'inquire about/ask about': 'nach dem Weg fragen' (ask for/about directions), 'nach den Eltern fragen' (ask about parents). 'fragen um' is older/formal usage. Modern usage: use 'bitten um' for requests and 'fragen nach' for inquiries. The construction 'um etwas bitten' is standard and mandatory.

um...zu construction for expressing purpose or goal

■ Web verified

The 'um...zu' construction expresses purpose, intention, or goal - meaning 'in order to' in English. This structure indicates that the action in the main clause is performed with the intention of achieving the action described in the infinitive clause. The subjects of both clauses must be the same; if they differ, use 'damit' + subordinate clause instead.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: [Main clause] + , + um + [additional elements] + zu + [infinitive]

Key Rules:

1. 'um' begins the purpose clause (after comma)
2. 'zu + infinitive' goes at the very end
3. All other elements (objects, adverbs) go between 'um' and 'zu'
4. Subject must be the same in both clauses

Word Order Pattern:

[Subject] [Verb] [Object/Time/Manner] , um [Manner/Time/Object] zu [Infinitive]

Example breakdown:

Man muss gesund essen, um gesund zu leben.

[main clause: one must eat healthily] + [purpose: in order to live healthily]

When to use 'um...zu' vs. 'damit':

- Same subject → um...zu

Ich lerne Deutsch, um in Deutschland zu arbeiten. (I learn German to work in Germany)

- Different subjects → damit

Ich gebe dir Geld, damit du essen kannst. (I give you money so that you can eat)

With separable verbs:

Ich gehe früh schlafen, um morgen früh aufzustehen.

('zu' goes between 'auf' and 'stehen')

Related constructions:

- ohne...zu (without doing): Ich gehe, ohne zu essen. (I'm leaving without eating)

- (an)statt...zu (instead of doing): Ich bleibe hier, anstatt zu gehen. (I'm staying instead of leaving)

EXAMPLES

→ Man muss gesund essen, um gesund zu leben. (One must eat healthily in order to live healthily.)

→ Ich gehe in die Küche, um Wasser zu trinken. (I go to the kitchen to drink water.)

→ Ich gehe in die Küche, um den Teller zu holen. (I go to the kitchen to get the plate.)

→ Ich lerne jeden Tag, um mein Deutsch zu verbessern. (I study every day to improve my German.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

- 1. USING JUST 'ZU' FOR PURPOSE: Incorrect: *Ich lerne Deutsch, zu arbeiten in Deutschland. Correct: Ich lerne Deutsch, um in Deutschland zu arbeiten. (Italian 'per + infinitive' → German 'um...zu', NOT just 'zu')
- 2. OMITTING 'UM': Incorrect: *Man muss gesund essen, gesund zu leben. Correct: Man muss gesund essen, um gesund zu leben. (The 'um' is required for purpose)
- 3. WRONG WORD ORDER: Incorrect: *Ich gehe in die Küche, um zu trinken Wasser. Correct: Ich gehe in die Küche, um Wasser zu trinken. (Object comes before 'zu + infinitive')
- 4. USING WITH DIFFERENT SUBJECTS: Incorrect: *Ich gebe dir Geld, um du kaufst Essen. Correct: Ich gebe dir Geld, damit du Essen kaufst. (Different subjects require 'damit', not 'um...zu')
- 5. PLACING 'UM' WRONG: Incorrect: *Um ich gehe in die Küche, Wasser zu trinken. Correct: Ich gehe in die Küche, um Wasser zu trinken. (Main clause comes first)

6. CONFUSION WITH 'PER': Italian 'per fare' seems simple, but German distinguishes:

- Purpose: um...zu (per fare)
- Attributive: zu (libro da leggere = Buch zu lesen)
- 7. WITH SEPARABLE VERBS: Incorrect: *...um zu aufstehen früh. Correct: ...um früh aufzustehen.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. ATTRIBUTIVE USE: When infinitive describes a noun, use 'zu' alone (NOT 'um...zu'):

- Die Aussicht, in Domburg auszuspannen, ist verlockend. (The prospect of relaxing in Domburg is tempting)
- This answers 'which prospect?' not 'for what purpose?'

2. RESULT VS. PURPOSE: In written German, 'zu' alone can sometimes express result (not purpose):

- Er ist alt genug, (um) dies zu verstehen. (He is old enough to understand this)
- Here 'um' can be omitted as it expresses consequence, not purpose

3. WITH 'ZU...ALS DASS': For negative result:

- Es ist zu spät, als dass wir noch anfangen könnten. (It's too late for us to start)

4. SHORTENED 'UM ZU': In very informal speech, sometimes reduced, but not recommended for learners

5. COGNATES WITH 'DAMIT': Purpose can also be expressed with 'damit' even when subjects are same (more formal):

- Ich lerne, damit ich bestehe. (formal)
- Ich lerne, um zu bestehen. (more common)

6. MOTION VERBS: With motion verbs, purpose can be implied without 'um...zu':

- Ich gehe einkaufen. (I'm going shopping - purpose implied)
- Ich gehe, um einzukaufen. (more explicit purpose)

um...zu infinitive construction for purpose

■ Web verified

The construction 'um...zu + infinitive' expresses purpose or intention (in order to do something). Place 'um' after the comma before the infinitive clause, and 'zu' comes directly before the infinitive at the end of the clause. This construction requires the same subject in both clauses.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: Main clause + COMMA + um + (other words) + zu + INFINITIVE

Word order in infinitive clause:

- um comes first after comma
- Objects and adverbs in middle
- zu + infinitive at the end

Example breakdown:

Ich gehe in die Stadt, um ein Geschenk zu kaufen

- Main clause: *Ich gehe in die Stadt*
- Purpose clause: *um ein Geschenk zu kaufen*
- um (conjunction)
- ein Geschenk (accusative object)
- zu kaufen (infinitive)

With separable verbs, 'zu' goes BETWEEN prefix and stem:

- einkaufen → *um einzukaufen*
- anschauen → *um anzuschauen*
- aufmachen → *um aufzumachen*

When subjects differ, use 'damit' + subordinate clause with conjugated verb:

- *Ich gebe dir Geld, damit du einkaufen kannst (so that you can shop)*

EXAMPLES

- *Ich gehe in die Stadt, um ein Geschenk zu kaufen. (I go to the city to buy a gift)*
- *Er lernt Deutsch, um in Deutschland zu arbeiten. (He learns German to work in Germany)*
- *Sie fährt nach Berlin, um ihre Freundin zu besuchen. (She travels to Berlin to visit her friend)*
- *Ich gehe ins Fitnessstudio, um zu trainieren. (I go to the gym in order to train)*
when no object, zu comes directly before infinitive)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers forget 'um' because Italian uses only 'per + infinitive' → 'Vado in città per comprare' becomes wrong 'Ich gehe in die Stadt zu kaufen' (should be 'um...zu kaufen'). Also placing 'zu' incorrectly with separable verbs: 'um einzukaufen' NOT 'um zu einkaufen'. Forgetting the comma

before 'um'. Using 'um...zu' when subjects differ (should use 'damit' clause instead). Italian doesn't require same subject, German 'um...zu' does.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

With separable verbs, 'zu' MUST go between prefix and stem: 'um einzukaufen', 'um anzufangen', 'um mitzukommen'. Modal verbs cannot be used in 'um...zu' constructions - use 'damit' instead: 'Ich rufe dich an, damit du kommen kannst' NOT 'um kommen zu können' (though grammatically possible, sounds awkward). When the purpose is obvious or the infinitive stands alone, simple 'zu' without 'um': 'Ich habe keine Zeit zu schlafen' (no purpose expressed, just the action).

Verb 'warten' + auf + accusative

■ Web verified

The verb 'warten' (to wait) requires the preposition 'auf' + accusative case. For complex structures with subordinate clauses, use 'darauf, dass': Sie warten darauf, dass du lachst (They wait for you to laugh). The construction 'warten auf' is fixed and cannot be separated.

COMPLETE RULE

WARTEN + AUF + ACCUSATIVE:

1. BASIC STRUCTURE:

warten + auf + ACCUSATIVE OBJECT

- Ich warte auf den Bus. (I'm waiting for the bus. - masculine acc.)
- Sie wartet auf die U-Bahn. (She's waiting for the subway. - feminine acc.)
- Wir warten auf das Essen. (We're waiting for the food. - neuter acc.)

2. WITH PRONOUNS:

- Ich warte auf dich. (I'm waiting for you.)
- Warte auf mich! (Wait for me!)
- Sie warten auf ihn. (They're waiting for him.)
- Worauf wartest du? (What are you waiting for?)

3. PREPOSITIONAL ADVERB + DASS-CLAUSE:

When the object is a clause (not a noun), use: darauf, dass...

Structure: warten + darauf, dass + SUBORDINATE CLAUSE

- Sie warten darauf, dass du lachst. (They wait for you to laugh.)
- Ich warte darauf, dass der Bus kommt. (I'm waiting for the bus to come.)
- Wir warten darauf, dass es regnet. (We're waiting for it to rain.)

4. PERFEKT TENSE:

Uses 'haben' as auxiliary

- Ich habe lange auf dich gewartet. (I waited a long time for you.)
- Sie hat auf das Paket gewartet. (She waited for the package.)

5. RELATED VERBS WITH 'AUF' + ACCUSATIVE:

- sich freuen auf (to look forward to)
- hoffen auf (to hope for)
- achten auf (to pay attention to)
- antworten auf (to answer to/reply to)
- verzichten auf (to renounce/give up)

6. WORD ORDER:

- Main clause: Subject + warten + ... + auf + object
- Subordinate: ..., dass + subject + ... + auf + object + warten

Example: Ich glaube, dass sie auf den Zug wartet. (I think she's waiting for the train.)

EXAMPLES

- Ich warte auf den Bus. (I'm waiting for the bus.)
- Sie warten darauf, dass du lachst. (They're waiting for you to laugh.)
- Warte auf mich! (Wait for me!)
- Ich habe lange auf diese Gelegenheit gewartet. (I've been waiting a long time for this opportunity.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' COMMON ERRORS:

1. USING WRONG PREPOSITION: Italian 'aspettare' doesn't need preposition or uses 'per'

- Ich warte dich (like Italian 'aspetto te' - direct object)
- Ich warte für dich (using 'für' like 'per te')
- ✓ Ich warte auf dich

■ 2. WRONG CASE AFTER 'AUF': Using dative instead of accusative

- Ich warte auf dem Bus (dative - location meaning 'on top of the bus!')
- ✓ Ich warte auf den Bus (accusative - 'waiting for')

3. FORGETTING 'DARAUF' WITH CLAUSES:

- Sie warten, dass du lachst (missing 'darauf')
- ✓ Sie warten darauf, dass du lachst

4. WRONG AUXILIARY IN PERFEKT: Italian speakers might use wrong tense formation

- Ich habe auf dich warten (missing past participle ending)
- Ich bin auf dich gewartet (wrong auxiliary - 'sein')
- ✓ Ich habe auf dich gewartet

5. SEPARATING 'AUF' FROM 'WARTEN': Treating it like a separable verb

- Ich warte dich auf (WRONG - this would be 'aufwarten' = to serve/attend)

■ ✓ Ich warte auf dich

6. PREPOSITION OMISSION IN QUESTIONS:

- Was wartest du? (like Italian 'Cosa aspetti?')
- ✓ Worauf wartest du? (What are you waiting for?)
- ✓ Auf was wartest du? (colloquial, but correct)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND VARIATIONS:

1. 'WARTEN MIT' (different meaning): to wait with/delay something

- Ich warte mit dem Essen. (I'm delaying the meal.)
- NOT the same as 'warten auf'!

2. 'ABWARTEN' (separable verb): to wait and see

- Wir müssen abwarten. (We have to wait and see.)
- Das bleibt abzuwarten. (That remains to be seen.)

3. WITHOUT PREPOSITION (rare, meaning 'to maintain/service'):

- Die Techniker warten die Maschinen. (The technicians service the machines.)
- Completely different meaning!

4. ERWARTEN (inseparable, no preposition): to expect

- Ich erwarte dich um 8 Uhr. (I expect you at 8 o'clock.)
- NOT: erwarten auf

5. FIGURATIVE USE: 'warten auf' can be used for things metaphorically waiting

- Zu Hause wartet eine Überraschung auf uns. (A surprise awaits us at home.)
- Das Buch wartet darauf, dass du es abholst. (The book is waiting for you to pick it up.)

6. OLD/FORMAL: Genitive case (veraltet)

- Dort wartete ihrer eine Überraschung. (A surprise awaited them there.)
- This form is archaic and rarely used

Verb Position - Main Clauses

■ From lesson

In German main clauses, the conjugated verb is always in second position

COMPLETE RULE

The verb must be in second position regardless of what comes first. If anything other than the subject starts the sentence, the subject comes after the verb (inversion)

EXAMPLES

- *Ich arbeite in Rom*
- *Am Montag arbeite ich*
- *Dann kaufe ich einen Laptop*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Putting the verb in third position or not inverting subject and verb

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Questions and commands have different word order

Verb position in subordinate clauses

■ Web verified

In all subordinate clauses (introduced by subordinating conjunctions like *ob*, *dass*, *wenn*, *weil*, *obwohl*, *als*, etc.), the conjugated verb moves to the end of the clause. This is called the verb-final rule (Verb-Endstellung) and is one of the most fundamental rules of German syntax. When multiple verbs are present, the conjugated verb goes last.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE:

1. **FUNDAMENTAL PRINCIPLE:** In subordinate clauses, conjugated verb **ALWAYS** goes to the **END**

2. **SUBORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS** that trigger verb-final position:

- *dass* (that)
- *weil* (because)
- *wenn* (if/when)
- *ob* (whether/if)
- *obwohl* (although)
- *als* (when - past)
- *während* (while)
- *bevor* (before)
- *nachdem* (after)
- *bis* (until)
- *seit/seitdem* (since)
- *da* (since/because)
- *damit* (so that)

3. BASIC STRUCTURE: Conjunction + Subject + Objects/Adverbs + Conjugated Verb

4. WITH ONE VERB:

Main clause: *Ich kaufe ein Buch.* (verb position 2)

Subordinate: *..., weil ich ein Buch kaufe.* (verb at end)

5. WITH MODAL VERBS: Infinitive + conjugated modal verb (last)

Example: *..., weil ich morgen arbeiten muss.*

6. WITH PERFECT TENSE: Past participle + conjugated auxiliary

Example: *..., weil ich das Buch gelesen habe.*

7. WITH FUTURE TENSE: Infinitive + conjugated werden

Example: *..., weil ich morgen kommen werde.*

8. WITH SEPARABLE VERBS: Prefix stays attached (no separation)

Example: *..., weil ich das Fenster aufmache.* (NOT: *...weil ich mache das Fenster auf*)

9. WHEN SUBORDINATE CLAUSE COMES FIRST:

- Entire subordinate clause = position 1

- Main verb immediately after comma (verb-comma-verb)

Example: *Weil es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause.*

10. COMMA RULE: Mandatory comma between main and subordinate clauses

11. WORD ORDER BEFORE VERB: TeKaMoLo (Time-Cause-Manner-Place)

Example: *..., weil ich gestern (Te) wegen des Regens (Ka) mit dem Auto (Mo) zur Arbeit (Lo) gefahren bin.*

12. NEGATION: 'nicht' typically before final verb

Example: *..., weil ich nicht komme.*

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich weiß nicht, ob mein Freund bald kommt.* (I don't know if my friend is coming soon.)

→ *Ich bleibe zu Hause, weil es regnet.* (I'm staying home because it's raining.)

→ *Er sagt, dass er die Prüfung bestanden hat.* (He says that he passed the exam.)

→ *Sie fragt mich, warum ich so früh gekommen bin.* (She asks me why I came so early.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. FORGETTING TO MOVE VERB TO END: Italian maintains normal word order in subordinate clauses.

■ **WRONG:** *Ich weiß, dass er ist krank.*

■ **CORRECT:** *Ich weiß, dass er krank ist.*

(Italian: 'So che lui è malato' - verb stays in middle)

2. PLACING CONJUGATED VERB BEFORE INFINITIVE/PARTICIPLE:

■ **WRONG:** ...weil ich habe das Buch gelesen.

■ ■ **CORRECT:** ...weil ich das Buch gelesen habe.

(Italians expect: 'perché ho letto il libro')

3. MISSING THE COMMA:

■ **WRONG:** Ich bleibe zu Hause weil ich müde bin.

■ ■ **CORRECT:** Ich bleibe zu Hause, weil ich müde bin.

4. WRONG WORD ORDER AFTER FRONT-PLACED SUBORDINATE CLAUSE:

■ **WRONG:** Wenn ich Zeit habe, ich gehe ins Kino.

■ ■ **CORRECT:** Wenn ich Zeit habe, gehe ich ins Kino.

(Italian: 'Se ho tempo, vado al cinema' - no inversion needed)

5. CONFUSING COORDINATING AND SUBORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS:

- 'weil' (subordinating) vs 'denn' (coordinating)

■ **WRONG:** ...denn ich müde bin. OR ...weil ich bin müde.

■ ■ **CORRECT:** ...weil ich müde bin. OR ...denn ich bin müde.

6. SEPARATING SEPARABLE VERBS IN SUBORDINATE CLAUSES:

■ **WRONG:** ...weil ich stehe früh auf.

■ ■ **CORRECT:** ...weil ich früh aufstehe.

7. NOT RECOGNIZING SUBORDINATE CLAUSES:

Italians may not recognize German subordinating conjunctions

- Learn these by heart: dass, weil, wenn, ob, obwohl, als, während, etc.

8. USING 'PERCHÉ' LOGIC: Italian 'perché' = both 'weil' and 'denn', but different rules

- weil = verb to end (subordinating)

- denn = verb position 2 (coordinating)

9. INDIRECT QUESTIONS: Forgetting verb goes to end

■ **WRONG:** Ich weiß nicht, wo ist er.

■ ■ **CORRECT:** Ich weiß nicht, wo er ist.

(Italian: 'Non so dove è' - no movement)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. COORDINATING CONJUNCTIONS: Do NOT send verb to end

- und, aber, oder, denn, sondern = coordinating (verb stays position 2)

Example: Ich bleibe zu Hause, denn ich bin müde. (NOT: ...denn ich müde bin)

2. PERFECT TENSE WITH MODAL VERBS: Helping verb 'haben' goes BEFORE two infinitives

Example: ...weil er hat kommen müssen. (irregular!)

- Most Germans avoid this by using simple past instead

3. VERBS 'LASSEN', 'SEHEN', 'HÖREN' + INFINITIVE: Same exception as modals

Example: ...weil ich das Auto habe reparieren lassen.

4. CASUAL SPOKEN GERMAN: Native speakers sometimes use main clause order after 'weil', but this is INCORRECT in formal/written German

Informal: ...weil, ich bin müde. (heard in speech but wrong!)

Correct: ...weil ich müde bin.

5. RELATIVE CLAUSES: Also subordinate clauses with verb-final

Example: Der Mann, der dort wohnt, ist mein Freund.

6. INDIRECT QUESTIONS: Question words (wer, was, wo, wann, wie, warum) + verb final

Example: Ich weiß nicht, wo er wohnt.

7. INFINITIVE CLAUSES WITH 'ZU': Also verb-final structure

Example: Ich versuche, die Tür zu öffnen.

8. TWO-PART CONJUNCTIONS: Also subordinating

- entweder...oder, nicht nur...sondern auch, sowohl...als auch

9. VERB-FIRST CONDITIONALS: 'Wenn' can be omitted, verb takes first position

Example: Habe ich Zeit, komme ich. (= Wenn ich Zeit habe, komme ich.)

10. HISTORICAL PATTERN: Verb-final is the OLDER Germanic pattern; V2 in main clauses is the innovation. Subordinate clauses preserve the original order.

11. AFTER 'WÄHREND', 'BEVOR', 'NACHDEM': Same verb-final rule

Example: Bevor ich zur Arbeit gehe, trinke ich Kaffee.

12. COMPOUND SUBORDINATE CLAUSES: Both verbs to end

Example: ...weil ich weiß, dass er kommt. (two subordinate clauses)

Verbi irregolari con cambio vocalico (a → ä)

■ From lesson

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich schlafe*

→ *Du schläfst*

→ *Er schläft*

→ *Wir schlafen*

Verbs with prepositions (Verben mit Präpositionalergänzung)

■ Web verified

Many German verbs require specific prepositions that govern either accusative or dative case. The preposition cannot be changed and must be memorized with the verb as a fixed unit. The case after two-way prepositions (an, auf, über) is fixed by the verb, ignoring spatial logic.

COMPLETE RULE

FORMATION: Verb + fixed preposition + fixed case

COMMON VERBS WITH ACCUSATIVE:

- *achten auf + Akk* (pay attention to)
- *sich freuen auf + Akk* (look forward to)
- *warten auf + Akk* (wait for)
- *denken an + Akk* (think of)
- *sich erinnern an + Akk* (remember)
- *bitten um + Akk* (ask for)
- *sich kümmern um + Akk* (take care of)
- *hoffen auf + Akk* (hope for)

COMMON VERBS WITH DATIVE:

- *abhängen von + Dat* (depend on)
- *sprechen mit + Dat* (speak with)
- *fragen nach + Dat* (ask about)
- *träumen von + Dat* (dream of)
- *erzählen von + Dat* (tell about)

IMPORTANT: The case is FIXED by the verb combination, not by motion/location rules that apply to spatial uses of these prepositions.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich freue mich auf das Wochenende.* (I look forward to the weekend.)
- *Es hängt davon ab, ob es regnet.* (It depends on whether it rains.)
- *Man sollte darauf achten.* (One should pay attention to that.)
- *Wir warten auf den Bus.* (We are waiting for the bus.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often make these errors:

- **1. WRONG PREPOSITION:** Using Italian preposition logic (e.g., *pensare DI instead of denken AN, *aspettare PER instead of warten AUF)
- **2. WRONG CASE:** Applying motion/location rules to prepositional verbs (e.g., *warten auf dem Bus instead of auf den Bus - always accusative with warten)
- **3. MISSING PREPOSITION:** Omitting the preposition entirely when Italian doesn't use one (*sich erinnern das Wort instead of sich erinnern AN das Wort)

- 4. TRANSLATING DIRECTLY: Italian 'interessarsi DI' becomes *sich interessieren von instead of sich interessieren FÜR

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. Some verbs can use different prepositions with different meanings (e.g., sich freuen AUF = look forward to future vs. sich freuen ÜBER = be happy about present/past)
2. A few prepositions cannot form da-compounds: außer, ohne, seit, gegenüber, and genitive prepositions
3. When referring to people (not things), use preposition + pronoun (auf ihn) instead of da-compound (darauf)

Verbs with prepositions: sprechen über + AKK, denken an + AKK

■ Web verified

Many German verbs require specific prepositions that form fixed combinations. These prepositional verbs must be learned together as units, and the preposition determines the case of the following object. 'Sprechen über' (to talk about) requires accusative, and 'denken an' (to think about/of) also requires accusative. The preposition often loses its original meaning in these fixed combinations.

COMPLETE RULE

Essential Prepositional Verbs:

With ACCUSATIVE:

- sprechen über + AKK (talk about): Wir sprechen über das Wetter
- denken an + AKK (think of/about): Ich denke an dich
- sich freuen auf + AKK (look forward to)
- warten auf + AKK (wait for)
- sich erinnern an + AKK (remember)

With DATIVE:

- sprechen mit + DAT (speak with): Ich spreche mit dem Mann
- träumen von + DAT (dream of/about)
- abhängen von + DAT (depend on)

Different meanings with different prepositions:

- denken an + AKK (think of - having in mind)
- nachdenken über + AKK (think about - ponder, contemplate)
- sprechen über + AKK (speak about a topic)
- sprechen mit + DAT (speak with a person)

In questions: Preposition combines with 'wo(r)-': Worüber sprichst du? (What are you talking about?)

EXAMPLES

→ **Wo wohnt der Hund, über den ich gesprochen habe?** (Where lives the dog I spoke about?)

über + accusative)

→ **Wo wohnt die Person, an die ich gestern gedacht habe?** (Where lives the person I thought of yesterday?)

an + accusative)

→ **Ich spreche mit meinem Lehrer über das Problem.** (I speak with my teacher about the problem)

mit + dative, über + accusative)

→ **Woran denkst du gerade? - Ich denke an meinen Urlaub.** (What are you thinking about? - I'm thinking about my vacation.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

1. Using the wrong case after the preposition (confusing accusative/dative)
2. Directly translating Italian prepositions (pensare a → denken an works, but parlare di → sprechen ÜBER not von)
3. Forgetting the preposition entirely in fixed combinations
4. Using the wrong preposition with the verb
5. Not recognizing that two-way prepositions (an, auf, über) take fixed cases with verbs
6. Separating the preposition from the verb in questions

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. Some verbs take multiple prepositions with different meanings: sprechen mit (with someone) vs. sprechen über (about something)
2. The preposition's case in fixed combinations does NOT follow motion/location rules for two-way prepositions
3. In relative clauses with prepositional verbs, the preposition moves before the relative pronoun: Der Mann, mit dem ich spreche
4. Some prepositional verbs don't require prepositions in English (warten auf = wait for, but 'for' is not literally 'auf')
5. Denken über (think about with opinion) vs. denken an (think of/have in mind) - subtle meaning difference

wegen + Genitive

■ Web verified

The preposition 'wegen' means 'because of' or 'due to' and requires the genitive case in standard German. Unlike 'weil' (because) which introduces a subordinate clause with a conjugated verb, 'wegen' is followed directly by a noun or noun phrase. It is used to express causality with nominal elements.

COMPLETE RULE

GENITIVE DECLENSION WITH WEGEN:

MASCULINE/NEUTER:

Definite: wegen des Wetters (because of the weather)

Indefinite: wegen eines Unfalls (because of an accident)

Without article: wegen Regens (because of rain)

FEMININE:

Definite: wegen der Kälte (because of the cold)

Indefinite: wegen einer Panne (because of a breakdown)

PLURAL:

Definite: wegen der Probleme (because of the problems)

Indefinite: wegen Problemen (DATIVE when genitive not visible)

GENITIVE ENDINGS:

Articles: des (m/n), der (f/pl)

Nouns: add -(e)s for masculine/neuter singular, no change for feminine/plural

Adjectives: -en ending after articles

NAME + WEGEN: Proper names have no genitive marker:

- wegen Nico (because of Nico)

- wegen Maria (because of Maria)

POSTNOMINAL POSITION: 'wegen' can follow the noun (genitive ALWAYS required):

- des Wetters wegen (because of the weather)

- meiner Freunde wegen (because of my friends)

DAT. EXCEPTIONS (standard German):

1. When genitive is NOT recognizable: wegen Bauarbeiten (because of construction work)

2. When genitive attribute intervenes: wegen dem von dir empfohlenen Buch

3. Colloquially/regionally: wegen dem Wetter (accepted in speech, avoid in writing)

COMPLETE GENITIVE FORMS TABLE:

SINGULAR MASCULINE:

Def: wegen des Staus (traffic jam)

Indef: wegen eines Fehlers (error)

Possessive: wegen meines Bruders (my brother)

SINGULAR NEUTER:

Def: wegen des Wetters

Indef: wegen eines Problems

Possessive: wegen seines Autos

SINGULAR FEMININE:

Def: wegen der Hitze

Indef: wegen einer Krankheit

Possessive: wegen ihrer Arbeit

PLURAL (all genders):

Def: wegen der Kosten

Indef: wegen Kosten (dative if no article)

Possessive: wegen unserer Kinder

EXAMPLES

- Sie sind wütend wegen des schlechten Wetters. (They are angry because of the bad weather.)
- Wegen des Unfalls bin ich zu spät gekommen. (Because of the accident I arrived late.)
- Wegen der Proteste wurde die Straße gesperrt. (Because of the protests the street was closed.)
- Das Spiel wurde wegen Regens abgesagt. (The game was cancelled because of rain.) [no article, so noun stays in genitive without clear ending]

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' ERRORS:

- 1. USING DATIVE INSTEAD OF GENITIVE: Italian has no genitive case, expressing possession/relation with 'di' (of). Italian speakers often default to dative: *'wegen dem Wetter' instead of 'wegen des Wetters'. Italian 'a causa del tempo' → German 'wegen des Wetters' (not *dem).
- 2. CONFUSION WITH 'weil': Italian 'perché' means both 'because' (clause) and 'because of' (+ noun). Italian speakers may incorrectly try: *'wegen es regnet' (mixing 'wegen' + clause). CORRECT: 'weil es regnet' (clause) OR 'wegen des Regens' (noun).
- 3. WRONG ARTICLE FORMS: Forgetting genitive articles: *'wegen der Wetter' (using dative 'der') instead of 'wegen des Wetters' (genitive 'des').
- 4. ADJECTIVE ENDING ERRORS: Italian adjectives don't decline by case, so speakers forget genitive adjective ending: *'wegen schlecht Wetter' instead of 'wegen schlechten Wetters' or 'wegen des schlechten Wetters'.
- 5. OVERUSING 'wegen': Italian uses 'per' for both purpose and cause. Italian speakers may confuse purpose (use 'um...zu') with cause (use 'wegen'): *'Ich gehe nach Hause wegen essen' instead of 'um zu essen'.
- 6. PERSONAL PRONOUN FORMS: Not using correct genitive pronouns: Standard = **meinetwegen, deinetwegen**; Colloquial = **wegen mir, wegen dir**. Italian speakers often say *'wegen ich' (incorrect).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. DATIVE IN PLURAL when genitive NOT visible (no article/determiner):

- CORRECT: wegen Bauarbeiten (dative plural)
- WITH ARTICLE: wegen der Bauarbeiten (genitive visible)

2. COLLOQUIAL DATIVE: In spoken German, especially southern regions (Bavaria, Austria), dative is common and accepted by Duden as 'regional/colloquial': wegen dem Wetter, wegen dir. **BUT:** Use genitive in formal/written German.

3. PERSONAL PRONOUNS - Standard forms:

- meinetwegen (because of me / for my sake)
- deinetwegen (because of you)
- seinetwegen, ihretwegen, unseretwegen
- Colloquial: wegen mir, wegen dir (accepted in speech)

4. POSTPOSED 'wegen' ALWAYS takes genitive:

- des Wetters wegen (ONLY genitive acceptable)
- *dem Wetter wegen (WRONG)

5. RELATIVSÄTZE (relative clauses) with 'wegen':

- Singular: wegen dem (dative accepted)
- Plural: wegen derer/denen (both acceptable)

6. ALTERNATIVE PREPOSITIONS:

- aufgrund + genitive (more formal, same meaning)
- wegen vs. aus: 'aus Liebe' (from/out of love) vs. 'wegen der Liebe' (because of the love)

7. VON-CONSTRUCTION as alternative when genitive unclear:

- wegen von Problemen (colloquial workaround)
- Better: wegen der Probleme

Wie geht's? / Wie geht es dir? (Greetings and asking 'How are you?')

■ Web verified

The phrase 'Wie geht's?' is the shortened colloquial form of 'Wie geht es dir?' (informal) or 'Wie geht es Ihnen?' (formal), used to ask 'How are you?' in German. Unlike English where 'How are you?' is often just a greeting, in German culture this question typically expects an honest answer. The construction uses the verb 'gehen' (to go) in third person with the dative case, literally meaning 'How goes it to you?' Germans value directness and expect genuine responses to this question.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE FORMS AND CONSTRUCTIONS:

INFORMAL (with friends, family, children):

- *Wie geht's?* (most common, casual)
- *Wie geht es dir?* (slightly more formal but still informal)
- *Wie gehts dir?* (variant without apostrophe)
- *Na, wie geht's?* (very casual, conversational)
- *Alles gut?* (Everything good? - very informal)
- *Alles klar?* (Everything clear/okay? - informal)

FORMAL (with strangers, elders, professional settings):

- *Wie geht es Ihnen?* (standard formal)
- *Wie befinden Sie sich?* (very formal, somewhat old-fashioned)

GRAMMATICAL CONSTRUCTION:

'Wie geht es' + dative pronoun

- *dir* (informal you - dative of 'du')
- *Ihnen* (formal you - dative of 'Sie')
- *ihm* (him)
- *ihr* (her)
- *uns* (us)
- *euch* (you plural informal)

COMMON RESPONSES:**POSITIVE:**

- *Gut, danke!* (Good, thanks!)
- *Sehr gut!* (Very good!)
- *Gut, und dir/Ihnen?* (Good, and you?)
- *Mir geht es gut.* (I'm doing well.)
- *Prima! / Super! / Ausgezeichnet!* (Great! / Super! / Excellent!)

NEUTRAL:

- *Es geht.* (It's okay. / So-so.)
- *Ganz gut.* (Quite good.)
- *Nicht schlecht.* (Not bad.)

NEGATIVE:

- *Nicht so gut.* (Not so good.)
- *Schlecht.* (Bad.)
- *Nicht besonders.* (Not particularly well.)

RECIPROCAL RESPONSES:**After answering, it's polite to ask back:**

- *Und dir?* (And you? - informal)

- Und Ihnen? (And you? - formal)
- Und selbst? (And yourself?)

REGIONAL VARIATIONS:

Northern Germany:

- Moin! (greeting, no response needed)
- Alles fit? (Everything fit?)

Southern Germany/Austria:

- Grüß Gott! (God greet you!)
- Servus! (casual greeting/goodbye)
- Wie geht's dir denn? (How are you then?)

Switzerland:

- Wie gaht's? / Wie gohts? (Swiss German variants)

EXAMPLES

→ Wie geht's? - Gut, danke! Und dir? - Auch gut. (How are you? - Good, thanks! And you? - Also good.) - Typical informal exchange between friends.

→ Guten Tag, Herr Schmidt. Wie geht es Ihnen heute? - Sehr gut, danke der Nachfrage. Und Ihnen? (Good day, Mr. Schmidt. How are you today? - Very well, thanks for asking. And you?) - Formal exchange in professional setting.

→ Na, wie geht's? - Nicht so gut, ich bin krank. - Oh, das tut mir leid! (Hey, how's it going? - Not so good, I'm sick. - Oh, I'm sorry to hear that!) - Informal exchange with honest negative response.

→ Hallo! Wie geht es dir? - Es geht. Viel Arbeit im Moment. (Hello! How are you? - It's okay. A lot of work at the moment.) - Neutral response with brief explanation, culturally appropriate.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

■ 1. TREATING IT AS PURE GREETING: Italian speakers may say 'Wie geht's?' and walk away, similar to English 'How are you?' as greeting. In German culture, this requires a genuine response. Wrong approach: Using it like 'Ciao, come va?' without expecting answer. Correct: Wait for response and reciprocate.

■ 2. INCORRECT CASE USAGE: Wrong: 'Wie geht es dich?' (accusative instead of dative). Correct: 'Wie geht es dir?' Italian speakers struggle with dative because Italian uses 'Come stai?' with different case logic.

■ 3. WRONG PRONOUN FORMALITY: Wrong: 'Wie geht es du?' Correct: 'Wie geht es dir?' or 'Wie geht's?' Italian has 'tu/Lei' but construction differs.

■ 4. MIXING FORMAL AND INFORMAL: Wrong: 'Wie geht es du?' (mixing 'es' formal construction with informal 'du'). Correct: Either 'Wie geht's?' (fully informal) or 'Wie geht es dir?' (semi-formal) or 'Wie geht es Ihnen?' (fully formal).

■ 5. LITERAL TRANSLATION FROM ITALIAN: Italian speakers may try 'Wie bist du?' (translating 'Come stai?' literally as 'How are you?'). Wrong: 'Wie bist du?' means 'What are you like?' (character). Correct: 'Wie geht's?' or 'Wie geht es dir?'

■ **6. OMITTING RECIPROCATION:** Responding without asking back is considered rude in German. Wrong: 'Gut, danke.' (and stopping). Correct: 'Gut, danke! Und dir?' Italians do this with 'Bene, grazie' but Germans expect the reciprocal question.

■ **7. OVER-ENTHUSIASTIC FALSE RESPONSES:** German culture values honesty. Wrong: Always saying 'Super!' when not true. Correct: 'Es geht.' or 'Nicht so gut.' are acceptable. Unlike Italian 'bene' as automatic response, Germans appreciate honesty.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. VERY CASUAL 'NA?': In very informal contexts, Germans often greet with just 'Na?' which can mean 'Well?' or 'How's it going?' Response can be 'Na?' back, or 'Gut' or just 'Ja, alles klar.' This is extremely casual - don't use with strangers or in formal settings.

2. 'WIE LÄUFT'S?': Younger Germans use 'Wie läuft's?' (How's it running?) instead of 'Wie geht's?' Same grammar rules apply.

3. SITUATIONAL VARIATIONS:

- 'Was geht?' or 'Was geht ab?' (What's up?) - very casual, youth slang
- 'Alles fit?' (Everything fit?) - casual, suggests physical/mental wellness
- 'Alles in Ordnung?' (Everything in order?) - checking if something is wrong

4. CULTURAL EXPECTATION OF HONESTY: Unlike English/Italian where 'How are you?' gets automatic positive response, Germans may answer honestly 'Nicht so gut' (not so good) and expect to discuss it briefly. Not answering honestly can seem fake.

5. TIME-SPECIFIC GREETINGS: These often replace 'Wie geht's?' altogether:

- 'Guten Morgen' (Good morning) - until ~10-11am
- 'Guten Tag' (Good day) - general daytime
- 'Guten Abend' (Good evening) - after ~6pm
- 'Gute Nacht' (Good night) - only when going to bed, NOT greeting

6. REGIONAL 'MOIN': In Northern Germany, 'Moin' is used all day (not just morning) and doesn't require 'How are you?' follow-up.

7. BUSINESS CONTEXT: In very formal business settings, 'Wie geht es Ihnen?' might be skipped entirely, going straight to business after 'Guten Tag.'

8. PHONE ETIQUETTE: On phone, Germans typically identify themselves first, then may ask 'Wie geht es dir?' Example: 'Hallo, hier ist Thomas. Wie geht's?'

9. EMAIL/WRITTEN: 'Wie geht es dir?' is too casual for most professional emails. Use 'Ich hoffe, es geht Ihnen gut' (I hope you are well) instead.

wiederholen vs. nochmal

■ Web verified

'Wiederholen' is a verb meaning to repeat, review, or go over something (especially for study/learning). 'Nochmal' (or 'noch einmal') is an adverb meaning 'once more/again' and is used with other verbs to indicate repetition of an action. For re-reading, use 'nochmal lesen', not 'wiederholen'.

COMPLETE RULE

WIEDERHOLEN (verb) - to repeat, review, go over:

Conjugation:

Präsens: ich wiederhole, du wiederholst, er/sie/es wiederholt, wir wiederholen, ihr wiederholt, sie wiederholen

Präteritum: ich wiederholte, du wiederholtest, er/sie/es wiederholte, wir wiederholten, ihr wiederholtet, sie wiederholten

Perfekt: ich habe wiederholt, du hast wiederholt, er/sie/es hat wiederholt, wir haben wiederholt, ihr habt wiederholt, sie haben wiederholt

NOTE: 'wiederholen' is NOT separable (unlike 'wieder holen' which means 'to fetch again')

Used for:

- Repeating words/phrases: *Können Sie das wiederholen? (Can you repeat that?)*
- Reviewing/studying material: *Ich muss die Grammatik wiederholen. (I need to review the grammar.)*
- Repeating a year in school: *Er muss die Klasse wiederholen. (He has to repeat the grade.)*

NOCHMAL/NOCH EINMAL (adverb) - once more, again:

Used with action verbs to indicate doing something again:

- *Ich lese das Buch nochmal. (I'm reading the book again.)*
- *Mach das nochmal! (Do that again!)*
- *Können Sie das noch einmal sagen? (Can you say that again?)*

Key distinction: Use 'wiederholen' for deliberate review/repetition of content; use 'nochmal' + verb for simply doing an action again.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich muss den Stoff für die Prüfung wiederholen. (I need to review the material for the exam.)*
- *Kannst du das bitte nochmal sagen? (Can you please say that again?)*
- *Wir haben die Lektion wiederholt. (We reviewed the lesson.)*
- *Ich möchte den Film nochmal sehen. (I want to see the movie again.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers might say 'das Buch wiederholen' when they mean to read it again, influenced by Italian 'ripetere'. German requires 'das Buch nochmal lesen'. 'Wiederholen' implies reviewing/studying the content, while 'nochmal lesen' means simply reading it again.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'Wieder holen' (separable, written as two words) means 'to fetch/get again': 'Ich hole mir noch ein Bier' (I'll get another beer). This is different from 'wiederholen' (inseparable, one word) which means to repeat/review.

worüber / darüber (preposition + question/demonstrative)

■ Web verified

Pronominal adverbs (Pronominaladverbien) are formed by combining 'wo-' with a preposition for questions and 'da-' with a preposition for statements/answers. When the preposition starts with a vowel, an 'r' is inserted (wor-, dar-). These compounds replace 'preposition + pronoun' constructions for things and situations, but NOT for people.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation:

Question forms (wo-compounds):

- wo + preposition (if starts with consonant): womit, wofür, wovon
- wor + preposition (if starts with vowel): worauf, worüber, woran

Answer/Reference forms (da-compounds):

- da + preposition (if starts with consonant): damit, dafür, davon
- dar + preposition (if starts with vowel): darauf, darüber, daran

Common combinations:

- über: worüber (about what?) / darüber (about that)
- auf: worauf (on what?) / darauf (on that)
- mit: womit (with what?) / damit (with that)
- von: wovon (from/of what?) / davon (from/of that)
- für: wofür (for what?) / dafür (for that)
- an: woran (on/at what?) / daran (on/at that)
- in: worin (in what?) / darin (in that)
- um: worum (about what?) / darum (about that)

Important: For people, use preposition + personal pronoun instead:

- Mit wem? / Mit ihm (not: *damit for people)
- Über wen? / Über ihn (not: *darüber for people)

Exceptions: 'darunter' and 'davon' CAN sometimes refer to people in certain contexts.

EXAMPLES

→ *Worüber streiten sie sich? - Über den Preis. / Darüber streiten sie sich. (What are they arguing about? - About the price. / They're arguing about that.)*

→ *Womit fährst du? - Mit dem Auto. / Damit fahre ich. (What are you traveling with? - With the car. / I'm traveling with that.)*

→ *Wovon sprichst du? - Von der Reise. / Davon spreche ich. (What are you talking about? - About the trip. / I'm talking about that.)*

→ *Worauf freust du dich? - Darauf freue ich mich sehr! (What are you looking forward to? - I'm really looking forward to that!)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers face several challenges:

1. Italian lacks this pronominal adverb system - expressions like 'di che cosa' (of what) and 'di questo' (of this) use separate words, while German fuses them

- 2. Using pronoun constructions instead of pronominal adverbs for things: *'Über es sprechen wir' instead of 'Darüber sprechen wir'
- 3. Using pronominal adverbs for people: *'Ich spreche damit' (meaning with a person) instead of 'Ich spreche mit ihm'
- 4. Forgetting to add 'r' before vowels: *'woauf' instead of 'worauf'
- 5. Separating the compound in speech: *'Wo sprichst du über?' instead of 'Worüber sprichst du?' (though separation occurs in informal speech)

6. Confusing 'wo-' (questions) with 'da-' (statements)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Cannot be formed from: *außer, ohne, seit, gegenüber*, or genitive prepositions. With people, always use preposition + personal pronoun: 'mit ihm' (with him), NOT 'damit' for people. 'Darunter' and 'davon' can exceptionally refer to people in expressions like 'darunter waren drei Studenten' (among them were three students). In colloquial speech, shortened forms exist: *drauf* (darauf), *drin* (darin), *drüber* (darüber).

während (subordinate conjunction)

■ Web verified

'Während' as a subordinating conjunction means 'while' and introduces a subordinate clause where the conjugated verb moves to the end. It expresses simultaneity of two actions and is more formal than 'beim + noun'. As a preposition, 'während' takes the genitive case (sometimes dative) and means 'during'.

COMPLETE RULE

AS SUBORDINATE CONJUNCTION (most common):

- Meaning: 'while' (simultaneous actions)
- Verb position: conjugated verb at END of subordinate clause

- Example: 'Während ich koche, höre ich Musik' (While I cook, I listen to music)
- Comma separates main and subordinate clauses

AS PREPOSITION (genitive, sometimes dative):

- Meaning: 'during'
- Takes genitive: 'während des Fluges' (during the flight)
- Takes dative when genitive unclear: 'während Gesprächen' (during conversations)
- Swiss German: 'während' with 'dauern': 'während einiger Stunden' (for several hours)

LIST OF SUBORDINATE CONJUNCTIONS (verb-final):

als, bevor, bis, dass, damit, ob, obwohl, seit, sobald, sofern, soweit, sowie, während, weil, wenn, wie, wo

FORMALITY: 'während' (conjunction) > 'beim + noun' > 'dabei' (ascending informality)

EXAMPLES

- Während ich koche, höre ich Musik. (While I cook, I listen to music.)
- Jemand hat die Tür geöffnet, während ich weg war. (Someone opened the door while I was away.)
- Während des Fluges schlief er. (During the flight he slept.) [preposition + genitive]
- Er rief an, während wir beim Essen waren. (He called while we were eating.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' MISTAKES:

- 1. Keeping verb in position 2 instead of moving to end: ■ 'Während ich koche Musik, höre ich' → ■ 'Während ich koche, höre ich Musik'
- 2. Using accusative/dative with preposition 'während' instead of genitive: ■ 'während dem Flug' → ■ 'während des Fluges'

3. Confusing 'während' (while/during) with 'seit' (since/for time): Italian 'durante' vs 'da quando'

4. Forgetting comma before/after während-clause

5. Confusing with 'währenddessen' (adverb meaning 'meanwhile' - no subordinate clause)

6. Wrong case after preposition: ■ 'während der Arbeit' (fem. but looks wrong) ✓ correct genitive

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

DATIVE EXCEPTION: 'während' as preposition takes dative (not genitive) when:

- Genitive not recognizable in plural: 'während Ausflügen' (during excursions)
- Another noun (genitive attribute) comes between: 'während meines letzten Aufenthalts in Berlin'
- In Swiss German always with dative
- In colloquial German, dative increasingly common

WÄHRENDDESSEN: Separate adverb (not subordinating) meaning 'meanwhile': 'Ich kochte.

Währenddessen hörte er Musik.' (I cooked. Meanwhile he listened to music.) - This does NOT create a subordinate clause.

Modalverben im Präsens - Modal verbs in present tense

■ From lesson

German modal verbs conjugate irregularly in the present tense. The six modal verbs are: müssen (must/have to), können (can/to be able to), dürfen (may/to be allowed to), wollen (want to), mögen (to like), and möchten (would like to).

COMPLETE RULE

Singular: ich muss/kann/darf/will/mag/möchte, du
musst/kannst/darfst/willst/magst/möchtest, er/sie/es muss/kann/darf/will/mag/möchte |
Plural: wir müssen/können/dürfen/wollen/mögen/möchten, ihr
müsst/könnt/dürft/wollt/mögt/möchtet, sie/Sie
müssen/können/dürfen/wollen/mögen/möchten

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Note: 'möchte' is the subjunctive II form of 'mögen' but is used as a normal modal verb in present tense with the meaning 'would like to / wish politely'

Wortstellung in Aussagesätzen und W-Fragen - Word order in statements and W-questions with modal verbs

■ From lesson

In German sentences with modal verbs, the modal verb takes Position 2 (conjugated verb position) and the main verb goes to the end of the sentence in infinitive form. The subject is in Position 1 in statements.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 1 (subject) + Position 2 (modal verb conjugated) + middle field + Satzende (main verb infinitive)

EXAMPLES

- *Beatriz muss in der Woche früh aufstehen.*
- *Am Wochenende kann sie lange schlafen.*
- *Man darf im Bus nicht laut Musik hören.*
- *Beatriz und Leopold wollen heute ins Kino gehen.*
- *Wann möchtet ihr nach Hause fahren?*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Remember: the modal verb is conjugated and takes Position 2, while the main verb stays in infinitive form at the end

Wortstellung in Ja/Nein-Fragen - Word order in yes/no questions with modal verbs

■ From lesson

In yes/no questions with modal verbs, the conjugated modal verb takes Position 1, followed by the subject in Position 2, and the main verb infinitive goes to the end.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 1 (modal verb conjugated) + Position 2 (subject) + middle field + Satzende (main verb infinitive)

EXAMPLES

→ *Darf man im Bus laut Musik hören?*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Don't forget to invert the subject and modal verb for yes/no questions

Präsens: Verben mit trennbaren Vorsilben

■ From lesson

Present tense: Verbs with separable prefixes. The prefix moves to the end of the sentence.

COMPLETE RULE

anrufen: Ich rufe dich an. | aufstehen: Wann stehst du auf? | anfangen: Nächste Woche fängt Tobias das Training an. | ausprobieren: Wir probieren das Lauftraining aus. | mitkommen: Ihr kommt zum Leonardo-Campus-Run mit. | mitmachen: Annika und Tobias machen beim Lauftraining mit.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich rufe dich an.*

→ *Wann stehst du auf?*

→ *Nächste Woche fängt Tobias das Training an.*

→ *Wir probieren das Lauftraining aus.*

→ *Ihr kommt zum Leonardo-Campus-Run mit.*

→ *Annika und Tobias machen beim Lauftraining mit.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to move the prefix to the end of the sentence

Präsens: Verben mit trennbaren Vorsilben und Modalverben

■ From lesson

Present tense: Verbs with separable prefixes and modal verbs. The infinitive with prefix stays together at the end.

COMPLETE RULE

mitmachen: Ich möchte unbedingt beim Lauftraining mitmachen. | mitnehmen: Tim kann uns im Auto mitnehmen.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich möchte unbedingt beim Lauftraining mitmachen.*

→ *Tim kann uns im Auto mitnehmen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Separating the prefix from the infinitive when using modal verbs

Perfekt: Verben mit trennbaren Vorsilben

■ From lesson

Perfect tense with verbs that have separable prefixes (an-, aus-, auf-, mit-, weg-, runter-, vorbei-, zurück-). The 'ge-' is inserted between the prefix and the verb stem.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 2 gets auxiliary verb (habe/hast/hat/haben/habt/sind/bin), sentence end gets past participle with prefix+ge+stem: angerufen, zurückgerufen, ausgefüllt, mitgenommen, runtergebracht, weggefahren, aufgestanden.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe dich heute mehrmals angerufen.*

→ *Du hast leider nicht zurückgerufen.*

→ *Wir haben Leon nach Frankfurt mitgenommen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to split the prefix from the verb, putting 'ge-' in the wrong position

Perfekt: Verben mit untrennbaren Vorsilben

■ From lesson

Perfect tense with verbs that have inseparable prefixes (er-, be-, ver-, hinter-). These verbs do NOT add 'ge-' to form the past participle.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 2 gets auxiliary verb (habe/hast/hat/haben), sentence end gets past participle *WITHOUT* 'ge-': vergessen, erreicht, hinterlassen, besucht. Inseparable prefixes remain attached to the verb stem.

EXAMPLES

- Ich habe euch nicht vergessen.
- Du hast den Hausmeister nicht erreicht.
- Er hat keine Notiz hinterlassen.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Adding 'ge-' to verbs with inseparable prefixes (wrong: *gevergesst instead of vergessen)

Präteritum - Modalverben

■ From lesson

Modal verbs in the simple past tense (Präteritum). Note: Möchte uses wollen in the past. Modal verbs have endings like regular verbs but sometimes with vowel changes

COMPLETE RULE

können: ich konnte, du konntest, er/sie/es konnte, wir konnten, ihr konntet, sie/Sie konnten | wollen: ich wollte, du wolltest, er/sie/es wollte, wir wollten, ihr wolltet, sie/Sie wollten | müssen: ich musste, du musstest, er/sie/es musste, wir mussten, ihr musstet, sie/Sie mussten | dürfen: ich durfte, du durftest, er/sie/es durfte, wir durften, ihr durftet, sie/Sie durften

EXAMPLES

- Ich konnte nicht kommen.
- Er wollte nach Berlin fahren.

→ *Wir mussten lange warten.*

→ *Sie durften nicht fotografieren.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using *möchte* in Präteritum instead of *wollte*. Modal verbs are used in Präteritum even in spoken German, unlike most other verbs

Bedeutung von Modalverben

■ From lesson

Modal verbs in German express different meanings: 'wissen' (to know), 'erlaubt sein' (to be allowed), 'nötig sein' (to be necessary), 'möglich sein' (to be possible), and 'fähig sein' (to be able/capable).

COMPLETE RULE

jemand weist an: soll (Beate soll viel schlafen / Beate soll nicht arbeiten). es ist (nicht) erlaubt: darf/kann (Beate darf/kann spazieren gehen / Beate darf nicht arbeiten). es ist (nicht) nötig: muss (Beate muss sich ausruhen / Beate muss sich nicht ausruhen / Beate braucht keine Diät zu machen / Beate braucht nicht mehr im Bett zu liegen). es ist (nicht) möglich: kann (Beate kann verreisen / Beate kann nicht verreisen). jemand ist (nicht) fähig: kann (Beate kann Chinesisch sprechen / Beate kann nicht Chinesisch sprechen).

EXAMPLES

- *Beate soll viel schlafen.*
- *Beate soll nicht arbeiten.*
- *Beate darf spazieren gehen.*
- *Beate kann spazieren gehen.*
- *Beate darf nicht arbeiten.*
- *Beate muss sich ausruhen.*
- *Beate muss sich nicht ausruhen.*
- *Beate braucht keine Diät zu machen.*
- *Beate braucht nicht mehr im Bett zu liegen.*
- *Beate kann verreisen.*
- *Beate kann nicht verreisen.*
- *Beate kann Chinesisch sprechen.*
- *Beate kann nicht Chinesisch sprechen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Confusing 'können' meanings (ability vs. permission vs. possibility). Using 'müssen' instead of 'nicht brauchen' for negation of necessity.

Passiv mit Modalverben – Präsens und Präteritum

■ From lesson

Passive voice with modal verbs in present and past tense. Structure: subject + modal verb (Position 2) + middle field + past participle + werden (sentence end)

COMPLETE RULE

Passive with modal verbs: Position 2 contains the conjugated modal verb (durften, darf, muss), middle field contains context, sentence end contains past participle + werden

EXAMPLES

- Früher durften Mopeds ohne Führerschein gefahren werden.
- Der Bus darf so lange nicht überholt werden, ...
- Das Abblendlicht muss im Tunnel eingeschaltet werden.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting 'werden' at the end of the sentence, incorrect word order

Konjunktiv II

■ From lesson

For regular verbs, the forms of Konjunktiv II and Präteritum are identical, therefore 'würde' + infinitive is used, e.g. 'er schaute nach' → 'er würde nachschauen'. The Konjunktiv II forms of 'haben', the modal verbs 'können', 'müssen', 'dürfen' and some mixed verbs (e.g. 'wissen') are like the Präteritum + Umlaut, e.g. 'ich hatte' → 'ich hätte', 'du konntest' → 'du könntest', 'er wusste' → 'er wüsste'. The Konjunktiv II forms of the irregular verbs are like the Präteritum + ending '-e' + Umlaut, e.g. 'ich kam' → 'ich käme', 'du warst' → 'du wärest', 'sie fand' → 'sie fände', 'er ging' → 'er ginge'. Konjunktiv II is used with 'haben', 'sein', modal verbs and some frequently used irregular and mixed verbs. Otherwise 'würde' + Infinitive is used.

COMPLETE RULE

Bei regelmäßigen Verben sind die Formen des Konjunktivs II und des Präteritums gleich. Deshalb verwendet man 'würde' + Infinitiv, z.B. 'er schaute nach' → 'er würde nachschauen'. Die Konjunktiv-II-Formen von 'haben', den Modalverben 'können', 'müssen', 'dürfen' und von einigen gemischten Verben (z.B. 'wissen') sind wie das Präteritum + Umlaut, z.B. 'ich hatte' → 'ich hätte', 'du konntest' → 'du könntest', 'er wusste' → 'er wüsste'. Die Konjunktiv-II-Formen bei den unregelmäßigen Verben sind wie das Präteritum + Endung '-e' + Umlaut, z.B. 'ich kam' → 'ich käme', 'du warst' → 'du wärest', 'sie fand' → 'sie fände', 'er ging' → 'er ginge'. Den Konjunktiv II verwendet man bei 'haben', 'sein', den Modalverben und einigen häufig gebrauchten unregelmäßigen und gemischten Verben. Sonst verwendet man 'würde' + Infinitiv.

EXAMPLES

→ *er schaute nach* → *er würde nachschauen*

→ *ich hatte* → *ich hätte*

→ *du konntest* → *du könntest*

→ *er wusste* → *er wüsste*

→ *ich kam* → *ich käme*

→ *du warst* → *du wärest*

→ *sie fand* → *sie fände*

→ *er ging* → *er ginge*

Irreale Konditionalsätze

■ From lesson

Unreal conditional sentences with Konjunktiv II express that the condition in the subordinate clause with 'wenn' is not fulfilled. This means that the consequence is not/only maybe realized.

COMPLETE RULE

Irreale Konditionalsätze mit dem Konjunktiv II drücken aus, dass die Bedingung im Nebensatz mit 'wenn' nicht erfüllt ist. Das bedeutet, dass die Folge nicht/nur vielleicht realisiert wird.

EXAMPLES

→ *Wenn Markus den Paketschein hätte, könnte er nachforschen, wo das Paket von seiner Schwester ist.* → *Markus hat den Paketschein nicht, daher kann er nicht nachforschen, wo das Paket von seiner Schwester ist.*

→ *Wenn seine Schwester Markus nächste Woche Bescheid geben könnte, wäre das toll.* → *Es ist toll, wenn seine Schwester ihm nächste Woche Bescheid geben kann. Aber es ist noch nicht sicher, dass sie das tun kann.*

Irreale Wunschsätze: Konjunktiv II

■ From lesson

Unreal wishes are expressed using Konjunktiv II, either with 'wenn' at the beginning or with the verb in Konjunktiv II at the beginning without 'wenn', or with 'oder' and verb in Konjunktiv II at the end

COMPLETE RULE

'wenn' am Satzanfang, Konjunktiv II am Ende OR Verb im Konjunktiv II am Satzanfang ohne 'wenn' OR 'oder' + Verb im Konjunktiv II am Satzanfang ohne 'wenn'. Irreale Wünsche verstärkt man oft mit den

Modalpartikeln 'doch', '(doch) nur' oder '(doch) bloß'.

EXAMPLES

→ *Wenn mir doch nur jemand helfen könnte!*

→ *Hätte ich doch bessere Noten!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Learners may forget to use Konjunktiv II forms or may misplace modal particles

Liste der unregelmäßigen und gemischten Verben (Irregular and Mixed Verbs List)

■ From lesson

This is a comprehensive list of irregular and mixed verbs in German showing their infinitive, simple past (Präteritum), and present perfect (Partizip II) forms. The list principally excludes verbs with separable or inseparable prefixes, with exceptions for verbs only used in these combinations (e.g. vergessen).

COMPLETE RULE

Irregular verbs in German change their stem vowel in the past tense forms. Partizip II forms use 'hat' or 'ist' as auxiliary verbs. Some verbs like 'stehen' and 'hängen' can use either auxiliary depending on region (marked with *). The verb 'ziehen' uses 'zog um' / 'ist umgezogen' in the separable form (marked with **).

EXAMPLES

→ Infinitiv: *haben* → Präteritum: *hatte* → Partizip II: *hat gehabt*

→ Infinitiv: *sein* → Präteritum: *ist* → Partizip II: *ist gewesen*

→ Infinitiv: *gehen* → Präteritum: *ging* → Partizip II: *ist gegangen*

→ Infinitiv: *nehmen* → Präteritum: *nahm* → Partizip II: *hat genommen*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Students often confuse when to use 'haben' vs 'ist' as auxiliary verb in Partizip II. Verbs of motion and change of state typically use 'ist'. Regional variations exist for some verbs (marked with *), where Southern Germany, Austria, and Switzerland use 'ist' instead of 'hat'.

(sich) lassen + Verb

■ From lesson

The verb '(sich) lassen' is often used with the infinitive of a second verb. In present tense: 'lässt sich' + infinitive. Perfect tense is formed with 'haben' + infinitive of 'lassen'. In perfect tense sentences and with

modal verbs, 'lassen' comes after the infinitive of the second verb.

COMPLETE RULE

Present: (sich) lassen + infinitive of second verb | Perfect: haben + infinitive of lassen | Perfect sentences and with modal verbs: lassen comes after the infinitive of the second verb

EXAMPLES

- *Christian lässt sich in der Informatikabteilung das Passwort vom Computer geben.*
- *Christian hat sich schon das Intranet zeigen lassen.*
- *Christian hat sich schon das Intranet zeigen lassen.*
- *Christian muss den Urlaubsantrag der Personalabteilung zukommen lassen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Word order in perfect tense - lassen comes after the infinitive of the second verb

Modalverben im Perfekt

■ From lesson

The perfect tense of modal verbs is formed with 'haben' + infinitive of the modal verb. The modal verbs come at the end of the sentence after the infinitive of the second verb.

COMPLETE RULE

Perfect tense of modal verbs: haben + infinitive of second verb + infinitive of modal verb (not past participle)

EXAMPLES

- *In der ersten Zeit in Dresden hat Christian viel arbeiten müssen.*
- *Er hat daher das Schloss noch nicht besuchen können.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using past participle (gemusst, gekonnt) instead of infinitive (müssen, können) in perfect tense with another verb

brauchen zu + Infinitiv - expressing necessity negatively

■ From lesson

'brauchen ... nur zu' + infinitive expresses 'only need to do something'. 'brauchen ... nicht zu' or 'brauchen ... kein ... zu' + infinitive means 'not need to' or 'don't have to', similar to 'nicht müssen'.

COMPLETE RULE

brauchen ... nur zu + Infinitiv = only need to do. brauchen ... nicht zu / brauchen ... kein ... zu + Infinitiv = don't need to, don't have to (same meaning as nicht müssen).

EXAMPLES

→ *Sie brauchen nur die Broschüre 'Länderinformationsschrift Österreich' zu bestellen.*

→ *Sie brauchen nicht lange zu warten.*

→ *Sie brauchen keine weiteren Informationen im Internet zu suchen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting 'zu' before the infinitive. Confusing with 'müssen nicht' (which can mean 'must not' in some contexts).

'zu' placement in separable verb infinitives

■ Web verified

With separable verbs in infinitive constructions requiring 'zu', the 'zu' is inserted between the separable prefix and the base verb, written as one word. Structure: prefix + zu + base verb stem (e.g., aufzuladen, anzurufen, einzukaufen).

COMPLETE RULE

Formation Pattern: [separable prefix] + zu + [verb stem] (written as one word)

Examples:

- *aufstehen* → *aufzustehen*

- *anrufen* → *anzurufen*

- *einkaufen* → *einzukaufen*

- *mitnehmen* → *mitzunehmen*

- *zurückkommen* → *zurückzukommen*

Usage contexts:

1. After certain verbs: *versuchen, vergessen, vorhaben, anfangen, aufhören*

2. With infinitive constructions: *um...zu, ohne...zu, (an)statt...zu*

3. After *sein* + adjective: *Es ist wichtig, früh aufzustehen.*

In modal verb constructions and future tense, the separable verb remains together in infinitive form WITHOUT zu (the verb stays whole at the end).

EXAMPLES

- *Ich versuche, die Batterie aufzuladen.*
- *Es ist wichtig, pünktlich anzukommen.*
- *Vergiss nicht, mich anzurufen.*
- *Ich habe keine Zeit, einkaufen zu gehen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may place 'zu' before the entire separable verb (e.g., *zu aufstehen instead of aufzustehen) because Italian 'di/a' precede the infinitive. They may write it as two separate words (*auf zu stehen). Italian doesn't have separable verbs, so the concept of inserting 'zu' inside the verb is completely foreign. Italian speakers may also forget that modal verbs DON'T use 'zu', similar to Italian modal verbs that take bare infinitives.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Modal verbs (können, müssen, wollen, sollen, dürfen, mögen) and the verbs 'lassen', 'sehen', 'hören' take a bare infinitive without 'zu'. With these verbs, separable verbs remain together but no 'zu' is inserted: 'Ich muss aufstehen' (not *aufzustehen). Inseparable verbs (beginnen with be-, ent-, er-, ver-, zer-, etc.) use 'zu' before the verb normally: 'zu verstehen', 'zu beginnen'.

Conditional mood with würde + infinitive

■ Web verified

To express conditional actions (would do), German uses würde + infinitive construction. This is called Konjunktiv II with würde-form. The construction is: subject + würde (conjugated) + other elements + infinitive (at end of clause). This form is used to avoid confusion when Konjunktiv II forms are identical to Präteritum, especially for regular verbs. It's more natural than using archaic Konjunktiv II forms for many verbs.

COMPLETE RULE

Conjugation: ich würde, du würdest, er/sie/es würde, wir würden, ihr würdet, sie/Sie würden + infinitive (placed at end of clause). Example: 'Wenn ich an deiner Stelle wäre, würde ich Deutsch lernen' (If I were in your place, I would learn German). Used for expressing present hypothetical/conditional situations.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich würde dir gerne helfen. (I would like to help you.)*
- *Was würdest du in dieser Situation machen? (What would you do in this situation?)*
- *Wenn ich du wäre, würde ich nicht dort arbeiten. (If I were you, I wouldn't work there.)*
- *Ich würde mit einem anderen Trainer bessere Fortschritte machen. (I would make better progress with another trainer.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use imperfect forms instead of würde construction; forgetting to place the infinitive at the end of the clause; using würde with modal verbs when direct Konjunktiv II is preferred (sollte, könnte, müsste instead of würde sollen/können/müssen); overusing würde in both clauses of conditional sentences

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Modal verbs (können, sollen, müssen, dürfen, mögen, wollen) and common verbs like haben/sein typically use direct Konjunktiv II forms: könnte, sollte, müsste, dürfte, möchte, wollte, wäre, hätte. The auxiliary verb werden also uses würde. For strong/irregular verbs with recognizable Konjunktiv II forms (like ginge, käme), either form is acceptable, though würde-construction is increasingly common in spoken German.

Confusion: 'bezahlen' (to pay) vs 'zählen' (to count)

■ Web verified

'Bezahlen' is a regular separable-prefix verb meaning 'to pay (for something)' and takes a direct accusative object (what you're paying for). 'Zählen' is a regular verb meaning 'to count' (enumerate) or used with 'auf' + accusative to mean 'to count on/rely on someone'. The confusion arises from their similar spelling and the fact that Italian speakers may mix up 'pagare' (pay) and 'contare' (count) with the German equivalents due to false cognates.

COMPLETE RULE

BEZAHLEN (be-zahlen): Etymology: be- (prefix) + zahlen (to pay). Meaning: to pay, to pay for. Construction: bezahlen + ACCUSATIVE (what you pay for). Conjugation (regular weak verb): ich bezahle, du bezahlst, er/sie/es bezahlt, wir bezahlen, ihr bezahlt, sie/Sie bezahlen. Perfect: hat bezahlt (auxiliary: haben). Examples: 'Ich bezahle das Eis' (I'm paying for the ice cream), 'Hast du die Rechnung bezahlt?' (Did you pay the bill?). **ZÄHLEN**: Meaning 1: to count (enumerate). Construction: zählen + ACCUSATIVE (what you count). Example: 'Ich zähle das Geld' (I'm counting the money). Meaning 2: to count on, rely on. Construction: zählen + auf + ACCUSATIVE. Example: 'Wir zählen auf Sie' (We count on you). Conjugation (regular weak verb): ich zähle, du zählst, er/sie/es zählt, wir zählen, ihr zählt, sie/zählen. Perfect: hat gezählt (auxiliary: haben).

EXAMPLES

→ Ich bezahle das Eis. (I'm paying for the ice cream - bezahlen + accusative)

→ Wir zählen auf Sie. (We count on you)

zählen auf + accusative)

→ Kannst du bis zehn zählen? (Can you count to ten? - zählen = enumerate)

→ Soll ich die Rechnung bezahlen? (Should I pay the bill?)

bezahlen + accusative)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers confuse them due to similar spelling and false cognates with Italian: mixing 'pagare' (pay) with 'zählen' or 'contare' (count) with 'bezahlen'. Errors: *'Ich zähle das Eis' (incorrect - wrong verb, should be 'bezahle'). *'Wir bezahlen auf Sie' (incorrect - wrong verb and preposition). *'Ich zahle das Eis' (missing prefix 'be-' changes meaning - 'zahlen' alone is archaic/literary). Pronunciation confusion: 'bezahlen' [bɛtsaːlən] vs 'zählen' [tsaːlən] - failing to hear/produce the prefix 'be-'. Case errors: using dative instead of accusative object with 'bezahlen'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The simple verb 'zahlen' (without prefix 'be-') exists but is archaic/literary, rarely used in modern German except in fixed expressions: 'Zahntag' (payday), 'Zahlungsmittel' (means of payment). In Austria and Southern Germany, 'zahlen' alone may still be used where Standard German uses 'bezahlen'. 'Zählen zu' means 'to be among, to be counted as': 'Er zählt zu den Besten' (He's among the best). 'Bezahlen für' is redundant but sometimes heard: usually 'bezahlen' alone suffices with accusative object.

Dative verb 'gefallen' (to please/like appearance)

■ Web verified

The verb 'gefallen' (to please) uses dative case where the thing/person liked is the nominative subject and the person who likes is in dative: 'Das Auto gefällt mir' (The car pleases me = I like the car). It typically refers to aesthetic appreciation of appearance or looks, distinguishing it from 'mögen' which is more emotional and refers to liking character or general preferences.

COMPLETE RULE

CONJUGATION (Present Tense):

ich gefalle / du gefälltst / er-sie-es gefällt / wir gefallen / ihr gefällt / sie gefallen

PRINCIPLE PAST: gefiel

PAST PARTICIPLE: gefallen (with 'haben')

STRUCTURE: [Thing/Person liked - NOMINATIVE] + gefällt/gefallen + [Person who likes - DATIVE]

DATIVE PRONOUNS: mir, dir, ihm, ihr, uns, euch, ihnen, Ihnen

VERB AGREEMENT: The verb agrees with the nominative subject (the thing liked), NOT the dative object.

Singular thing: 'Der Film gefällt mir' (singular verb)

Plural things: 'Die Schuhe gefallen mir' (plural verb)

EXAMPLES

→ *Dein Hund gefällt mir sehr. (I really like how your dog looks / Your dog pleases me very much)*

→ *Die neue Jacke gefällt mir nicht. (I don't like the new jacket / The new jacket doesn't please me)*

→ *Gefällt dir dieser Film?* (Do you like this movie? / Does this movie please you?)

→ *Diese Schuhe gefallen mir richtig gut.* (I really like these shoes / These shoes please me very well)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers commonly make two critical errors: (1) **REVERSED SUBJECT-OBJECT**: Saying 'Ich gefalle das Buch' (I please the book) instead of 'Das Buch gefällt mir' (The book pleases me / I like the book). Italian uses 'mi piace' where 'mi' is indirect object, but the sentence structure differs. (2) **USING ACCUSATIVE**: Saying 'Das Auto gefällt mich' instead of 'Das Auto gefällt mir' - confusing accusative 'mich' with dative 'mir' because Italian doesn't distinguish these cases.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When 'gefallen' is used with reflexive pronoun 'sich', it means 'to behave in a self-satisfied way' - a completely different meaning. Example: 'Er gefällt sich in seiner Rolle' (He's pleased with himself in his role). The verb can also mean 'to let something happen to oneself' in the construction 'sich etwas gefallen lassen' (to put up with something).

Directional adverbs: hin and her

■ Web verified

German uses 'hin' to indicate movement away from the speaker (to there) and 'her' to indicate movement toward the speaker (to here). These combine with other adverbs (dorthin = to there, hierher = to here) and can form separable verbs (hinfliegen = to fly there, herkommen = to come here). The question words are 'wohin' (where to) answered by 'dorthin', and 'woher' (where from) answered by 'von dort'.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE DIRECTIONAL ADVERB SYSTEM:

BASIC PARTICLES:

- *hin* = away from speaker (movement to there)
- *her* = toward speaker (movement to here)

COMBINATIONS WITH LOCATION ADVERBS:

- *hierher* = (to) here, hither
- *dorthin/dahin* = (to) there, thither
- *wohin* = where to (question)
- *woher* = where from (question)

COMBINATIONS WITH PREPOSITIONS:

- *hinein/herein (rein)* = in (away/toward)
- *hinaus/heraus (raus)* = out (away/toward)
- *hinauf/herauf (rauf)* = up (away/toward)

- *hinunter/herunter* (runter) = down (away/toward)
- *hinüber/herüber* (rüber) = over/across (away/toward)

AS SEPARABLE VERB PREFIXES:

- *hinkommen* = to get there, arrive
- *hergehen* = to come here, walk here
- *hinfliegen* = to fly there
- *herkommen* = to come (from)

SEPARATION IN SENTENCES:

Present tense: *Er fliegt nächste Woche hin.*

Perfect tense: *Er ist hingeflogen.*

With modal: *Er will hinfliegen.*

QUESTION-ANSWER PATTERNS:

Wohin fährst du? → *Ich fahre nach Berlin/dorthin.*

Woher kommst du? → *Ich komme aus Italien/von dort.*

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich fliege nächste Woche hin.* (I'm flying there next week.) - 'hin' separates to end

→ *Komm bitte hierher!* (Please come here!) - 'her' indicates toward speaker

→ *Wohin fährst du morgen?* - *Ich fahre nach München.* (Where are you going tomorrow? - I'm going to Munich.)

→ *Die Kinder laufen die Treppe hinauf.* (The children are running up the stairs.) - movement away from speaker perspective

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER ERRORS:

- 1. OMITTING HIN/HER: Italian has no equivalent directional particles. Italians often say **'Ich gehe'* instead of *'Ich gehe hin'* (I'm going there). In Italian: *'Vado'* or *'Vado là'* - the directional element is optional.
- 2. USING WRONG DIRECTION: Confusing hin/her perspective. **'Komm hin!'* instead of *'Komm her!'* Italian uses *'vieni qui'* (come here) without speaker-reference particles.
- 3. MIXING WITH WO: Using 'wo' instead of 'wohin' for movement. **'Wo gehst du?'* instead of *'Wohin gehst du?'* Italian uses *'Dove vai?'* for both location and direction.
- 4. FORGETTING IN SEPARABLE VERBS: **'Er kommt nicht'* instead of *'Er kommt nicht her/hin'* when direction is implied. Italian: *'Non viene'* is sufficient without directional specification.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

- 1. **COLLOQUIAL OMISSION:** In spoken German, *hin/her* are sometimes dropped when context is clear: *'Gehst du mit?'* (Are you going along?) instead of *'Gehst du dahin mit?'*

2. IDIOMATIC TIME EXPRESSIONS: 'hin und her' = back and forth; 'hin und wieder' = now and then (from and again) - these are fixed expressions.

3. FIXED REGIONAL USAGE: Some regions prefer 'rein/raus/rauf/runter' (shortened forms) over full 'herein/hinaus' etc.

4. WITH CERTAIN VERBS: Some verbs have hin/her integrated and don't separate: 'hinterlassen' (to leave behind) - inseparable prefix.

es gab (Imperfekt) for weather expressions

■ Web verified

For weather expressions with 'es gibt', German prefers Präteritum/Imperfekt (es gab) over Perfekt (es hat gegeben) in both spoken and written language. While Perfekt is generally preferred in spoken German, 'es gab' remains an exception alongside other commonly used verbs like sein, haben, werden, and modal verbs.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete conjugation of 'geben' in Präteritum:

- ich gab (I gave/there was)
- du gabst (you gave)
- er/sie/es gab (he/she/it gave / there was)
- wir gaben (we gave)
- ihr gabt (you gave)
- sie/Sie gaben (they/you formal gave)

Perfekt forms (less preferred for weather):

- es hat gegeben (there has been)

Usage: 'es gibt' means 'there is/are' and in impersonal weather expressions, the Präteritum 'es gab' is strongly preferred over Perfekt even in conversational contexts. This aligns with the preference for Präteritum with auxiliary verbs (sein, haben, werden) and modal verbs in spoken German.

EXAMPLES

- Letzte Woche gab es 33 Grad. (Last week there were 33 degrees.)
- Es gab hohe Wellen gestern. (There were high waves yesterday.)
- Es gab viele Wolken. (There were many clouds.)
- Es gab Gewitter und starken Regen. (There was a thunderstorm and heavy rain.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly overgeneralize the Perfekt tense from spoken German to all contexts. In Italian, the passato prossimo (similar to German Perfekt) is the standard conversational past tense.

However, Italian speakers may incorrectly say 'es hat gegeben' when 'es gab' is more natural. They may also fail to recognize that certain high-frequency verbs (sein, haben, werden, geben in weather expressions, modals) prefer Präteritum even in speech. Additionally, Italian's imperfetto vs. passato prossimo distinction doesn't map perfectly onto German's Präteritum vs. Perfekt, causing confusion.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The Perfekt form 'es hat gegeben' can be used in formal written contexts or when emphasizing a result that extends to the present. However, this is rare for weather expressions. In northern Germany, Präteritum is more common overall, while southern German speakers use more Perfekt in general speech, but 'es gab' for weather remains preferred across all regions.

herunter vs hinunter (directional prefixes)

■ Web verified

'her-' indicates movement toward the speaker (hither, to here), while 'hin-' indicates movement away from the speaker (thither, to there). Combined with 'unter' (under/down): 'herunter' expresses movement downward toward the speaker, while 'hinunter' expresses movement downward away from the speaker. This deictic distinction adds the speaker's perspective to directional motion.

COMPLETE RULE

Basic distinction:

- her- = toward the speaker (hither, to me/here)
- hin- = away from the speaker (thither, to there/away)

Common combinations with directions:

Toward speaker (her-):

- herauf (up toward speaker)
- herab (down toward speaker)
- herunter (down toward speaker)
- heraus (out toward speaker)
- herein (in toward speaker)
- herüber (over toward speaker)

Away from speaker (hin-):

- hinauf (up away from speaker)
- hinab (down away from speaker)
- hinunter (down away from speaker)
- hinaus (out away from speaker)
- hinein (in away from speaker)
- hinüber (over away from speaker)

Colloquial shortened forms (neutralize distinction):

- *rauf* (*herauf/hinauf*)
- *runter* (*herunter/hinunter*)
- *raus* (*heraus/hinaus*)
- *rein* (*herein/hinein*)

Usage with separable verbs:

- *herunterkommen* (to come down, toward speaker)
- *hinuntergehen* (to go down, away from speaker)
- *herunterhandeln* (to bargain down - figurative use)

EXAMPLES

→ ***Er hat den Preis heruntergehandelt.*** (*He bargained the price down.*

from buyer's perspective/toward speaker)

→ ***Der Verkäufer sagt: Er hat den Preis hinuntergehandelt.*** (*The seller says: He bargained the price down.*

from seller's perspective/away from speaker)

→ ***Komm herunter!*** (*Come down here to me!*)

→ ***Geh hinunter in den Keller!*** (*Go down to the basement! - away from speaker*)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers struggle with this concept because Italian doesn't grammatically encode the speaker's perspective in directional verbs. Italian uses context or separate expressions:

1. **Translating both as same word:** Using 'scendere' for both 'hinunter-' and 'herunter-' without distinction
2. **Omitting the directional particle entirely**, as Italian often doesn't require it
3. **Confusing the perspective:** Using 'hinunter' when 'herunter' is appropriate and vice versa
4. **Not recognizing that the speaker's location determines the choice**
5. **Overgeneralizing shortened forms** (*rauf*, *runter*) to formal contexts
6. **In Italian**, expressions like '*vieni giù!*' (come down!) don't mark whether movement is toward or away from speaker - German requires this: '*Komm herunter!*' (come down to me)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In colloquial speech, especially in northern Germany, 'her-' is often preferred regardless of actual direction, blurring the distinction. Southern German speakers maintain the distinction more strictly. The shortened forms (*rauf*, *runter*, *raus*, *rein*) neutralize the her-/hin- distinction entirely and are very common in spoken German but should be avoided in formal writing. Figurative uses like '*herunterhandeln*' (to bargain down) have become lexicalized and don't strictly follow the spatial logic.

holen vs. nehmen: movement distinction

■ Web verified

The verbs 'holen' and 'nehmen' both relate to taking or getting something, but they differ crucially in whether movement is required. 'Nehmen' means to take something that is within reach or immediately available (no significant movement needed). 'Holen' means to go and get/fetch something from another location (movement required). The separable verb 'abholen' specifically means to pick up someone or something, usually implying you will bring them/it somewhere else.

COMPLETE RULE

NEHMEN (to take - strong verb, stem change: nehmen, nimmt, nahm, genommen):

Conjugation Present:

ich nehme

du nimmst

er/sie/es nimmt

wir nehmen

ihr nehmt

sie/Sie nehmen

Perfect: hat genommen

Präteritum: nahm

Usage:

1. Taking something within arm's reach

- Ich nehme das Glas. (I take the glass.)

- Kannst du mir das Salz nehmen? (Can you pass me the salt?)

2. Making a choice/selection

- Ich nehme das Schnitzel. (I'll take the schnitzel - ordering food)

- Welchen Bus nimmst du? (Which bus do you take?)

3. Using/taking transportation

- Ich nehme den Zug. (I'm taking the train.)

4. Accepting something offered

- Nehmen Sie Kreditkarten? (Do you accept credit cards?)

HOLEN (to get/fetch - regular verb: holen, holte, geholt):

Conjugation Present:

ich hole

du holst

er/sie/es holt

wir holen

ihr holt

sie/Sie holen

Perfect: hat geholt

Präteritum: holte

Usage:

1. Getting something from another place (movement required)

- Ich hole Wasser aus der Küche. (I'll get water from the kitchen.)

- Kannst du das Buch holen? (Can you get/fetch the book?)

2. Going to get and return with something

- Ich hole schnell meine Tasche. (I'll quickly get my bag.)

3. Fetching/retrieving

- Wir holen den Brief aus dem Briefkasten. (We get the letter from the mailbox.)

ABHOLEN (to pick up - separable verb: abholen, holte...ab, abgeholt):

Conjugation Present:

ich hole...ab

du holst...ab

er/sie/es holt...ab

wir holen...ab

ihr holt...ab

sie/Sie holen...ab

Perfect: hat abgeholt

Usage:

1. Picking up people

- Ich hole dich am Flughafen ab. (I'll pick you up at the airport.)

- Kannst du mich abholen? (Can you pick me up?)

2. Collecting something that's ready/waiting

- Das Auto ist repariert, ich hole es ab. (The car is fixed, I'll pick it up.)

- Ich hole das Paket bei der Post ab. (I'm picking up the package at the post office.)

EXAMPLES

→ Ich hole Wasser aus der Küche. (I'll get water from the kitchen - requires walking to another room.)

→ Ich nehme das Glas. (I take the glass

it's right in front of me.)

→ *Ich hole meinen Freund am Flughafen ab. (I'm picking up my friend at the airport.)*

→ *Kannst du das Handy holen? Es liegt im Schlafzimmer. (Can you get the phone? It's in the bedroom.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers make these errors:

■ 1. USING 'NEHMEN' FOR EVERYTHING: Incorrect: *Ich nehme Wasser aus der Küche. Correct: Ich hole Wasser aus der Küche. (Italian 'prendere' covers both, but German distinguishes: nehmen = take (close), holen = fetch (far))

■ 2. USING 'HOLEN' FOR CLOSE OBJECTS: Incorrect: *Ich hole das Glas (das vor mir steht). Correct: Ich nehme das Glas. (If it's right in front of you, use 'nehmen')

■ 3. PERFECT TENSE CONFUSION: Incorrect: *Ich habe das Buch gehohlt. Correct: Ich habe das Buch geholt. (Past participle is 'geholt', not *gehohlt)

■ 4. NEHMEN STEM CHANGE: Incorrect: *Du nimmst, er nimmt is correct, but beginners forget: *Du nehmt, *er nehmt. Correct: du nimmst, er/sie/es nimmt

■ 5. FORGETTING 'AB' WITH PEOPLE: Incorrect: *Ich hole dich am Flughafen. Correct: Ich hole dich am Flughafen ab. (For picking up people, 'abholen' is more natural)

■ 6. WORD ORDER WITH 'ABHOLEN': Incorrect: *Ich abhole dich. Correct: Ich hole dich ab. (Separable prefix goes to end in main clause)

7. ITALIAN CALQUES:

- Italian 'andare a prendere' → German 'holen gehen' (awkward) → just 'holen'

- Italian 'venire a prendere' → German 'abholen' (for picking up)

■ 8. USING 'BEKOMMEN': Incorrect: *Ich bekomme das Buch. (means 'I receive/get given the book'). Correct: Ich hole das Buch. OR Ich nehme das Buch. (bekommen = receive passively)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. IDIOMATIC EXPRESSIONS WITH 'HOLEN':

- Luft holen (to catch one's breath - no movement)
- tief Luft holen (to take a deep breath)
- Schwung holen (to gain momentum)
- sich einen Rat holen (to get advice)
- sich Hilfe holen (to get help)

2. IDIOMATIC WITH 'NEHMEN':

- Rücksicht nehmen auf (to consider/show consideration)
- in Anspruch nehmen (to take advantage of)
- ernst nehmen (to take seriously)
- Abschied nehmen (to say goodbye)
- Platz nehmen (to take a seat)
- in Kauf nehmen (to accept/put up with)

3. INTERCHANGEABLE IN SOME CONTEXTS:

- Ich nehme ein Taxi. (I'm taking a taxi - more common)
- Ich hole mir ein Taxi. (I'm getting myself a taxi - less common)

4. REGIONAL VARIATIONS:

In some regions, 'holen' is used more broadly, but standard German maintains the distinction.

5. WITH 'SICH' (REFLEXIVE):

- sich etwas holen (to get oneself something - often implies going to get it)
- sich etwas nehmen (to take something for oneself - within reach)

Example: Ich hole mir einen Kaffee. (I'm getting myself a coffee - going to café/kitchen)

Example: Ich nehme mir einen Keks. (I'm taking a cookie - from the plate in front of me)

6. NEHMEN WITHOUT MOVEMENT:

- Nehmen Sie Platz! (Please take a seat - idiomatic, no 'holen')
- Zeit nehmen (to take time - abstract, no movement)

irgend- prefix with pronouns and adverbs

■ Web verified

The prefix 'irgend-' adds indefiniteness meaning 'some-/any-' or vagueness: irgendwo (somewhere/anywhere), irgendjemand (someone/anyone), irgendwann (sometime/anytime), irgendwie (somehow/someway), irgendwohin (to somewhere), irgendwas/irgendetwas (something/anything), irgendein (some/any - requires declension). It emphasizes lack of specific knowledge or that the exact detail doesn't matter. Never stands alone (except phrase 'wenn irgend möglich').

COMPLETE RULE

IRGEND- PREFIX FORMS: irgendwo (somewhere), irgendwohin (to somewhere), irgendwoher (from somewhere), irgendwann (sometime), irgendwie (somehow), irgendwas/irgendetwas (something - invariable), irgendjemand/irgendwer (someone - declinable), irgendein (some/any - declines like 'ein').
DECLENSION OF IRGENDEIN: Masculine: irgendein (nom.), irgendeinen (acc.), irgendeinem (dat.), irgendeines (gen.). Feminine: irgendeine (nom./acc.), irgendeiner (dat./gen.). Neuter: irgendein (nom./acc.), irgendeinem (dat.), irgendeines (gen.). Plural: irgendwelche (all cases have different forms like 'welche').
IRGENDJEMAND declension: Nominative: irgendjemand, Accusative: irgendjemand(en), Dative: irgendjemand(em), Genitive: irgendjemand(e)s. Note: Dative/accusative endings optional.
 Meaning: expresses 'some-ness' or vagueness - the speaker doesn't know or doesn't care about specifics.

EXAMPLES

- Mein Handy ist irgendwo in der Wohnung. (My phone is somewhere in the apartment)
- Gibt es irgendjemanden, der Chinesisch spricht? (Is there anyone who speaks Chinese?)
- Hast du irgendeine Idee? (Do you have any idea at all?)
- Irgendwann werden wir uns wiedersehen. (Sometime we will see each other again)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers struggle because Italian uses different words without a unified prefix system ('qualcosa, qualcuno, da qualche parte' etc.). Common errors: (1) Spacing error: *'irgend ein' instead of 'irgendein' (must be one word). (2) Wrong plural: *'irgendeine Leute' instead of 'irgendwelche Leute' (irgendein has no plural, use irgendwelche). (3) Declining invariable forms: *'irgendetwas' with endings instead of keeping it unchanged. (4) Capitalization: *'irgend Wo' instead of 'irgendwo'. (5) Confusing irgendein (some/any) with kein (no/none) - opposite meanings.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The only time 'irgend' stands alone is in the fixed phrase 'wenn irgend möglich' (if at all possible). Otherwise ALWAYS appears as prefix attached to another word. The forms irgendetwas/irgendwas and irgendjemand/irgendwer are interchangeable (shorter forms more colloquial). Irgendein has no plural - use irgendwelche instead. When emphasizing vagueness even more, use 'irgend' forms; when less vague, use simple forms (etwas, jemand, wo, etc.).

kaputt machen (separable-like structure)

■ Web verified

To express breaking or destroying something, German uses 'kaputt machen' (make broken/destroy). It behaves like a separable verb: 'kaputt' separates and goes to the end in main clauses with simple tenses, but stays together in compound tenses (Perfekt/Plusquamperfekt) and in subordinate clauses. In Perfekt, it forms 'kaputt gemacht' (past participle).

COMPLETE RULE

Present tense (separated): Er macht das Fenster kaputt. Perfekt (together): Er hat das Fenster kaputt gemacht. Subordinate clause (together): ...weil er es kaputt macht. Can be written as one word (kaputtmachen) or two words (kaputt machen) - both spellings are correct. Duden recommends Getrennschreibung (separate writing) as primary form.

EXAMPLES

- *Er macht das Fenster kaputt. (He breaks the window.)*
- *Er hat ein Fenster kaputt gemacht. (He broke a window.)*
- *Ich habe mein Handy kaputt gemacht. (I broke my phone.)*
- *Reiß dir nicht das Hemd kaputt! (Don't tear your shirt!)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers try to conjugate 'kaputt' as if it were a verb (*gekaputtet); separating incorrectly in Perfekt (*Er hat kaputt das Fenster gemacht); using wrong auxiliary verb (sein instead of haben); not placing 'kaputt' at the end in main clauses; confusion about spelling (one word vs. two words)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Both spellings are acceptable: 'kaputt machen' (separated) and 'kaputtmachen' (together). Duden recommends the separated form. In combinations describing result of action, both are valid: 'Das Auto ist kaputt gefahren/kaputtgefahren.' With reflexive use for exhaustion: 'sich kaputt machen' (to exhaust oneself).

Konjunktiv II für Hypothesen (wäre, würde)

■ Web verified

Konjunktiv II expresses hypothetical/unreal situations, wishes, and polite requests. For 'sein' and 'haben', use original forms (wäre, hätte). For modal verbs, use original forms (könnte, sollte, müsste, dürfte, möchte, wollte). For other verbs, use 'würde + infinitive'. Example: 'Wenn ich die Mutter wäre, würde ich etwas sagen.'

COMPLETE RULE

PRESENT: sein → ich wäre, du wärest, er/sie/es wäre, wir wären, ihr wärt, sie/Sie wären | haben → ich hätte, du hättest, er/sie/es hätte, wir hätten, ihr hättet, sie/Sie hätten | werden → ich würde, du würdest, er würde, wir würden, ihr würdet, sie würden | Other verbs: würde + infinitive (ich würde sagen, du würdest machen) | Modals: könnte, sollte, müsste, dürfte, möchte, wollte | PAST: hätte/wäre + Partizip II (ich hätte gesagt, ich wäre gegangen)

EXAMPLES

→ *Wenn ich die Mutter wäre, würde ich etwas sagen. (If I were the mother, I would say something.)*

→ *Was würdest du machen, wenn du Zeit hättest? (What would you do if you had time?)*

→ **Ich hätte gerne einen Kaffee. (I would like a coffee**

polite request.)

→ *Wenn er früher gegangen wäre, hätte er den Zug erwischt. (If he had left earlier, he would have caught the train.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers using Präsens instead of Konjunktiv II in hypothetical 'wenn' clauses. Saying 'ich würde sein' or 'ich würde haben' instead of 'ich wäre' or 'ich hätte'. Forgetting to use Konjunktiv II for polite requests ('Ich will' instead of 'Ich hätte gern').

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Modal verbs and some strong verbs (kommen, gehen, wissen, lassen, tun) have their own Konjunktiv II forms that can be used instead of würde-construction (käme, ginge, wüsste, ließe, täte). However, würde + infinitive is often preferred in spoken German for weak verbs to avoid confusion with Präteritum.

lügen vs. belügen/anlügen - direct object changes verb

■ Web verified

The verb 'lügen' (to lie) is intransitive and cannot take a direct object. However, 'belügen' and 'anlügen' are transitive with the prefix making the person a direct accusative object. The prefix 'be-' transforms intransitive verbs to transitive verbs that take accusative objects directly.

COMPLETE RULE

Conjugation:

lügen: ich lüge, du lügst, er lügt (intransitive - no direct person object)

belügen: ich belüge dich, er belügt mich (transitive - takes accusative)

anlügen: ich lüge dich an, er log sie an (separable transitive - takes accusative)

Structure patterns:

- *lügen: requires preposition (zu + dative) for person: 'Ich lüge zu dir' (archaic/rare)*

- *belügen: direct accusative: 'Ich belüge dich'*

- *anlügen: direct accusative: 'Ich lüge dich an'*

The prefix 'be-' systematically creates transitive verbs from intransitive ones by eliminating prepositions and creating direct accusative objects.

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich lüge. (I lie**

no object, intransitive)

→ **Ich belüge dich. (I lie to you**

accusative direct object)

→ **Ich lüge dich an. (I lie to you**

accusative, separable verb)

→ **Er hat mich angelogen. (He lied to me**

past perfect, 'an' separates: angelogen)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers try using 'lügen' with a direct object like 'mentire a qualcuno' becomes 'Ich lüge dich' (wrong - should be 'Ich belüge dich' or 'Ich lüge dich an'). Also confusing when to use belügen vs anlügen: both mean the same but anlügen is slightly more colloquial and separable.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The verb 'lügen' alone almost never takes 'zu + person' in modern German. Instead, Germans use 'belügen' or 'anlügen' for lying to someone. 'Lügen' is used alone: 'Du lügst!' (You're lying!) or with prepositions about topics: 'über etwas lügen'.

Modal verb 'sollen' in Konjunktiv II: 'sollte' for advice (should)

■ Web verified

The modal verb 'sollen' in its Konjunktiv II form 'sollte' expresses advice, recommendations, or suggestions (English 'should'). It is softer and more polite than the present tense 'soll' which expresses obligation or is used to ask for instructions. The Konjunktiv II of modal verbs is formed by taking the Präteritum stem, adding an Umlaut (for most modals), and adding subjunctive endings. 'Sollte' is one of the most commonly used Konjunktiv II forms in everyday German.

COMPLETE RULE

SOLLEN CONJUGATION:

Present (Indikativ): *ich soll, du sollst, er/sie/es soll, wir sollen, ihr sollt, sie sollen*

Meaning: *shall, supposed to, should (obligation or asking for instructions)*

Präteritum: *ich sollte, du solltest, er/sie/es sollte, wir sollten, ihr solltet, sie sollten*

Konjunktiv II (Present): *ich sollte, du solltest, er/sie/es sollte, wir sollten, ihr solltet, sie sollten*

Meaning: *should (advice, recommendation)*

(Note: Präteritum and Konjunktiv II forms are IDENTICAL for 'sollen')

FORMATION OF KONJUNKTIV II FOR MODAL VERBS:

1. Take Präteritum stem
2. Add Umlaut (if possible): *können*→*könnte*, *müssen*→*müsste*, *dürfen*→*dürfte*
3. Exception: *sollen*→*sollte*, *wollen*→*wollte* (NO Umlaut because 'o' doesn't take Umlaut to ö in subjunctive)
4. Add endings: *-e, -est, -e, -en, -et, -en*

COMPLETE KONJUNKTIV II MODAL VERBS:

können → *könnte* (could, would be able to)

müssen → *müsste* (would have to)

dürfen → *dürfte* (would be allowed to)

sollen → *sollte* (should)

wollen → *wollte* (would want - rarely used, use 'möchte' instead)

mögen → *möchte* (would like)

USAGE:

1. Advice/Recommendation: *Du solltest mehr Wasser trinken.* (You should drink more water.)
2. Polite suggestion: *Wir sollten jetzt gehen.* (We should go now.)

3. Moral obligation: *Man sollte immer die Wahrheit sagen. (One should always tell the truth.)*

CONTRAST WITH PRESENT TENSE:

Present 'soll': *Soll ich das Fenster öffnen? (Shall I open the window? / Am I supposed to open the window?)*

Konjunktiv II 'sollte': *Du solltest das Fenster öffnen. (You should open the window.)*

EXAMPLES

→ *Der Mann rechts sollte den Einkauf machen. (The man on the right should do the shopping.)*

→ *Du solltest mehr Wasser trinken. (You should drink more water.)*

→ *Wir sollten früher ins Bett gehen. (We should go to bed earlier.)*

→ *Sie sollten einen Arzt aufsuchen. (You should see a doctor.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: 1) Using 'würde + sollen' instead of 'sollte' directly. Incorrect: *'Du würdest sollen mehr Sport machen' → Correct: 'Du solltest mehr Sport machen.' (Never use 'würde' with modal verbs in Konjunktiv II). 2) Confusing 'sollte' (should - advice) with 'musste' (had to - past obligation). Italian 'dovrei' = German 'sollte', but Italian 'dovevo' can mean both 'I was supposed to' and 'I had to.' German distinguishes: 'ich sollte' (Konjunktiv II, advice) vs 'ich sollte' (Präteritum, was supposed to) vs 'ich musste' (had to). Context determines meaning. 3) Forgetting the Umlaut on other modal verbs: Incorrect: *'Du musste mehr lernen' → Correct: 'Du müsstest mehr lernen' OR 'Du solltest mehr lernen.' 4) Using present tense instead of Konjunktiv II for advice: Incorrect: *'Du sollst mehr essen' (sounds like an order) → Correct for advice: 'Du solltest mehr essen.' 5) Adding 'zu' before the infinitive: Incorrect: *'Du solltest zu arbeiten' → Correct: 'Du solltest arbeiten' (modal verbs take bare infinitive, no 'zu').

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The Präteritum form 'sollte' and the Konjunktiv II form 'sollte' are identical for the verb 'sollen.' Context determines the meaning: 'Er sollte gestern kommen' can mean either 'He was supposed to come yesterday' (Präteritum, obligation in past) or 'He should come yesterday' (Konjunktiv II - unusual but possible). In past Konjunktiv II with modal verbs, use double infinitive construction: 'Er hätte kommen sollen' (He should have come). The modal 'mögen' has a special Konjunktiv II form 'möchte' used so frequently it's taught as if it were a separate present tense modal verb meaning 'would like.'

Modal Verb 'sollen' in Present Tense

■ Web verified

Sollen in the present tense (Präsens) expresses an obligation, instruction, duty, or what someone is supposed to do according to external requirements, orders, or third-party instructions. It translates to 'shall I...?', 'am supposed to', or 'should' (as an obligation from someone else), NOT the Konjunktiv II 'sollte' which means 'should' as advice or recommendation. Sollen is unique among modal verbs because it has no vowel change in conjugation. It is used to express commands passed on from others, assignments, rules, expectations, or to report what someone said one should do.

COMPLETE RULE

Sollen conjugation (Präsens): ich soll, du sollst, er/sie/es soll, wir sollen, ihr sollt, sie/Sie sollen. Structure: subject + sollen (conjugated) + other elements + infinitive at end. Sollen is the only modal verb with no stem vowel change (no umlaut change). Usage: (1) External obligation/order from authority (e.g., 'Die Kinder sollen Hausaufgaben machen' - The teacher assigned homework). (2) Reporting instructions/commands (e.g., 'Du sollst den Müll rausbringen' - You're supposed to take out the trash). (3) Expressing purpose or expectation (e.g., 'Das soll genug sein' - That should be enough). (4) With Konjunktiv II (sollte): gives advice or recommendation (e.g., 'Du solltest mehr lernen' - You should study more). Difference from müssen: müssen expresses necessity, while sollen emphasizes an external instruction or expectation. Negation: nicht sollen expresses prohibition, while nicht müssen means something is not necessary.

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich soll in den USA wohnen. (I am supposed to live in the USA.**

The job requires it.)

→ **Was soll ich machen? (What shall I do? / What am I supposed to do?)**

→ **Die Kinder sollen ihr Zimmer aufräumen. (The children are supposed to clean their room. - Parents told them to.)**

→ **Du solltest mehr Wasser trinken. (You should drink more water.**

Konjunktiv II, advice)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often translate 'sollen' as 'dovere' (must/should) without understanding the nuance that *sollen* specifically indicates an external obligation or instruction from someone else, not internal necessity. They may confuse *sollen* (present tense = supposed to) with *sollte* (Konjunktiv II = should as advice). For example, saying 'Ich soll lernen' means someone told me to study, while 'Ich sollte lernen' means I should study (it's good advice). Italian speakers may also use *müssen* when *sollen* is more appropriate if emphasizing an external command. They might forget that *sollen* is the most regular modal verb with no vowel changes. In past tense constructions, they may struggle with the double infinitive (e.g., 'Ich habe lernen sollen' - I was supposed to study).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Sollen can also express reported speech or hearsay (e.g., 'Er soll reich sein' - He is said to be rich / They say he's rich). In Konjunktiv II, *sollte/sollten* expresses polite suggestions, advice, or hypothetical obligations rather than direct commands. When used with 'man', it expresses general rules or moral obligations (e.g., 'Man soll nicht lügen' - One should not lie). Unlike other modal verbs, *sollen* in present tense maintains the same meaning in past tense (*sollte*), just shifted to the past timeframe (was supposed to), not becoming a recommendation.

Modal verbs (Modalverben)

■ From lesson

Modal verbs express ability, permission, obligation, or desire. They are conjugated and used with an infinitive at the end of the sentence

COMPLETE RULE

Modal verb is conjugated in second position, main verb stays in infinitive at end: Ich kann gut singen

EXAMPLES

- *wollen: ich will, du willst, er will - to want*
- *können: ich kann, du kannst, er kann - to be able to*
- *müssen: ich muss, du musst, er muss - to must/have to*
- *dürfen: ich darf, du darfst, er darf - to be allowed to*
- *mögen/möchten: ich mag/möchte - to like/would like*
- *Ich kann Gitarre spielen*
- *Ich muss arbeiten*
- *Du darfst nicht rauchen*

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Modal verbs are all irregular in conjugation

Modal Verbs - Conjugation and Use

■ From lesson

Modal verbs express ability, permission, necessity, or desire. They are conjugated and used with infinitive at sentence end

COMPLETE RULE

Modal verbs are irregular. The accompanied infinitive goes to the end of the clause. Möchten is the subjunctive form of mögen and means 'would like'

EXAMPLES

- *können: ich kann, du kannst, er kann - Ich kann gut singen*
- *müssen: ich muss, du musst, er muss - Ich muss arbeiten*
- *wollen: ich will, du willst, er will - Ich will schlafen*
- *dürfen: ich darf, du darfst, er darf - Darfst du rauchen?*

→ mögen/möchten: *ich mag/möchte, du magst/möchtest*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Conjugating both the modal verb and the main verb

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Modal verbs can be used without an infinitive when context is clear

Modal verbs with separable verb infinitives

■ Web verified

When using a modal verb (können, müssen, wollen, etc.) with a separable verb, the separable prefix stays attached to the verb stem in the infinitive form at the end of the sentence. The prefix does NOT separate.

COMPLETE RULE

MODAL VERBS + SEPARABLE VERBS:

MODAL VERBS LIST:

- können (can, to be able to)
- müssen (must, to have to)
- wollen (to want to)
- sollen (should, ought to)
- dürfen (may, to be allowed to)
- mögen/möchten (to like/would like to)

RULE: Modal verb conjugated + ... + separable verb infinitive (TOGETHER)

STRUCTURE:

Subject + MODAL (position 2) + other elements + SEPARABLE VERB INFINITIVE (end)

EXAMPLES OF STRUCTURE:

Normal sentence: *Ich stehe um 7 Uhr auf.* (I get up at 7 o'clock) - prefix separates

With modal: *Ich muss um 7 Uhr aufstehen.* (I must get up at 7 o'clock) - prefix attached

COMMON SEPARABLE VERBS WITH MODALS:

- aufstehen (get up): *Ich muss früh aufstehen.*
- anrufen (call): *Du sollst deine Mutter anrufen.*
- mitnehmen (take along): *Wir können das Buch mitnehmen.*
- anfangen (begin): *Sie will morgen anfangen.*
- aufhören (stop): *Er muss mit dem Rauchen aufhören.*

- einladen (invite): *Darf ich dich einladen?*
- zurückkommen (come back): *Wann wollt ihr zurückkommen?*
- abfahren (depart): *Der Zug soll um 10 Uhr abfahren.*

ALL TENSES WITH MODAL + SEPARABLE:

Present: *Ich kann anfangen.*

Past: *Ich konnte anfangen.*

Perfect: *Ich habe anfangen können.* (double infinitive)

Future: *Ich werde anfangen können.*

EXAMPLES

→ **Wir können jetzt anfangen.** (We can begin now.)

anfangen stays together, NOT 'Wir können jetzt an fangen'

→ **Du musst deine Schwester vom Bahnhof abholen.** (You must pick up your sister from the station.)

abholen together at end

→ **Ich möchte heute Abend ausgehen.** (I would like to go out this evening.)

ausgehen as complete infinitive

→ **Sie soll morgen früh aufstehen.** (She should get up early tomorrow.)

aufstehen infinitive, prefix attached

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER ERRORS:

■ 1. SEPARATING THE PREFIX: *'Ich muss an morgen fangen' or *'Ich muss fangen morgen an' instead of 'Ich muss morgen anfangen'. Italians apply main clause rules incorrectly.

■ 2. WRONG WORD ORDER: *'Ich muss aufstehen um 7 Uhr' instead of 'Ich muss um 7 Uhr aufstehen'. Italian modal constructions (dovere + infinitive) allow different word order: 'Devo alzarmi alle 7' (must get-up-myself at 7).

■ 3. PUTTING MODAL AT END: *'Ich morgen anfangen muss' instead of 'Ich muss morgen anfangen'. Confusion with subordinate clause word order.

4. FORGETTING INFINITIVE ZU: In Italian 'Cerco di andare' (I try to go) uses 'di'. Germans sometimes add *'zu' incorrectly: *'Ich muss zu aufstehen' - modal verbs NEVER take 'zu'.

■ 5. DOUBLE CONJUGATION: *'Ich kann anfängt' instead of 'Ich kann anfangen' - trying to conjugate both verbs.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. PERFECT TENSE WITH MODALS: Uses double infinitive construction

- *Ich habe früh aufstehen müssen.* (I had to get up early.) - both verbs in infinitive
- *Er hat anrufen können.* (He was able to call.)

2. SUBORDINATE CLAUSES: Modal goes to end but separable verb still stays together

- ..., weil ich früh aufstehen muss. (because I must get up early)
- ..., dass er anrufen soll. (that he should call)

3. WITH LASSEN (let/have done): Same pattern as modals

- Ich lasse mein Auto reparieren. (I'm having my car repaired.)
- Er lässt seine Haare schneiden. (He's having his hair cut.)

4. SOME VERBS OPTIONAL: 'brauchen' (need) + 'zu' + infinitive

- Du brauchst nicht aufzustehen. (You don't need to get up.) - 'zu' inserted between prefix and stem

Modal Verbs: Präsens vs Konjunktiv II

■ Web verified

German uses Präsens (present indicative) with modal verbs for real situations, rules, and recommendations. Konjunktiv II (subjunctive) is used only for hypothetical, contrary-to-fact, or unreal situations. This differs significantly from Italian, which uses conditional/subjunctive (condizionale/congiuntivo) much more frequently.

COMPLETE RULE

PRÄSENS (INDICATIVE) - For REAL situations:

Used for: actual obligations, real recommendations, repeating rules, facts

sollen (Präsens) = expressing obligation from external source, repeating a rule

- Der Arzt sagt, ich soll weniger Süßigkeiten essen. (The doctor says I should eat less candy - repeating real advice)

- Du sollst deine Hausaufgaben machen. (You should do your homework - real obligation)

müssen (Präsens) = strong necessity, requirement (must)

- Wenn du Deutsch lernen willst, musst du viele Audios hören. (real recommendation - If you want to learn German, you must listen to many audios)

- Ich muss heute arbeiten. (real obligation - I must work today)

können (Präsens) = real ability, possibility (can)

- Ich kann schwimmen. (I can swim - real ability)

KONJUNKTIV II - For HYPOTHETICAL/UNREAL situations:

Used for: contrary-to-fact conditions, polite requests, wishes, hypotheticals

FORMATION:

sollen → sollte, solltest, sollte, sollten, solltet, sollten

müssen → müsste, müsstest, müsste, müssten, müsstet, müssten

können → könnte, könntest, könnte, könnten, könntet, könnten

dürfen → dürfte, dürftest, dürfte, dürften, dürftet, dürften

wollen → wollte (same as Präteritum)

mögen → möchte (used as standard for 'would like')

sollte (Konjunktiv II) = something that should happen but doesn't, advice for hypothetical

- Er sollte mir öfter sagen, wie sehr er mich liebt. (He should tell me more often - but he doesn't)
- Wenn du Zeit hättest, solltest du mehr Sport machen. (hypothetical)

müsste (Konjunktiv II) = would have to (hypothetical necessity)

- Wenn du Deutsch lernen müsstest, müsstest du viele Audios hören. (imaginary situation)

könnte (Konjunktiv II) = could, would be able to (hypothetical possibility)

- Ich könnte dir helfen, wenn ich Zeit hätte. (I could help you if I had time)

KEY RULE: Both clauses match in mood!

- Real: Wenn du Deutsch lernen willst (Präsens), musst (Präsens) du üben.
- Hypothetical: Wenn du Deutsch lernen müsstest (K2), müsstest (K2) du üben.

COMPARISON WITH ITALIAN:

Italian: Se vuoi imparare il tedesco, dovresti ascoltare... (conditional)

German: Wenn du Deutsch lernen willst, musst du hören... (Präsens for real advice!)

EXAMPLES

- Wenn du Deutsch lernen willst, musst du jeden Tag üben. (both Präsens - real situation: If you want to learn German, you must practice every day)
- Wenn du Deutsch lernen müsstest, müsstest du jeden Tag üben. (both Konjunktiv II
hypothetical: If you had to learn German, you would have to practice daily)
- Der Arzt sagt, ich soll mehr Wasser trinken. (Präsens
repeating real recommendation: The doctor says I should drink more water)
- Du solltest mehr schlafen, aber du gehst immer spät ins Bett. (Konjunktiv II
something that should happen but doesn't: You should sleep more, but you always go to bed late)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers overuse Konjunktiv II because Italian uses conditional/subjunctive for politeness and recommendations ('dovresti' = you should). They say 'Du solltest deine Hausaufgaben machen' (K2) for a real obligation when 'Du sollst deine Hausaufgaben machen' (Präsens) is correct. They use Konjunktiv II for real advice: 'Du solltest weniger rauchen' when someone actually is smoking (should be 'Du sollst' for real advice). Italian speakers mix moods in wenn-clauses: 'Wenn du Deutsch lernen willst (Präsens), solltest du üben (K2)' - both clauses must match. They translate Italian 'Se volessi..., dovresti...' word-for-word as 'Wenn du wolltest, solltest du' without understanding when German actually uses which mood.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Möchte is technically Konjunktiv II of mögen but is used as the standard present tense form for 'would like' in all contexts, not just hypothetical: 'Ich möchte einen Kaffee' (I would like a coffee - standard polite request, not hypothetical). For polite requests, Konjunktiv II is preferred even for real situations: 'Könnten Sie mir helfen?' (Could you help me?) is more polite than 'Können Sie mir helfen?' Wollen and sollen have the same form in Präteritum and Konjunktiv II: wollte/wollte, sollte/sollte - context determines meaning. In indirect speech, German may mix moods: 'Er sagt, ich sollte mehr üben' (He says I should practice more) - main clause Präsens, indirect clause Konjunktiv for reported speech.

Perfect tense with 'vergessen' + infinitive with 'zu'

■ Web verified

The verb 'vergessen' (to forget) is a strong irregular verb that commonly takes an infinitive clause with 'zu' (similar to English 'to forget to do something'). The basic pattern is: conjugated 'vergessen' + comma + 'zu' + infinitive at the end of the clause. With separable verbs, 'zu' is inserted BETWEEN the prefix and the verb stem, written as one word (e.g., 'einzukaufen', 'abzuschließen'). 'Vergessen' is an inseparable prefix verb, so its past participle is 'vergessen' (no 'ge-' prefix added).

COMPLETE RULE

VERGESSEN CONJUGATION:

Present: ich vergesse, du vergisst, er/sie/es vergisst, wir vergessen, ihr vergesst, sie vergessen

Präteritum: ich vergaß, du vergaßt, er vergaß, wir vergaßen, ihr vergaßt, sie vergaßen

Perfect: ich habe vergessen, du hast vergessen, er/sie/es hat vergessen, wir haben vergessen, ihr habt vergessen, sie haben vergessen

(Note: Strong verb with vowel change e-a-e; auxiliary is 'haben')

INFINITIVE WITH 'ZU' STRUCTURE:

1. With regular verbs: Subject + vergessen + comma + zu + infinitive

Example: Ich habe vergessen, dich anzurufen.

2. With separable verbs: 'zu' goes BETWEEN prefix and stem (written as one word)

einkaufen → einzukaufen

abschließen → abzuschließen

aufstehen → aufzustehen

Example: Er hat vergessen, einzukaufen.

3. With inseparable verbs: 'zu' goes before the whole verb

verstehen → zu verstehen

besuchen → zu besuchen

4. In subordinate clauses: comma + 'zu' + infinitive at absolute end

Example: Ich weiß, dass er vergessen hat, die Tür abzuschließen.

VERBS THAT DO NOT USE 'ZU' (exceptions):

Modal verbs: können, müssen, dürfen, sollen, wollen, mögen → 'Ich habe vergessen, es zu tun' BUT 'Ich kann es nicht tun' (no 'zu')

Perception verbs: sehen, hören → 'Ich höre ihn singen' (no 'zu')

'lassen' → 'Ich lasse es machen' (no 'zu')

EXAMPLES

→ *Vielleicht hat er vergessen, einzukaufen. (Perhaps he forgot to go shopping.)*

→ *Ich habe vergessen, die Tür abzuschließen. (I forgot to lock the door.)*

→ *Sie hat vergessen, ihre Mutter anzurufen. (She forgot to call her mother.)*

→ *Wir haben vergessen, die Fenster zuzumachen. (We forgot to close the windows.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: 1) Using 'di' structure from Italian instead of 'zu': Italian 'dimenticare di fare' → Incorrect German: *'vergessen zu machen' → but the structure is the same! The mistake is more subtle: forgetting the comma. Italian: 'Ho dimenticato di comprare il pane' → German requires comma: 'Ich habe vergessen, das Brot zu kaufen.' 2) With separable verbs, placing 'zu' incorrectly: Incorrect: *'zu einkaufen' or *'ein zu kaufen' → Correct: 'einzukaufen' (one word). Italian doesn't have separable verbs, so this is a new concept. 3) Adding 'ge-' to the past participle: Incorrect: *'Ich habe gevergessen' → Correct: 'Ich habe vergessen' (inseparable prefix verbs never take 'ge-'). 4) Confusing 'vergessen' (transitive) with 'sich erinnern' (reflexive): Italian 'ricordare/ricordarsi' can be both → German 'vergessen' is NOT reflexive. Incorrect: *'Ich habe mich vergessen' → Correct: 'Ich habe vergessen' OR 'Ich habe mich nicht erinnert.' 5) Wrong verb form: Incorrect: *'Er hat vergessen einkaufen' (missing 'zu') → Correct: 'Er hat vergessen einzukaufen.'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

After modal verbs, 'vergessen' uses the infinitive form without 'zu': 'Ich kann nicht vergessen, was passiert ist' (NOT *'zu vergessen'). When 'vergessen' means 'to leave something behind' (in a place), it can be replaced with 'liegen lassen' or 'stehen lassen' in colloquial German: 'Ich habe meinen Schirm im Zug vergessen' = 'Ich habe meinen Schirm im Zug liegen lassen.' The past participle 'vergessen' is identical to the infinitive. In older German or formal writing, 'zu' could be omitted after certain verbs, but this is no longer standard with 'vergessen.'

Präteritum vs. Perfekt with es gibt/es gab

■ Web verified

For expressing 'there is/are' in the past, German strongly prefers the Präteritum form 'es gab' over the Perfekt 'es hat gegeben' in spoken German, similar to modal verbs which also prefer Präteritum over Perfekt.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete conjugation:

PRÄSENS: es gibt (there is/are)

PRÄTERITUM: es gab (there was/were) - PREFERRED IN SPEECH

PERFEKT: es hat gegeben (there has been) - FORMAL/WRITTEN

PLUSQUAMPERFEKT: es hatte gegeben (there had been)

Modal verb parallel: Like modal verbs (können, müssen, wollen, etc.), 'geben' in the construction 'es gibt/gab' behaves similarly by preferring the Präteritum in spoken German because the Perfekt sounds clunky and unnatural. The Perfekt form creates an awkward construction that Germans generally avoid in conversation.

EXAMPLES

→ *Es gab viele Unfälle auf der Autobahn. (There were many accidents on the highway.)*

→ *Gestern gab es ein großes Fest. (Yesterday there was a big party.)*

→ *Es gibt heute viele Probleme. (There are many problems today.)*

→ *Was gab es zum Essen? (What was there to eat?)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often use 'es hat gegeben' in conversation, translating literally from 'c'è stato/ci sono stati', when Germans naturally say 'es gab'. Using Perfekt here sounds overly formal and unnatural in spoken contexts.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In formal written German (reports, news articles, formal documents), 'es hat gegeben' may occasionally appear, but even in writing 'es gab' is more common and natural. The Präteritum remains the standard choice across registers.

Separable verb 'ausleihen' and 'ausnehmen'

■ Web verified

Separable verbs in German consist of a prefix (which can exist independently as a word) attached to a base verb. In present tense and simple past main clauses, the prefix separates from the verb and moves to the end of the clause, while the base verb is conjugated and occupies the standard verb position (position 2). In compound tenses (perfect), the prefix rejoins with 'ge-' inserted between the prefix and the stem: 'ausgeliehen', 'ausgenommen'. The prefix carries the stress when pronouncing separable verbs.

COMPLETE RULE

AUSLEIHEN (to borrow/lend out) - Strong separable verb

Present: ich leihe aus, du leihst aus, er/sie/es leiht aus, wir leihen aus, ihr leiht aus, sie leihen aus

Präteritum: ich lieh aus, du liehst aus, er/sie/es lieh aus, wir liehen aus, ihr lieht aus, sie liehen aus

Perfect: ich habe ausgeliehen, du hast ausgeliehen, er/sie/es hat ausgeliehen, wir haben ausgeliehen, ihr habt ausgeliehen, sie haben ausgeliehen

Imperative: Leih aus! Leih aus! Leihen Sie aus!

Infinitive with 'zu': auszuleihen (one word, 'zu' between prefix and stem)

AUSNEHMEN (to take out, to gut/clean [fish], to make an exception) - Strong separable verb

Present: ich nehme aus, du nimmst aus, er/sie/es nimmt aus, wir nehmen aus, ihr nehmt aus, sie nehmen aus

(Note: vowel change e→i in 2nd & 3rd person singular from 'nehmen')

Präteritum: ich nahm aus, du nahmst aus, er/sie/es nahm aus, wir nahmen aus, ihr nahmt aus, sie nahmen aus

Perfect: ich habe ausgenommen, du hast ausgenommen, er/sie/es hat ausgenommen, wir haben ausgenommen, ihr habt ausgenommen, sie haben ausgenommen

Imperative: Nimm aus! Nehmt aus! Nehmen Sie aus!

Infinitive with 'zu': auszunehmen

COMMON SEPARABLE PREFIXES:

ab-, an-, auf-, aus-, bei-, ein-, mit-, nach-, vor-, zu-, zurück-, weg-, weiter-, zusammen-, etc.

WHEN PREFIX SEPARATES:

- 1. Present/Präteritum main clauses: Ich leihe ein Boot aus.*
- 2. Imperative: Nimm die Bücher aus dem Regal!*
- 3. Questions: Leihst du das Buch aus?*

WHEN PREFIX STAYS ATTACHED:

- 1. With modal verbs: Ich kann ein Boot ausleihen.*
- 2. In subordinate clauses: ..., weil ich ein Boot ausleihe.*
- 3. Perfect tense: Ich habe ein Boot ausgeliehen. (but 'ge-' inserted)*
- 4. With 'zu' + infinitive: Ich vergesse, das Boot auszuleihen.*
- 5. Future: Ich werde ein Boot ausleihen.*

EXAMPLES

- Wir leihen ein Segelboot aus. (We are borrowing/renting a sailboat.)*
- Ich kann viele Dinge aus dem Schrank nehmen. (I can take many things out of the cupboard.)*
- Er hat gestern Bücher aus der Bibliothek ausgeliehen. (He borrowed books from the library yesterday.)*
- Nimm bitte die Wäsche aus der Maschine! (Please take the laundry out of the machine!)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often make these errors: 1) Not separating the prefix at all because Italian doesn't have separable verbs. Incorrect: *'Ich ausleihe ein Boot' → Correct: 'Ich leihe ein Boot aus.' This is the most fundamental error. 2) Placing the prefix in the wrong position (not at the very end): Incorrect: *'Ich leihe aus ein Boot' → Correct: 'Ich leihe ein Boot aus' (prefix must be at the END of the clause). 3) In

perfect tense, incorrect past participle formation: Incorrect: *'Ich habe geausgeliehen' or *'Ich habe ausleihen' → Correct: 'Ich habe ausgeliehen' ('ge-' goes BETWEEN prefix and stem). 4) Using 'zu' incorrectly with separable verbs: Incorrect: *'Ich vergesse zu ausleihen' or *'Ich vergesse aus zu leihen' → Correct: 'Ich vergesse auszuleihen' (one word). 5) Separating prefix when using modal verbs: Incorrect: *'Ich kann leihen ein Boot aus' → Correct: 'Ich kann ein Boot ausleihen' (stays together with modals). 6) Wrong auxiliary verb: most separable verbs of motion use 'sein', but 'ausleihen' and 'ausnehmen' use 'haben.' 7) Not recognizing which prefixes are separable vs inseparable: 'aus-' is always separable, but 'ver-', 'be-', 'er-', 'ent-', 'emp-', 'miss-', 'zer-', 'ge-' are NEVER separable.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some prefixes can be either separable OR inseparable depending on the verb, changing the meaning: 'durchfahren' (inseparable, stressed on stem) = to drive through without stopping vs 'durchfahren' (separable, stressed on prefix) = to saw through. The prefixes 'durch-', 'über-', 'um-', 'unter-', 'wider-', 'wieder-' can be either separable or inseparable. In subordinate clauses, separable verbs stay together with the prefix at the end: 'Ich weiß, dass er das Boot ausleiht' (NOT *'dass er leiht das Boot aus'). With 'lassen' + infinitive, the separable verb remains together: 'Ich lasse das Boot ausleihen' (I have the boat rented).

Separable verb 'kennenlernen'

■ Web verified

'Kennenlernen' (to get to know/meet for the first time) is a separable verb formed from 'kennen' (to know) + 'lernen' (to learn). In simple tenses in main clauses, it separates. In subordinate clauses, with modal verbs, or with 'zu', it stays together.

COMPLETE RULE

INFINITIVE: kennenlernen (one word)

MAIN CLAUSE PRESENT/PAST:

Separates - 'lernen' conjugates, 'kennen' goes to end

ich lerne kennen, du lernst kennen, er/sie/es lernt kennen

wir lernen kennen, ihr lernt kennen, sie/Sie lernen kennen

Past: ich lernte kennen, du lerntest kennen, etc.

WITH MODAL VERBS:

Stays together at end

Ich möchte dich kennenlernen.

Der Vermieter möchte uns kennenlernen.

SUBORDINATE CLAUSES:

Stays together at end (conjugated)

wo Nico Selma kennenlernt

dass er sie kennenlernt

WITH 'ZU':

'zu' goes between the parts: kennenzulernen

Schön, dich kennenzulernen. (Nice to meet you.)

Freut mich, dich kennenzulernen.

PERFECT TENSE:

Participle: kennengelernt (ge- goes between)

Ich habe ihn kennengelernt.

EXAMPLES

→ Nico lernt Selma auf einer Party kennen. (Nico meets Selma at a party.)

→ Ich möchte dich kennenlernen. (I would like to meet you.)

→ Wo hast du ihn kennengelernt? (Where did you meet him?)

→ Das ist die Frau, wo Nico Selma kennenlernt. (That's where Nico meets Selma.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. Not separating in main clauses (Italian 'conoscere' doesn't split)
2. Separating in subordinate clauses (Italian influence: not recognizing verb-final position rule)
3. Writing as two words 'kennen lernen' always (both spellings acceptable, but as verb it should be one word)
 - 4. Forgetting 'ge-' in past participle or placing it wrong: *gekennenlernt instead of kennengelernt
 - 5. Not placing 'zu' between the parts: *zu kennenlernen instead of kennenzulernen
6. Confusing 'kennen' (to know/be acquainted with) and 'wissen' (to know facts) - Italian 'sapere/conoscere' distinction

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

SPELLING: Both 'kennenlernen' and 'kennen lernen' are acceptable in German orthography (2006 reform allows both). As a verb concept, prefer one word. In subordinate clauses with multiple verbs, word order: modal + kennenlernen at end: 'dass er sie kennenlernen will' (that he wants to meet her).

Separable verb: abfahren

■ Web verified

The separable verb 'abfahren' means 'to depart/leave/set off'. In main clauses with simple tenses, the prefix 'ab' separates from 'fahren' and moves to the end of the sentence.

COMPLETE RULE

Conjugation (Present): *ich fahre ab, du fährst ab, er/sie/es fährt ab, wir fahren ab, ihr fahrt ab, sie/Sie fahren ab*. Präteritum: *ich fuhr ab, du fuhrst ab, er/sie/es fuhr ab, wir fuhren ab, ihr fuhr ab, sie/Sie fuhren ab*. Perfekt: *ich bin abgefahren, du bist abgefahren, er/sie/es ist abgefahren, wir sind abgefahren, ihr seid abgefahren, sie/Sie sind abgefahren* (uses 'sein' as auxiliary). Position rules: Main clause simple tense: prefix at end; Main clause with modal: verb stays together at end (*Ich muss abfahren*); Subordinate clause: verb stays together at end (*wenn ich abfahre*); Perfekt: *ge-* inserted between prefix and stem (*abgefahren*); Infinitive with *zu*: *zu* inserted between prefix and stem (*abzufahren*).

EXAMPLES

- *Der Zug fährt um 8 Uhr ab.* (The train departs at 8 o'clock.)
- *Ich fahre am Morgen ab.* (I'm leaving in the morning.)
- *Wann fährst du ab?* (When are you departing?)
- *Ich bin gestern abgefahren.* (I departed yesterday
Perfekt)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Keeping the prefix attached in main clauses with simple tenses (saying 'Ich abfahre' instead of 'Ich fahre ab'). Italian speakers may struggle with the concept as Italian doesn't have separable verbs. Incorrect placement in perfect tense (saying 'Ich habe ab gefahren' instead of 'Ich bin abgefahren'). Using wrong auxiliary verb - 'abfahren' takes 'sein', not 'haben'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In subordinate clauses, the verb stays together: 'Ich weiß nicht, wann der Zug abfährt'. With modal verbs, stays together: 'Ich muss um 8 Uhr abfahren'. Imperative forms: 'Fahr ab!' (singular informal), 'Fahrt ab!' (plural informal), 'Fahren Sie ab!' (formal). Some prefixes like 'durch-', 'über-', 'unter-' can be separable or inseparable depending on meaning - but 'ab-' is always separable.

Separable Verbs

■ From lesson

Separable verbs have a prefix that separates and moves to the end of the clause in present tense

COMPLETE RULE

The prefix separates in main clauses and moves to sentence end. In infinitive form and with modal verbs, it stays attached: *Ich muss aufstehen*

EXAMPLES

- *anrufen: Ich rufe meine Mutter an*
- *aufstehen: Ich stehe um 7 Uhr auf*

→ **einkaufen**: *Ich kaufe im Supermarkt ein*

→ **fernsehen**: *Ich sehe am Abend fern*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Not separating the prefix or putting it in the wrong position

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

With modal verbs, the separable verb stays in infinitive form at the end

Separable verbs (Trennbare Verben)

■ From lesson

Separable verbs have a prefix that separates from the verb stem in main clauses and goes to the end of the sentence

COMPLETE RULE

In main clauses: conjugated verb stays in second position, prefix goes to end. In infinitive constructions and subordinate clauses, the verb stays together

EXAMPLES

→ **anrufen**: *Ich rufe die Bank an*

I call the bank

→ **einkaufen**: *Ich kaufe ein*

I go shopping

→ **aufstehen**: *Ich stehe um 9 Uhr auf*

I get up at 9 o'clock

→ **fernsehen**: *Ich sehe fern*

I watch TV

→ **aufwachen**: *Wann wachst du auf? - When do you wake up?*

Separable verbs in Perfekt: prefix goes to end

■ Web verified

Separable verbs like 'ankommen' (to arrive) form the past participle by inserting 'ge-' between the prefix and the stem: an + ge + komm + en → angekommen. The verb uses sein or haben as auxiliary depending on the main verb. In sentences: Wann bist du angekommen? (When did you arrive?)

COMPLETE RULE

Formation of Partizip II for separable verbs:

1. REGULAR SEPARABLE VERBS:

- Structure: PREFIX + ge + STEM + t/en
- Example: *aufmachen* → *aufgemacht* (opened up)
- Example: *einkaufen* → *eingekauft* (shopped)

2. IRREGULAR SEPARABLE VERBS:

- Structure: PREFIX + ge + STEM(changed) + en
- *ankommen* → *angekommen* (arrived) [o-a-o stem change]
- *mitnehmen* → *mitgenommen* (taken along) [e-a-o stem change]
- *aufstehen* → *aufgestanden* (gotten up)

3. AUXILIARY VERB SELECTION:

- Use *SEIN* for: movement verbs (*ankommen, ausgehen, weggehen*), change of state verbs
- Use *HABEN* for: most other separable verbs (*anfangen, anrufen, aufräumen, mitnehmen*)

4. SENTENCE STRUCTURE IN PERFEKT:

- Main clause: Subject + aux.verb(conjugated) + ... + past participle(end)
- Example: *Ich bin gestern angekommen.* (I arrived yesterday)
- Example: *Sie hat die Sonnencreme mitgenommen.* (She took the sunscreen along)
- Subordinate clause: ..., dass + subject + ... + past participle + aux.verb
- Example: ..., dass du gestern angekommen bist. (...that you arrived yesterday)

EXAMPLES

- *Wann bist du hier angekommen?* (When did you arrive here?)
- *Ich habe die Sonnencreme mitgenommen.* (I took the sunscreen along.)
- *Er ist gestern ausgegangen.* (He went out yesterday.)
- *Wir haben das Konzert abgesagt.* (We canceled the concert.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' COMMON ERRORS:

1. WRONG PREFIX PLACEMENT: Italian speakers may try to keep the prefix separate or place it at the end (influenced by Italian phrasal verbs with prepositions)

- *Ich bin an gekommen* (separating prefix)
- ✓ *Ich bin angekommen*

2. MISSING 'GE-' INSERTION: Forgetting to insert 'ge-' between prefix and stem

- *Ich bin ankommt / Ich bin ankommen*
- ✓ *Ich bin angekommen*

■ 3. WRONG AUXILIARY VERB: Using 'avere' (haben) logic from Italian instead of 'essere' (sein) for movement verbs

■ Ich habe angekommen (like Italian 'ho arrivato' - incorrect in both!)

■ ✓ Ich bin angekommen / Sono arrivato

4. PRESENT TENSE CONFUSION: Mixing present and past participle forms

■ Sie fliegt heute ausgeflogen (mixing tenses)

■ ✓ Sie ist heute ausgeflogen (She flew out today)

■ ✓ Sie fliegt heute aus (She's flying out today - present)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. INSEPARABLE PREFIXES: Verbs with be-, emp-, ent-, er-, ge-, miss-, ver-, zer- do NOT add 'ge-' and do NOT separate:

- bekommen → bekommen (NOT: begekammt)

- verstehen → verstanden (NOT: vergestanden)

2. VERBS ENDING IN -ieren: No 'ge-' prefix, even if separable-looking:

- studieren → studiert

- BUT: separable verbs with -ieren are extremely rare

3. DOUBLE PREFIX VERBS: If a verb has both separable and inseparable prefixes, only the separable one splits:

- zurückkommen → zurückgekommen (came back)

4. MIXED VERBS: Some verbs can be separable or inseparable with different meanings:

- durchlaufen (separable: 'lief durch') = to run through

- durchlaufen (inseparable: 'durchlief') = to undergo

Separable verbs: rausschauen, reinschauen, reingehen, rausgehen

■ From lesson

These separable verbs combine 'raus' (out) or 'rein' (in) with a base verb like 'schauen' (to look) or 'gehen' (to go), and the prefix separates in main clauses.

EXAMPLES

→ Die Frau links schaut raus.

→ Schau rein!

Separable verbs: reinkommen, runterfallen

Separable verbs split in main clauses when conjugated in present/past tense: prefix goes to end ('Die Mutter kommt rein'). They stay together in: (1) subordinate clauses ('dass sie reinkommt'), (2) infinitive forms ('reinkommen'), (3) infinitive with 'zu' ('reinzukommen'), (4) past participles ('reingekommen'), (5) with modal verbs ('sie will reinkommen'). With directional prepositions, use Akkusativ for motion: 'in die Küche rein'.

COMPLETE RULE

MAIN CLAUSE (present/past): Prefix separates to end. Example: 'Sie kommt in die Küche rein' (prefix 'rein' at end) | SUBORDINATE CLAUSE: Stays together at end. Example: 'Ich glaube, dass sie reinkommt' | INFINITIVE: Stays together. Example: 'Sie will reinkommen' | INFINITIVE + ZU: 'zu' goes between prefix and verb. Example: 'um reinzukommen' | PERFECT/PAST PERFECT: ge- goes between prefix and verb. Example: 'Sie ist reingekommen' | IMPERATIVE: Prefix at end. Example: 'Komm rein!'

EXAMPLES

- Die Mutter kommt in die Küche rein. (The mother comes into the kitchen.)
- Etwas ist runtergefallen. (Something fell down.)
- Ich glaube, dass sie reinkommt. (I believe she is coming in.)
- Ich versuche, die Tür aufzumachen. (I'm trying to open the door.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers forgetting to separate the prefix in main clauses. Using Dativ instead of Akkusativ with directional 'in' (motion toward a place). Separating the verb in subordinate clauses where it should stay together. Not inserting 'zu' between prefix and verb in infinitive constructions ('reinzukommen' not 'zu reinkommen').

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Not all prefixes are separable. Inseparable prefixes (be-, ent-, emp-, er-, ge-, miss-, ver-, zer-) never separate and have no 'ge-' in past participle: 'verstehen → verstanden' (not 'ge-ver-standen'). Some prefixes can be both separable and inseparable depending on meaning: 'umfahren' (separate: drive around; inseparable: run over).

Sollen (Präsens) - shall

Sollen in present tense (soll) is used for: 1) Questions making suggestions or offers (always real, not hypothetical). Example: 'Soll ich dir helfen?' means 'Shall I help you?' - you are really offering to help. 2) It is almost always used in 1st person singular or plural when asking questions.

COMPLETE RULE

Sollen is a modal verb and functions like wollen, müssen, können with the infinitive at the end. Present tense conjugation: ich soll, du sollst, er/sie/es soll, wir sollen, ihr sollt, sie/Sie sollen. Note: Sollen is the only modal verb that does NOT change its stem vowel in present tense conjugation. The conjugated modal verb goes in position 2, and the infinitive verb goes to the end of the sentence. In questions with sollen for suggestions, it typically appears in 1st person: 'Soll ich...?' (Shall I...?) or 'Sollen wir...?' (Shall we...?). This expresses real suggestions and offers, not hypothetical situations.

EXAMPLES

- **Soll ich dir einen Tee machen?** (Shall I make you a tea?
real offer)
- **Soll ich dich morgen besuchen?** (Shall I visit you tomorrow?
real suggestion)
- **Sollen wir nicht laut sein?** (Shall we not be loud? - *real suggestion/question*)
- **Was soll ich tun?** (What shall I do? / What am I supposed to do?)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often confuse 'soll' (shall - real, present indicative) with 'sollte' (should - hypothetical, Konjunktiv II). Remember: 'soll' is for real situations and questions about actual actions you are offering to do; 'sollte' is for unreal recommendations and advice. Italian speakers may also try to use 'dovere' patterns incorrectly - in German, the modal stays conjugated and the main verb stays in infinitive form at the end. Italian speakers sometimes forget that sollen does NOT get an umlaut in any form, unlike most other modal verbs.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When sollen appears with a question word (was, wo, wann, etc.) or pronoun, it can be in present tense indicative rather than Konjunktiv II. Sollen is unique among modal verbs because it undergoes NO vowel change in any conjugation (no umlaut added in past or subjunctive forms either).

Sollen - Repeating orders and rules

■ Web verified

Sollen (shall) is used to repeat orders, rules, or assignments that someone else has given. When you talk about what someone was told to do, you use 'sollen'. This is like 'supposed to' in English. Example: The teacher says 'Macht die Hausaufgaben!' The mother repeats: 'Du sollst die Hausaufgaben machen' (You are supposed to do your homework).

COMPLETE RULE

When repeating someone else's direct order or rule (often given as imperative), use 'sollen' to indicate that this is what was instructed. The original speaker gave the order; you are just reporting it. Structure: Subject

+ *sollen* (conjugated) + infinitive verb (at end). Conjugation: *ich soll, du sollst, er/sie/es soll, wir sollen, ihr sollt, sie/Sie sollen*. This usage expresses an obligation coming from an external authority or person, not from the speaker's own judgment. The difference between *müssen* and *sollen* is that *müssen* expresses general necessity while *sollen* expresses necessity that results from a specific request or command from someone.

EXAMPLES

→ *Die Kinder sollen Hausaufgaben machen.* (The children are supposed to do homework - the teacher said so)

→ *Er soll 3 Mal am Tag Tabletten nehmen.* (He is supposed to take his meds three times per day the doctor said so)

→ *Du sollst keine anderen Götter haben außer mir.* (You shall have no other gods beside me the commandment)

→ *Sie sollen sofort Ihr Büro anrufen. Das hat Ihre Sekretärin gesagt.* (You should call your office immediately. Your secretary said so.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers might use 'müssen' instead of 'sollen', but 'sollen' is more precise when clearly repeating someone else's specific instruction or rule. In Italian, 'dovere' covers both meanings, but German distinguishes between *müssen* (internal/logical necessity) and *sollen* (external command/expectation). Italian speakers may also place the infinitive incorrectly in the sentence - remember it must go to the END of the clause in German.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When the command is extremely urgent or represents a moral/legal obligation, Germans sometimes use *müssen* instead. However, *sollen* is preferred when it's clear that a specific person gave the instruction. In the famous biblical Ten Commandments (die Zehn Gebote), *sollen* is consistently used: 'Du sollst nicht töten' (Thou shalt not kill).

Sollen - Reporting what was heard (B1)

■ Web verified

Sollen can be used to report something you heard from others, similar to 'supposed to' or 'said to be' in English. This is a B1 level usage. Example: 'Er soll sehr reich sein' means 'They say he's very rich' or 'He's said to be very rich.' You are repeating information, not stating a fact you verified.

COMPLETE RULE

This usage of '*sollen*' indicates reported information or hearsay (epistemische Verwendung). You heard it from news, rumors, or other sources, but you're not claiming it as verified fact. Structure: Subject + *sollen* (conjugated) + adjective/infinitive. Either present indicative (*soll/sollen*) or Konjunktiv I (*solle/sollen*) can be used. This is different from *wollen* in reported speech - *wollen* suggests doubt about the truth ('Er will reich

sein' = He claims to be rich, but I doubt it), while *sollen* is more neutral. This usage is common in journalism and formal reporting.

EXAMPLES

- *Er soll sehr reich sein.* (They say he's very rich / He's said to be very rich)
- *Morgen soll es schneien.* (They say it's gonna snow tomorrow / It's supposed to snow tomorrow)
- *Die Firma Hansen & Co. soll Pleite sein.* (The company Hansen & Co. is said to be bankrupt)
- *Der neue Freund von Gaby soll sehr viel Geld besitzen.* (Gaby's new boyfriend is said to have a lot of money)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers learning German often don't have an equivalent structure in Italian and may try to use direct speech or 'si dice che' constructions. They may forget to use *sollen* and instead say 'Man sagt, dass...' which is correct but less concise. Italian speakers should note this is **ONLY** used in present or Konjunktiv I for reported speech - not in past tenses for this meaning.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

This is a B1 level structure and less common in everyday A2 conversation. In colloquial speech, people often use 'angeblich' (supposedly) or 'Man sagt, dass...' (People say that...) instead. When using modal verbs for indirect speech, if Konjunktiv I is identical to indicative, use Konjunktiv II instead to maintain the subjunctive mood distinction.

Sollte (Konjunktiv II) - should

■ Web verified

Sollte is the Konjunktiv II (conditional) form and means 'should' in English. It is used for unreal situations - things that haven't happened but you recommend they should happen. Example: 'Du *solltest* zum Mechaniker gehen' (You should go to the mechanic). The person hasn't gone yet, but you're giving advice that they should.

COMPLETE RULE

Konjunktiv II of *sollen* expresses recommendations, advice, or suggestions for situations that are not real or have not happened yet. Conjugation: *ich sollte, du solltest, er/sie/es sollte, wir sollten, ihr solltet, sie/Sie sollten*. NOTE: Unlike other modal verbs, *sollen* does NOT add an umlaut in Konjunktiv II - the forms are identical to *Präteritum* (simple past). This is different from 'soll' which is always about real situations, questions, or repeated orders. *Sollte* is used for: 1) Giving advice/recommendations, 2) Expressing what would be better/appropriate, 3) Polite suggestions, 4) Hypothetical obligations. Structure: Subject + *sollte*(conjugated) + infinitive (at end).

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich sollte weniger rauchen. (I should smoke less**

but I don't)

→ **Du solltest nicht rausgehen. (You should not go outside)**

→ **Wenn sein Motorrad kaputt ist, sollte er zum Mechaniker gehen. (If his motorcycle is broken, he should go to the mechanic)**

→ **Du solltest mehr Wasser trinken. (You should drink more water**

advice)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'sollte' with 'soll' is the most common mistake. Remember: soll = shall (real, indicative mood), sollte = should (unreal/advice, subjunctive mood). Italian speakers often try to use 'dovrebbe' patterns but forget the infinitive goes to the end in German. Italian speakers may also add an umlaut (*söllte) which is **WRONG** - sollen never gets an umlaut. Unlike Italian conditional which uses 'dovrebbe + infinitive,' German requires the infinitive at the **END** of the clause.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The Konjunktiv II and Präteritum forms of sollen are identical because sollen (like wollen) does not take an umlaut. This can create ambiguity, but context usually makes the meaning clear. In conditional sentences with 'wenn,' sollte in the wenn-clause can emphasize the condition: 'Solltest du Hunger haben, gibt es Essen im Kühlschrank' (Should you be hungry, there is food in the fridge).

TE-KA-MO-LO sentence order

■ Web verified

TeKaMoLo is a guideline for ordering adverbials in German: TEmporal (time), KAusal (reason/cause), MOfal (manner), LOfal (place). Example: 'Ich gehe heute (TE) wegen der Arbeit (KA) schnell (MO) in die Stadt (LO).' This is the default, natural order; native speakers may vary for emphasis. The conjugated verb still follows position 2 rule in main clauses. Time before place is opposite of English.

COMPLETE RULE

ORDER: Time (when?) → Cause (why?) → Manner (how?) → Location (where?) | TIME (temporal): heute, gestern, morgen, am Montag, um 8 Uhr, jede Woche, im Sommer | CAUSE (kausal): wegen des Wetters, aus Freude, aufgrund der Arbeit, weil-clauses | MANNER (modal): schnell, gerne, mit Freunden, laut, konzentriert, mit dem Auto, allein | LOCATION (lokal): zu Hause, in der Schule, ins Kino, nach Berlin, auf dem Land | NOTE: TeKaMoLo describes default order in the Mittelfeld (middle field) of the sentence. Any element can be moved to Position 1 for emphasis, after which the verb takes position 2.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich gehe heute wegen der Arbeit schnell in die Stadt. (I'm going to the city today because of work quickly.)*

→ *Es gibt heute großes Chaos in der Küche. (There is big chaos today in the kitchen.)*

→ *Sie kommt jetzt mit dem Auto nach Hause. (She comes now by car home.)*

→ *Josh hat gestern aus Rücksicht auf seine Oma sehr laut am Küchentisch gesprochen. (Josh spoke very loudly at the kitchen table yesterday out of consideration for his grandmother.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers placing location before time (English order: 'at school today' vs German: 'heute in der Schule'). Placing manner before cause. Not recognizing that TeKaMoLo can be broken for emphasis, causing rigid, unnatural sentences. Forgetting that pronouns generally precede nouns regardless of TeKaMoLo. Confusing TeKaMoLo with the position 2 verb rule - they work together.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

TeKaMoLo is a default, not a rigid rule. Native speakers frequently vary order for emphasis by fronting an element to Position 1, which doesn't disrupt the remaining TeKaMoLo order. Example: 'Wegen der Arbeit gehe ich heute schnell in die Stadt' (KA-TE-MO-LO for emphasis). Known information tends to precede new information. Pronouns precede nouns. Objects have their own rules (Dativ noun before Akkusativ noun, but Akkusativ pronoun before Dativ pronoun).

Trennbare Verben (Separable Verbs)

■ Web verified

Separable verbs in German consist of a prefix and a base verb. In main clauses with finite verb forms, the prefix separates from the verb and moves to the end of the sentence. The conjugated verb occupies the second position while the prefix goes to the clause-final position. In infinitive constructions, subordinate clauses, and with modal verbs, the prefix remains attached to the verb.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE CONJUGATION TABLE - aufstehen (to get up):

PRESENT TENSE (Main Clause - Separated):

ich stehe auf

du stehst auf

er/sie/es steht auf

wir stehen auf

ihr steht auf

sie/Sie stehen auf

PAST SIMPLE (Präteritum - Separated):

ich stand auf
du standest auf
er/sie/es stand auf
wir standen auf
ihr standet auf
sie/Sie standen auf

PERFECT TENSE (Partizip II - ge- inserted between prefix and verb):

ich bin aufgestanden
du bist aufgestanden
er/sie/es ist aufgestanden
wir sind aufgestanden
ihr seid aufgestanden
sie/Sie sind aufgestanden

FUTURE TENSE (Infinitive - Not separated):

ich werde aufstehen
du wirst aufstehen
er/sie/es wird aufstehen
wir werden aufstehen
ihr werdet aufstehen
sie/Sie werden aufstehen

WITH MODAL VERBS (Not separated):

ich muss aufstehen
du musst aufstehen
er/sie/es muss aufstehen

SUBORDINATE CLAUSES (Not separated, verb at end):

Ich weiß, dass er früh aufsteht.
Er sagt, dass sie morgen aufsteht.

INFINITIVE WITH ZU (zu inserted between prefix and verb):

Es ist Zeit aufzustehen.
Ich vergesse nicht aufzustehen.

COMMON SEPARABLE PREFIXES:

ab-, an-, auf-, aus-, bei-, ein-, mit-, nach-, vor-, zu-, zurück-, weg-, weiter-

IMPERATIVE (Separated):

Steh auf! (du form)
Steht auf! (ihr form)
Stehen Sie auf! (Sie form)

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich rufe meine Mutter morgen an.* (I'm calling my mother tomorrow.) - Present tense, separated prefix at end.

→ *Der Kurs fängt um 9 Uhr an.* (The course starts at 9 o'clock.) - anfangen with time expression between verb parts.

→ *Wir sind gestern sehr spät angekommen.* (We arrived very late yesterday.)

Perfect tense with ge- between an- and -kommen.

→ *Kannst du bitte das Fenster zumachen?* (Can you please close the window?) - Modal verb with infinitive form, not separated.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

- 1. NOT SEPARATING IN MAIN CLAUSES: Italian speakers often forget to separate the prefix because Italian doesn't have this structure. Wrong: 'Ich aufstehe um 7 Uhr.' Correct: 'Ich stehe um 7 Uhr auf.' Italian has verbs like 'alzarsi' but the reflexive pronoun behaves differently.
- 2. SEPARATING IN SUBORDINATE CLAUSES: Wrong: 'Ich weiß, dass er steht früh auf.' Correct: 'Ich weiß, dass er früh aufsteht.' Italian maintains word order in subordinate clauses differently.
- 3. WRONG PAST PARTICIPLE FORMATION: Wrong: 'Ich habe geaufstanden.' Correct: 'Ich bin aufgestanden.' Italian uses 'mi sono alzato' with different auxiliary logic.
- 4. SEPARATING WITH MODAL VERBS: Wrong: 'Ich muss stehen auf.' Correct: 'Ich muss aufstehen.' Italian 'Devo alzarmi' keeps the pronoun attached differently.
- 5. FORGETTING STRESS ON PREFIX: Italian speakers may stress the base verb instead of the separable prefix. Stress should be on 'AUFstehen' not 'aufSTehen'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. **AMBIGUOUS PREFIXES:** durch-, hinter-, über-, um-, unter-, wieder-, wider- can be EITHER separable OR inseparable depending on the verb. The stress pattern indicates: separable verbs stress the prefix (ÜBERsetzen = to ferry across, separable), inseparable verbs stress the verb stem (überSETzen = to translate, inseparable). Example: 'Er setzt über' (he ferries across) vs 'Er übersetzt den Text' (he translates the text).
2. **INSEPARABLE PREFIXES:** be-, emp-, ent-, er-, ge-, miss-, ver-, zer- are NEVER separable. Example: verstehen (to understand) - 'Ich verstehe' NOT 'Ich stehe ver'.
3. **PAST PARTICIPLE WITH INSEPARABLE PREFIX VERBS:** No ge- added. Example: verstehen → verstanden (NOT *geverstanden).
4. **SOME PREFIXES CHANGE MEANING:** ausgehen can mean 'to go out' (separable) but different verbs with aus- have different meanings: ausdenken (to think up), ausgeben (to spend money).
5. **NOUN + VERB COMPOUNDS:** Some separable verbs use nouns as prefixes: teilnehmen (to participate), radfahren (to ride a bike). These follow the same separation rules: 'Ich nehme an dem Kurs teil.'

6. DOUBLE INFINITIVE CONSTRUCTION: In perfect tense with modal verbs, use double infinitive at end: 'Ich habe aufstehen müssen' (I had to get up) instead of 'Ich habe aufstehen gemusst.'

Verbi separabili (Trennbare Verben)

■ From lesson

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich stehe auf*

→ *Du stehst auf*

→ *Die Kinder stehen auf*

Regular verbs in the present tense (Regelmäßige Verben im Präsens)

■ From lesson

Regular German verbs are conjugated by removing the -en ending from the infinitive and adding personal endings. Five verbs are shown: kommen (to come), wohnen (to live), heißen (to be called), arbeiten (to work), and sein (to be - irregular).

COMPLETE RULE

ich: komme/wohne/heiße/arbeite/bin | du: kommst/wohnst/heißt/arbeitest/bist |
er/sie/es: kommt/ohnt/heißt/arbeitet/ist | wir: kommen/wohnen/heißen/arbeiten/sind |
ihr: kommt/ohnt/heißt/arbeitet/seid | sie/Sie: kommen/wohnen/heißen/arbeiten/sind |
Note: Verb stems ending in -t, -d add -e- before endings (arbeitsest). Verb stems
ending in -s, -ß, -z have -t instead of -st for du (heißt).

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich komme aus Marokko.*

→ *Du wohnst in Tübingen.*

→ *Er arbeitet in Stuttgart.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Forgetting the extra -e- in verbs with stems ending in -t or -d (arbeiten: du arbeitest, not du arbeitst).
Using -st instead of -t for du with verbs ending in -s/-ß/-z (heißen: du heißt, not du heißst).

Verben 'haben' und 'sein' im Präsens und Präteritum

■ From lesson

Conjugation of the irregular verbs 'haben' (to have) and 'sein' (to be) in present and simple past tense

COMPLETE RULE

haben Präsens: ich habe, du hast, er/sie/es hat, wir haben, ihr habt, sie/Sie haben |
haben Präteritum: ich hatte, du hattest, er/sie/es hatte, wir hatten, ihr hattet,
sie/Sie hatten | sein Präsens: ich bin, du bist, er/sie/es ist, wir sind, ihr seid,
sie/Sie sind | sein Präteritum: ich war, du warst, er/sie/es war, wir waren, ihr wart,
sie/Sie waren

EXAMPLES

- *Ich habe Zeit.*
- *Du hattest keine Zeit.*
- *Er ist hier.*
- *Wir waren gestern da.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Mixing up 'haben' and 'sein' conjugations, especially in past tense

Präsens: Verben mit Vokalwechsel

■ From lesson

Present tense: Verbs with vowel change in du and er/sie/es forms

COMPLETE RULE

lesen: ich lese, du liest, er/sie/es liest, wir lesen, ihr lest, sie/Sie lesen | sprechen/treffen: ich spreche/treffe, du sprichst/triffst, er/sie/es spricht/trifft, wir sprechen/treffen, ihr sprecht/trefft, sie/Sie sprechen/treffen | fahren/schlafen: ich fahre/schlafe, du fährst/schläfst, er/sie/es fährt/schläft, wir fahren/schlafen, ihr fahrt/schlaft, sie/Sie fahren/schlafen | laufen: ich laufe, du läufst, er/sie/es läuft, wir laufen, ihr lauft, sie/Sie laufen | wissen: ich weiß, du weißt, er/sie/es weiß, wir wissen, ihr wisst, sie/Sie wissen

EXAMPLES

- *Du liest gern.*
- *Er spricht Deutsch.*
- *Sie fährt Fahrrad.*
- *Du läufst schnell.*
- *Ich weiß das nicht.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting the vowel change in du and er/sie/es forms

Perfekt: regelmäßige Verben

■ From lesson

Perfect tense: Regular verbs. Formed with haben or sein + past participle. Past participles of regular verbs: ge-[stem]-(e)t or just -t for verbs ending in -ieren.

COMPLETE RULE

ge-[...](e)t pattern: ich habe geschafft, du hast geschafft, er/sie/es hat geschafft, wir haben geschafft, ihr habt geschafft, sie/Sie haben geschafft | with sein: ich bin gestartet, du bist gestartet, er/sie/es ist gestartet, wir sind gestartet, ihr seid gestartet, sie/Sie sind gestartet | -t pattern (no ge-): ich habe trainiert, du hast trainiert, er/sie/es hat trainiert, wir haben trainiert, ihr habt trainiert, sie/Sie haben trainiert | passieren with sein: er/sie/es ist passiert, sie/Sie sind passiert

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe es geschafft.*

→ *Er ist gestartet.*

→ *Wir haben trainiert.*

→ *Es ist passiert.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using haben instead of sein for movement/change of state verbs; forgetting ge- prefix; adding ge- to -ieren verbs

Perfekt: unregelmäßige und gemischte Verben

■ From lesson

Perfect tense with irregular and mixed verbs. Irregular verbs use 'haben' or 'sein' + past participle starting with 'ge-'. Mixed verbs combine features of both regular and irregular verbs.

COMPLETE RULE

Irregular verbs: ich habe getroffen, bin gefahren | du hast gefunden, bist geblieben | er/sie/es hat geschlafen, ist gekommen | wir haben gelesen, sind gegangen | ihr habt geholfen, seid gelaufen | sie/Sie haben gesprochen, sind gefahren. Mixed verbs: habe gewusst, hast gedacht, hat gewusst, haben gedacht, habt gewusst, haben gedacht. Sein conjugation: bin gewesen, bist gewesen, ist gewesen, sind gewesen, seid gewesen, sind gewesen. Note: With 'haben' and 'sein', most use Präteritum instead of Perfekt. 'sitzen' uses Perfekt with 'haben', but Southern Germany and Switzerland use Perfekt with 'sein'.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe heute mehrmals angerufen.*

→ *Du hast leider nicht zurückgerufen.*

→ *Er hat den Antrag vom Studierendenwohnheim ausgefüllt.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Imperativsätze - Verben mit Vokalwechsel (informell Sg.)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with verbs that have vowel change in informal singular form. The vowel change from the du form is kept in the imperative.

COMPLETE RULE

Informal singular with vowel change: du fährst → Fahr! | du liest → Lies! | du lädst ein → Lade ein!

EXAMPLES

→ *Fahr!*

→ *Lies!*

→ *Lade ein!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Note the vowel change and that some verbs revert to original vowel in imperative

Imperativsätze - Verben mit Vokalwechsel (informell Pl.)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with verbs that have vowel change in informal plural form. The ihr form is used as imperative.

COMPLETE RULE

Informal plural with vowel change: ihr fahrt → Fahrt! | ihr lest → Lest! | ihr ladet ein → Ladet ein!

EXAMPLES

→ *Fahrt!*

→ *Lest!*

→ *Ladet ein!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

The ihr form has no vowel change in most verbs

Imperativsätze - Verben mit Vokalwechsel (formell)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with verbs that have vowel change in formal form. The Sie form with inverted word order is used.

COMPLETE RULE

Formal with vowel change: Sie fahren → Fahren Sie! | Sie lesen → Lesen Sie! | Sie laden ein → Laden Sie ein!

EXAMPLES

→ *Fahren Sie!*

→ *Lesen Sie!*

→ *Laden Sie ein!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

The Sie form has no vowel change

Imperativsätze - haben und sein (informell Sg.)

■ From lesson

Imperative sentences with the verbs haben and sein in informal singular form. These verbs have irregular imperative forms.

COMPLETE RULE

Informal singular irregular: du hast → Hab keine Angst! | du bist → Sei vorsichtig!

EXAMPLES

→ *Hab keine Angst!*

→ *Sei vorsichtig!*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

These are irregular forms that must be memorized

Verwendung von Präsens

■ From lesson

Using present tense for present and future meanings in German

COMPLETE RULE

Gegenwart / allgemeine Gültigkeit = Verb im Präsens (present/general validity = verb in present tense) | Zukunft = Verb im Präsens + Zeitangabe für die Zukunft (future = verb in present tense + time expression for the future)

EXAMPLES

→ *Morgen gehe ich ins Zentrum Paul Klee.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

English speakers try to use future tense constructions when simple present with time expression is sufficient

Präteritum - regelmäßige Verben

■ From lesson

Regular verbs in the simple past tense (Präteritum) add -te endings to the stem

COMPLETE RULE

suchen: ich suchte, du suchtest, er/sie/es suchte, wir suchten, ihr suchtet, sie/Sie suchten | warten: ich wartete, du wartetest, er/sie/es wartete, wir warteten, ihr wartetet, sie/Sie warteten

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich suchte meine Schlüssel.*

→ *Du wartetest auf den Bus.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing Präteritum with Perfekt in spoken German

Präteritum - unregelmäßige Verben

■ From lesson

Irregular verbs in the simple past tense (Präteritum) have stem changes and different endings

COMPLETE RULE

gehen: ich ging, du gingst, er/sie/es ging, wir gingen, ihr gingt, sie/Sie gingen |
laufen: ich lief, du liefst, er/sie/es lief, wir liefen, ihr lieft, sie/Sie liefen |
ankommen: ich kam...an, du kamst...an, er/sie/es kam...an, wir kamen...an, ihr
kamt...an, sie/Sie kamen...an

EXAMPLES

- *Er ging zur Arbeit.*
- *Sie lief schnell nach Hause.*
- *Der Zug kam pünktlich an.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Not learning the irregular stem changes by heart

Präteritum - gemischte Verben

■ From lesson

Mixed verbs in the simple past tense (Präteritum) have stem changes like irregular verbs but take regular -te endings

COMPLETE RULE

rennen: ich rannte, du ranntest, er/sie/es rannte, wir rannten, ihr ranntet, sie/Sie rannten | denken: ich dachte, du dachtest, er/sie/es dachte, wir dachten, ihr dachtet, sie/Sie dachten

EXAMPLES

- *Er rannte zum Bus.*
- *Ich dachte an dich.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Treating mixed verbs as either fully regular or fully irregular

Diminutiv = Verkleinerungsform

■ From lesson

Nouns ending in -chen, -lein have the article 'das'. Most have a vowel change: a→ä, o→ö, u→ü. The ending -chen/-lein means: Something is small; -chen can also mean: One finds something cute/nice.

COMPLETE RULE

Nouns with ending *-chen* or *-lein* have article *das*: *der Rock* → *das Röckchen*. Vowel changes: *a*→*ä*, *o*→*ö*, *u*→*ü*, e.g. *Jacke* → *Jäckchen*. Meaning: something is small OR something is cute/nice (e.g. *ein hübsch/nett*)

EXAMPLES

→ *der Rock* → *das Röckchen*

→ *Jacke* → *Jäckchen*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting the vowel change (umlaut) when forming diminutives

Aktiv zu Passiv (Active to Passive)

■ From lesson

In active sentences, the agent (who does the action) is important. In passive sentences, the action/what is done is important. The passive can be formed with 'von' + dative when the agent information is also important.

COMPLETE RULE

Active: Subject + verb + accusative object. Passive: Subject (former object) + werden + past participle + von + dative (former subject/agent). Passive without agent is used for general information or rules.

EXAMPLES

→ *Die Eheleute gründen 1912 die Fabrik. (Active)*

→ *Die Fabrik wird 1912 (von den Eheleuten) gegründet. (Passive)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to use 'werden' as auxiliary verb or placing the agent incorrectly

Passiv Präsens conjugation (Passive Present tense)

■ From lesson

The passive present tense is formed with the present tense of 'werden' + past participle.

COMPLETE RULE

Passive Present: werden (conjugated in present) + past participle

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich werde aufgenommen.*

→ *Du wirst aufgenommen.*

→ *Er wird aufgenommen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'werden' (passive) with 'sein' (perfect tense)

Passiv word order - Position 2 and Satzende

■ From lesson

In passive sentences, the conjugated form of 'werden' takes position 2, and the past participle goes to the end of the sentence.

COMPLETE RULE

Subject/Time/Other element - Position 2 (werden conjugated) - middle field - Satzende (past participle)

EXAMPLES

→ *Viele neue Sorten werden in den 60er- und 70er-Jahren produziert.*

→ *Die Fabrik wurde 1912 von den Eheleuten gegründet.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Placing the past participle in the wrong position or forgetting position 2 for werden

Temporale Nebensätze mit 'wenn' und 'als'

■ From lesson

Temporal subordinate clauses with 'wenn' and 'als'. Both mean 'when', but 'als' is used for a single event in the past, 'wenn' is used for repeated events in the past or events in present/future.

COMPLETE RULE

'als' = for an event that happened once in the past. 'wenn' = for events that happened multiple times in the past (immer wenn, jedes Mal wenn). 'wenn' = for events in present or future (once or multiple times).

EXAMPLES

→ *Das Wetter war leider nicht so gut, als wir ankamen.*

- *Als wir dort waren, hat eine Musikgruppe traditionelle Musik gespielt.*
- *(Immer) wenn das Wetter gut war, haben wir Wanderungen in den Bergen gemacht.*
- *(Jedes Mal) wenn wir sehr müde waren, haben wir einen Pausentag eingeplant.*
- *Man erholt sich am besten, wenn man faulenz.*
- *Wenn das Wetter morgen schön ist, (dann) machen wir einen Ausflug.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using 'wenn' for single past events instead of 'als'. Remember: 'als' = one time in past, 'wenn' = repeated past OR present/future

Passiv – Perfekt

■ From lesson

Perfect tense passive voice. Structure: subject (Position 1) + conjugated 'sein' (Position 2) + middle field + past participle + worden (sentence end). Note: 'worden' not 'geworden'.

COMPLETE RULE

Passive Perfect: Position 1 subject + Position 2 conjugated sein + middle field + past participle + worden at sentence end

EXAMPLES

- *Der Radfahrer ist nicht verletzt worden.*
- *Herr Nolte ist als Zeuge befragt worden.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using 'geworden' instead of 'worden', using 'haben' instead of 'sein'

Passiv Perfekt Konjugation

■ From lesson

Conjugation of passive perfect for all persons: conjugated form of 'sein' + befragt + worden

COMPLETE RULE

ich bin befragt worden, du bist befragt worden, er/sie/es ist befragt worden, wir sind befragt worden, ihr seid befragt worden, sie/Sie sind befragt worden

EXAMPLES

- *ich bin befragt worden*
- *du bist befragt worden*
- *wir sind befragt worden*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Wrong auxiliary verb conjugation, using 'geworden'

Vorgangspassiv und Zustandspassiv

■ From lesson

Process passive (Vorgangspassiv) with 'werden' describes an action or process (What is happening?). State passive (Zustandspassiv) with 'sein' describes the result of an action or a state (What is the current state?)

COMPLETE RULE

Vorgangspassiv uses 'werden' + past participle to describe a process. Zustandspassiv uses 'sein' + past participle to describe a resulting state.

EXAMPLES

- *Die Ausfahrt wurde gesperrt. (process - blocking happened)*
- *Beim Unfall wurde der Radfahrer verletzt. (process - injury occurred)*
- *Die Ausfahrt ist (jetzt) gesperrt. (state - blocked now)*
- *Der Radfahrer ist verletzt. (state - injured now)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing when to use 'werden' vs 'sein' passive, not recognizing the difference between process and state

Partizip Perfekt als Adjektiv

■ From lesson

Past participle (Partizip Perfekt) used as adjective. When used as adjective, it has the same endings as regular adjectives. When used attributively (before noun), it often has passive meaning.

COMPLETE RULE

Past participle as adjective: has adjective endings, often passive meaning. Example: der verletzte Mann = der Mann ist/wurde verletzt; die gesperrte Ausfahrt = die Ausfahrt ist/wurde gesperrt

EXAMPLES

→ *der verletzte Mann* → *der Mann ist / wurde verletzt*
→ *die gesperrte Ausfahrt* → *die Ausfahrt ist / wurde gesperrt*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting adjective endings, not recognizing passive meaning

lassen + Nomen

■ From lesson

The verb 'lassen' can also be used with a noun or pronoun in the accusative case. The perfect tense is formed with 'haben' + participle perfect of 'lassen'.

COMPLETE RULE

Present: lassen + noun/pronoun in accusative | Perfect: haben + sein/ihr/seinen/ihren + noun/pronoun + participle perfect of lassen (gelassen)

EXAMPLES

→ *Christian lässt sein Handy im Büro.*
→ *Christian lässt es im Büro.*
→ *Christian hat sein Handy im Büro gelassen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing the two uses of lassen - with infinitive vs. with noun

Futur I - Future tense formation and usage

■ From lesson

Futur I is used to express intentions about the future and more certain predictions. It is formed with the present tense forms of 'werden' and the infinitive.

COMPLETE RULE

Futur I: conjugated form of 'werden' in Position 2 + infinitive at the end of the sentence. Example: Ich werde einen Schwedischkurs machen. Wir werden ab August zusammen in Berlin wohnen.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich werde vermutlich/wohl/wahrscheinlich Portugal vermissen.*
- *Vermutlich/Wahrscheinlich werde ich Portugal vermissen.*
- *Es wird schon klappen.*
- *Ich werde als Dolmetscher bestimmt/sicherlich/sicher gute Chancen haben.*
- *Bestimmt/Sicherlich/Sicher werde ich als Dolmetscher gute Chancen haben.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing Futur I with simple present for future events. Remember particles and adverbs with Futur I have meaning differences: *Vermutung* (vermutlich, wohl, wahrscheinlich), *Zuversicht* (schon), *Sicherheit* (bestimmt, sicherlich, sicher).

als vs wenn (subordinate clauses)

■ Web verified

'Als' is used exclusively for single events in the past tense (one-time occurrence). 'Wenn' is used for present tense actions, future events, repeated/habitual past actions ('whenever'), and conditional sentences ('if'). Both are subordinating conjunctions that send the conjugated verb to the end of the clause.

COMPLETE RULE

ALS:

- Temporal conjunction for ONE-TIME past events only
- Always with Präteritum or Perfekt tense
- Example: 'Als ich Kind war' (when I was a child - single period)

WENN:

- Present tense: 'Wenn ich zu Hause bin, putze ich' (when I'm home, I clean)
- Future: 'Wenn wir heiraten, machen wir eine Party' (when we marry, we'll have a party)
- Repeated past ('whenever'): 'Immer wenn es regnete, blieb ich zu Hause' (whenever it rained, I stayed home)
- Conditional ('if'): 'Wenn du möchtest, kannst du lernen' (if you want, you can learn)

VERB POSITION: In subordinate clauses with *als/wenn*, the conjugated verb moves to the LAST position. When the *als/wenn* clause comes first, the main clause uses inversion (verb before subject).

EXAMPLES

- *Als ich nach Hause kam, war die Tür offen. (When I came home [one time], the door was open.)*
- *Wenn ich zu Hause bin, putze ich immer. (When(ever) I'm home, I always clean.)*
- *Immer wenn es geregnet hat, bin ich zu Hause geblieben. (Whenever it rained, I stayed home.)*

→ *Wenn du Deutsch lernen willst, kannst du das machen. (If you want to learn German, you can do that.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' MISTAKES:

■ 1. Using 'wenn' for single past events (Italian 'quando' covers both): ■ 'Wenn ich ein Kind war' → ■ 'Als ich ein Kind war'

■ 2. Using 'als' for repeated past events: ■ 'Als wir nach Berlin fahren (immer)' → ■ 'Wenn wir nach Berlin fahren'

3. Confusing 'wenn' (when/if) with 'ob' (whether) in indirect questions - 'ob' expresses doubt/questions only

■ 4. Using 'wann' (question word) instead of 'wenn/als' in subordinate clauses

5. Forgetting verb-final position in subordinate clauses

■ 6. Forgetting inversion after als/wenn clause: ■ 'Als ich ankam, ich ging' → ■ 'Als ich ankam, ging ich'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

COMPARATIVE EXCEPTION: 'Als' is also used in comparatives (not temporal): 'Ich bin größer als du' (I am taller than you). This is completely different from temporal 'als'.

WENN AMBIGUITY: 'Wenn' in future contexts can be ambiguous between 'when' and 'if' - use 'falls' for clearer conditional meaning if needed.

PERIOD AS SINGLE EVENT: Extended periods count as single events with 'als' if conceptually one continuous time: 'Als ich in Deutschland war' (the whole period of being in Germany = one event).

Comparative Formation (Komparativ)

■ Web verified

The comparative is formed by adding -er to the adjective. Many one-syllable adjectives with a, o, or u add an umlaut. The comparison uses 'als' (than) for inequality: Die Giraffe ist größer als die Maus. Unlike English, German never uses 'mehr' (more) + adjective except with 'viel'.

COMPLETE RULE

Regular formation: adjective + -er. Monosyllabic adjectives with stem vowels a, o, u often add umlaut: groß → größer, alt → älter, jung → jünger, warm → wärmer, kurz → kürzer, lang → länger, kalt → kälter, stark → stärker. Adjectives ending in -el drop the 'e' before adding -er: dunkel → dunkler. Adjectives ending in -er with a vowel before it also lose the 'e': teuer → teurer. Irregular forms: gut → besser, viel → mehr, gern → lieber, hoch → höher (drops the 'c'), nah → näher. When used attributively (before nouns), comparative adjectives take regular adjective declension endings: ein schnelleres Auto, der größere Hund. Comparison of superiority uses 'als': schneller als (faster than). Some adjectives do NOT take umlaut despite having a, o, or u: bunt → bunter, schlank → schlanker, froh → froher, rund → runder.

EXAMPLES

- *Die Giraffe ist größer als die Maus. (The giraffe is bigger than the mouse.)*
- *Der Zug ist schneller als das Auto. (The train is faster than the car.)*
- *Das Wetter ist heute besser als gestern. (The weather is better today than yesterday.)*
- *Dieses Buch ist interessanter als das andere. (This book is more interesting than the other.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may try to use 'weniger' (less) + adjective for inferiority comparisons like Italian 'meno grande', but this is unnatural in German. WRONG: 'Die Maus ist weniger groß als die Giraffe'. CORRECT: Use 'nicht so...wie' or the opposite comparative. Italian uses 'più' + adjective, but German NEVER uses 'mehr' + adjective (except with 'viel'). WRONG: 'mehr interessant'. CORRECT: 'interessanter'. Forgetting umlaut changes: WRONG: 'groser'. CORRECT: 'größer'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular forms must be memorized: gut → besser → am besten, viel → mehr → am meisten, gern → lieber → am liebsten, hoch → höher → am höchsten (drops -c-), nah → näher → am nächsten. Not all monosyllabic adjectives with a, o, u take umlaut: bunt, schlank, froh, rund, toll, flach remain unchanged (bunter, schlanker, etc.).

Conditional sentences with 'wenn'

■ Web verified

'Wenn' is used for conditional sentences (if-then situations) and when-clauses. It expresses a condition: 'If X happens, then Y happens'. As a subordinating conjunction, 'wenn' sends the conjugated verb to the end of its clause. 'Wenn' means both 'if' (for conditions) and 'when' (for repeated actions in present/future).

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE:

1. **STRUCTURE:** *Wenn + subject + other elements + conjugated verb, main clause verb + subject + rest*
OR: *Main clause, wenn + subject + other elements + conjugated verb*

2. **VERB POSITION IN WENN-CLAUSE:** *Conjugated verb goes to END*

3. **VERB-COMMA-VERB PATTERN:** *When wenn-clause comes first, entire subordinate clause = position 1, so main verb immediately follows comma*

Example: Wenn es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause.

4. TYPES OF CONDITIONAL SENTENCES:

- **TYPE 1 (Real/Possible):** *Present + Present/Future*

Example: Wenn ich Zeit habe, helfe ich dir.

- TYPE 2 (Unreal Present/Hypothetical): Konjunktiv II + Konjunktiv II

Example: Wenn ich Zeit hätte, würde ich dir helfen.

- TYPE 3 (Unreal Past): Past Perfect Subjunctive + Past Perfect Subjunctive

Example: Wenn ich Zeit gehabt hätte, hätte ich dir geholfen.

5. OMITTING 'WENN': Possible only when wenn-clause comes first; verb moves to position 1

Example: Habe ich Zeit, helfe ich dir.

6. ALTERNATIVE 'FALLS': Means 'in case/if' with more uncertainty, only in Type 1 conditionals

Example: Falls es regnet, nehmen wir den Bus.

7. WITH SEPARABLE VERBS: Prefix stays attached in wenn-clause

Example: Wenn du das Fenster aufmachst, wird es hell.

8. WITH MODAL VERBS: Modal verb goes last, infinitive precedes it

Example: Wenn ich morgen arbeiten muss, komme ich nicht.

9. COMMA: Always mandatory between wenn-clause and main clause

EXAMPLES

→ Wenn es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause. (If it rains, I stay at home.)

→ Wenn mein Freund kommt, gehen wir ins Kino. (If/When my friend comes, we go to the cinema.)

→ Ich lerne jeden Tag, wenn ich Zeit habe. (I study every day when I have time.)

→ Wenn du nicht aufhörst, gehe ich nach Hause. (If you don't stop, I'm going home.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. KEEPING VERB IN SECOND POSITION: Italian conditional 'se' doesn't move verb.

■ **WRONG:** Wenn es regnet, ich bleibe zu Hause.

■ **CORRECT:** Wenn es regnet, bleibe ich zu Hause.

(Italian: 'Se piove, io resto a casa' - verb stays after subject)

2. FORGETTING VERB AT END IN WENN-CLAUSE:

■ **WRONG:** Wenn du kommst morgen, rufe ich dich an.

■ **CORRECT:** Wenn du morgen kommst, rufe ich dich an.

3. NO INVERSION AFTER WENN-CLAUSE: Forgetting subject-verb inversion in main clause.

■ **WRONG:** Wenn ich Zeit habe, ich gehe ins Kino.

■ **CORRECT:** Wenn ich Zeit habe, gehe ich ins Kino.

4. USING FUTURE TENSE IN WENN-CLAUSE: Like English, but German uses present.

■ **WRONG:** Wenn ich werde Zeit haben, helfe ich dir.

■ **CORRECT:** Wenn ich Zeit habe, werde ich dir helfen.

(Italian often uses future: 'Se avrò tempo')

5. CONFUSING 'WENN' AND 'ALS': Italians struggle since 'quando' covers both.

- wenn = when (repeated/future) OR if (condition)

- als = when (one-time past event)

■ ■ CORRECT: Als ich Kind war... (When I was a child - one time)

■ ■ CORRECT: Wenn ich Zeit habe... (When/if I have time)

6. MIXING CONDITIONAL TYPES: Wrong tense combinations.

■ WRONG: Wenn ich Zeit habe, würde ich helfen. (mixing Type 1 + Type 2)

■ ■ CORRECT: Wenn ich Zeit hätte, würde ich helfen. (Type 2)

7. SEPARATING SEPARABLE VERBS IN WENN-CLAUSE:

■ WRONG: Wenn du machst das Fenster auf...

■ ■ CORRECT: Wenn du das Fenster aufmachst...

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. OMITTING 'WENN': Only possible when wenn-clause comes FIRST, verb takes position 1

Example: Regnet es, bleibe ich zu Hause.

- NOT possible: Ich bleibe zu Hause, regnet es. ■

2. WENN VS. ALS: 'Wenn' for repeated/future events; 'als' for one-time past events

Example: Wenn ich nach Berlin fahre, besuche ich dich. (every time)

Example: Als ich nach Berlin fuhr, besuchte ich dich. (one specific time in past)

3. 'FALLS' AS ALTERNATIVE: Means 'in case' with extra uncertainty, only Type 1

Example: Falls ich Zeit habe, helfe ich dir. (stronger doubt than wenn)

4. WENN IN INDIRECT QUESTIONS: Can't be used; use 'ob' instead

■ WRONG: Ich frage mich, wenn er kommt.

■ CORRECT: Ich frage mich, ob er kommt. (I wonder if/whether he's coming)

5. SCIENTIFIC REALITIES (Type 0): Present + Present for universal truths

Example: Wenn Wasser gefriert, wird es zu Eis. (When water freezes, it becomes ice.)

6. CONDITIONAL WITHOUT CONSEQUENCE: Wenn-clause can stand alone if context clear

Example: Wenn ich nur mehr Zeit hätte! (If only I had more time!)

7. 'IMMER WENN': Emphasizes repetition

Example: Immer wenn ich sie sehe, lächelt sie. (Whenever I see her, she smiles.)

8. WITH MODAL VERBS IN PERFECT: Very complex; Germans prefer simple past

Example: Wenn ich hätte kommen können... (If I could have come...) - awkward

Better: Wenn ich kommen konnte... (simple past)

9. POLITE REQUESTS WITH TYPE 2: Konjunktiv II makes requests more polite

Example: Wenn Sie mir helfen könnten, wäre ich sehr dankbar.

Difference between 'sich freuen auf' and 'sich freuen über'

■ Web verified

Sich freuen auf (+ Akk) expresses anticipation for something in the future. Sich freuen über (+ Akk) expresses happiness about something that has already happened or is happening now. Both always take accusative case.

COMPLETE RULE

CONJUGATION (Present Tense):

ich freue mich

du freust dich

er/sie/es freut sich

wir freuen uns

ihr freut euch

sie/Sie freuen sich

PREPOSITION USAGE:

AUF + Akkusativ = future anticipation/expectation

ÜBER + Akkusativ = present/past joy/happiness

TIME FRAME RULE:

- Use *AUF* when the event has *NOT* yet occurred
- Use *ÜBER* when the event *IS* occurring or *HAS* occurred

Both prepositions are followed by accusative case articles:

Masculine: den/einen

Feminine: die/eine

Neuter: das/ein

Plural: die

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich freue mich auf das Konzert. (I'm looking forward to the concert - it's in the future.)*

→ ***Ich freue mich über das Geschenk. (I'm happy about the gift***

I already have it.)

→ *Wir freuen uns schon auf den Urlaub. (We are already looking forward to the vacation.)*

→ *Sie hat sich sehr über die guten Nachrichten gefreut. (She was very happy about the good news.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these mistakes:

- 1. CONFUSING THE TIME FRAMES: Using 'über' for future events because Italian uses 'per' or 'di' without clear temporal distinction (*Ich freue mich über morgen instead of auf morgen)
- 2. WRONG CASE: Using dative instead of accusative (*sich freuen auf dem Wochenende instead of auf das Wochenende)
- 3. FORGETTING REFLEXIVE PRONOUN: Italian 'essere contento/felice' is not reflexive, so speakers forget 'sich' (*Ich freue auf instead of Ich freue MICH auf)
- 4. USING WRONG PREPOSITION: Translating Italian 'per' directly as 'für' (*sich freuen für instead of auf/über)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. In colloquial German, 'sich freuen auf' can sometimes be used for present situations when emphasizing ongoing anticipation
2. When followed by a clause (dass/zu), both require da-compound: 'Ich freue mich darauf, dich zu sehen' (I look forward to seeing you)
3. For negation, 'nicht' typically comes before the prepositional phrase: 'Ich freue mich nicht auf die Prüfung'

Diminutive suffix -chen creates neutral nouns

■ Web verified

The suffix '-chen' creates diminutives (small/cute versions) of nouns and always makes them neutral (das), regardless of the original noun's gender. It often causes an umlaut in the stem vowel: Korb → Körbchen.

COMPLETE RULE

Add '-chen' (or less commonly '-lein') to noun stems to create diminutives. All diminutives are neuter (das), overriding the original gender completely. Stem vowels often take umlauts: a→ä, o→ö, u→ü, au→äu. Declension: das Mädchen (nom.), des Mädchens (gen.), dem Mädchen (dat.), das Mädchen (akk.). The plural form is identical to singular: das Mädchen (sg.) → die Mädchen (pl.). Word-final -e and -en are lost before the suffix: Katze → Kätzchen, Garten → Gärtchen. Full examples with articles: der Hund → das Hündchen, die Katze → das Kätzchen, das Haus → das Häuschen. The suffix '-lein' follows identical rules but is less common and more literary: das Tischlein, das Vöglein.

EXAMPLES

- der Korb → das Körbchen (basket → little basket, masculine to neuter with umlaut)
- die Katze → das Kätzchen (cat → kitten, feminine to neuter with umlaut, -e dropped)
- das Brot → das Brötchen (bread → bread roll, remains neuter with umlaut)
- das Mädchen (girl - historically from 'Magd' + chen, neuter despite referring to female)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers commonly keep the original gender instead of changing to neuter. Error: '*die Häuschen' or '*der Hund-chen' (should always be 'das Häuschen', 'das Hündchen'). Forgetting the umlaut: '*das Hauschen' (should be 'das Häuschen' with umlaut). Italian speakers familiar with diminutives like '-ino/-ina' that maintain gender may struggle with German's gender override. Another error: trying to create plurals by adding endings: '*die Mädchenen' (should be just 'die Mädchen'). Confusion with words that look like diminutives but aren't: 'der Kuchen' (cake - not neuter because 'chen' is part of the root, not a suffix; the word doesn't come from 'Ku').

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some diminutives have become independent words with specialized meanings: 'das Brötchen' (bread roll, not just 'small bread'), 'das Märchen' (fairy tale, from 'Mär' = tale), 'das Kaninchen' (rabbit, from 'Kanin'), 'das Eichhörnchen' (squirrel). These are always neuter despite being standard vocabulary. Not all -chen words are diminutives: 'der Kuchen' (cake), 'der Knochen' (bone), 'der Drachen' (dragon/kite) - these are masculine because -chen is part of the original root, not a suffix. Regional variation: In Bavaria/Austria, '-erl' is used: 'das Sackerl'; in Swabia: '-le': 'das Häusle'.

Future expressed with present tense

■ Web verified

German commonly uses the present tense (Präsens) for future events when context (time expressions, dates, adverbs) makes the future meaning clear. This is preferred over 'werden + infinitive' when certainty is high: 'Ich bleibe bis Sonntag' (I will stay until Sunday). The future tense with 'werden' is reserved for predictions, intentions, or when future isn't clear from context.

COMPLETE RULE

PRESENT TENSE FOR FUTURE MEANING:

1. WHEN TO USE PRESENT FOR FUTURE:

The present tense expresses future when:

- a) Time expressions make it clear: *heute Abend, morgen, nächste Woche, 2027*
- b) The action is planned/scheduled with high certainty
- c) Questions about plans: *Wie lange bleibst du? (How long will you stay?)*

Structure: PRESENT TENSE + TIME EXPRESSION

- *Ich bleibe bis Sonntag. (I will stay until Sunday.)*
- *Morgen fahre ich nach Berlin. (Tomorrow I'm going/will go to Berlin.)*
- *2027 fahre ich nach Kolumbien. (In 2027 I'm going to Colombia.)*
- *Nächste Woche fängt die Schule an. (School starts next week.)*

2. COMMON TIME EXPRESSIONS FOR FUTURE:

- *morgen (tomorrow)*
- *übermorgen (day after tomorrow)*

- heute Abend (this evening)
- nächste Woche/nächsten Monat/nächstes Jahr
- in zwei Tagen (in two days)
- bald (soon)
- später (later)
- gleich (right away/soon)

3. WHEN TO USE 'WERDEN' + INFINITIVE (FUTUR I):

- a) Predictions/uncertainty: *Es wird regnen. (It will rain.)*
- b) Promises/intentions: *Ich werde dir helfen. (I will help you.)*
- c) Assumptions about present: *Er wird wohl krank sein. (He's probably sick.)*
- d) When no time marker makes future clear

Structure: *werden* (conjugated) + *INFINITIVE* (end)

- *Es wird schneien. (It will snow.)*
- *Ich werde ein neues Auto kaufen. (I will buy a new car.)*

4. CONJUGATION OF 'WERDEN' (Futur I):

ich werde ... bleiben
du wirst ... bleiben
er/sie/es wird ... bleiben
wir werden ... bleiben
ihr werdet ... bleiben
sie/Sie werden ... bleiben

5. PRESENT VS. FUTUR I COMPARISON:

CERTAIN/PLANNED → Present:

- *Ich fahre morgen nach München. (I'm going to Munich tomorrow.)*

INTENTION/PROMISE → Futur I:

- *Ich werde nach München fahren. (I will go to Munich. - promise/intention)*

6. QUESTIONS ABOUT FUTURE:

Usually present tense is used:

- *Kommst du morgen? (Are you coming tomorrow?)*
- *Wie lange bleibst du hier? (How long will you stay here?)*
- *Wann fährt der Zug ab? (When does/will the train leave?)*

EXAMPLES

- *Wie lange bleibst du hier? (How long will you stay here?)*
- *Ich bleibe bis Sonntag. (I will stay until Sunday.)*
- *2027 fahre ich nach Kolumbien. (In 2027 I'm going to Colombia.)*

→ *Morgen gehe ich ins Kino. (Tomorrow I'm going to the cinema.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' COMMON ERRORS:

1. OVERUSING FUTURE TENSE: Italian uses future tense ('andrò') more often; German prefers present

■ Ich werde bis Sonntag bleiben (too formal for simple future)

■ ✓ Ich bleibe bis Sonntag (natural German)

Compare Italian: 'Resterò fino a domenica' (future tense normal)

2. FORGETTING TIME MARKERS: Using present without clear future context

■ Ich fahre nach Kolumbien (unclear when - could be now)

■ ✓ Ich fahre 2027 nach Kolumbien (clear future time)

■ ✓ Ich fahre morgen nach Kolumbien

3. WRONG WORD ORDER WITH 'WERDEN':

■ Ich werde fahren morgen nach Berlin (infinitive must be at end)

■ ✓ Ich werde morgen nach Berlin fahren

4. CONFUSING 'WERDEN' = 'TO BECOME' WITH FUTURE:

■ Ich werde müde (I'm becoming tired - NOT future!)

■ ✓ Ich werde müde sein (I will be tired - future)

5. USING FUTURE FOR SCHEDULED EVENTS: Germans prefer present for schedules

■ Der Zug wird um 9 Uhr ankommen (sounds like uncertainty)

■ ✓ Der Zug kommt um 9 Uhr an (schedule - certain)

6. LITERAL TRANSLATION OF ITALIAN PRESENT CONTINUOUS:

Italian: 'Sto per partire' (I'm about to leave)

■ Ich bin zu fahren (doesn't exist)

■ ✓ Ich fahre gleich (I'm leaving soon)

■ ✓ Ich bin dabei zu fahren (I'm in the process of leaving - rare)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. MODAL VERBS: Often use 'werden' even with time expressions for nuance

- Ich werde morgen kommen müssen. (I will have to come tomorrow. - emphasis on obligation)

- vs. Ich muss morgen kommen. (I have to come tomorrow. - simpler)

2. WEATHER PREDICTIONS: Usually require 'werden'

- Es wird morgen regnen. (It will rain tomorrow. - prediction)

- NOT: Es regnet morgen (sounds strange)

3. IMMEDIATE FUTURE: 'gleich' with present is very common

- Ich komme gleich. (I'm coming right away.)
- Der Bus kommt gleich. (The bus is coming soon.)

4. 'WERDEN' FOR ASSUMPTIONS ABOUT PRESENT:

- Er wird wohl krank sein. (He's probably sick. - NOT future!)
- Sie wird im Büro sein. (She's probably in the office.)

5. FUTUR II (rare): Used for assumptions about past

- Er wird wohl angekommen sein. (He has probably arrived.)
- Structure: werden + past participle + sein/haben

6. FIXED SCHEDULES: Always present tense

- Der Film beginnt um 20 Uhr. (The movie starts at 8 PM.)
- Die Schule fängt am Montag an. (School starts on Monday.)
- Das Konzert findet nächste Woche statt. (The concert takes place next week.)

7. 'WOLLEN' VS. 'WERDEN' FOR INTENTION:

- Ich will nach Berlin fahren. (I want to go to Berlin. - desire)
- Ich werde nach Berlin fahren. (I will go to Berlin. - promise/determination)

Future Tense (Futur I)

■ Web verified

The future tense in German (Futur I) is formed with werden (conjugated) plus the infinitive at the end of the sentence. However, German speakers often prefer using the present tense with clear time indicators (like 'nächstes Jahr', 'morgen', 'nächste Woche') instead of Futur I. Use Futur I when there is no time indication in the sentence, or to express uncertainty, predictions, assumptions, or intentions about the future. Futur I can also express present assumptions using words like 'wohl', 'wahrscheinlich', 'sicher'.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: subject + werden (conjugated) + other elements + infinitive at end. Werden conjugation: ich werde, du wirst, er/sie/es wird, wir werden, ihr werdet, sie/Sie werden. Main clause: conjugated werden in second position, infinitive at end. Subordinate clause: infinitive first, then werden at end (e.g., 'Ich glaube, dass ich morgen nach Berlin fahren werde'). With modal verbs: werden + other elements + infinitive + modal infinitive (both at end). With separable verbs: the prefix remains attached to the infinitive. Present tense vs. Futur I: Use present tense when clear time indicators are present (e.g., 'Nächstes Jahr fliege ich in die USA'). Use Futur I without time indicators or to emphasize uncertainty, predictions, or assumptions (e.g., 'Wir werden sehen').

EXAMPLES

→ **Wir werden sehen. (We will see.**
no time indication)

→ *Ich werde in Zukunft in Basel arbeiten. (I will work in Basel in the future.)*

→ *Nächstes Jahr fliege ich in die USA. (Next year I'm flying to the USA. - present tense with clear time indicator)*

→ *Es wird wohl morgen regnen. (It will probably rain tomorrow. - expressing assumption)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often overuse the future tense when a clear time indicator is present, where German prefers the present tense. For example, Italians might say 'Morgen werde ich ins Kino gehen' when 'Morgen gehe ich ins Kino' is more natural. Another mistake is confusing 'werden' with 'wollen' (to want), similar to the Italian 'volere'. Italian speakers may also forget to place the infinitive at the end of the sentence. In subordinate clauses, they might incorrectly keep *werden* in second position instead of moving it to the end after the infinitive. They may also incorrectly conjugate *werden* (especially *du wirst* and *er/sie/es wird*).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Use future tense even with time indicators when emphasizing uncertainty, making predictions, or expressing strong intentions. Futur I can express present assumptions using modal particles like 'wohl', 'wahrscheinlich', 'sicher' (e.g., 'Er wird wohl zu Hause sein' = He's probably at home right now). The future tense is preferred over present tense for promises, commands, or when there's no clear time context. In spoken German, the simple past tense of modal verbs is often preferred over Futur I to avoid the double infinitive construction.

gerade = right now (present continuous)

■ Web verified

German has no continuous tense like English 'is doing'. Add 'gerade' (right now) or 'im Moment' (at the moment) to normal present tense to show ongoing action: 'Ich esse gerade' = 'I am eating right now.' Position: typically after the conjugated verb in main clauses, but can also appear after the object or at end for emphasis. Alternative: 'jetzt' (now) can also be used but is less specific for progressive actions.

COMPLETE RULE

FORMATION: Present tense verb + gerade (or im Moment/jetzt) | POSITION IN MAIN CLAUSE: After conjugated verb: 'Ich lese gerade ein Buch' | After verb and object: 'Ich lese ein Buch gerade' (less common) | SUBORDINATE CLAUSE: Flexible position: 'weil ich gerade lerne' | ALTERNATIVES: 'im Moment' (at the moment), 'jetzt' (now), 'gerade jetzt' (right now), 'gerade dabei sein' (to be in the process of). Colloquial: 'am + infinitive noun': 'Ich bin am Lesen' (regional, informal)

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich esse gerade. (I am eating right now.)*

→ *Sie macht sich Sorgen darüber, was ihr Freund gerade macht. (She is worried about what her boyfriend is doing right now.)*

→ *Was machst du gerade?* (What are you doing right now?)

→ *Kannst du mich später anrufen? Ich lerne gerade für meine Prüfung.* (Can you call me later? I'm studying for my exam at the moment.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers (and other Romance language speakers) trying to construct an English-style continuous tense with auxiliary verbs like 'stare + gerundio'. Omitting 'gerade' when the continuous aspect is important. Placing 'gerade' incorrectly in the sentence. Using only 'jetzt' when 'gerade' would be more precise for ongoing actions.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The construction 'sein + am + nominalized infinitive' (e.g., 'Ich bin am Essen') is common in colloquial speech, especially in Western Germany (Rheinland), but is not considered standard German and should be avoided in formal writing. For past ongoing actions, use Präteritum or Perfekt + 'gerade': 'Ich habe gerade gegessen' (I was just eating/I have just eaten).

Imperative Formation

■ Web verified

The German imperative (Befehlsform) is used to give commands, requests, or instructions. It has three main forms: du-form (informal singular), ihr-form (informal plural), and Sie-form (formal singular and plural). The imperative can only be formed in the present tense and cannot exist in past tense.

COMPLETE RULE

IMPERATIVE CONJUGATION TABLE:

du-form (informal singular): Remove -st from present tense 2nd person singular

- *gehen* → *du gehst* → *Geh!* (optional: *Gehe!*)

- *bringen* → *du bringst* → *Bring!*

- *machen* → *du machst* → *Mach(e)!*

ihr-form (informal plural): Use present tense 2nd person plural without pronoun

- *gehen* → *ihr geht* → *Geht!*

- *bringen* → *ihr bringt* → *Bringt!*

- *machen* → *ihr macht* → *Macht!*

Sie-form (formal): Infinitive + Sie (with inversion)

- *gehen* → *Sie gehen* → *Gehen Sie!*

- *bringen* → *Sie bringen* → *Bringen Sie!*

- *machen* → *Sie machen* → *Machen Sie!*

wir-form (Let's...): Infinitive + wir OR Lass uns/Lasst uns + infinitive

- gehen → Gehen wir! OR Lass uns gehen!

SPECIAL RULES:

1. Verbs with stem ending in -d, -t, -m, -n MUST keep the -e: du arbeitest → Arbeite! (not Arbeit!)
2. Strong verbs with e→i/ie vowel change keep the change in du-form: du gibst → Gib! (not Gebe!), du siehst → Sieh! (not Sehe!)
3. Verbs with a→ä vowel change DO NOT take umlaut in imperative: du fährst → Fahr! (not Fähr!)
4. Verbs ending in -eln, -ern add -e and may drop stem -e: handeln → Handle! or Handele!
5. Separable verbs: prefix goes to end: aufstehen → Steh auf! / Steht auf! / Stehen Sie auf!
6. Reflexive verbs: pronoun follows verb: Setz dich! / Setzt euch! / Setzen Sie sich!

IRREGULAR IMPERATIVES (MUST MEMORIZE):

sein: Sei! / Seid! / Seien Sie! / Seien wir!

haben: Hab(e)! / Habt! / Haben Sie!

werden: Werde! / Werdet! / Werden Sie!

POLITENESS PARTICLES: Add bitte, doch, mal to soften: Komm doch mal her!

EXAMPLES

→ Du bringst mir einen Kaffee. → Bring mir einen Kaffee! (informal singular command - remove -st ending)

→ Ihr esst das Gemüse. → Esst das Gemüse! (informal plural - use present tense ihr-form without pronoun, with vowel change e→i)

→ Sie öffnen das Fenster. → Öffnen Sie bitte das Fenster! (formal command with politeness particle bitte)

→ Du stehst auf. → Steh auf! (separable verb - prefix auf goes to end of sentence)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often try to form imperative in past tense (impossible in German - imperative only exists in present). They may forget that Italian uses subjunctive for polite commands (Lei venga!) while German uses infinitive + Sie inversion. Italian speakers may incorrectly add umlauts where vowel changes don't apply (Fähr instead of Fahr). They may also forget to move separable prefixes to the end of the sentence.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The verb sein has completely irregular forms: Sei!/Seid!/Seien Sie! Verbs with e→i or e→ie vowel changes keep the change in du-form but NEVER add -e ending: Gib! (not Gebe!), Lies! (not Lese!). Verbs with a→ä changes do NOT take umlaut in imperative: Fahr! (not Fähr!). Modal verbs (können, müssen, dürfen, wollen, sollen, mögen) have NO imperative forms. In written/formal German, the -e ending on du-form may be retained (Komme!), but in spoken German it's usually dropped (Komm!).

Irregular verb conjugation - vowel change in present tense

■ From lesson

Some irregular verbs change their stem vowel in the 2nd (du) and 3rd (er/sie/es) person singular forms

COMPLETE RULE

Common patterns: e→i (geben, treffen), e→ie (lesen, sehen), a→ä (fahren, schlafen, tragen)

EXAMPLES

- lesen: ich lese, du liest, er liest
- schlafen: ich schlafe, du schläfst, er schläft
- tragen: ich trage, du trägst, er trägt
- fahren: ich fahre, du fährst, er fährt
- essen: ich esse, du isst, er isst
- nehmen: ich nehme, du nimmst, er nimmt
- treffen: ich treffe, du triffst, er trifft
- geben: ich gebe, du gibst, er gibt

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

These changes only occur in present tense, not in past tenses or with modal verbs

liegen vs. legen distinction

■ Web verified

liegen (lag, gelegen) = to lie, be in a position (intransitive, state); legen (legte, gelegt) = to lay, place something (transitive, action). Liegen describes WHERE something IS (Wo? + dative), legen describes putting something somewhere (Wohin? + accusative). Liegen uses auxiliary 'haben' in Perfect tense; legen also uses 'haben'.

COMPLETE RULE

LIEGEN (intransitive, irregular): Present: ich liege, du liegst, er/sie/es liegt, wir liegen, ihr liegt, sie/Sie liegen. Simple Past: ich lag, du lagst, er/sie/es lag, wir lagen, ihr lagt, sie/Sie lagen. Perfect: ich habe gelegen, du hast gelegen, etc. Participle II: gelegen. Used with dative prepositions (auf dem Tisch).
LEGEN (transitive, regular): Present: ich lege, du legst, er/sie/es legt, wir legen, ihr legt, sie/Sie legen. Simple Past: ich legte, du legtest, er/sie/es legte, wir legten, ihr legtet, sie/Sie legten. Perfect: ich habe gelegt, du hast gelegt, etc. Participle II: gelegt. Used with accusative prepositions (auf den Tisch).
Reflexive form: sich legen (to lie down oneself).

EXAMPLES

→ *Das Buch liegt auf dem Tisch. (The book is lying on the table - state, dative)*

→ *Ich lege das Buch auf den Tisch. (I put/lay the book on the table
action, accusative)*

→ *Er liegt krank im Bett. (He is lying sick in bed
state)*

→ *Sie hat sich ins Bett gelegt. (She laid herself down in bed
reflexive action)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often confuse these verbs because Italian uses 'giacere/stare' for lying and 'mettere/posare' for laying without the grammatical distinction of case-triggering prepositions. Common errors: (1) Using *'Ich lege im Bett' instead of 'Ich liege im Bett' (I lie in bed). (2) Mixing dative/accusative cases: *'auf dem Tisch legen' instead of 'auf den Tisch legen'. (3) Forgetting reflexive pronoun with people: *'Er hat auf das Bett gelegt' instead of 'Er hat sich auf das Bett gelegt'. (4) Using regular conjugation for liegen: *'Ich habe gelegt' (I lay) instead of 'Ich habe gelegen'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some objects that are placed horizontally but are habitually described as 'standing': bottles, books on shelves typically use *stehen/stellen* instead of *liegen/legen* if they are upright. The position (horizontal vs. vertical) determines which verb pair to use. For people, when describing the completed action of lying down, use reflexive '*sich legen*'; when describing the state of being horizontal, use '*liegen*'.

Perfekt with sein: schon im Urlaub gewesen

■ Web verified

To say you have already been on a trip, German uses the Perfekt tense with the auxiliary 'sein' plus 'gewesen' (past participle of sein). 'Du bist schon im Urlaub gewesen' = 'You have already been on vacation.'

COMPLETE RULE

sein is one of the handful of verbs (along with *passieren*, *bleiben*, *werden*) that always form the Perfekt with the auxiliary *sein* rather than *haben*. Because *sein* is both the main verb and its own auxiliary here, the Perfekt of *sein* looks like '*sein* (conjugated) + *gewesen*'.

CONJUGATION TABLE - Perfekt of 'sein' (Duden):

ich bin gewesen

du bist gewesen

er/sie/es ist gewesen

wir sind gewesen

ihr seid gewesen

sie/Sie sind gewesen

Plusquamperfekt (for reference): ich war gewesen, du warst gewesen, er/sie/es war gewesen, wir waren gewesen, ihr wart gewesen, sie waren gewesen.

General rule for haben vs sein in the Perfekt (germanveryeasy.com / Duden):

- *sein is used as the auxiliary for: the verbs sein, passieren, bleiben, werden; intransitive verbs of movement/change of location (gehen, fahren, laufen, rennen, springen, fallen, kommen, fliegen, schwimmen); intransitive verbs expressing a change of state (sterben, werden, aufwachen, einschlafen, wachsen, schmelzen).*
- *haben is used in all other cases (transitive verbs, reflexive verbs, most intransitive verbs that don't express motion/change of state).*
- *Some motion verbs (schwimmen, joggen, klettern, tanzen) can take either haben or sein depending on whether the focus is on the activity itself (haben) or on covering a distance/reaching a destination (sein).*

Word order note: with time expressions like 'schon' (already), the adverb is placed directly after the conjugated auxiliary: Subject + sein(conj.) + schon + [place phrase] + gewesen. E.g. 'Du bist schon im Urlaub gewesen.'

EXAMPLES

- *Du bist schon im Urlaub gewesen.*
- *Ich bin gestern wieder zurück nach Hause gekommen.*
- *Wir sind noch nie in Italien gewesen.*
- *Seid ihr schon einmal in Berlin gewesen?*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers, whose L1 Perfetto Composto also uses two auxiliaries (essere/avere), sometimes still default to using 'haben' for 'sein' or confuse it with the Italian pattern 'essere stato/a', and try to add a gender/number-agreeing ending onto 'gewesen' (German past participles used with an auxiliary do NOT agree in gender/number, unlike Italian past participles with essere, e.g. 'sono stata/stato'). Another common error is placing 'gewesen' in the wrong position: Italian word order keeps the participle right after the auxiliary ('sono stata a casa'), so learners may say '*Ich bin gewesen schon im Urlaub' instead of correctly sending the participle 'gewesen' to the very end of the clause: 'Ich bin schon im Urlaub gewesen.' Learners also sometimes confuse 'sein' (to be) with 'sein' as a possessive pronoun (his/its), leading to confusion when parsing sentences with 'ist gewesen'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

A small set of verbs (liegen, sitzen, stehen) form the Perfekt with 'haben' in northern Germany but with 'sein' in southern Germany, Austria, and Switzerland (regional variation confirmed by Duden: 'Ich habe gelegen/gestanden/gesessen' vs. 'Ich bin gelegen/gestanden/gesessen'). Motion verbs like schwimmen, fahren, fliegen, klettern, joggen can take either haben or sein depending on whether the emphasis is on the action/duration (haben) or the movement/destination (sein). The verbs gehen and reisen are now used almost exclusively with sein in modern German.

Positioning verbs: stellen/stehen, legen/liegen, setzen/sitzen, hängen

German uses specific verb pairs for positioning objects. Active verbs (stellen, legen, setzen, hängen-transitive) take Akkusativ and describe putting something somewhere. Passive/static verbs (stehen, liegen, sitzen, hängen-intransitive) take Dativ and describe where something is.

COMPLETE RULE

Active positioning verbs (weak/transitive): stellen (put standing/vertical), legen (put laying/horizontal), setzen (put sitting - only for things with legs/bottoms), hängen (hang something - weak conjugation: hängte, gehängt). Static position verbs (strong/intransitive): stehen (stand, be standing), liegen (lie, be lying), sitzen (sit, be sitting), hängen (be hanging - strong conjugation: hing, gehangen). Active verbs require Akkusativ with Wechselpräpositionen; static verbs require Dativ. Full conjugation for hängen (transitive): ich hänge, du hängst, er hängt / ich hängte / ich habe gehängt. Full conjugation for hängen (intransitive): ich hänge, du hängst, er hängt / ich hing / ich habe gehangen. Reflexive forms exist: sich setzen (to sit down - Akkusativ), sich legen (to lie down - Akkusativ), sich hinstellen (to go and stand - Akkusativ).

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich stelle das Glas auf den Tisch. (I put the glass on the table**

Akkusativ, vertical placement)

→ **Das Glas steht auf dem Tisch. (The glass stands on the table - Dativ, static vertical position)**

→ **Sie legt das Buch auf den Tisch. (She lays the book on the table**

Akkusativ, horizontal placement)

→ **Das Buch liegt auf dem Tisch. (The book lies on the table - Dativ, static horizontal position)**

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly confuse which verb to use based on object orientation. Error: Using 'liegen' with Akkusativ or 'legen' with Dativ (remember: active = Akkusativ, static = Dativ). Example: '*Ich lege das Buch auf dem Tisch' (should be 'auf den Tisch' with Akkusativ). Error with 'setzen': Using it for inanimate objects without legs - '*Ich setze das Glas auf den Tisch' (should be 'stelle' for vertical placement). Italian speakers familiar with 'mettere' (general 'to put') must learn three different German verbs. Hängen confusion: mixing weak and strong forms - '*Das Bild hängte an der Wand' (should be 'hing' - strong form for static position).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The verb 'hängen' has two forms with different conjugations: weak (hängen-hängte-gehängt) when transitive/active, strong (hängen-hing-gehangen) when intransitive/static. Books can use either stellen/stehen (if vertical on shelf) or legen/liegen (if flat on table). For putting things inside containers where orientation is unclear, use 'tun' or 'stecken' instead: 'Ich tue den Schlüssel in die Tasche' or 'Ich stecke den Schlüssel in die Tasche.'

Present Tense Conjugation - Irregular Verbs with Vowel Change

■ From lesson

Some irregular verbs change their stem vowel in du and er/sie/es forms (e→i, e→ie, a→ä)

COMPLETE RULE

Vowel changes occur only in 2nd and 3rd person singular. Common patterns: e→i (essen, treffen, vergessen), e→ie (lesen, sehen), a→ä (fahren, schlafen, tragen)

EXAMPLES

- *lesen*: ich lese, du liest, er liest
- *treffen*: ich treffe, du triffst, er trifft
- *schlafen*: ich schlafe, du schläfst, er schläft
- *fahren*: ich fahre, du fährst, er fährt

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Applying vowel change to all forms instead of just du/er/sie/es

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

wissen is highly irregular: ich weiß, du weißt, er weiß, wir wissen

Present Tense Conjugation - Regular Verbs

■ From lesson

Regular verbs in present tense are conjugated by removing -en from the infinitive and adding personal endings: -e, -st, -t, -en, -t, -en

COMPLETE RULE

For verbs with stems ending in -t or -d (like arbeiten), an extra -e- is added before endings for smoother pronunciation: du arbeitest (not arbeitst), er arbeitet (not arbeit)

EXAMPLES

- *arbeiten*: ich arbeite, du arbeitest, er arbeitet
- *spielen*: ich spiele, du spielst, er spielt
- *machen*: ich mache, du machst, er macht

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting the extra -e- in verbs like arbeiten, warten

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some verbs are irregular even if they look regular

sich freuen auf vs. sich freuen über

■ Web verified

'Sich freuen auf' (+ accusative) expresses looking forward to future events. 'Sich freuen über' (+ accusative) expresses being pleased about present or past events.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete conjugation with reflexive pronouns: *ich freue mich, du freust dich, er/sie/es freut sich, wir freuen uns, ihr freut euch, sie/Sie freuen sich*. Structure: **SUBJECT** + reflexive pronoun (accusative) + **freuen** + **auf** (future) / **über** (present/past) + **ACCUSATIVE OBJECT**. These are prepositional objects (*Präpositionalobjekte*) - the prepositions are fixed to the verb. Question forms: *Worauf freust du dich?* (What are you looking forward to?) / *Worüber freust du dich?* (What are you happy about?).

EXAMPLES

- *Ich freue mich auf das Wochenende.* (I'm looking forward to the weekend - future)
- *Wir freuen uns auf den Ausflug.* (We're looking forward to the excursion - future)
- *Ich habe mich über das Geschenk gefreut.* (I was pleased about the gift past)
- *Ich freue mich über deine Hilfe.* (I'm happy about your help - present)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Forgetting the reflexive pronoun entirely (saying 'Ich freue auf' instead of 'Ich freue mich auf').
Confusing the prepositions 'auf' and 'über', using 'auf' for past events or 'über' for future events. Italian speakers may confuse this with Italian 'rallegrarsi di' and use wrong prepositions.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'Freut mich' (or 'Es freut mich') is a fixed expression meaning 'pleased to meet you' / 'nice to meet you' without requiring a preposition. 'Sich freuen an' (+ dative) means 'to take pleasure in/enjoy': 'sich an Blumen freuen'. 'Sich freuen für' means 'to be happy for someone': 'Ich freue mich für dich'.

Superlative Formation (Superlativ)

■ Web verified

The superlative has two forms: 1) Predicative with 'am' + adjective + -(e)sten: 'Der Elefant ist am größten'
2) Attributive before nouns with article + adjective + -(e)ste + declension ending: 'das größte Tier'. Add -e- before -sten when stem ends in -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -x, -z for pronunciation. Many one-syllable adjectives add umlaut.

COMPLETE RULE

Predicative/adverbial superlative: am + adjective + -(e)sten. Use -esten when adjective ends in -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -x, -z: am lautesten, am heißesten, am weitesten. Attributive superlative (before nouns): definite article + adjective + -(e)ste + declension ending. Drop 'am' when using attributively. The adjective takes normal strong, weak, or mixed declension endings depending on what precedes it: der größte Berg (weak -e), ein größtes Haus (mixed -es), größte Berge (strong -e plural). Monosyllabic adjectives with a, o, u add umlaut: alt → am ältesten, groß → am größten, jung → am jüngsten, kurz → am kürzesten. Irregular forms: gut → am besten, viel → am meisten, gern → am liebsten, hoch → am höchsten, nah → am nächsten. Note: groß → am größten (no extra -e- added despite -ß because pronunciation flows naturally).

EXAMPLES

- Der Hamster ist am kleinsten. (The hamster is the smallest.)
- Der Elefant ist am größten von allen. (The elephant is the biggest of all.)
- Der Elefant ist das größte Tier der Welt. (The elephant is the biggest animal in the world.)
- Dies ist das interessanteste Buch, das ich je gelesen habe. (This is the most interesting book I've ever read.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may forget adjective declension when using superlative attributively. WRONG: 'das größte Tier' in dative. CORRECT: 'mit dem größten Tier' (dative requires -en ending). Confusion between predicative and attributive forms: WRONG: 'Das am größte Tier'. CORRECT: Either 'Das Tier ist am größten' (predicative) OR 'das größte Tier' (attributive without 'am'). Using 'am' before nouns: WRONG: 'das am größten Tier'. CORRECT: 'das größte Tier'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular superlatives: gut → am besten (NOT am gutesten), viel → am meisten (NOT am vielsten), gern → am liebsten, hoch → am höchsten (drops -c-), nah → am nächsten. The word 'groß' becomes 'am größten' without adding -e- before -sten (despite ending in -ß) because the pronunciation is natural. Adjectives ending in -el or -er: dunkel → am dunkelsten, teuer → am teuersten (maintain the pattern from comparative).

Superlatives with 'am + -sten'

■ Web verified

For standalone superlatives (not before a noun), use 'am' + adjective stem + '-sten' ending. This form is used predicatively (after sein, bleiben, werden) or adverbially (modifying verbs). For example: 'Der ICE ist

am teuersten' (The ICE is the most expensive). Monosyllabic adjectives with a, o, u add umlaut: groß→am größten, lang→am längsten.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: am + adjective stem + -sten. Add -esten when stem ends in -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -x, or -z for easier pronunciation (am heißesten, am weitesten). Monosyllabic adjectives with a, o, u typically add umlaut: alt→am ältesten, groß→am größten, lang→am längsten, jung→am jüngsten, kurz→am kürzesten, warm→am wärmsten, kalt→am kältesten, stark→am stärksten.

Complete Superlative Forms Table:

Positive | Comparative | Superlative (am + -sten)

teuer (expensive) | teurer | am teuersten

lang (long) | länger | am längsten

groß (big) | größer | am größten

alt (old) | älter | am ältesten

gut (good) | besser | am besten

viel (much) | mehr | am meisten

gern (gladly) | lieber | am liebsten

hoch (high) | höher | am höchsten

nah (near) | näher | am nächsten

wenig (little) | weniger/minder | am wenigsten/mindesten

EXAMPLES

→ *Der ICE ist am teuersten. (The ICE is the most expensive.)*

→ *Der Regionalzug braucht am längsten. (The regional train takes the longest.)*

→ *Tom verdient am wenigsten. (Tom earns the least.)*

→ *Er läuft am schnellsten. (He runs the fastest.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may try to use definite article + adjective structure (like Italian 'il più' + adjective) instead of 'am' + adjective + -sten. They might say 'der teuerste' when the predicative form 'am teuersten' is required. Confusion arises because Italian uses 'il più' + adjective for superlatives in all positions. Italian learners forget the umlaut in common adjectives (groß, lang, alt) because Romance languages don't have this vowel mutation. They may also forget to add the -e- infix before -sten when adjectives end in -d, -t, -s, -ß.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular superlatives: gut→am besten (not 'am gutesten'), viel→am meisten (not 'am vielsten'), gern→am liebsten (not 'am gernsten'). The adjective 'nah' has irregular superlative: am nächsten (not 'am nahsten'). Some adjectives cannot be compared (absolute adjectives): tot (dead), schwanger (pregnant), ledig (single), dreieckig (triangular).

Umlaut in comparative and superlative forms

■ Web verified

Many common one-syllable adjectives with stem vowels a, o, u add an umlaut (ä, ö, ü) in comparative and superlative forms. This applies to most monosyllabic adjectives but not all - there are exceptions that must be memorized. The umlaut appears in both comparative (-er) and superlative (-st/-est) forms.

COMPLETE RULE

COMMON ADJECTIVES WITH UMLAUT:

a → ä:

alt → *älter* → *am ältesten* (old)

lang → *länger* → *am längsten* (long)

kalt → *kälter* → *am kältesten* (cold)

warm → *wärmer* → *am wärmsten* (warm)

stark → *stärker* → *am stärksten* (strong)

o → ö:

groß → *größer* → *am größten* (big)

u → ü:

jung → *jünger* → *am jüngsten* (young)

kurz → *kürzer* → *am kürzesten* (short)

NO UMLAUT (exceptions):

bunt → *bunter* → *am buntesten* (colorful)

froh → *froher* → *am frohsten* (happy)

voll → *voller* → *am vollsten* (full)

flach → *flacher* → *am flachsten* (flat)

EXAMPLES

→ *Im Winter ist es kälter als im Herbst.* (In winter it is colder than in autumn.)

→ *Der älteste Baum im Park ist 300 Jahre alt.* (The oldest tree in the park is 300 years old.)

→ *Mein jüngerer Bruder ist größer als ich.* (My younger brother is taller than I.)

→ *Das ist die kürzeste Route zum Bahnhof.* (That is the shortest route to the train station.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may:

1. Forget to add umlauts entirely (Italian has no umlaut system)
2. Apply umlauts inconsistently or to adjectives that don't take them
3. Pronounce umlauted vowels incorrectly (ä, ö, ü don't exist in Italian)

4. Add umlaut to multi-syllable adjectives (umlaut mainly for monosyllabic adjectives)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Not all monosyllabic adjectives take umlaut - must be memorized. Common non-umlaut adjectives: froh, voll, rund, bunt, flach, klar, rasch, stolz, falsch. Irregular: nah→näher (umlaut) but hoch→höher (vowel change, not umlaut). Multi-syllable adjectives generally don't take umlaut.

Verbi irregolari con cambio vocalico (a → ä) - Irregular Verbs with Vowel Change a to ä

■ Web verified

Strong verbs (starke Verben) with the stem vowel 'a' change to 'ä' in the second person singular (du) and third person singular (er/sie/es) forms in the present tense only. All other forms remain regular. This vowel change is called Ablaut. Verbs with this pattern typically also have irregular past tense forms. The endings remain the same as regular verbs.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE CONJUGATION PATTERN (a → ä):

SCHLAFEN (to sleep):

ich schlafe (I sleep)

du schläfst (you sleep)

er/sie/es schläft (he/she/it sleeps)

wir schlafen (we sleep)

ihr schlaft (you all sleep)

sie/Sie schlafen (they/you formal sleep)

FAHREN (to drive/go):

ich fahre

du fährst

er/sie/es fährt

wir fahren

ihr fahrt

sie/Sie fahren

TRAGEN (to carry/wear):

ich trage

du trägst

er/sie/es trägt

wir tragen

ihr tragt

sie/Sie tragen

COMPLETE LIST OF COMMON a → ä VERBS:

- schlafen (to sleep): du schläfst, er schläft
- fahren (to drive): du fährst, er fährt
- tragen (to carry/wear): du trägst, er trägt
- laufen (to run): du läufst, er läuft
- fallen (to fall): du fällst, er fällt
- fangen (to catch): du fängst, er fängt
- halten (to hold/stop): du hältst, er hält
- lassen (to let): du lässt, er lässt
- waschen (to wash): du wäschst, er wäscht
- wachsen (to grow): du wächst, er wächst
- backen (to bake): du bäckst, er bäckt
- braten (to fry): du brätst, er brät
- raten (to guess/advise): du rätst, er rät
- laden (to load): du lädst, er lädt
- schlagen (to hit): du schlägst, er schlägt
- graben (to dig): du gräbst, er gräbt

SPECIAL CASE - LAUFEN (au → äu):

ich laufe

du läufst

er/sie/es läuft

wir laufen

ihr lauft

sie/Sie laufen

RULE: The vowel change *ONLY* occurs in *du* and *er/sie/es* forms in *PRESENT TENSE*. Past tenses use different patterns.

EXAMPLES

→ *Mein Bruder schläft jeden Tag bis 10 Uhr. (My brother sleeps until 10 o'clock every day.)* - Daily routine with *er/sie/es* form

→ *Fährst du mit dem Auto oder mit dem Zug? (Are you going by car or by train?)* - Question with *du* form showing transportation context

→ ***Sie trägt heute ein schönes Kleid zur Party. (She is wearing a beautiful dress to the party today.)***

*Fashion/clothing context with *sie* form*

→ *Ich laufe gern im Park, aber er läuft lieber am Strand. (I like to run in the park, but he prefers to run at the beach.)*

Contrast showing *ich* (no change) vs *er* (with change)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. FORGETTING THE VOWEL CHANGE:

■ Du fahrst nach Berlin (missing umlaut)

■ ■ Du fährst nach Berlin

(Italian verbs don't have vowel changes in conjugation, so speakers forget the ä)

2. ADDING UMLAUT TO ALL FORMS:

■ Wir fähren, Ihr fährt

■ ■ Wir fahren, Ihr fahrt

(Only *du* and *er/sie/es* change, not *wir/ihr/sie*)

3. APPLYING CHANGE TO WRONG PERSONS:

■ Ich schläfe gut

■ ■ Ich schlafe gut

(*ich* form never changes)

4. MIXING UP WITH REGULAR VERBS:

■ Er kauft → Er kauft (kaufen is regular, no change needed)

■ ■ Er kauft

(Not all verbs with 'a' change; only strong verbs)

5. WRONG CONSONANT DOUBLING:

■ Du schläffst (double f is wrong)

■ ■ Du schläfst

(Only one f, but add st ending)

6. ASSUMING ITALIAN-LIKE REGULARITY:

Italian: *io dormo, tu dormi, lui dorme* (regular pattern)

German: *ich schlafe, du schläfst, er schläft* (vowel changes)

(Italian speakers expect consistent stems)

7. CONFUSING WITH PAST TENSE:

■ Er fährt gestern (trying to use present for past)

■ ■ Er fuhr gestern OR Er ist gefahren

(Present *a→ä* change is different from past vowel changes)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

IMPORTANT EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. BACKEN (to bake): Can be regular OR irregular

- du backst OR du bäckst (both acceptable)
- er backt OR er bäckt

Modern German tends toward regular form

2. VERBS WITH SEPARABLE PREFIXES: Still change vowel

- einladen (to invite): du lädst ein, er lädt ein
- abfahren (to depart): du fährst ab, er fährt ab
- anfangen (to begin): du fängst an, er fängt an

3. VERBS WITH INSEPARABLE PREFIXES: Still change vowel

- beraten (to advise): du berätst, er berät
- erfahren (to experience): du erfährst, er erfährt

4. VERBS THAT LOOK SIMILAR BUT ARE REGULAR:

- machen (to make): du machst, er macht (NO umlaut)
- sagen (to say): du sagst, er sagt (NO umlaut)
- fragen (to ask): du fragst, er fragt (NO umlaut)

5. PAST TENSE CHANGES ARE DIFFERENT:

- Present: ich fahre, du fährst, er fährt
- Past: ich fuhr, du fuhrst, er fuhr (no umlaut in past)
- Perfect: ich bin gefahren

6. SOME a→ä VERBS BECOME VERY IRREGULAR:

- halten → du hältst (consonant change + umlaut)
- laden → du lädst (consonant simplification)

7. IMPERATIVE FORMS: Usually NO umlaut

- Fahr langsam! (Drive slowly!) - not 'Fähr'
- Schlaf gut! (Sleep well!) - not 'Schläf'

Exception: some regional variations may use umlaut

Verbi irregolari con cambio vocalico a → ä (Stem-Changing Verbs a → ä)

■ Web verified

Strong verbs with the stem vowel 'a' undergo a vowel change to 'ä' in the present tense second person singular (du) and third person singular (er/sie/es) forms only. All other persons (ich, wir, ihr, sie/Sie) maintain the regular 'a' vowel. The verb endings remain completely regular; only the internal stem vowel changes. This vowel shift is a characteristic feature of strong verbs in German and must be memorized for each verb.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE CONJUGATION TABLES:

SCHLAFEN (to sleep):

ich schlafe (I sleep)

du schläfst (you sleep - informal)

er/sie/es schläft (he/she/it sleeps)

wir schlafen (we sleep)

ihr schlaft (you sleep - plural)

sie/Sie schlafen (they/you sleep - formal)

FAHREN (to drive, to go):

ich fahre

du fährst

er/sie/es fährt

wir fahren

ihr fahrt

sie/Sie fahren

LAUFEN (to run, to walk):

ich laufe

du läufst

er/sie/es läuft

wir laufen

ihr lauft

sie/Sie laufen

TRAGEN (to wear, to carry):

ich trage

du trägst

er/sie/es trägt

wir tragen

ihr tragt

sie/Sie tragen

HALTEN (to hold, to stop):

ich halte

du hältst

er/sie/es hält

wir halten

ihr haltet

sie/Sie halten

FALLEN (to fall):

ich falle

du fällst

er/sie/es fällt

wir fallen

ihr fallt

sie/Sie fallen

FANGEN (to catch):

ich fange

du fängst

er/sie/es fängt

wir fangen

ihr fangt

sie/Sie fangen

WASCHEN (to wash):

ich wasche

du wäschst

er/sie/es wäscht

wir waschen

ihr wascht

sie/Sie waschen

SCHLAGEN (to hit, to beat):

ich schlage

du schlägst

er/sie/es schlägt

wir schlagen

ihr schlagt

sie/Sie schlagen

COMPLETE LIST OF COMMON a→ä VERBS:

*backen (to bake) → er bäckt/backt**

blasen (to blow) → er bläst

braten (to roast) → er brät

fahren (to drive) → er fährt

fallen (to fall) → er fällt

fangen (to catch) → er fängt

halten (to hold) → er hält

laden (to load) → er lädt

lassen (to let) → er lässt
laufen (to run) → er läuft
raten (to guess/advise) → er rät
schlafen (to sleep) → er schläft
schlagen (to hit) → er schlägt
tragen (to carry) → er trägt
wachsen (to grow) → er wächst
waschen (to wash) → er wäscht

VERBS WITH au→äu CHANGE:

laufen (to run) → du läufst, er läuft
saufen (to drink/booze) → du säufst, er säuft

*Note: backen can be conjugated with or without vowel change

EXAMPLES

- *Mein Bruder schläft jeden Tag bis 10 Uhr. (My brother sleeps until 10 o'clock every day.) - Third person singular with vowel change.*
- *Fährst du morgen mit dem Auto zur Arbeit? (Are you driving to work by car tomorrow?) - Question form, second person singular with vowel change and question inversion.*
- *Die Kinder laufen schnell zum Spielplatz. (The children run quickly to the playground.) - Third person plural, no vowel change, remains 'laufen'.*
- *Ich trage heute einen warmen Mantel, weil es kalt ist. (I'm wearing a warm coat today because it's cold.) - First person singular, no vowel change, remains 'trage'.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

- 1. APPLYING VOWEL CHANGE TO ALL PERSONS: Italian speakers accustomed to regular patterns may incorrectly change all forms. Wrong: 'Ich schlafe jeden Tag.' Correct: 'Ich **schlafe** jeden Tag.' (First person keeps 'a'). Wrong: 'Wir fahren nach Berlin.' Correct: 'Wir **fahren** nach Berlin.'
- 2. FORGETTING VOWEL CHANGE IN DU/ER FORMS: Italian doesn't have internal vowel changes in present tense, so learners forget this. Wrong: 'Du schlafs bis 10 Uhr.' Correct: 'Du **schläfst** bis 10 Uhr.' Wrong: 'Er tragt einen Rucksack.' Correct: 'Er **trägt** einen Rucksack.'
- 3. INCORRECT UMLAUT PLACEMENT: Wrong: 'Du fahrst' (missing umlaut). Correct: 'Du **fährst**.'
- 4. MIXING UP SIMILAR VERBS: Italian speakers confuse stem-changing with regular verbs. Wrong: 'Er sagt zu Hause' (using sagen instead of staying). Correct for 'to say': 'Er **sagt**' (no change, regular verb).

5. PRONUNCIATION ERRORS: Italian speakers may not distinguish 'a' from 'ä' sound. 'fahren' (faa-ren, like 'far') vs 'fährt' (fair-t, like 'fair'). The 'ä' is pronounced like the 'e' in English 'bed' or Italian 'è'.

- 6. IMPERATIVE CONFUSION: Wrong: 'Schläft gut!' Correct: 'Schlaf gut!' (du-form imperative drops ending and usually drops umlaut). But: 'Schlaft gut!' (ihr-form keeps regular form).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

- 1. BACKEN SPECIAL CASE:** The verb 'backen' (to bake) is in transition. Both forms are currently correct: 'du backst/bäckst' and 'er backt/bäckt'. The form without umlaut (backt) is becoming more common in modern German, though the traditional form with umlaut is still correct.
- 2. VERBS WITH SEPARABLE PREFIXES:** If a stem-changing verb has a separable prefix, it still undergoes the vowel change: 'einladen' (to invite) → 'du lädst ein', 'er lädt ein'. The vowel change applies to the base verb regardless of prefixes.
- 3. VERBS WITH INSEPARABLE PREFIXES:** The vowel change still occurs: 'beraten' (to advise, from raten) → 'du berätst', 'er berät'. 'erfahren' (to experience, from fahren) → 'du erfährst', 'er erfährt'.
- 4. PAST TENSE IRREGULARITY:** Verbs with vowel changes in present tense are typically strong verbs, meaning they're also irregular in past tenses. 'schlafen' → 'schief' (past) → 'geschlafen' (past participle). This is NOT a → ä in past, but different vowels: 'fahren' → 'fuhr' → 'gefahren'.
- 5. NO CHANGE IN PAST TENSES:** The a → ä change ONLY occurs in present tense. Past simple: 'ich schlief' (NOT 'schläfte'), 'er fuhr' (NOT 'fährete').
- 6. COMPOUND VERBS:** Some compound verbs maintain the change: 'anfangen' (to begin) → 'du fängst an', 'er fängt an'.
- 7. IMPERATIVE FORMS:** The du-form imperative typically loses both the umlaut and ending: 'Schlaf!' (Sleep!), 'Fahr!' (Drive!), 'Lauf!' (Run!). But ihr-form keeps normal conjugation: 'Schlaft!', 'Fahrt!', 'Lauft!'.

Präposition mit + Dativ

■ From lesson

The preposition 'mit' (with) always takes dative case

COMPLETE RULE

mit + Dativ (with + dative case)

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich fahre mit dem Bus.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using accusative instead of dative after 'mit'

Ortsangaben (Place expressions with prepositions)

■ From lesson

Prepositions for locations in German. 'bei', '(bis) zu', 'links/rechts/gegenüber von' use dative. The prepositions 'zu' and 'bei' combine with the definite article: zu+dem=zum, zu+der=zur, bei+dem=beim, von+dem=vom.

COMPLETE RULE

bei, (bis) zu, links/rechts/gegenüber von use Dativ. Prepositions zu and bei combine with articles: zu+dem=zum, zu+der=zur, bei+dem=beim, von+dem=vom. | entlang + Akkusativ stands after the noun. | rein/raus, rein/raus are short forms of hinein/herein and hinaus/heraus used mainly in spoken German. rein/hinein/herein can combine with preposition in + Akkusativ and raus/hinaus/heraus can combine with preposition aus + Dativ. | heraus/herein/herauf/herunter → her- means: from a place to the speaker. | hinaus/hinein/hinauf/hinunter → hin- means: away from the speaker to a place.

EXAMPLES

→ *Jörg soll bis zum Ring/bis zur Dumbastraße gehen.*

→ *Jörg soll die Kärntner Straße entlang gehen.*

→ *Jörg geht in das Wien Museum rein/hinein.*

→ Jörg geht aus dem Wien Museum raus/heraus.

→ Komm heraus!

→ Jörg geht aus dem Museum hinaus.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing hin- and her- prefixes, or forgetting case requirements with prepositions.

Fragewort wo(r)...? mit was + Präposition

■ From lesson

Questions with 'was' (what) + preposition become 'wo(r) + preposition' compound question words. Use 'wor-' before vowels, 'wo-' before consonants.

COMPLETE RULE

was + preposition → wo(r) + preposition. Format: wo(r) + für/mit/von/an/auf etc.

EXAMPLES

→ Für was? → Wofür dankt Frau Egger Bernd? → Sie dankt Bernd für die Bewerbung.

→ Worin möchte Bernd Erfahrungen sammeln? → Er möchte Erfahrungen im ökologischen Landbau sammeln.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using 'für was' instead of 'wofür' in formal/written German

Präpositionalpronomen da(r)...

■ From lesson

The prepositional pronoun 'da(r) + preposition' refers back to a thing or idea mentioned before. Use 'dar-' before vowels, 'da-' before consonants. For persons, use preposition + personal pronoun (e.g., auf wen, mit wem).

COMPLETE RULE

da(r) + preposition refers to things/ideas. Format: da(r) + für/mit/von/an/auf/in etc. Can refer forward (Vorwärtsverweis) or backward (Rückverweis).

EXAMPLES

→ Bernd hat ein kleines Zimmer. Darin stehen wenig Möbel. (= In dem Zimmer stehen wenig M.)

- *Bernd arbeitet bei Frau Egger. Er freut sich darüber. (= darüber, dass er bei Frau E. arbeitet.)*
- *Vorwärtsverweis: Frau Egger kann sich darauf verlassen, dass Bernd drei Monate bleibt.*
- *Rückverweis: Bernd bleibt drei Monate. Darauf kann sich Frau Egger verlassen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using prepositional pronouns for people instead of preposition + personal pronoun

Relativpronomen was / wo(r)-

■ From lesson

The relative pronoun 'was' or 'wo(r)-' can refer to a whole sentence or to pronouns like 'das, nichts, alles, etwas, einiges, vieles'. When combined with a preposition, use 'wo(r)-' + preposition (e.g., wofür, worauf, worüber) instead of 'was' + preposition.

COMPLETE RULE

Use 'was' when no preposition is needed. Use 'wo(r)-' + preposition when a preposition is required (wofür, worauf, worüber). Examples: 'Ich studiere in Berlin, und es gibt vieles, was super funktioniert.' 'Es gibt politisch nichts mehr, was mich wirklich beeindruckt.' With preposition: 'Man kann damit auf etwas aufmerksam machen, womit man nicht einverstanden ist.' 'Das ist etwas, worauf wir vom Asta aufmerksam machen wollten.'

EXAMPLES

- *Ich studiere in Berlin, und es gibt vieles, was super funktioniert.*
- *Es gibt politisch nichts mehr, was mich wirklich beeindruckt.*
- *Man kann damit auf etwas aufmerksam machen, womit man nicht einverstanden ist. (= einverstanden sein mit)*
- *Das ist etwas, worauf wir vom Asta aufmerksam machen wollten. (= aufmerksam machen auf)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using 'was' with prepositions instead of 'wo(r)-' forms

Wechselpräpositionen: an, auf, in, über, unter, hinter, vor, neben, zwischen

■ From lesson

Two-way prepositions that take either Accusative (for movement/direction) or Dative (for location)

COMPLETE RULE

Wohin? (direction) → mit Akkusativ (an das→ans, auf das→aufs, in das→ins; colloquially also: hinters, übers, unters, vors). Example: Stell den Kaffee ins Regal! Wo? (location) → mit Dativ (an dem→am, in dem→im; colloquially also: auf'm, hinter'm, über'm, unter'm, vorm). Example: Der Kaffee steht im Regal.

EXAMPLES

→ Wohin? Stell den Kaffee ins Regal! (Akkusativ - movement)

→ Wo? Der Kaffee steht im Regal. (Dativ - location)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing Wohin (Akkusativ) with Wo (Dativ). Remember: movement = Akkusativ, location = Dativ

Außer with Dativ

■ Web verified

The preposition 'außer' (except, besides) always takes the Dativ case. Example: 'keine anderen Götter außer mir' (no other gods except me) - 'mir' is Dativ.

COMPLETE RULE

Außer is a Dativ preposition and the noun or pronoun following it must be in Dativ case. The 9 main dative prepositions are: aus, außer, bei, mit, nach, seit, von, zu, gegenüber. Dative case articles: masculine/neuter: dem/einem, feminine: der/einer, plural: den + -n on noun. Dative pronouns: mir, dir, ihm, ihr, uns, euch, ihnen/Ihnen. Außer means 'except (for)' or 'besides' and indicates an exception. Structure: noun/pronoun + außer + DATIVE noun/pronoun, OR außer + DATIVE + verb.

EXAMPLES

→ Du sollst keine anderen Götter haben außer mir. (You shall have no other gods beside me)

→ Außer dir kommt niemand. (Nobody is coming except you)

→ Alle außer ihm gab mir ein Geschenk. (Everyone but he gave me a present)

→ Außer diesem Schmuckstück habe ich nicht viel von ihr. (Apart from this jewelry, I don't have much from her)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use the wrong case after außer, using nominative or accusative instead of dative. Italian 'eccetto' or 'tranne' don't require case changes, so this is a new concept. Common error: 'außer ich' (WRONG) instead of 'außer mir' (CORRECT). Italian speakers may also confuse außer (except) with außerhalb (outside of) which is genitive in formal German but increasingly dative in colloquial speech.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In the fixed expression 'außer Landes' (out of the country), the genitive case is used instead of dative. This is a fossilized expression. In all other modern usage, außer takes dative. Note: außer can also take genitive in very formal, archaic, or legal language, but this is considered outdated and dative is standard in contemporary German.

bei (preposition: location/time)

■ Web verified

'Bei' is a dative preposition with multiple meanings: 'at' (location/someone's place), 'at/with' (professional's location), 'during/while' (activity), 'with' (company/institution), 'near', 'in case of'. Always requires dative case. Can express spatial location, temporal simultaneity, or figurative association.

COMPLETE RULE

ALWAYS DATIVE CASE (*bei + dem = beim*)

MAIN USES:

1. AT SOMEONE'S HOME/PLACE:

- 'Ich bin bei meiner Mutter' (I'm at my mother's place)
- 'bei Hans' (at Hans's place)

2. AT PROFESSIONAL'S LOCATION:

- 'beim Arzt' (at the doctor's)
- 'beim Frisör' (at the hairdresser's)
- 'beim Bäcker' (at the baker's)

3. AT WORK/COMPANY/INSTITUTION:

- 'bei der Arbeit' (at work)
- 'bei Siemens arbeiten' (to work at Siemens)

4. NEAR/AT (location):

- 'bei der Ampel' (at the traffic light)
- 'bei München' (near Munich)

5. DURING/AT TIME OF EVENT:

- 'bei der Meisterschaft' (at/during the championship)
- 'bei Sonnenuntergang' (at sunset)

6. WITH NOMINALIZED VERB (activity):

- 'beim Kochen' (while cooking)
- 'beim Sprechen' (while speaking)

DATIVE FORMS:

der → dem (beim)

die → der

das → dem (beim)

die (pl) → den

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich bin bei meiner Mutter. (I'm at my mother's place.)*

→ *Bei der Ampel gehen Sie rechts. (At the traffic light, go right.)*

→ *Brasilien hat bei der Fußball-Weltmeisterschaft verloren. (Brazil lost at the soccer world championship.)*

→ *Beim Kochen höre ich Musik. (While cooking, I listen to music.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' MISTAKES:

■ 1. Using wrong case (accusative/nominative instead of dative): ■ 'bei der Mutter' (but fem. = correct), ■ 'bei der Arzt' → ■ 'bei dem Arzt/beim Arzt'

2. Confusing 'bei' (at/near) with 'zu' (to/toward): Italian 'da' confusion

- bei = location AT: 'Ich bin bei der Arbeit' (I'm at work)

- zu = movement TO: 'Ich gehe zur Arbeit' (I go to work)

3. Confusing 'bei' with 'mit' (with): ■ 'Ich wohne bei meinem Bruder' (at his place) vs 'Ich wohne mit meinem Bruder' (with him as roommate)

■ 4. Wrong article contractions: ■ 'bei das' → ■ 'beim' (bei dem)

■ 5. Using 'bei' for 'in' with buildings: ■ 'bei der Schule' → ■ 'in der Schule' (inside), BUT 'bei der Schule arbeiten' (at/for the institution) ✓

6. Temperature/numbers: forgetting dative: 'bei 30 Grad' (at 30 degrees)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

INSTITUTION vs BUILDING: 'bei' refers to the INSTITUTION or WORK relationship, not physical location inside:

- 'bei der Schule arbeiten' (work at/for the school as institution)

- 'in der Schule sein' (be inside the school building)

NO MOVEMENT: 'bei' indicates static location, never movement. For movement, use 'zu':

- 'Ich bin beim Arzt' (I'm at the doctor's - location)

- 'Ich gehe zum Arzt' (I'm going to the doctor's - movement)

WITH vs AT: Distinguish 'bei' (at someone's place) from 'mit' (together with):

- 'bei meinem Freund wohnen' (live at friend's apartment)

- 'mit meinem Freund wohnen' (live together as roommates)

Compass Directions with Articles

■ Web verified

German compass directions (Himmelsrichtungen) are masculine nouns that always take the definite article 'der': der Norden (the north), der Süden (the south), der Westen (the west), der Osten (the east). When used with prepositions like 'in' or 'im', they decline according to case. These nouns are used to indicate cardinal directions, geographic regions, or areas within a country. Adjectives modifying compass directions must be declined according to the case and article (e.g., 'im mittleren Westen' - in the midwest, where 'mittleren' is dative masculine weak declension).

COMPLETE RULE

All compass directions are masculine: der Norden, der Süden, der Westen, der Osten. Dative case (with 'in' + dem = im): im Norden, im Süden, im Westen, im Osten. Genitive case: des Nordens, des Südens, des Westens, des Ostens. Accusative case (motion toward): in den Norden, in den Süden, in den Westen, in den Osten. Adjective declension: When an adjective modifies the direction, it follows weak declension after the definite article. Dative: im mittleren Westen (in the midwest), im fernen Osten (in the far east). Nominative: der mittlere Westen (the midwest). Usage without article: When indicating direction rather than region, articles may be omitted (e.g., 'nach Norden' - toward north). Regional usage: These nouns also describe geographic regions (e.g., 'der Norden Deutschlands' - the north of Germany, 'im Süden wohnen' - to live in the south).

EXAMPLES

→ *Im Osten ist die Arbeit. (In the east is the work. - dative, location)*

→ *Im mittleren Westen leben viele Deutsche. (In the midwest live many Germans. - adjective declension)*

→ *Der Norden Deutschlands ist kälter als der Süden. (The north of Germany is colder than the south. - nominative)*

→ *Wir fahren in den Süden. (We are traveling to the south. accusative, motion)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may forget to use the article with compass directions, as Italian directions (nord, sud, est, ovest) are often used without articles. They might say 'in Norden' instead of 'im Norden'. Another mistake is using the wrong gender, as Italian directions don't have gender (they're invariable). Italian speakers may forget to decline adjectives properly when they modify directions (e.g., saying 'im mittlere Westen' instead of 'im mittleren Westen'). They might also confuse preposition usage: 'nach Norden' (toward north, motion) vs. 'im Norden' (in the north, location). Italian speakers may incorrectly capitalize 'norden' etc. when used as adverbs of direction (lowercase) vs. as regions (capitalized nouns).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When used as pure directional indicators (not regions), compass directions may be used without articles or in lowercase as adverbs: 'nach Norden fahren' (to drive northward), 'nördlich von München' (north of Munich - lowercase adjective/adverb). In weather contexts, directions are masculine: 'der

Südwind' (south wind). In compound nouns, the gender follows the last element: 'die Nordseite' (the north side - feminine because 'Seite' is feminine). When abbreviated (N, S, O/E, W), no articles are used. Fixed expressions may vary: 'gen Norden' (toward north - archaic/literary).

Da-compounds with prepositions (darauf, davon, daran)

■ Web verified

When referring back to things (not people) with prepositions, German uses da- + preposition. If the preposition starts with a vowel, use dar- + preposition (darauf, daran, darüber). This replaces constructions like 'on it', 'from it', 'to it'. Da-compounds are gender and case neutral.

COMPLETE RULE

FORMATION RULES:

1. Preposition starts with consonant: da + preposition

- damit (with it), dafür (for it), davon (from it), danach (after it)

2. Preposition starts with vowel: dar + preposition

- darauf (on it), darüber (about it/over it), daran (at it/on it), darum (around it/about it), daraus (out of it)

USAGE:

1. REFERRING BACK: Replace 'preposition + es/das/die'

Das Buch → Ich denke daran (not: an das)

2. ANTICIPATORY: Before clauses (dass/zu)

Ich freue mich darauf, dass du kommst.

3. GENDER/CASE NEUTRAL: Same form regardless of original noun gender or case

der Tisch (masc), die Party (fem), das Interview (neut) → ALL become darauf

CANNOT form da-compounds with: außer, ohne, seit, gegenüber, genitive prepositions

FOR PEOPLE: Use preposition + pronoun instead

- auf ihn/sie (not: darauf for person)

- mit ihm/ihr (not: damit for person)

EXAMPLES

→ **Hast du an das Treffen gedacht?**

Ja, ich habe daran gedacht. (Did you think about the meeting? - Yes, I thought about it.)

→ **Worauf freust du dich?** - Ich freue mich darauf. (What are you looking forward to? - I'm looking forward to it.)

→ **Er träumt davon, Pilot zu werden.** (He dreams of becoming a pilot.)

→ **Ich warte darauf, dass die Sonne scheint.** (I'm waiting for the sun to shine.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers typically make these errors:

- 1. USING FOR PEOPLE: Italian doesn't distinguish, so speakers use da-compounds for people (*darauf for 'auf ihn'). CORRECT: Use preposition + pronoun for people.
- 2. FORGETTING DA-COMPOUND BEFORE CLAUSES: Italian uses direct construction, German requires anticipatory da-compound (*Ich freue mich, dich zu sehen instead of darauf, dich zu sehen)
- 3. WRONG FORM: Using 'da' before vowel prepositions (*daauf instead of darauf, *daüber instead of darüber)

4. TRYING TO DECLINE THEM: Da-compounds never change form - they are invariable regardless of case or gender that would apply to the original noun

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

- 1. Some da-compounds have developed independent meanings: damit = 'so that' (conjunction), daher = 'therefore', dabei = 'and yet'
- 2. In spoken German, da-compounds are often split: 'Ich freue mich da drauf' (instead of darauf) with extra 'd' for vowel-initial prepositions (drauf, dran, drüber)
- 3. Cannot replace relative pronouns: 'das Buch, auf das ich warte' (not: das Buch, darauf ich warte)
- 4. Animals can be treated as things (darauf) or persons (auf ihn) depending on context and perceived personality

Dative Case - Prepositions

■ From lesson

Certain prepositions always require dative case: aus, bei, mit, nach, seit, von, zu

COMPLETE RULE

Dative prepositions: aus (from/out of), bei (at/near), mit (with), nach (after/to), seit (since), von (from), zu (to). Articles change: der→dem, die→der, das→dem, plural→den (+n on noun)

EXAMPLES

- Ich fahre mit dem Bus (m)
- Ich komme aus der Schweiz (f)
- Ich bin bei meiner Mutter
- von Montag bis Freitag
- seit dem zehnten April

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using accusative instead of dative with these prepositions

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

bis typically takes accusative but often appears with von+dative: von...bis

Dative case with prepositions (Dativ mit Präpositionen)

■ From lesson

Certain prepositions always require the dative case: mit, aus, von, zu, seit, nach, bei

COMPLETE RULE

Dative prepositions: mit, aus, von, (bis) zu, seit, nach, bei. Articles change: der→dem, die→der, das→dem, die(pl)→den

EXAMPLES

→ mit dem Bus, mit der U-Bahn, mit dem Auto - with/by bus, subway, car

→ **Ich komme aus der Schweiz**

I come from Switzerland

→ von Montag bis Freitag - from Monday to Friday

→ seit dem zehnten April - since April 10th

→ nach dem Abendessen - after dinner

→ bei dem (beim) Zahnarzt - at the dentist

→ **Ich esse bei meiner Mutter**

I eat at my mother's

Dative plural ending -n (mit den Händen, von den Leuten, mit allen Dingen)

■ Web verified

In the dative plural, German nouns add -n to their plural form unless the plural already ends in -n or -s. This applies after all dative prepositions (mit, von, zu, bei, nach, aus, seit) and with plural dative articles (den). The rule helps German speakers clearly identify the dative case.

COMPLETE RULE

Dative Plural -n Rule:

ADD -n if plural does NOT end in -n or -s:

- die Freunde → den Freunden (mit den Freunden)

- die Kinder → den Kindern (von den Kindern)

- die Männer → den Männern (bei den Männern)

- die Hände → den Händen (mit den Händen)

NO CHANGE if plural already ends in -n or -s:

- die Frauen → den Frauen (mit den Frauen) - already ends in -n

- die Autos → den Autos (mit den Autos) - already ends in -s

This applies to ALL plural nouns in dative case, regardless of gender in singular.

EXAMPLES

→ Ich möchte mit den Händen arbeiten. (I want to work with my hands.)

→ Einige von den Leuten sind zu spät gekommen. (Some of the people came too late.)

→ Ich habe einen Koffer mit allen Dingen, die ich brauche. (I have a suitcase with all things that I need.)

→ Wir danken den Männern für ihre Hilfe. (We thank the men for their help.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers frequently omit the dative plural -n ending because Italian plural forms do not change in different cases (Italian has no case system). They might say 'mit den Kinder' instead of 'mit den Kindern' or 'von den Leute' instead of 'von den Leuten'. This error is particularly common since Italian uses invariable plural forms like 'le mani' (the hands) regardless of grammatical function. Italian speakers may also add -n to plurals already ending in -n or -s, overgeneralizing the rule. Since dative case does not exist in Italian, recognizing when to apply this rule requires conscious attention.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

DO NOT add -n when plural already ends in -n: die Frauen → den Frauen (not 'den Frauenn'). DO NOT add -n when plural ends in -s: die Autos → den Autos, die Hotels → den Hotels. Foreign loanwords ending in -s keep -s in dative plural. Nouns with irregular plurals follow the same rule: add -n unless already present.

Dative with preposition 'in' (location)

■ Web verified

When 'in' indicates location (Wo? where?) without movement toward a destination, it takes dative case. When indicating movement toward (Wohin? where to?), it takes accusative. This is part of the two-way prepositions (Wechselpräpositionen).

COMPLETE RULE

TWO-WAY PREPOSITIONS (Wechselpräpositionen): an, auf, hinter, in, neben, über, unter, vor, zwischen

DATIVE (Location - Wo?):

Masculine: in dem/im (contracted)

Feminine: in der

Neuter: in dem/im (contracted)

Plural: in den

ACCUSATIVE (Direction - Wohin?):

Masculine: in den

Feminine: in die

Neuter: in das/ins (contracted)

Plural: in die

QUESTION TEST:

Wo? (Where? - static) → Dative

Wohin? (Where to? - movement) → Accusative

EXAMPLES

→ *In der Tasche war der Pass. (The passport was in the bag. - location, dative)*

→ *Sie wohnen in einer WG. (They live in a shared apartment. - location, dative)*

→ *In seinem Zimmer ist ein Bett. (In his room is a bed. - location, dative)*

→ ***Er geht in die Schule. (He goes to school.***

direction, accusative)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. Not distinguishing between location and direction (Italian 'in' doesn't change articles this way)
2. Using accusative for both location and direction (confusion from Italian 'nel, nella' patterns)
3. Forgetting article changes: *die* → *der* (fem. dat.), *das* → *dem* (neut. dat.)
4. Confusing 'in' with 'zu' (Italian speakers may use 'zu' where 'in' + dative is needed)
5. Not using contractions *im/ins* appropriately (overusing or underusing them)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS: Some expressions with 'in' are fixed and may not follow the strict location/direction rule: 'in der Nacht' (at night - always dative), 'in der Tat' (indeed - fixed expression). Institutions can take both: 'in der Schule' (in the building) vs 'in die Schule gehen' (going to school as destination).

Distance expressions with 'bis zu'

■ From lesson

To express distance to a location, use 'Es sind [number] Meter bis zum/zur [place]'. 'Bis zu' means 'up to' and requires dative case. The preposition 'zu' governs the dative case and contracts with articles (*zu* +

dem = zum, zu + der = zur).

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: *Es sind* + [distance measurement] + *bis* + *zu* + [dative article] + [place]

Preposition 'zu' + dative case:

- *zu* + *dem* = *zum* (masculine/neuter dative)

- *zu* + *der* = *zur* (feminine dative)

Common contractions:

- *bis zum Strand* (to the beach - masculine)

- *bis zur Stadt* (to the city - feminine)

- *bis zum Zentrum* (to the center - neuter)

'Bis' alone (without 'zu') can be used with accusative for time or places without articles, but for expressing distance to a specific place, 'bis zu' + dative is standard.

EXAMPLES

→ *Es sind nur 100 Meter bis zum Strand.*

→ *Es sind 5 Kilometer bis zur Stadt.*

→ *Es sind wenige Schritte bis zum Bahnhof.*

→ *Es sind etwa 200 Meter bis zur Haltestelle.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may use preposition 'a' patterns from Italian ('a 100 metri dalla spiaggia') and try to translate literally. They may forget the dative case requirement after 'zu' since Italian uses only one preposition form. Italian speakers might omit 'zu' entirely and use only 'bis' with accusative, following Italian 'fino a' + article patterns. They may also forget the 'es sind' impersonal construction since Italian uses 'sono' (plural agreement with meters) or 'ci sono'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'Bis' without 'zu' is used for temporal expressions (*bis morgen* - until tomorrow) or with place names without articles (*bis Berlin* - to Berlin). When emphasizing 'up to' a maximum distance, 'bis zu' is required. With direction/movement verbs, alternatives like *zum Strand gehen* (go to the beach) can replace distance expressions.

durch + Akkusativ

■ From lesson

The preposition 'durch' (through) always takes the accusative case.

EXAMPLES

→ *Sie geht durch das Flugzeug.*

Ordinal numbers (Ordinalzahlen)

■ From lesson

Ordinal numbers express position/order and must be declined like adjectives. Form: 1-19 add -te, 20+ add -ste

COMPLETE RULE

1-19: add -te (*der erste, zweite, dritte...*); 20+: add -ste (*der zwanzigste*). Must decline like adjectives!
Exception: *erste, dritte* (not *einte, dreite*)

EXAMPLES

- *der erste April - the first of April*
- *Ich habe am ersten April Geburtstag - My birthday is on April 1st*
- *der zweite, der dritte, der vierte, der fünfte*
- *der zwanzigste, der einundzwanzigste*
- *Das ist der erste Stock - That's the first floor*

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular forms: *erste* (not *einte*), *dritte* (not *dreite*), *siebte* (not *siebente*)

Preposition durch + accusative

■ Web verified

The preposition 'durch' (through, by means of) ALWAYS takes the accusative case, without exception. It expresses movement through something or means/instrument by which something happens. Common usage: *durch* + *das/den/die* (accusative articles). The preposition never changes case based on movement vs. location (unlike two-way prepositions).

COMPLETE RULE

durch + accusative (always): *durch das* (often contracted: *durchs*), *durch den*, *durch die*, *durch die* (plural).
Meanings: 1) through (spatial): *durch das Fenster* (through the window), 2) by means of/through (instrumental): *durch Zufall* (by chance), 3) throughout (temporal): *das ganze Jahr durch* (throughout the year). No exceptions to case requirement.

EXAMPLES

- *Er hat den Ball durch das Fenster geworfen. (He threw the ball through the window.)*
- *Wir fahren durch die Stadt. (We drive through the city.)*
- *Er geht durch den Park. (He walks through the park.)*
- *Durch seine Hilfe haben wir es geschafft. (Through his help we managed it.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers use dative case after *durch* (**durch dem Fenster*, **durch dem Park*) - influenced by Italian '*attraverso*' or confusion with dative prepositions; confusing *durch* with other prepositions that can take dative; not recognizing contraction '*durchs*' (*durch* + *das*); using *durch* when other prepositions are needed for certain contexts

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

No exceptions: *durch* ALWAYS requires accusative case. Note: '*durch-*' as a separable or inseparable verb prefix follows different rules (*durchqueren* = inseparable, *durchlaufen* can be separable or inseparable depending on meaning).

Prepositions with islands: auf + dative/accusative

■ Web verified

With islands, German uses '*auf*' (on) rather than '*in*'. Use '*auf der Insel*' (dative) for location (being on the island) and '*auf die Insel*' (accusative) for direction (going to the island). This parallels English '*on the island*' / '*onto the island*'.

COMPLETE RULE

PREPOSITION 'AUF' WITH ISLANDS:

BASIC RULE: Islands take '*auf*' (on), NOT '*in*'

LOCATION (DATIVE - WO?):

auf + *der Insel* (feminine) = on the island

- *Ich bin auf der Insel. (I am on the island.)*
- *Wir wohnen auf der Insel Sylt. (We live on the island of Sylt.)*
- *Das Leben auf der Insel ist ruhig. (Life on the island is peaceful.)*

DIRECTION (ACCUSATIVE - WO?):

auf + *die Insel* = to the island, onto the island

- *Ich fahre auf die Insel. (I'm going to the island.)*
- *Wir fliegen morgen auf die Insel. (We're flying to the island tomorrow.)*

- Komm mit auf die Insel! (Come with me to the island!)

COMPLETE DECLENSION:

Nominative: die Insel (the island)

Accusative: auf die Insel (to the island)

Dative: auf der Insel (on the island)

Genitive: der Insel (of the island - rarely used with auf)

SPECIFIC ISLAND NAMES:

- auf Mallorca (location) / nach Mallorca (direction with names)

- auf Rügen / nach Rügen

- auf den Malediven (plural!)

- auf den Kanarischen Inseln (plural!)

NOTE: With named islands, both 'auf' and 'nach' are possible for direction:

- Ich fahre nach Mallorca. (more common)

- Ich fahre auf die Insel Mallorca. (with article)

QUESTION WORDS:

- Wo bist du? - Auf der Insel. (Where are you? - On the island.)

- Wohin fährst du? - Auf die Insel. (Where are you going? - To the island.)

OTHER 'AUF' CONTEXTS (TWO-WAY PREPOSITION):

- auf dem Tisch (on the table - dative)

- auf den Tisch (onto the table - accusative)

- auf dem Berg (on the mountain)

- auf den Berg (onto/up the mountain)

EXAMPLES

→ Ich wohne auf einer kleinen Insel in der Nordsee. (I live on a small island in the North Sea.)

dative, location

→ Nächstes Jahr fahren wir auf die Kanarischen Inseln. (Next year we're going to the Canary Islands.)

- accusative, direction, plural

→ Wie kommt man auf die Insel? - Mit der Fähre. (How do you get to the island? - By ferry.) -

accusative, movement

→ Der schönste Strand auf der Insel liegt im Süden. (The most beautiful beach on the island is in the south.) - dative, location

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER ERRORS:

■ 1. USING 'IN': *'Ich bin in der Insel' instead of 'Ich bin auf der Insel'. Italian uses 'sull'isola' (on-the-island) but can also say 'nell'isola' (in-the-island) in some contexts, causing confusion.

■ 2. WRONG CASE: *'Ich fahre auf der Insel' instead of 'Ich fahre auf die Insel' (direction requires accusative). Italians struggle with two-way prepositions since Italian prepositions don't change based on movement.

■ 3. MIXING WITH NACH: *'Ich fahre nach die Insel' instead of either 'auf die Insel' or 'nach [island name]'. Italian uses 'a' (to) uniformly: 'vado a Capri'.

■ 4. ARTICLE CONFUSION: *'Ich bin auf Insel' instead of 'auf der Insel'. Italian 'sull'isola' contracts the article, leading to omission in German.

5. PLURAL ISLANDS: *'auf die Malediven' (accusative) vs 'auf den Malediven' (dative - plural!). Italian 'alle Maldive' doesn't show this case distinction.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. NAMED ISLANDS WITH 'NACH':

- Ich fahre nach Mallorca. (I'm going to Mallorca.) - no article, preferred
- Ich fahre nach Kreta, nach Sizilien, nach Rügen
- BUT: auf die Insel Mallorca (with article + 'Insel')

2. ISLAND GROUPS (PLURAL):

- auf den Malediven (dative plural)
- auf die Malediven fahren (accusative plural)
- auf den Kanarischen Inseln
- auf den Bahamas

3. PENINSULA CONFUSION: Not islands, use 'in'

- in Florida (NOT auf Florida)
- auf der Halbinsel (on the peninsula) - but specific regions may use 'in'

4. COUNTRIES THAT ARE ISLANDS:

- nach Island (to Iceland) - country name
- auf Island (on Iceland - emphasizing island nature)
- nach Großbritannien / in Großbritannien (to/in Great Britain - treated as country)
- nach Zypern / auf Zypern (to/on Cyprus - both acceptable)

5. FIXED EXPRESSIONS:

- Robinson Crusoe auf der Insel (literary/traditional usage)
- gestrandet auf einer Insel (stranded on an island)

Prepositions with locations: 'auf' + Dative for islands

■ Web verified

German uses 'auf' (on) with the dative case for islands because they are conceptualized as surfaces. For countries without articles, use 'in' with dative for location, or 'nach' with dative for direction. Islands use 'auf' + accusative when expressing movement TO the island, and 'auf' + dative when expressing location ON

the island.

COMPLETE RULE

LOCATION (no movement): *auf* + **DATIVE** - 'Ich wohne auf Teneriffa' (I live on Tenerife), 'Ich bin auf der Insel' (I am on the island). **DIRECTION** (with movement): *auf* + **ACCUSATIVE** - 'Ich fliege auf die Kanarischen Inseln' (I'm flying to the Canary Islands). Named islands without article: 'nach + island name' is also acceptable - 'Ich ziehe nach Gran Canaria'. Countries: *in* + **DATIVE** for location - 'in Deutschland', 'in Spanien'. Directions: *nach* + **DATIVE** - 'nach Berlin'. Islands conceptualized as countries (Cuba, Cyprus, Malta): treated as countries with 'in'.

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich wohne auf einer Insel.** (I live on an island)

dative, location)

→ **Wir leben auf den Kanarischen Inseln.** (We live on the Canary Islands)

dative, location)

→ **Ich fliege auf die Kanarischen Inseln.** (I'm flying to the Canary Islands - accusative, movement)

→ **Ich bin auf der Insel Mallorca.** (I am on the island of Mallorca)

dative, location)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often incorrectly use *'in Teneriffa' instead of 'auf Teneriffa', transferring the Italian pattern 'a Tenerife'. Another error: using 'aus' for origin from islands (*'Ich komme aus Mallorca') instead of 'von' ('Ich komme von Mallorca'), since you live **ON** not **IN** an island. Confusing when to use accusative vs. dative with 'auf' - movement toward requires accusative, static location requires dative.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Islands that are also countries (Cuba, Cyprus, Malta, Iceland, etc.) are treated grammatically as countries, not islands: 'Ich fahre nach Zypern' (I'm going to Cyprus), 'Ich wohne in Island' (I live in Iceland). When the word 'Insel' itself is used, always use 'auf': 'auf der Insel'. Some regions and island groups may take 'in' when they function as administrative units.

Question words: wo vs. wohin

■ Web verified

'Wo' asks about static location (where something is) and expects Dativ. 'Wohin' asks about destination or direction (where something is going) and expects Akkusativ. This distinction helps identify which case to use with Wechselpräpositionen.

COMPLETE RULE

Use 'wo' (where) for static location questions requiring Dativ answers - answers the question 'at what location?' Use 'wohin' (where to) for movement/direction questions requiring Akkusativ answers - answers the question 'to what destination?' 'Woher' (where from) asks about origin and also uses Dativ. In spoken German, 'wohin' is often split: 'Wo gehst du hin?' The answer to 'wo' typically uses Dativ: 'im Park', 'auf dem Tisch', 'in der Schule'. The answer to 'wohin' typically uses Akkusativ: 'in den Park', 'auf den Tisch', 'in die Schule'.

EXAMPLES

- Wo ist die Lampe? - In der Ecke. (Where is the lamp? - In the corner, Dativ for static location)
- Wohin stellst du die Lampe? - In die Ecke. (Where are you putting the lamp? - In the corner, Akkusativ for destination)
- Wo sitzt der Hippie? - Auf dem Boden. (Where is the hippie sitting? - On the floor, Dativ static)
- Wohin fällt die Vase? - Auf den Boden. (Where is the vase falling? - Onto the floor, Akkusativ movement)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers often use 'wo' for both static and directional questions because Italian 'dove' serves both functions. Error: '*Wo gehst du?' (should be 'Wohin gehst du?' or 'Wo gehst du hin?'). Conversely, overusing 'wohin': '*Wohin ist das Buch?' (should be 'Wo ist das Buch?' - no movement involved). Another error: answering 'wo' questions with Akkusativ case or vice versa: 'Wo ist die Katze? - *Auf den Tisch' (should be 'Auf dem Tisch' - Dativ). Italian speakers may not realize that 'dove vai?' (where are you going) must be 'Wohin gehst du?' not 'Wo gehst du?'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In some regions and informal speech, 'wo' is used for both static and directional questions, relying on context and verb choice to clarify meaning. Southern German dialects may say 'Wo gehst du?' even when asking about destination. Some fixed expressions: 'Wo geht's lang?' (Which way?) uses 'wo' despite implying direction. With certain verbs of placement, native speakers might accept both: 'Wo hast du es hingelegt?' (using 'wo' even though 'wohin' would be more precise).

Relativsatz position and word order flexibility

■ Web verified

A relative clause can be positioned either in the middle of a sentence (as an insertion immediately after its antecedent) or at the end. When positioned in the middle, the main clause must continue after the relative clause ends. The relative clause always immediately follows the noun it describes. Both positions are grammatically correct, though middle positioning requires careful attention to continuing the main clause properly.

COMPLETE RULE

Position Rules:

1. MIDDLE POSITION (Insertion):

Structure: [Subject] + [Relative Clause] + [continues main clause verb + objects]

Example: Das Paar, das ein Problem hat, wohnt im vierten Stock

- Relative clause interrupts between subject and verb
- Main clause continues after relative clause closes
- Creates emphasis on the described noun

2. END POSITION:

Structure: [Complete main clause] + [Relative Clause]

Example: Im vierten Stock wohnt das Paar, das ein Problem hat

- Relative clause comes after main clause verb
- More straightforward structure
- Common in spoken German

3. BEGINNING (with subordinate clause first):

Structure: [Relative Clause], [main clause with inverted verb]

Example: Das Paar, das ein Problem hat, wohnt im vierten Stock

Proximity Rule:

- Relative clause must immediately follow its antecedent
- Cannot separate antecedent and relative clause with other elements
- Exception: Single word after relative clause is acceptable if leaving verb alone: Die Leute wohnen, die ich kenne, im dritten Stock

EXAMPLES

- Das Paar, das ein Problem mit dem Dach hat, wohnt im vierten Stock. (Relative clause in middle, between subject and verb)
- Im vierten Stock wohnt das Paar, das ein Problem mit dem Dach hat. (Relative clause at end)
- Wo wohnt das Paar, das ein Problem mit dem Dach hat? (Relative clause at end in question)
- Der Mann, den ich gestern traf, der hat mir geholfen. (Middle position with resumption - rare but possible in spoken German)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

1. Separating the relative clause from its antecedent with other sentence elements
2. Not continuing the main clause after a middle-position relative clause
3. Forgetting that word order remains flexible as long as proximity to antecedent is maintained
4. Creating ambiguity by placing relative clause near wrong noun when multiple nouns present
5. Not recognizing that relative clause can interrupt subject-verb connection in main clause

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. **Avoiding dangling verb:** If placing relative clause immediately after noun would leave main clause verb isolated at end, German allows slight reordering
2. **Multiple relative clauses:** Can stack relative clauses: *Der Mann, der dort steht, der ein rotes Hemd trägt, ist mein Bruder* (though usually avoided as awkward)
3. **Emphasis patterns:** Middle position emphasizes the noun being described; end position feels more neutral
4. **Spoken vs. written:** Spoken German tends toward end position for simplicity; written German uses more middle insertions
5. **With verb-final subordinate clauses:** Can create complex nesting: *Ich weiß, dass der Mann, der dort steht, mein Bruder ist*

Superlatives before nouns

■ Web verified

When a superlative directly precedes a noun (attributive position), it takes the definite article (der/die/das) and appropriate adjective endings according to case, gender, and number. For example: 'Die teuerste Option ist der ICE' (The most expensive option is the ICE). The superlative stem is adjective + -st (or -est), then add declension endings.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: Definite article + adjective stem + -st/-est + declension ending + noun. Use -est when stem ends in -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -x, or -z.

Attributive Superlative Declension (Weak endings after definite article):

MASCULINE: Nom: der größte Mann | Acc: den größten Mann | Dat: dem größten Mann | Gen: des größten Mannes

FEMININE: Nom: die größte Frau | Acc: die größte Frau | Dat: der größten Frau | Gen: der größten Frau

NEUTER: Nom: das größte Auto | Acc: das größte Auto | Dat: dem größten Auto | Gen: des größten Autos

PLURAL (all genders): Nom: die größten Leute | Acc: die größten Leute | Dat: den größten Leuten | Gen: der größten Leute

Pattern: Nominative and accusative singular (feminine/neuter) take -e ending; all other forms take -en ending.

EXAMPLES

- *Der ICE ist die teuerste Option. (The ICE is the most expensive option.)*
- *Der Fernbus ist die billigste Option. (The long-distance bus is the cheapest option.)*
- *Die schnellste Option ist der ICE. (The fastest option is the ICE.)*
- *Ist Alexander der größte Mann? (Is Alexander the tallest man?)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may forget adjective endings entirely because Italian adjectives have simpler agreement rules (only gender and number, no cases). They might say 'der teuerst Option' instead of 'die teuerste Option'. Italian learners confuse attributive superlatives (die teuerste Option) with predicative superlatives (am teuersten), using 'am' structure before nouns. They may use indefinite article with superlative (like English 'a fastest car') when German requires definite article. Romance language interference causes errors in case endings since Italian doesn't have a case system.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The superlative 'nächst-' (nearest) from 'nah' is irregular. When used with indefinite article or possessive (mixed declension), endings differ: 'ein größter Mann' (nominative masculine takes -er), 'eine größte Frau' (nominative feminine takes -e), 'mein größtes Auto' (nominative/accusative neuter takes -es). Without article (strong declension), adjective carries full case marking.

Temporal prepositions vor and seit with Dativ

■ Web verified

vor means 'ago' and indicates a point in the past (vor zwei Jahren = two years ago). seit means 'since/for' and indicates duration up to the present (seit 20 Jahren = for 20 years). Both require Dativ case: vor dem Jahr, seit einem Jahr.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE WITH DECLENSION TABLES:

VOR (ago/before) - always takes DATIV case:

- Meaning: Indicates time that has passed, equivalent to English 'ago' or 'before'
- Usage: Completed actions in the past
- Tense: Used with past tenses (Perfekt, Präteritum)

Declension with VOR + DATIV:

Masculine: vor dem Jahr, vor einem Monat

Feminine: vor der Woche, vor einer Stunde

Neuter: vor dem Jahr, vor einem Jahr

Plural: vor den Jahren, vor zwei Wochen

SEIT (since/for) - always takes DATIV case:

- Meaning: Duration from past continuing to present, equivalent to English 'since' or 'for'
- Usage: Ongoing actions/states
- Tense: Used with PRESENT tense in German (unlike English which uses present perfect)

Declension with SEIT + DATIV:

Masculine: seit dem Jahr, seit einem Monat

Feminine: seit der Woche, seit einer Stunde

Neuter: seit dem Jahr, seit einem Jahr

Plural: seit den Jahren, seit zwei Jahren

Key difference: VOR = finished action (ago), SEIT = continuing action (for/since)

EXAMPLES

→ Vor zwei Jahren habe ich meinen Bachelor abgeschlossen. (Two years ago I completed my bachelor's degree.)

→ Ich lebe seit 20 Jahren in Spanien. (I have been living in Spain for 20 years.)

→ Ich bin vor 30 Jahren nach Deutschland gekommen. (I came to Germany 30 years ago.)

→ Seit einer Woche lerne ich Deutsch. (I have been learning German for one week.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

COMMON MISTAKES FOR ITALIAN SPEAKERS:

1. TENSE CONFUSION: Italian speakers often use past tense with 'seit' because Italian uses present perfect (ho studiato da due anni). German requires PRESENT tense: 'Ich lerne seit zwei Jahren Deutsch' (NOT: Ich habe seit zwei Jahren gelernt).

2. PREPOSITION CHOICE: Italian uses 'da' for both 'ago' and 'for/since', leading to confusion between vor and seit. Remember: vor = completed (ago), seit = ongoing (for/since).

3. CASE ERRORS: Both prepositions ALWAYS take Dativ. Italian speakers may forget case marking: 'seit zwei Jahre' (WRONG) → 'seit zwei Jahren' (CORRECT).

■ **4. LITERAL TRANSLATION:** Italian 'sono qui da tre ore' might be translated as 'Ich bin hier von drei Stunden' (WRONG). Correct: 'Ich bin seit drei Stunden hier'.

5. OMITTING PREPOSITION: When stating years in Italian, no preposition is needed (sono nato nel 1990). German also omits preposition for specific years but requires it for time spans.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

1. VOR can also mean 'in front of' (spatial) when indicating location, still with Dativ: 'vor dem Haus' (in front of the house).

2. VOR as two-way preposition: When indicating spatial direction with motion verbs, vor can take Akkusativ (rare): 'Er trat vor den Spiegel' (He stepped in front of the mirror).

3. SEIT can also function as a subordinating conjunction (verb goes to end): 'Seit ich in Deutschland wohne, lerne ich Deutsch' (Since I live in Germany, I'm learning German).

4. Specific years require no preposition: '1990 bin ich geboren' or 'Im Jahre 1990 bin ich geboren' (optional 'im Jahr/Jahre').

5. VOR with Dativ for 'before' (sequential): 'vor dem Frühstück' (before breakfast), 'vor der Arbeit' (before work).

Time expressions: ab, von...bis, vor

■ Web verified

'ab' means 'from (time) onwards' with open end time (starting point). 'von...bis' means 'from...to' with specific start and end times (bounded period). 'vor' means 'before' a specific time or 'ago' (past reference). 'nach' means 'after'. These prepositions structure appointments and schedules with different cases.

COMPLETE RULE

Case patterns:

ab + DATIVE: starting point onwards (future/present)

- *Ab Montag (starting Monday)*
- *Ab 18 Uhr (from 6 PM onward)*
- *Ab nächster Woche (starting next week)*

von...bis + DATIVE: bounded time period

- *Von Montag bis Freitag (from Monday to Friday)*
- *Von 9 bis 17 Uhr (from 9 to 5 o'clock)*
- *Vom 1. bis zum 4. Januar (from Jan 1 to Jan 4)*

vor + DATIVE: before (future) or ago (past)

- *Vor 5 Uhr (before 5 o'clock)*
- *Vor drei Jahren (three years ago)*
- *Vor der Arbeit (before work)*

nach + DATIVE: after (time)

- *Nach der Arbeit (after work)*
- *Nach 8 Uhr (after 8 o'clock)*

Note: bis can take accusative when used alone with specific times: 'bis nächste Woche'

EXAMPLES

→ **Ab sieben Uhr habe ich Zeit.** (From 7 o'clock onwards I have time

open ended)

→ **Von sieben bis acht Uhr.** (From 7 to 8 o'clock - specific bounded period)

→ **Vor halb drei.** (Before 2:30 - or: half past two ago, depending on context)

→ **Ich arbeite von Montag bis Freitag, ab 9 Uhr.** (I work Monday to Friday, from 9 o'clock onward each day)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers use 'von' alone meaning 'from onwards' like 'da lunedì' → 'von Montag' (wrong - should be 'ab Montag'). Confusing: von needs bis for endpoints. Also using 'vor' for future 'before' when meaning 'until' (should use 'bis'). Italian 'prima delle 5' (before 5) = German 'vor 5 Uhr' BUT 'fino alle 5' (until 5) = 'bis 5 Uhr'. Forgetting 'ab' implies ongoing/no endpoint while 'von...bis' requires both boundaries.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'bis' alone with specific time takes accusative: 'bis nächste Woche', 'bis nächsten Montag'. When combined with prepositions: 'bis zu' + dative ('bis zum Freitag'), 'bis vor' + time span ('bis vor zwei Wochen' = until two weeks ago). 'ab' sometimes takes accusative in modern German: 'ab nächsten Montag' (increasingly common). With year numbers alone, no preposition: 'Ich bin 1990 geboren' (not 'in 1990').

Time expressions: letzten vs. vorletzten Sonntag

■ Web verified

'Letzten Sonntag' = last Sunday (the most recent one that passed). 'Vorletzten Sonntag' = the Sunday before last (two Sundays ago). 'Nächsten Sonntag' = next Sunday (the coming one). These temporal expressions use accusative case (den letzten Sonntag) without preposition.

COMPLETE RULE

TEMPORAL EXPRESSIONS WITHOUT PREPOSITION (ACCUSATIVE):

1. BASIC FORMS:

- letzten Sonntag = last Sunday (most recent past)
- vorletzten Sonntag = Sunday before last (two Sundays ago)
- nächsten Sonntag = next Sunday (coming Sunday)
- diesen Sonntag = this Sunday (current week)
- jeden Sonntag = every Sunday

2. DECLENSION PATTERN (Accusative):

Masculine/Neuter days and time periods:

- den letzten Montag (last Monday)
- letzten Monat (last month)
- letztes Jahr (last year)
- nächsten Mittwoch (next Wednesday)
- vorigen Dienstag (previous Tuesday)

3. WITH PREPOSITIONS (Dative):

- am letzten Sonntag (on last Sunday - more formal)

- am vorletzten Montag (on the Monday before last)
- bis nächsten Montag (until next Monday)

4. OTHER TEMPORAL ADVERBS:

- gestern = yesterday
- vorgestern = day before yesterday
- morgen = tomorrow
- übermorgen = day after tomorrow
- heute = today

5. COMPOUND TIME EXPRESSIONS:

- letzte Woche = last week
- nächstes Wochenende = next weekend
- vorletztes Jahr = year before last
- übernächste Woche = week after next

6. USAGE WITH VERBS:

- Ich bin letzten Sonntag angekommen. (I arrived last Sunday.)
- Wir treffen uns nächsten Freitag. (We're meeting next Friday.)
- Er war vorletzten Monat in Berlin. (He was in Berlin the month before last.)

EXAMPLES

- Ich bin letzten Sonntag angekommen. (I arrived last Sunday.)
- Ich bin am vorletzten Sonntag angekommen. (I arrived the Sunday before last.)
- Bis nächsten Montag! (Until next Monday!)
- Wir fahren nächstes Wochenende nach München. (We're driving to Munich next weekend.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKERS' COMMON ERRORS:

1. USING PREPOSITION INCORRECTLY: Italians use 'scorso/prossimo' with articles

- in letzten Sonntag (like Italian 'domenica scorsa')
- im letzten Sonntag

■ ✓ letzten Sonntag (no preposition in German!)

■ ✓ am letzten Sonntag (only with 'am')

2. WRONG CASE: Using nominative instead of accusative

■ letzter Sonntag bin ich angekommen

■ ✓ letzten Sonntag bin ich angekommen

3. ARTICLE CONFUSION: Adding definite article unnecessarily

■ den letzten Sonntag bin ich angekommen (article not needed without preposition)

■ ✓ letzten Sonntag bin ich angekommen

■ ✓ am letzten Sonntag bin ich angekommen (with 'am', article incorporated)

4. 'PROSSIMO' = NEXT CONFUSION: Italian 'prossimo' can mean 'next' or 'following,' causing ambiguity

- nächsten Sonntag = next Sunday (the coming one)
- folgenden Sonntag = the following Sunday (in a narrative context)

5. MISSING ADJECTIVE ENDING:

- nächste Sonntag (wrong ending for accusative masculine)
- ✓ nächsten Sonntag

6. WRONG PREFIX: Using 'vor-' incorrectly

- vornächsten Sonntag (doesn't exist)
- ✓ übernächsten Sonntag (Sunday after next)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS:

1. FESTIVALS AND HOLIDAYS: Often use different constructions

- letztes Weihnachten (last Christmas - neuter)
- nächstes Ostern (next Easter - neuter)
- zu Weihnachten (at Christmas - with preposition)

2. 'NACHT' USES 'IN' NOT 'AM':

- in der Nacht (during the night)
- letzte Nacht (last night - but: in der letzten Nacht is more common)

3. PARTS OF DAY: Can use accusative or 'am'

- letzten Abend / am letzten Abend (last evening)
- nächsten Morgen / am nächsten Morgen (next morning)

4. 'VORIG-' AS ALTERNATIVE TO 'LETZT-':

- vorigen Montag = letzten Montag (last Monday)
- More common in formal writing

5. MONTHS: Usually without article in accusative

- letzten Januar (last January)
- BUT: im letzten Januar (also correct with preposition)

6. AMBIGUITY WITH 'NÄCHST-': In spoken German, 'nächsten Sonntag' could mean:

- The very next Sunday (most common interpretation)
- OR the following Sunday (in narrative context)

To clarify: 'am kommenden Sonntag' = the very next coming Sunday

Two-way prepositions (Wechselpräpositionen)

■ From lesson

Some prepositions take dative (location/state: wo?) or accusative (direction/movement: wohin?) depending on whether there is movement or not

COMPLETE RULE

Wechselpräpositionen: in, an, auf, über, unter, vor, hinter, neben, zwischen. Use DATIV for location (wo?), AKKUSATIV for direction (wohin?)

EXAMPLES

→ *Wo ist das Bad? - Das Bad ist zwischen dem kleinen Schlafzimmer und dem großen Schlafzimmer (DATIV)*

→ *Ich bin im Supermarkt (DATIV - location)*

→ *Ich gehe in den Supermarkt (AKKUSATIV - movement)*

→ *Ich sitze auf der Toilette (DATIV)*

→ *Ich gehe auf die Toilette (AKKUSATIV)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing when to use dative vs accusative

Wechselpräpositionen with Akkusativ (movement) vs. Dativ (location)

■ Web verified

Nine two-way prepositions (an, auf, hinter, in, neben, über, unter, vor, zwischen) take Akkusativ when indicating movement toward a destination (answering 'wohin?') and Dativ when indicating a static location (answering 'wo?').

COMPLETE RULE

The nine Wechselpräpositionen are: an (on, at), auf (on), hinter (behind), in (in, into), neben (next to), über (over, above), unter (under), vor (in front of, before), zwischen (between). Use Akkusativ when there is movement from point A to point B - the action answers 'wohin?' (where to?). Use Dativ when describing a static position with no change of location - the action answers 'wo?' (where?). Declension tables: Akkusativ masculine 'den', feminine 'die', neuter 'das', plural 'die'; Dativ masculine 'dem', feminine 'der', neuter 'dem', plural 'den'.

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich stelle die Vase auf den Tisch. (Akkusativ - I'm putting the vase onto the table, movement to destination)*

→ *Die Vase steht auf dem Tisch. (Dativ - The vase stands on the table, static location)*

→ *Er hängt das Bild an die Wand. (Akkusativ)*

He hangs the picture on the wall, movement)

→ *Das Bild hängt an der Wand. (Dativ - The picture is hanging on the wall, static position)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers (and other learners) commonly confuse movement with general action. Error: Using Dativ with movement verbs like 'auf dem Boden fallen' instead of 'auf den Boden fallen' (accusative, because the object moves to a new location). Another error: Using Akkusativ for static positions like 'in den Park joggen' when meaning 'joggen im Park' (dative, when the jogging happens while already in the park). The key is not whether there's movement in general, but whether there's movement from A to B. Italian speakers may struggle because Italian uses different prepositions rather than case changes to express this distinction.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Fixed expressions always use one case regardless of actual movement: 'auf dem Land' (in the countryside, always Dativ), 'auf dem Laufenden sein' (to be up to date, always Dativ), 'im Stehen' (while standing, always Dativ). With figurative/abstract usage, Akkusativ is common: 'denken an + Akkusativ' (to think of), even though thinking involves no physical movement.

Wo-compounds in questions (womit, worauf, wovon)

■ Web verified

When asking questions about things (not people) with prepositions, German uses wo- + preposition. If the preposition starts with a vowel, use wor- + preposition (worauf, woran, worüber). This replaces 'with what', 'on what', 'from what'. For people, use preposition + wen/wem.

COMPLETE RULE

FORMATION RULES:

1. Preposition starts with consonant: wo + preposition

- womit (with what), wofür (for what), wovon (from what), wonach (after what)

2. Preposition starts with vowel: wor + preposition

- worauf (on what), worüber (about what), woran (on what), worum (about what), woraus (from what)

USAGE:

1. QUESTIONS ABOUT THINGS:

Womit schreibst du? (What are you writing with?)

Worauf wartest du? (What are you waiting for?)

2. FOR PEOPLE: Use preposition + wen (accusative) or wem (dative)

Auf wen wartest du? (Who are you waiting for?)

Mit wem sprichst du? (Who are you speaking with?)

3. WORD ORDER: Wo-compound starts the question, verb comes second

Worüber sprichst du? (What are you talking about?)

CANNOT form wo-compounds with: außer, ohne, seit, gegenüber

COMMON WO-COMPOUNDS:

womit, wofür, wogegen, worauf, worüber, woran, worin, worum, wodurch, wovon, wonach, wozu

EXAMPLES

→ Womit fängst du an? (With what do you start? / What are you starting with?)

→ Worauf freust du dich? (What are you looking forward to?)

→ Wovon hängt es ab? (What does it depend on?)

→ Worüber spricht ihr? (What are you talking about?)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

- 1. STRANDING PREPOSITIONS: English-style word order influenced by Italian (*Was wartest du auf? instead of Worauf wartest du?). German MUST front the wo-compound.
- 2. USING FOR PEOPLE: Italian doesn't distinguish, so speakers ask *Womit sprichst du? for 'with whom'. CORRECT: Mit wem sprichst du?
- 3. SEPARATING WO AND PREPOSITION: Writing/saying *wo auf or *wo über as two words instead of worauf, worüber
- 4. FORGETTING 'R' WITH VOWELS: Saying *woauf, *woüber instead of worauf, worüber
- 5. USING WRONG PREPOSITION: Translating Italian preposition directly (*wo di pensare instead of woran denken)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. For people, ALWAYS use preposition + wen/wem, never wo-compound: Auf wen wartest du? (Who are you waiting for?)
2. Some prepositions cannot form wo-compounds: außer, ohne, seit → Must use 'was' + preposition separately (less common)
3. In indirect questions, wo-compounds maintain the same form: Ich weiß nicht, worauf er wartet.
4. Animals can be treated as things (worauf) or persons (auf wen) depending on context
5. 'Warum' (why) is NOT a wo-compound - it's a separate question word

wütend auf + Akkusativ

■ Web verified

The adjective 'wütend' (angry) is used with the preposition 'auf', which requires the accusative case here, not the dative.

COMPLETE RULE

'auf' belongs to the group of nine German two-way prepositions (Wechselpräpositionen: an, auf, hinter, in, neben, über, unter, vor, zwischen) that can take either the accusative or the dative case depending on meaning (motion/direction -> accusative; static location -> dative). However, when 'auf' is used figuratively/idiomatically after certain adjectives of emotion — such as 'wütend auf' (angry at), 'stolz auf' (proud of), 'eifersüchtig auf' (jealous of), 'gespannt auf' (curious about) — it is fixed and always governs the ACCUSATIVE case, regardless of any physical motion or location.

DECLENSION TABLE for 'auf' + Akkusativ (masculine/feminine/neuter/plural):

auf + den (masc.) - wütend auf den Mann

auf + die (fem.) - wütend auf die Frau

auf + das (neut.) - wütend auf das Kind

auf + die (plural) - wütend auf die Leute

Contraction: auf + das = aufs (less common with this idiom)

Duden confirms the idiomatic phrase 'wütend auf/über jemanden sein' (to be very angry/incensed), listing 'auf' as a standard preposition choice alongside 'über' for this meaning. A commonly cited nuance (from general usage sources) is that 'wütend auf' + Akkusativ is typically used with a person as the object of anger, while 'wütend über' + Akkusativ is used with a thing, statement, or situation as the cause of anger.

EXAMPLES

→ Er ist wütend auf die Frau.

→ Ich bin wütend auf meinen Bruder.

→ Warum bist du so wütend auf mich?

→ Sie war wütend auf ihren Kollegen, weil er zu spät kam.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Kevin initially tried 'über' with dative; corrected to 'auf' + accusative. Italian speakers frequently make this error because the equivalent Italian construction 'arrabbiato con qualcuno' uses 'con' (with), which has no case-marking equivalent in Italian, so learners have no built-in intuition for which German case to select and often default to the dative because many two-way prepositions describing static 'location of emotion' seem, by analogy with physical location (e.g., 'im Zimmer'), to call for dative. Another typical error is mixing up 'auf' and 'über': because Italian uses a single preposition regardless of whether the object of anger is a person or a situation, Italian learners often use 'wütend über' even when referring to a person, or vice versa. Learners also sometimes wrongly decline the noun after 'auf' in the dative (e.g., '*wütend auf der Frau' instead of correctly 'wütend auf die Frau'), treating 'auf' as always requiring dative because of its frequent use in fixed dative expressions like 'auf der Arbeit'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'wütend über' + Akkusativ is an accepted alternative, generally used when the cause of the anger is a thing, statement, or situation rather than a person (e.g., 'Er war wütend über die ungerechte Behandlung' — angry about the unjust treatment), whereas 'wütend auf' is preferred with a person as the object. As a two-way preposition, 'auf' still takes the dative in its literal, spatial sense of static location (e.g., 'Das Buch liegt auf dem Tisch' — the book lies on the table), so learners must distinguish

the fixed idiomatic emotional use (always accusative) from the general locative use (dative for location, accusative for motion onto a surface).

Zwischen + Dative

■ Web verified

The preposition 'zwischen' (between) is a two-way preposition (Wechselpräposition) that can take either dative or accusative case. It takes the dative case when expressing a static position or location (answering 'wo?' - where?), with no movement from point A to point B. It takes accusative when expressing movement toward a destination (answering 'wohin?' - where to?), indicating a change in position from one location to another. When expressing position, abstract concepts, or static relationships, use dative.

COMPLETE RULE

Zwischen + Dative (wo? - position, no movement from A to B): Use when describing static location between two points. Examples: zwischen dem Haus und der Straße (between the house and the street), zwischen den beiden Städten (between the two cities). Zwischen + Accusative (wohin? - direction, movement from A to B): Use when describing movement into a position between two points. Examples: zwischen die Tische stellen (to place between the tables), zwischen seine Eltern springen (to jump between his parents - changing position). With temporal meaning: zwischen always takes dative (e.g., zwischen dem 1. und 5. Januar - between January 1st and 5th). With modal/quantitative meaning: dative (e.g., zwischen 18 und 25 Jahren alt - between 18 and 25 years old). Declension: der → dem, die → der, das → dem, die (plural) → den + -n on noun if needed.

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich bin die Brücke zwischen der Schweiz und den USA.** (I am the bridge between Switzerland and the USA.)

static position, dative)

→ **Das Kind springt zwischen seine Eltern.** (The child jumps between his parents. - movement to position, accusative)

→ **Das Kind springt zwischen seinen Eltern.** (The child jumps between his parents. - staying in that position, dative)

→ **Zwischen dem Haus und der Straße ist ein Garten.** (Between the house and the street is a garden. - static location, dative)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often confuse dative and accusative with two-way prepositions because Italian uses different prepositions (fra/tra) that don't change the following noun's form. They may use accusative when dative is needed for static position (e.g., incorrectly saying 'zwischen die Schweiz und die USA' instead of 'zwischen der Schweiz und den USA' for a static bridge position). Another mistake is forgetting to add -n to dative plural nouns. Italian speakers may also fail to recognize that abstract concepts or metaphorical positions require dative. They might forget that temporal expressions with zwischen always use dative.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When movement occurs but remains within the same general location (no change from point A to point B), use dative even with movement verbs. For example, 'Das Kind läuft zwischen seinen Eltern' (The child runs between his parents - staying between them) uses dative, not accusative. Temporal expressions with *zwischen* always take dative regardless of whether they refer to a time span or a point within a timeframe. Some fixed expressions may override the normal rules.

Personalpronomen im Akkusativ

■ From lesson

Personal pronouns in accusative case (used as direct objects)

COMPLETE RULE

Singular Nominativ: ich, du, er/es/sie | Singular Akkusativ: mich, dich, ihn/es/sie |
Plural Nominativ: wir, ihr, sie/Sie | Plural Akkusativ: uns, euch, sie/Sie

EXAMPLES

- *Siehst du mich?*
- *Ich rufe dich an.*
- *Wir besuchen sie.*
- *Er kennt uns.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using nominative forms (ich, du) instead of accusative (mich, dich) after verbs

Konnektor 'denn' (Grund) - Connector 'denn' (reason)

■ From lesson

The connector 'denn' (because/for) is used to give a reason. It connects two main clauses. 'Denn' occupies Position 0 (before the first position), followed by normal word order in the second clause.

COMPLETE RULE

1. Hauptsatz: Pos.1 (subject) + Pos.2 (verb) + Satzende | Konnektor (Pos.0): denn | 2.
Hauptsatz: Pos.1 (subject) + Pos.2 (verb) + Satzende

EXAMPLES

- *Beatriz geht gern ins Theater, denn sie liebt Literatur.*
- *Beatriz und Leopold kaufen Brot und Wurst, denn sie wollen ein Picknick machen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Important: A comma must come before 'denn'!

Indirekte Fragesätze (Indirect questions)

■ From lesson

Indirect questions in German. When a direct yes/no question becomes indirect, it starts with 'ob'. When a direct question with a question word (W-Frage) becomes indirect, it uses the same question word. There can also be tour/guide expressions with these structures.

COMPLETE RULE

When direct yes/no questions (ja/Nein-Frage) become indirect, they begin with 'ob'.
Example: Gibt es Führungen zum Thema 'Film'? → Ich möchte wissen, ob es auch Führungen zum Thema 'Film' gibt. | When direct questions with question words (Fragewort) become indirect, they use the same question word. Example: Wie lange dauert die Führung? → Können Sie mir sagen, wie lange die Führung dauert?

EXAMPLES

- Ich möchte wissen, ob es auch Führungen zum Thema 'Film' gibt.
- Können Sie mir sagen, wie lange die Führung dauert?
- Wo ist der Treffpunkt? → Können Sie mir auf dem Plan zeigen, wo der Treffpunkt ist?
- Welches Ticket ist am besten? → Ich möchte gern wissen, welches Ticket am besten ist.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting 'ob' for yes/no questions, or using wrong word order in indirect questions.

Vergleichssätze: etwas / jemand ist gleich / nicht gleich

■ From lesson

Comparative clauses expressing equality or inequality using 'wie' (as...as) and 'als' (more...than). 'Wie' is used for equal comparisons, 'als' is used when something is more/different.

COMPLETE RULE

For equal comparisons use: so + adjective + wie. For unequal comparisons use: comparative adjective + als. Examples: genauso gern wie, nicht so attraktiv wie, billiger als, gesünder als, lieber als, mehr Sportmöglichkeiten als

EXAMPLES

- Immer mehr Deutsche verbringen ihren Urlaub genauso gern in Deutschland wie im Ausland.
- Für den Urlaub findet Niclas die Ostsee nicht so attraktiv wie die Alpen.

- *Linus meint, Urlaub in Deutschland ist billiger als im Ausland.*
- *Viele denken, die Luft auf dem Land ist gesünder als die Luft in der Stadt.*
- *Niclas möchte lieber mit Freunden als allein in Urlaub fahren.*
- *Niclas findet, die Alpen bieten mehr Sportmöglichkeiten als die Ostsee.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'als' and 'wie' - remember 'wie' is for equal comparisons (as...as), 'als' is for unequal comparisons (more...than)

Alternativen: entweder – oder

■ From lesson

The conjunctions 'entweder ... oder' (either ... or) are used to express alternatives. 'Entweder' can be in position 0 (before the subject) or in the first main clause. 'Oder' is always in position 0 of the second clause.

COMPLETE RULE

Position 0: 1. Hauptsatz/1. Satzteil: Entweder wir gehen in 'Criminal Dinner' |
Position 0: oder | 2. Hauptsatz/2. Satzteil: wir sehen die 'Dreigroschenoper'. //

Alternative positions: Entweder gehen wir ins Theater im Hafen | oder | wir besuchen das Stadtfest. // Wir können entweder in 'Criminal Dinner' | oder | das Musical gehen.

EXAMPLES

- *Entweder wir gehen in 'Criminal Dinner' oder wir sehen die 'Dreigroschenoper'.*
- *Entweder gehen wir ins Theater im Hafen oder wir besuchen das Stadtfest.*
- *Wir können entweder in 'Criminal Dinner' oder das Musical gehen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Incorrect word order after 'entweder' and 'oder'

Zweiteilige Konnektoren - Two-part connectors (nicht nur...sondern auch, sowohl...als auch, weder...noch)

■ From lesson

Two-part connectors link elements in a sentence. 'nicht nur ..., sondern auch' and 'sowohl ... als auch' replace 'und' and emphasize that the listed elements are equally important. In connections with 'nicht nur ..., sondern auch', the second element is more emphasized.

COMPLETE RULE

nicht nur ..., sondern auch = not only ... but also (second element emphasized). *sowohl ... als auch* = both ... and (elements equally important). *weder ... noch* = neither ... nor (no element applies).

EXAMPLES

- *Innsbruck bietet sowohl Kultur als auch Natur.*
- *Besucher können dort nicht nur die Architektur, sondern auch die Aussicht bewundern.*
- *Das Restaurant ist weder besonders schick, noch ist die Speisekarte aufregend.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using 'und' when emphasis is needed. Word order: 'weder ... noch' means no element applies, so neither element happens.

Präposition statt + Genitiv (standardsprachlich) / + Dativ (umgangssprachlich)

■ From lesson

The preposition 'statt' (instead of) expresses an alternative. In standard German, it takes the genitive case, but in colloquial German, the dative is also used. 'Statt' can also be combined with other prepositions.

COMPLETE RULE

Statt + Genitiv (standard): Statt der Grünen, Statt des Zuges. Statt + Dativ (colloquial): Statt den Grünen, Statt dem Zug. With other prepositions: Statt im (statt + in + dem), Statt für.

EXAMPLES

- *Statt der Grünen / Statt den Grünen wählt Lisa das nächste Mal eine andere Partei.*
- *Statt im Mai war die Wahl im Juni.*
- *Statt für die SPD hat sie für die Grünen gestimmt.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Mixing genitive and dative forms, or forgetting to decline the article after 'statt'

aber, denn, und, sondern, oder → aduso-Konnektoren

■ From lesson

Coordinating conjunctions in German (aduso) that connect main clauses without changing word order. Position 0 means they stand between clauses and don't count as part of the clause structure.

COMPLETE RULE

1. Hauptsatz + Position 0 (aber/denn/und/sondern/oder) + 2. Hauptsatz/2. Satzteil. These conjunctions connect clauses but don't occupy position 1, so normal word order continues in the second clause.

EXAMPLES

- *Witikon liegt etwas außerhalb, aber es hat gute Verkehrsverbindungen.*
- *Lindenhof ist schön, denn es liegt in der Altstadt.*
- *In Witikon sind die Mieten nicht so hoch und die Verkehrsverbindungen sind gut.*
- *Frankfurt liegt nicht westlich (von Mainz), sondern (es liegt) östlich von Mainz.*
- *Lara und Andrea möchten in Enge oder (sie möchten) in Lindenhof wohnen.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Don't invert subject and verb after these conjunctions - they are position 0, not position 1. 'sondern' is used for correction after a negative statement, not 'aber'.

Accusative case (Akkusativ)

■ From lesson

The accusative case is used for direct objects (the thing/person directly affected by the action). Only masculine articles change: der→den, ein→einen

COMPLETE RULE

Nominative vs Accusative: der→den (m), die→die (f), das→das (n), die→die (pl). Only masculine singular changes!

EXAMPLES

- *Ich habe einen Bruder (m)*
- *Ich habe ein Kind (n)*
- *Ich habe eine Tochter (f)*
- *Ich kaufe einen neuen Hut (m)*
- *Ich brauche ein neues Handy (n)*
- *Er besucht eine alte Freundin (f)*

Accusative Case - Articles

■ From lesson

The accusative case is used for direct objects. Only masculine articles change: *der*→*den*, *ein*→*einen*

COMPLETE RULE

Accusative changes: der→*den*, *ein*→*einen*, *kein*→*keinen*, *mein*→*meinen* (masculine only). Feminine, neuter, and plural stay the same

EXAMPLES

- *Ich habe einen Bruder (m)*
- *Ich sehe den Mann*
- *Ich kaufe ein Auto (n)*
- *Ich treffe eine Freundin (f)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Changing articles for feminine or neuter nouns

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

None

Accusative Case - Personal Pronouns

■ From lesson

Personal pronouns change form in accusative case when they are direct objects

COMPLETE RULE

Nominative→*Accusative*: *ich*→*mich*, *du*→*dich*, *er*→*ihn*, *sie*→*sie*, *es*→*es*, *wir*→*uns*, *ihr*→*euch*, *sie*→*sie*

EXAMPLES

- *Ich sehe ihn (I see him)*
- *Kennst du sie? (Do you know her?)*
- *Er trifft mich (He meets me)*
- *Ich rufe dich an (I call you)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using nominative pronouns as objects

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

sie (she) and es stay the same in accusative

Comparative 'als' in comparisons

■ Web verified

Use 'als' (than) for unequal comparisons with comparative adjectives in German. 'Als' introduces the comparative of superiority. The case after 'als' typically matches the case of what's being compared.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete conjugation: als (invariable conjunction)

Usage: adjective + comparative form (-er) + als + comparison element

Examples: größer als (bigger than), schneller als (faster than), besser als (better than)

The element after 'als' takes the same grammatical case as the element being compared.

EXAMPLES

→ Die anderen Hotels sind weiter als mein Hotel.

→ Er ist größer als sein Bruder.

→ Dieses Buch ist interessanter als das andere.

→ Sie läuft schneller als ich.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may confuse 'als' with 'wie' (which is used for equal comparisons with 'so...wie'). Italian uses 'di' or 'che' for comparisons, which doesn't distinguish between equal/unequal like German does. Italian speakers may also incorrectly apply verb conjugation patterns after 'als' since Italian 'che' can introduce subordinate clauses with conjugated verbs.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'Als' is also used for temporal meanings ('when' in past tense contexts) and must not be confused with the comparative usage.

Comparative with 'als' and 'nicht so...wie'

■ Web verified

For unequal comparisons (superiority), use comparative + 'als' (than). For negative equality (inferiority), use 'nicht so + positive adjective + wie' (not as...as). For positive equality, use 'so/ebenso/genauso + positive adjective + wie' (as...as). Never use 'wie' with comparative forms - this is a common dialectal error.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPARATIVE OF SUPERIORITY:

Form: adjective + -er + als

Example: größer als, schneller als, besser als

COMPARATIVE OF EQUALITY:

Form: so/ebenso/genauso/gleich + adjective + wie

Example: so groß wie, genauso schnell wie

COMPARATIVE OF INFERIORITY:

Form: nicht so + adjective + wie

Example: nicht so groß wie, nicht so schnell wie

IMPORTANT: 'als' = than (with comparative -er)

'wie' = as (with positive form only)

NEVER: *größer wie (dialectal/incorrect)

ALWAYS: größer als

EXAMPLES

→ Die Donau ist länger als der Rhein. (The Danube is longer than the Rhine.)

→ Mein Auto ist nicht so schnell wie deins. (My car is not as fast as yours.)

→ Berlin ist genauso interessant wie München. (Berlin is just as interesting as Munich.)

→ Dieser Film ist besser als der andere. (This film is better than the other.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may:

■ 1. Use 'wie' instead of 'als' after comparatives (influenced by Italian 'come' which serves both functions)

■ 2. Add 'più' (more) before adjectives instead of using -er suffix (Italian: 'più grande di')

3. Confuse 'di' and 'che' (Italian than) with German 'als'

4. Omit 'nicht' in negative comparisons (Italian uses 'meno...di' for inferiority)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Common error to avoid: 'besser wie' instead of 'besser als' (regional dialect, considered non-standard). 'wie' with comparative is marked as 'Regionalismus' (regionalism) by Duden and should be avoided in standard German. Some fixed expressions may vary regionally.

Comparatives with 'als'

To compare two things where one has more of a quality, use the comparative form + 'als' (than). The comparative is formed by adding -er to the adjective stem. For example: 'Der ICE ist teurer als der Regionalzug' (The ICE is more expensive than the regional train). This structure is parallel to English 'adjective-er than'.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: Adjective stem + -er + als + comparison element (noun/pronoun in same case). Monosyllabic adjectives with a, o, u often add umlaut: alt→älter, groß→größer, lang→länger. Adjectives ending in -el drop the e: dunkel→dunkler. Adjectives ending in -er with a vowel before may drop the e: teuer→teurer. Irregular forms: gut→besser, viel→mehr, gern→lieber, hoch→höher, nah→näher.

Full Conjugation Table (example: groß/big):

Positive: groß	Comparative: größer	Superlative: am größten
Positive: teuer	Comparative: teurer	Superlative: am teuersten
Positive: gut	Comparative: besser	Superlative: am besten
Positive: viel	Comparative: mehr	Superlative: am meisten
Positive: gern	Comparative: lieber	Superlative: am liebsten
Positive: hoch	Comparative: höher	Superlative: am höchsten
Positive: nah	Comparative: näher	Superlative: am nächsten

EXAMPLES

- *Der ICE ist teurer als der Regionalzug. (The ICE is more expensive than the regional train.)*
- *Alexander ist 13 Zentimeter größer als Leon. (Alexander is 13 centimeters taller than Leon.)*
- *Mein Auto ist schneller als dein Auto. (My car is faster than your car.)*
- *Berlin ist größer als München. (Berlin is bigger than Munich.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use 'wie' instead of 'als' because Italian uses 'di' or 'che' for both equal and unequal comparisons, while German distinguishes between them. Error: 'größer wie' instead of 'größer als'. Italian uses 'più + adjective + di/che' structure, leading learners to confuse comparison particles. Romance language interference causes difficulty distinguishing when to use 'als' vs 'wie' since Italian doesn't make this grammatical distinction. Native German speakers also make this error dialectally (especially in southern regions), but it is considered non-standard.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

The adjective 'hoch' drops the c in the comparative: höher (not hoher). When comparative adjectives precede nouns, they must take appropriate adjective endings according to case, gender, and number: 'ein größerer Mann' (nominative masculine with indefinite article).

Coordinating Conjunctions without Inversion

Conjunctions und, aber, oder, denn, sondern connect clauses without changing word order

COMPLETE RULE

These conjunctions (und=and, aber=but, oder=or, denn=because, sondern=but rather) don't affect word order. The verb stays in second position in both clauses

EXAMPLES

- *Ich lerne Deutsch und ich koche gerne*
- *Ich kann nicht, denn ich muss arbeiten*
- *Ich mag Tee, aber ich trinke lieber Kaffee*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Inverting subject and verb after these conjunctions

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

None - word order always stays normal

Dative Case - Articles and Pronouns

Dative case is used for indirect objects. All articles change in dative

COMPLETE RULE

Dative articles: der→dem, die→der, das→dem, die(pl)→den. Plural nouns add -n if they don't already end in -n or -s. ein→einem, eine→einer

EXAMPLES

- *Ich gebe dem Mann das Buch (m)*
- *Ich helfe der Frau (f)*
- *mit dem Auto (n)*
- *nach den Ferien (pl)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to add -n to plural nouns in dative

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Nouns ending in -s don't add -n

Double conjunctions: nicht nur...sondern auch (not only...but also)

■ Web verified

nicht nur...sondern auch connects two elements showing addition or expansion. The structure parallels English 'not only...but also'.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE FOR NICHT NUR...SONDERN AUCH:

STRUCTURE: Two-part coordinating conjunction expressing addition/escalation

- First part: NICHT NUR (not only)
- Second part: SONDERN AUCH (but also)

FUNCTION: Cumulative/additive conjunction adding emphasis to second element

WORD ORDER PATTERNS:

Pattern 1: Connecting PARALLEL ELEMENTS (same grammatical function)

- Er spricht nicht nur Französisch, sondern auch Japanisch.
- NICHT NUR + element 1 + SONDERN AUCH + element 2
- Verb position unchanged (main clause structure maintained)

Pattern 2: Connecting CLAUSES

- Ich spreche nicht nur Englisch, sondern auch Italienisch, Französisch und Deutsch.
- Both parts are coordinating conjunctions (position 0)
- Verb remains in position 2 in both clauses

POSITIONAL RULES:

- NICHT NUR: Negation particle + adverb (can occupy position 1 or later)
- SONDERN: Coordinating conjunction (position 0)
- AUCH: Modal particle (emphasizing addition)

VARIATIONS:

- Can connect: nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, clauses
- Must connect PARALLEL structures (same grammatical category)
- SONDERN (without AUCH) possible: 'nicht nur...sondern' (less common)

EMPHASIS: Second element (after SONDERN AUCH) receives stronger emphasis

EXAMPLES

→ *Er spricht nicht nur Französisch, sondern auch Japanisch und Mandarin. (He speaks not only French, but also Japanese and Mandarin.)*

→ *Ich spreche nicht nur Englisch, sondern auch Italienisch, Französisch und Deutsch. (I speak not only English, but also Italian, French, and German.)*

→ *Sie ist nicht nur intelligent, sondern auch sehr fleißig. (She is not only intelligent, but also very hardworking.)*

→ *Wir haben nicht nur gelernt, sondern auch viel Spaß gehabt. (We didn't just learn, but also had a lot of fun.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

COMMON MISTAKES FOR ITALIAN SPEAKERS:

■ **1. WORD ORDER WITH SONDERN:** Italian 'non solo...ma anche' doesn't affect word order. German SONDERN is position 0, but elements after it follow normal word order rules. **WRONG:** 'sondern spreche auch Italienisch'. **CORRECT:** 'sondern (ich) spreche auch Italienisch'.

■ **2. USING 'ABER' INSTEAD OF 'SONDERN':** After negation, German requires SONDERN (not ABER). Italian uses 'ma' for both. **WRONG:** 'nicht nur...aber auch'. **CORRECT:** 'nicht nur...sondern auch'.

3. OMITTING 'AUCH': Italian 'non solo...ma' works without 'anche'. German strongly prefers 'sondern auch'. **INCOMPLETE:** 'nicht nur...sondern'. **BETTER:** 'nicht nur...sondern auch'.

■ **4. PARALLEL STRUCTURE ERRORS:** Connecting non-parallel elements. **WRONG:** 'Er spricht nicht nur gut Französisch, sondern auch Japanisch' (adverb + noun mismatch). **CORRECT:** 'Er spricht nicht nur Französisch gut, sondern auch Japanisch'.

5. COMMA PLACEMENT: Unlike Italian, German requires comma before SONDERN when connecting clauses: 'Ich lerne nicht nur Deutsch, sondern ich spreche auch Italienisch'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND VARIATIONS:

1. SHORTENED FORMS: 'AUCH' can be omitted in formal writing: 'nicht nur...sondern' (though 'auch' is preferred).

2. ALTERNATIVE STRUCTURES:

- 'sowohl...als auch' (both...and): More neutral, no emphasis
- 'nicht nur...sondern darüber hinaus' (furthermore): Adding extra information

3. MULTIPLE ELEMENTS: Can connect more than two items:

'nicht nur A, sondern auch B, C und D'

4. INVERSION POSSIBLE: In formal/literary style:

'Nicht nur spricht er Französisch, sondern auch Japanisch'

(placing 'nicht nur' in position 1 inverts subject-verb)

5. SONDERN without NICHT NUR: 'Sondern' can stand alone after any negation:

'Er lernt nicht Spanisch, sondern Deutsch' (He's not learning Spanish, but German)

6. EMPHATIC VARIANTS: 'nicht nur...sondern sogar' (not only...but even): Even stronger emphasis

Double conjunctions: zwar...aber (although...but still)

■ Web verified

zwar...aber expresses a contrast: although X is true, Y is still the case. The structure is: zwar + clause, aber + clause. In English this is often 'although...still' or 'even though...but'.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE FOR ZWAR...ABER:

STRUCTURE: Two-part compound conjunction connecting main clauses

- First clause contains ZWAR (position 1 or 3 as adverb)
- Second clause contains ABER (position 0 as coordinating conjunction)

FUNCTION: Adversative conjunction (Adversativsatz) expressing contrast/concession

WORD ORDER:

Option 1: ZWAR in position 1 (inverted word order)

- Zwar + VERB + subject + rest, aber + subject + VERB + rest
- Example: Zwar ist es kalt hier, aber wir finden den Schnee schön.

Option 2: ZWAR in position 3 (normal word order)

- Subject + verb + zwar + rest, aber + subject + VERB + rest
- Example: Es ist zwar nicht kalt hier, aber (es ist) recht grau.

POSITIONAL DETAILS:

- ZWAR: Adverb taking syntactic position (1 or 3)
- ABER: Coordinating conjunction (position 0, doesn't affect verb position)
- Verb in BOTH clauses remains in position 2 (normal main clause position)
- Subject can be omitted in second clause if identical

MEANING NUANCES:

- Acknowledges truth of first statement
- Introduces limiting/contrasting information
- English: 'it's true that...but', 'although...nevertheless', 'while...yet'

EXAMPLES

→ Ich komme zwar aus Peru, aber seit zwanzig Jahren wohne ich in Spanien. (I'm from Peru, but I've been living in Spain for twenty years.)

→ Yara kommt zwar aus Spanien, aber ihr Zuhause ist Deutschland. (Yara is from Spain, but her home is Germany.)

→ Ich bin zwar müde, aber ich putze meine Wohnung. (I am tired, but I'm cleaning my apartment.)

→ Zwar ist es kalt hier, aber wir finden den Schnee so schön. (It's true that it's cold here, but we find the snow so beautiful.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

COMMON MISTAKES FOR ITALIAN SPEAKERS:

■ 1. SUBORDINATE CLAUSE ERROR: Italian 'sebbene' requires subjunctive and subordinate word order. Germans may incorrectly treat 'zwar' as subordinating conjunction. **WRONG:** 'Zwar es kalt ist'. **CORRECT:** 'Zwar ist es kalt' (main clause word order).

2. MIXING WITH 'OBWOHL': Italian speakers confuse **zwar...aber** with **obwohl** (although). 'Obwohl' is subordinating (verb to end), 'zwar...aber' uses **TWO** main clauses.

3. OMITTING 'ABER': Italian 'sì...ma' requires both parts. Some speakers use only 'zwar' without 'aber'. **INCOMPLETE:** 'Ich komme zwar aus Peru'. **COMPLETE:** 'Ich komme zwar aus Peru, aber ich wohne in Spanien'.

4. **WRONG POSITION OF ZWAR:** Placing **zwar** only in position 1. While common, position 3 is equally correct and often more natural.

■ 5. VERB POSITION: Keeping verb in position 2 after 'aber' when another element occupies position 1. **WRONG:** 'aber seit zwanzig Jahren ich wohne'. **CORRECT:** 'aber seit zwanzig Jahren wohne ich'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND VARIATIONS:

1. **ABER** can be replaced by **DOCH** (stronger contrast): 'Ich bin zwar müde, doch ich arbeite weiter'.

2. **ZWAR** can stand alone (without **aber**) in informal speech to emphasize concession, though this is incomplete: 'Das ist zwar wahr' (That's true, indeed).

3. **ZWAR...JEDOCH/DENNOCH** (more formal variants): 'Zwar regnet es, dennoch gehen wir spazieren'.

4. **ABER** can be replaced by other adversative conjunctions: **SONDERN** (exclusion), **JEDOCH** (however), **ALLERDINGS** (however).

5. In emphatic speech, **ZWAR** can appear in both clauses: 'Ich bin zwar müde, zwar sehr müde, aber ich arbeite weiter' (rare, emphatic).

6. **ELLIPSIS:** Second subject often omitted when identical: 'Es ist zwar kalt, aber (es ist) schön'.

Equal comparisons with 'so...wie'

■ Web verified

To express equality, use 'so + adjective (base form) + wie' (as...as) or 'genauso + adjective + wie' (just as...as). For negative equality, use 'nicht so + adjective + wie' (not as...as). The adjective remains in its

base form (positive degree), not comparative. For example: 'Leon ist genauso groß wie Robert' (Leon is just as tall as Robert).

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: (genau)so/ebenso + adjective in base form + wie + comparison element. Variations: 'so...wie' (as...as), 'genauso...wie' (just as...as), 'ebenso...wie' (just as...as), 'gleich...wie' (equally...as). Negative: 'nicht so...wie' (not as...as).

Equality Comparison Structures:

Simple equality: so + Adj + wie | Er ist so groß wie ich.

Emphatic equality: genauso + Adj + wie | Er ist genauso groß wie ich.

Formal equality: ebenso + Adj + wie | Er ist ebenso groß wie ich.

Negative inequality: nicht so + Adj + wie | Er ist nicht so groß wie ich.

Approximate equality: ungefähr so + Adj + wie | Er ist ungefähr so groß wie ich.

Perfect equality: gleich + Adj + wie | Sie ist gleich groß wie er.

Note: The adjective NEVER takes comparative form (-er) in equality comparisons.

EXAMPLES

→ Leon ist genauso groß wie Robert. (Leon is just as tall as Robert.)

→ Der Fernbus ist nicht so teuer wie der ICE. (The long-distance bus is not as expensive as the ICE.)

→ Leon verdient nicht so viel wie Elin. (Leon doesn't earn as much as Elin.)

→ Mein Bruder ist so groß wie ich. (My brother is as tall as me.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers use comparative form instead of base form because Italian uses the same structure for both ('così grande come'). They might say 'so größer wie' instead of 'so groß wie'. Major error: using 'als' instead of 'wie' for equality (saying 'so groß als' instead of 'so groß wie') due to Italian using 'come' for both contexts. Italian learners may omit 'so' and say only 'groß wie' instead of 'so groß wie', following Italian pattern where 'così' is optional. Romance language structure confusion: Italian 'tanto...quanto' (as...as) doesn't map directly to German 'so...wie' construction.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In colloquial German, especially southern dialects, 'wie' is sometimes replaced by 'als' in equality comparisons, but this is non-standard: 'so groß als' (dialectal) vs 'so groß wie' (standard). The word order is flexible: 'Er ist genauso groß wie ich' or 'Genauso groß wie ich ist er'. When comparing with pronouns, nominative case is formally correct, though accusative is common colloquially: 'so groß wie ich' (formal) vs 'so groß wie mich' (colloquial).

Indefinite pronouns: jemand/niemand declension

■ Web verified

'Jemand' (somebody/someone) and 'niemand' (nobody/no one) are indefinite pronouns that CAN be declined in accusative and dative, but the endings are optional. Nominative: jemand/niemand; Accusative: jemand(en)/niemand(en); Dative: jemand(em)/niemand(em); Genitive: jemand(e)s/niemand(e)s.

COMPLETE RULE

FULL DECLENSION TABLE:

NOMINATIVE:

jemand / niemand

ACCUSATIVE:

jemanden OR jemand (endungslos preferred in colloquial)

niemanden OR niemand

DATIVE:

jemandem OR jemand

niemandem OR niemand

GENITIVE:

jemandes OR jemand's

niemandes OR niemand's

USAGE NOTES:

- Singular only
- No gender distinction
- Both declined and undeclined forms are correct
- Endungslos (without ending) form often preferred in accusative
- In dative, declined form (jemandem/niemandem) more common
- With 'anders' or substantivized adjectives: endungslos form preferred

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich kenne hier niemanden. (I don't know anyone here.*

accusative)

→ *Ich spreche mit niemandem. (I speak with nobody.*

dative)

→ *Ist da jemand? (Is someone there? - nominative)*

→ *Hast du jemanden gesehen? (Did you see someone? - accusative)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. Always using undeclined form (Italian 'qualcuno/nessuno' don't decline)

2. Trying to use plural forms (Italian: *alcuni/nessuno* → German only singular)
3. Adding gender distinction (Italian: *qualcuno/qualcuna* → German: only *jemand*)
4. Incorrect case: using nominative everywhere (Italian case system simpler)
5. Confusion with 'man' (one/people): *niemand* ≠ *man nicht*
6. Double negation issues: Italian '*non ho visto nessuno*' → German '*Ich habe niemanden gesehen*' (NOT **nicht niemand*)
7. With prepositions: forgetting that preposition governs case: '*mit jemandem*' (dative), '*für jemanden*' (accusative)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS: With 'anders' or substantivized adjectives, *endungslos* form preferred: '*niemand anders*' OR '*niemand anderen*' (both correct, first more common); '*jemand Fremdes*' OR '*jemandem Fremdem*' (both possible). In combination with 'anders': avoid '*niemanden anders*' (less preferred than '*niemand anders*'). Genitive is rare in modern German, often replaced by other constructions.

Personal pronouns in accusative

■ From lesson

Personal pronouns change form in the accusative case when they are direct objects

COMPLETE RULE

Nominative: *ich, du, er, sie, es, wir, ihr, sie, Sie* → Accusative: *mich, dich, ihn, sie, es, uns, euch, sie, Sie*

EXAMPLES

- *ich*→*mich*: *Du triffst mich*
- *du*→*dich*: *Ich treffe dich*
- *er*→*ihn*: *Ich muss ihn anrufen*
- *sie*→*sie*: *Ich kenne sie*
- *es*→*es*: *Ich mag es sehr*
- *wir*→*uns*: *Wir treffen uns*
- *ihr*→*euch*: *Ich sehe euch*
- *sie/Sie*→*sie/Sie*: *Ich besuche sie*

Position vs. Platz

■ Web verified

'Platz' refers to a place, space, seat, or rank in a competition/ranking (similar to Italian '*posto*'). 'Position' refers to a physical location, a job position, or an opinion/stance on an issue (similar to Italian '*posizione*').

COMPLETE RULE

PLATZ uses:

1. Physical space/room: *Hier ist kein Platz.* (There's no room here.)
2. Seat: *Ist dieser Platz frei?* (Is this seat free?)
3. Square/plaza: *der Marktplatz* (the market square)
4. Rank in competition/sport: *den ersten Platz belegen* (to take first place)
5. Position in ranking: *auf Platz drei kommen* (to come in third place)

POSITION uses:

1. Physical location/stance: *die Position des Gebäudes* (the position of the building)
2. Job/role: *eine hohe Position in der Firma* (a high position in the company)
3. Opinion/standpoint: *eine Position zu einem Thema beziehen* (to take a position on a topic)
4. Military/strategic placement: *Position einnehmen* (to take up position)
5. Sports positioning (but not ranking): *Spielposition* (playing position)

Key distinction: Use 'Platz' for rankings/competition results; use 'Position' for opinions, job roles, or physical locations.

EXAMPLES

- *Er hat den ersten Platz im Rennen belegt.* (He took first place in the race.)
- *Ich habe eine klare Position zu diesem Thema.* (I have a clear position on this topic.)
- *Nehmen Sie bitte Platz!* (Please take a seat!)
- *Die Position des Spielers auf dem Feld ist wichtig.* (The player's position on the field is important.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use 'Position' when talking about competition rankings because of the similarity to 'posizione', but German requires 'Platz' in these contexts. Saying 'Ich habe die erste Position gemacht' instead of 'Ich habe den ersten Platz gemacht' sounds unnatural.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In team sports, 'Position' can refer to a player's role/function (e.g., 'Torwart-Position' = goalkeeper position), but final standings/rankings always use 'Platz' (e.g., 'auf dem dritten Platz' = in third place).

Possessive articles (Possessivartikel)

■ From lesson

Possessive articles (mein, dein, sein, ihr, unser, euer, ihr) decline like 'kein' and change based on gender and case of the possessed object

COMPLETE RULE

mein/dein/sein/ihr decline like *ein/kein*. Use *sein* for masculine/neuter possessor, *ihr* for feminine possessor

EXAMPLES

- *Wie heißt seine Tochter?* - *What is his daughter called?*
- *Wie heißt ihr Vater?* - *What is her father called?*
- *mein Handy (n), meine Freundin (f), mein Kind (n), meine Eltern (pl)*
- *Ich vergesse meinen Termin (m) beim Arzt*

Reflexive pronouns with body parts use dative

■ Web verified

When washing body parts, German uses dative reflexive pronouns because the body part is the direct object (accusative). You cannot have two accusatives in one sentence, so the reflexive pronoun becomes dative. Example: 'Ich wasche mir die Hände' (I wash my hands to myself) - 'mir' is dative, 'die Hände' is accusative.

COMPLETE RULE

Reflexive Pronoun Table:

ACCUSATIVE: *mich, dich, sich, uns, euch, sich*

DATIVE: *mir, dir, sich, uns, euch, sich*

Rule: Normally reflexive pronouns are accusative. However, when the verb already has an accusative object (typically body parts or clothing), the reflexive pronoun becomes dative. Only *ich*-form and *du*-form change: *mich*→*mir*, *dich*→*dir*. All other forms (*uns, euch, sich*) remain identical in both cases.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich wasche mir die Hände.* (I wash my hands
'mir' dative, 'die Hände' accusative)
- *Du putzt dir die Zähne.* (You brush your teeth
'dir' dative, 'die Zähne' accusative)
- *Sie kämmt sich die Haare.* (She combs her hair
'sich' stays same, 'die Haare' accusative)
- *Er zieht sich die Jacke an.* (He puts on his jacket
'sich' dative, 'die Jacke' accusative)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often use accusative 'mich' instead of dative 'mir' with body parts because Italian uses possessive adjectives (mi lavo le mani uses 'mi' which looks similar). German requires: definite article + dative reflexive (die Hände + mir), NOT possessive pronoun. Also forgetting that euch/uns/sich don't change between accusative and dative.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Simple reflexive verbs without body parts use accusative: 'Ich dusche mich' (I shower myself - only one object). 'Ich wasche mich' (I wash myself completely) uses accusative, but 'Ich wasche mir die Hände' (I wash my hands) uses dative because hands are the accusative object.

Relative pronoun 'was' with alles/nichts/etwas

■ Web verified

Indefinite antecedents (alles, nichts, etwas, vieles, manches, wenig) and neuter demonstrative pronouns (das, dasselbe, dasjenige) require the relative pronoun 'was' instead of der/die/das. 'Was' is also used after neuter superlatives and when referring to entire clauses. It is invariable and does not decline.

COMPLETE RULE

Use 'was' (not der/die/das) after:

1. Indefinite pronouns: *alles, nichts, etwas, vieles, manches, wenig, einiges*
2. Neuter demonstrative pronouns: *das, dasselbe, dasjenige*
3. Neuter superlatives: *das Beste, das Schönste, das Wichtigste*
4. Entire clauses/sentences

'Was' is invariable - it does not change form for case. When a preposition is needed, use *wo(r)+preposition* (*worüber, wofür*, etc.).

Standard relative pronouns (*der/die/das*) are used for specific nouns with defined gender/number.

EXAMPLES

- *Das ist alles, was ich sagen wollte.* (That is all that I wanted to say.)
- *Es gibt nichts, was wir nicht lösen könnten.* (There is nothing that we couldn't solve.)
- *Das Beste, was mir passiert ist, war der Urlaub.* (The best thing that happened to me was the vacation.)
- *Er hat die Prüfung bestanden, was mich sehr gefreut hat.* (He passed the exam, which made me very happy.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often incorrectly use 'che' (that) equivalents like 'der/die/das' with indefinite pronouns, translating directly from Italian constructions like 'tutto quello che' (all that which). They may write 'alles, das ich sagen wollte' instead of 'alles, was ich sagen wollte'. Italian does not distinguish

between defined and undefined antecedents in the same way, so learners must memorize which antecedents trigger 'was'. They may also forget that 'was' never changes form (no declension), unlike Italian 'che' which can combine with articles.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When referring to entire clauses or sentences (rather than specific nouns), 'was' must be used. After neuter superlatives (das Beste, das Schönste), always use 'was', never 'das'. In prepositional constructions, 'was' cannot be used directly with prepositions; instead use 'wo(r)+ preposition': worüber, wofür, womit, etc. The pronoun 'was' is never used in the genitive case.

wer vs. der in questions

■ Web verified

'Wer' is the interrogative pronoun meaning 'who' and is used in direct and indirect questions about unknown persons. When asking 'which one?' among known options, German uses the definite article (der/die/das) as a demonstrative pronoun, not 'wer'. This demonstrative use is similar to Italian 'quale'.

COMPLETE RULE

Complete paradigm:

INTERROGATIVE 'WER' (who?):

Nominative: *wer* (who)

Accusative: *wen* (whom)

Dative: *wem* (to whom)

Genitive: *wessen* (whose)

Used for: Unknown persons in questions

DEMONSTRATIVE ARTICLE AS PRONOUN (which one?):

MASCULINE: *der* (nominative), *den* (accusative), *dem* (dative), *dessen* (genitive)

FEMININE: *die* (nominative), *die* (accusative), *der* (dative), *deren* (genitive)

NEUTER: *das* (nominative), *das* (accusative), *dem* (dative), *dessen* (genitive)

PLURAL: *die* (nominative), *die* (accusative), *denen* (dative), *deren* (genitive)

When emphasized in speech, *der/die/das* function as demonstratives meaning 'that one' or 'the one', similar to asking 'which one?' This is particularly common in spoken German.

EXAMPLES

→ *Wer hat die Tür geöffnet?* (Who opened the door? - unknown person)

→ *Ich weiß nicht, wer das gemacht hat.* (I don't know who did that.
indirect question)

→ *Welcher Hund gehört dir? Der kleine oder der große? — Der kleine. (Which dog is yours? The small one or the big one? — The small one.)*

→ **Die kenne ich nicht. (I don't know her/that one.**

demonstrative use)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may confuse the usage because Italian 'chi' (who) and 'quale' (which one) are more clearly distinguished, leading them to overuse 'wer' or create awkward constructions when they should use the demonstrative article.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

For 'which one' questions where you want to specify among options, 'welcher/welche/welches' can also be used and is more explicit than the demonstrative article, though both are correct. Example: 'Welcher ist deiner?' vs 'Der ist meiner' (Which one is yours? That one is mine).

ändern vs. wechseln

■ Web verified

ändern = to change/alter/modify something (general modification, same object stays); wechseln = to change/switch/exchange something for another (replacement, different object). Example: 'Ich ändere die Tür' (I modify the door) vs. 'Ich wechsele die Tür' (I replace the door). Related: Wechselstube = currency exchange office.

COMPLETE RULE

ÄNDERN (regular verb, transitive): Present: *ich ändere, duänderst, er/sie/es ändert, wir ändern, ihr ändert, sie/Sie ändern*. Simple Past: *ich änderte, du ändertest, er/sie/es änderte, wir änderten, ihr ändertet, sie/Sie änderten*. Perfect: *ich habe geändert, du hast geändert, etc.* Participle II: *geändert*. Auxiliary: *haben*. Reflexive: *sich ändern* (to change oneself, one's character/personality). **WECHSELN** (regular verb, transitive): Present: *ich wechsele/wechsele, du wechselst, er/sie/es wechselt, wir wechseln, ihr wechselt, sie/Sie wechseln*. Simple Past: *ich wechselte, du wechseltest, er/sie/es wechselte, wir wechselten, ihr wechseltet, sie/Sie wechselten*. Perfect: *ich habe gewechselt, du hast gewechselt, etc.* Participle II: *gewechselt*. Auxiliary: *haben*. **MEANING:** *ändern = modify/alter (same thing, different properties); wechseln = exchange/switch/replace (different thing).*

EXAMPLES

→ **Ich sollte meine Handyfirma wechseln. (I should switch my phone company**

different provider)

→ **Ich möchte etwas ändern. (I want to change/modify something**

alter it)

→ **Kannst du 50 Euro wechseln? (Can you exchange 50 euros? - into smaller bills)**

→ *Er hat sich geändert. (He has changed*

his personality/behavior)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers confuse these because Italian uses 'cambiare' for both concepts. Common errors: (1) Using ändern for replacement: *'Ich ändere meine Handyfirma' instead of 'Ich wechsele meine Handyfirma' (I switch phone companies). (2) Using wechseln for modification: *'Ich wechsle meine Meinung' instead of 'Ich ändere meine Meinung' (I change my opinion). (3) With clothing: Geld wechseln (exchange money), but Kleidung wechseln (change clothes - replacement) vs. Kleidung ändern (alter clothes - tailoring). (4) Personal change: sich ändern (change one's character) vs. sich verändern (change one's life situation).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Some fixed expressions: Geld wechseln (exchange money/currency), die Wäsche wechseln (change laundry/linens), das Thema wechseln (change the subject - switch to different topic), den Job wechseln (change jobs - get a new one). But: seine Meinung ändern (change one's opinion - modify it), seinen Plan ändern (change one's plan - alter it). With 'sich': sich ändern (personality change), sich verändern (life situation change - more comprehensive). Verändern is more dramatic/comprehensive change than ändern.

Bestimmter Artikel im Nominativ und Akkusativ

■ From lesson

Definite articles in Nominative and Accusative case change by gender. Only masculine changes from 'der' to 'den' in Accusative.

COMPLETE RULE

Nominativ: Maskulinum=der, Neutrum=das, Femininum=die, Plural=die | Akkusativ: Maskulinum=den, Neutrum=das, Femininum=die, Plural=die

EXAMPLES

- *der Computer (Nominativ)*
- *den Computer (Akkusativ)*
- *das Telefon (both cases)*
- *die Kamera (both cases)*
- *die Kassetten (both cases)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to change 'der' to 'den' in Accusative for masculine nouns

Unbestimmter Artikel und Negativartikel im Nominativ und Akkusativ

■ From lesson

Indefinite articles (ein/eine) and negative articles (kein/keine) in Nominative and Accusative case. Masculine changes from 'ein' to 'einen' in Accusative.

COMPLETE RULE

Nominativ: Maskulinum=ein/kein, Neutrum=ein/kein, Femininum=eine/keine, Plural=ø/keine | Akkusativ: Maskulinum=einen/keinen, Neutrum=ein/kein, Femininum=eine/keine, Plural=ø/keine

EXAMPLES

- *ein Computer (Nominativ)*
- *einen Computer (Akkusativ)*

- *kein Telefon (both cases)*
- *keine Kamera (both cases)*
- *keine Kassetten (both cases)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting the -en ending for masculine Accusative (einen/keinen)

Possessivartikel im Nominativ

■ From lesson

Possessive articles in Nominative case. They decline like the indefinite article (ein/eine) and show gender agreement with the possessed noun.

COMPLETE RULE

ich=mein/mein/meine/meine | du=dein/dein/deine/deine | er+es=sie=sein/ihr |
sein/sein/seine/seine | ihr=sein/ihr | wir=unser/unser/unsere/unsere |
ihr=euer/euer/eure/eure | sie/Sie=ihr/Ihr | ihr/ihr/ihre/ihre | Ihr/Ihr/Ihre/Ihre.
Note: Nullartikel (ø) for unbestimmter Artikel plural, ending 'Söhne, Töchter, Kinder'

EXAMPLES

- *mein Sohn (ich, M)*
- *dein Kind (du, N)*
- *seine Tochter (er, F)*
- *ihre Kinder (sie, Plural)*
- *unser Computer*
- *eure Kamera*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'sein' (his/its) with 'ihr' (her); forgetting plural -e ending

Lokale Angaben - Richtungsangaben + Akkusativ

■ From lesson

Directional phrases with accusative case - indicating movement towards a destination

COMPLETE RULE

durch (den/das/die) + Akkusativ = through | um (den/das/die) ... (herum) + Akkusativ = around

EXAMPLES

- *durch den Park*
- *durch das Einkaufszentrum*
- *durch die Stadt*
- *um den Haupteingang*
- *um das Haus*
- *um die Ecke herum*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing accusative case endings with directional movement

Lokale Angaben - Richtungsangaben + Dativ

■ From lesson

Directional phrases with dative case - indicating movement from/to locations

COMPLETE RULE

von + Dativ = from | von (← von dem) = from the (m/n) | von der = from the (f) | zu + Dativ = to | zum (← zu dem) = to the (m/n) | zur (← zu der) = to the (f) | von - (bis) zu = from - (up to) to | bei + Dativ = at, near | beim (← bei dem) = at the (m/n) | bei der = at the (f)

EXAMPLES

- *vom Bahnhof*
- *von der Zytglogge*
- *zum Park*
- *zur Zytglogge*
- *vom Münster (bis) zum Bahnhof*
- *von der Postgasse (bis) zur Kramgasse*
- *beim Bahnhof*
- *bei der Zytglogge*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting contracted forms (vom, zum, zur, beim)

Lokale Angaben + Akkusativ oder Dativ

■ From lesson

Local phrases with accusative or dative - choosing case based on whether asking 'where to?' (accusative) or 'where?' (dative)

COMPLETE RULE

in - wohin? (Akkusativ) = where to? | in den, ins (← in das), in die | in - wo? (Dativ) = where? | im (← in dem), im, in der | Note: 'in' is a Wechselpräposition (two-way preposition). Wohin? = 'in' + Akkusativ (ins Haus). Wo? = 'in' + Dativ (im Haus)

EXAMPLES

- *wohin? in den Park (Akkusativ)*
- *wohin? ins Haus (Akkusativ)*
- *wohin? in die Kramgasse (Akkusativ)*
- *wo? im Bärenpark (Dativ)*
- *wo? im Haus (Dativ)*
- *wo? in der Schweiz (Dativ)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using wrong case - remember: movement/direction = accusative, location = dative

Adjektive nach dem bestimmten Artikel

■ From lesson

Adjective endings after the definite article change according to case, gender, and number.

COMPLETE RULE

Nominativ: M=der lebendige Dialekt, N=das neue Leben, F=die lange Tradition, Plural=die alten Lieder.

Akkusativ: M=den lebendigen Dialekt, N=das neue Leben, F=die lange Tradition, Plural=die alten Lieder.

Dativ: M=dem lebendigen Dialekt, N=dem neuen Leben, F=der langen Tradition, Plural=den alten Liedern.

EXAMPLES

- *der lebendige Dialekt (Nom. M)*
- *das neue Leben (Nom./Akk. N)*
- *die lange Tradition (Nom./Akk. F)*
- *die alten Lieder (Nom./Akk. Plural)*
- *den lebendigen Dialekt (Akk. M)*

- *dem lebendigen Dialekt (Dat. M)*
- *dem neuen Leben (Dat. N)*
- *der langen Tradition (Dat. F)*
- *den alten Liedern (Dat. Plural)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to add adjective endings or using wrong endings after definite articles

Frageartikel und -pronomen **welch-** und Demonstrativartikel und -pronomen **dies-, der/das/die**

■ From lesson

welch- asks about things and people. **dies-** and **der/das/die** point to things and people. They decline according to case, gender, and number.

COMPLETE RULE

welch- asks about things and people. *dies-* and *der/das/die* point to things and people. Nominative: M=Welcher/Welches/Welche/Welche → *dieser/der, dieses/das, diese/die, diese/die*. Akkusative: M=Welchen/Welches/Welche/Welche → *diesen/den, dieses/das, diese/die, diese/die*. Dative: M=Zu welchem/Zu welchem/Zu welcher/Zu welchen/welchen → *zu diesem/dem, zu diesem/dem, zu dieser/der, zu diesen/denen/den*

EXAMPLES

- *Welchen Pullover findest du besser? → Diesen/Den hier.*
- *Zu welcher Bluse passt der Rock? → Zu dieser/der gestreiften.*
- *Schau mal, die Kleider. Welches gefällt dir am besten? → Dieses/Das da.*
- *Und da die Hosen. Welche ist schicker? → Diese/Die schwarze.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing demonstrative pronouns with articles; forgetting case endings

Indefinitpronomen und Indefinitartikel **jed-, kein-, all-, viel-, wenig-**

■ From lesson

Indefinite pronouns and articles express quantity or absence. **jed-** (every/each), **kein-** (no/none), **all-** (all), **viel-** (many/much), **wenig-** (few/little). They decline according to case, gender, and number.

COMPLETE RULE

Nominative: M=jeder/(k)ein Mann/(k)einer, N=jedes/(k)ein Fest/(k)eins, F=jede/(k)eine,
Plural=alle/viele/wenige. Akkusative: M=jeden/(k)einen, N=jedes/(k)ein Fest/(k)eins, F=jede/(k)eine,
Plural=alle/viele/wenige. Dative: M=jedem/(k)einem, N=jedem/(k)einem, F=jeder/(k)einer,
Plural=allen/vielen/wenigen

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing jeder (every) with jemand (someone); forgetting endings in dative plural

Possessivpronomen

■ From lesson

Possessive pronouns in German decline according to case, gender and number

COMPLETE RULE

Maskulinum: Nom=der→meiner, Akk=den→meinen, Dat=dem→meinem. Neutrum: Nom=das→meins,
Akk=das→meins, Dat=dem→meinem. Femininum: Nom=die→meine, Akk=die→meine, Dat=der→meiner.
Plural: Nom=die→meine, Akk=die→meine, Dat=den→meinen

EXAMPLES

- Ist das dein Kaffee? - Ja, das ist meiner.
- Ist das deine Wohnung? - Ja, das ist meine.
- Sind das deine Schlüssel? - Ja, das sind meine.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Don't confuse possessive articles (mein, dein) with possessive pronouns (meiner, deiner)

Adjektive vor Nomen ohne Artikel im Genitiv

■ From lesson

Adjectives before nouns without articles in the genitive case take specific endings depending on gender and number

COMPLETE RULE

Maskulinum: der Genuss frischen Fisches | Neutrum: ein Beispiel erfolgreichen Engagements | Femininum: Fisch bester Qualität | Plural (M, N, F): ein Fotomotiv begeisterter Besucher

EXAMPLES

- *der Genuss frischen Fisches*
- *ein Beispiel erfolgreichen Engagements*
- *Fisch bester Qualität*
- *ein Fotomotiv begeisterter Besucher*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Forgetting to add the genitive ending to adjectives when no article is present

Unbestimmte Anzahl / Menge - Indefinitpronomen und -artikel manch-, einig-

■ From lesson

The indefinite pronouns and articles 'manch-' (some, many a) and 'einig-' (some, several) indicate an indefinite quantity. They decline like definite articles when used as articles, and their endings match the case and gender of the noun they accompany.

COMPLETE RULE

Nominativ: M=mancher/manches/einiges, N=manches/einiges, F=manche, Plural=manche/einige.
Akkusativ: M=manchen, N=manches/einiges, F=manche, Plural=manche/einige. Dativ: M=manchem, N=manchem/einigem, F=mancher, Plural=manchen/einigen. Genitiv: M=manches, N=manches/einiges, F=mancher, Plural=mancher/einiger.

EXAMPLES

- *Mancher Student hat Probleme mit der Grammatik.*
- *Ich habe manches Buch gelesen.*
- *Manche Leute verstehen das nicht.*
- *Einiges ist noch unklar.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing the endings with adjective endings or not declining them at all

Accusative Case - Adjective Endings

■ From lesson

Adjectives before nouns take endings that depend on gender, case, and article type

COMPLETE RULE

With indefinite articles in accusative: masculine -en, neuter -es, feminine -e, plural -e. Der Bayer trägt einen grünen Hut

EXAMPLES

- einen großen Bruder (m)
- ein neues Handy (n)
- eine kleine Schwester (f)
- keine alten Autos (pl)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using wrong endings or no endings at all

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Endings change with different article types (definite, indefinite, no article)

Adjective declension in accusative

■ From lesson

Adjectives before nouns take specific endings depending on gender, case, and article type. In accusative with indefinite article: -en (m), -e (f), -es (n), -e (pl)

COMPLETE RULE

Accusative with indefinite article: masculine=-en, feminine=-e, neuter=-es, plural=-e

EXAMPLES

- Er trägt einen grünen Hut (m)
- Ich kaufe neue Schuhe (pl)
- Ich brauche ein neues Handy (n)
- Er hat eine kleine Schwester (f)
- Ich lese ein interessantes Buch (n)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Endings change with definite articles and no articles

Adjective declension in accusative with indefinite article

Adjectives following indefinite articles (ein/eine/einen) in accusative case take specific endings based on gender: masculine takes -en, feminine takes -e, neuter takes -es. This is called 'mixed declension' because it combines aspects of weak and strong declension patterns.

COMPLETE RULE

Mixed declension with indefinite article - Accusative case:

Masculine: einen + adjective + -en + noun

Example: einen besseren Preis (a better price)

Feminine: eine + adjective + -e + noun

Example: eine bessere Antwort (a better answer)

Neuter: ein + adjective + -es + noun

Example: ein besseres Auto (a better car)

Plural: keine/meine etc. + adjective + -en + noun

Example: keine besseren Preise (no better prices)

Complete mixed declension table (indefinite article + adjective):

MASCULINE FEMININE NEUTER PLURAL

NOM: ein gut-er eine gut-e ein gut-es (keine) gut-en

ACC: einen gut-en eine gut-e ein gut-es (keine) gut-en

DAT: einem gut-en einer gut-en einem gut-en (keinen) gut-en

GEN: eines gut-en einer gut-en eines gut-en (keiner) gut-en

Same pattern applies to: kein-, mein-, dein-, sein-, ihr-, unser-, euer-, Ihr-

Reason: The indefinite article 'ein' has no ending in nominative masculine/neuter and accusative neuter, so the adjective takes the strong ending (-er, -es) to show case/gender. When 'ein' has an ending (einen, einem, eines), the adjective takes weak ending (-en).

EXAMPLES

→ **Er könnte einen besseren Preis machen.** (He could make a better price.

masculine accusative)

→ **Ich suche ein besseres Auto.** (I'm looking for a better car. - neuter accusative)

→ **Sie gibt mir eine bessere Antwort.** (She gives me a better answer.

feminine accusative)

→ **Wir brauchen keine neuen Stühle.** (We don't need any new chairs.

plural accusative)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers commonly make these errors:

- 1. Using wrong accusative ending: *'einen besserer Preis' or *'einen besser Preis' instead of 'einen besseren Preis' - Italian adjectives don't decline for case, only number and gender
- 2. Forgetting that masculine accusative differs from nominative: nominative 'ein guter Mann' but accusative 'einen guten Mann' - Italian shows this only in the article (un/uno), not the adjective
- 3. Overgeneralizing one ending to all genders: using -en for all genders in accusative
- 4. Mixing up weak and strong declension: Italian doesn't have this distinction
- 5. Not recognizing that feminine and neuter accusative look like nominative (both -e and -es respectively)
- 6. Adding extra endings: *'einen besseren großen Preis' when both adjectives should take -en
- 7. Italian adjectives typically follow nouns ('un prezzo migliore'), while German adjectives precede nouns, affecting their endings

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When no article precedes the adjective (strong declension), endings differ: accusative masculine takes -en, feminine -e, neuter -es (guten Wein, kalte Milch, frisches Brot). When a definite article precedes (weak declension), all accusative take -en except feminine and neuter which take -e: den guten Wein, die kalte Milch, das frische Brot. Multiple adjectives in succession all take the same ending: 'einen großen, schönen Garten' (a big, beautiful garden).

Adjective endings in dative plural

■ Web verified

In dative plural, adjectives take the '-en' ending regardless of gender. The definite article is 'den' and plural nouns that don't already end in -n or -s add -n in the dative case.

COMPLETE RULE

Dative Plural Pattern:

With definite article: *den + adjective-en + noun-(e)n*

With indefinite/possessive: *(no plural indefinite article) / possessive article + adjective-en + noun-(e)n*

Without article: *adjective-en + noun-(e)n*

Examples:

- mit den gelben Streifen (with the yellow stripes)

- mit meinen kleinen Kindern (with my small children)

- mit guten Freunden (with good friends)

Noun plural ending: Add -n to plural nouns in dative unless they already end in -n or -s.

EXAMPLES

- *Ich spiele mit den kleinen Kindern.*
- *Er hilft den älteren Menschen.*
- *Sie spricht mit ihren besten Freunden.*
- *Wir danken allen fleißigen Studenten.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may forget the adjective ending entirely since Italian adjectives following the noun only change for number and gender, not case. They may confuse the dative plural article 'den' with the accusative masculine 'den'. Italian speakers may also forget to add -n to the plural noun itself in dative case, as Italian has no case system for nouns. The double -en pattern (article marker + adjective ending) doesn't exist in Italian.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Nouns that already end in -n or -s in the plural do not add an additional -n (e.g., 'mit den Katzen', 'mit den Hotels'). Foreign loanwords ending in -s keep this ending.

fragen nach vs. fragen um

■ Web verified

CORRECTION: 'fragen um' is NOT standard German. Use 'fragen nach' (+ Dativ) when asking ABOUT information ('nach dem Weg fragen' = ask about directions). For requests (asking FOR something), use 'bitten um' (+ Akkusativ): 'um einen Teller bitten' = ask for a plate. 'Fragen' takes Akkusativ for the person and 'nach + Dativ' for the topic.

COMPLETE RULE

fragen + Akkusativ (person) + nach + Dativ (information/topic). For requests: bitten + Akkusativ (person) + um + Akkusativ (thing requested). Examples: 'Ich frage dich' (Akk.), 'Ich frage nach dem Weg' (Dativ), 'Ich bitte dich um Hilfe' (both Akk.)

EXAMPLES

- *Ich frage den Kellner nach einer Empfehlung. (I ask the waiter about a recommendation.)*
- *Er fragt mich nach der Uhrzeit. (He asks me about the time.)*
- *Ich bitte dich um Hilfe. (I ask you for help.)*
- *Sie bittet den Lehrer um einen Teller. (She asks the teacher for a plate.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may confuse 'fragen nach' with 'bitten um' - remember: fragen = ask questions (information), bitten = ask for/request (things/actions). Do NOT use 'fragen um' - this is not correct German. Using 'fragen' for requests instead of 'bitten'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Fragen can take two Akkusativ objects in abstract contexts: 'Ich frage dich etwas' (I ask you something). This is rare - only a handful of German verbs (kosten, lehren, nennen) have double Akkusativ.

Genitive in Fixed Expressions

■ Web verified

The Genitive case appears in certain fixed expressions, especially with 'der Welt' (of the world). Formation: die Welt (nom.) → der Welt (gen.). Example: 'Der Elefant ist das größte Tier der Welt' (The elephant is the biggest animal in the world). With proper names, add -s without apostrophe: 'Das ist Kevins Haus' (NOT Kevin's Haus).

COMPLETE RULE

Genitive case is used less in spoken German but remains important in formal/written language and fixed expressions. Common genitive expressions: 'der Welt' (in the world), 'des Jahres' (of the year), 'eines Tages' (one day/someday), 'meines Wissens' (to my knowledge), 'des Lebens' (of life). Genitive article changes: Masculine/Neuter: der/das → des (+ noun adds -(e)s: des Mannes, des Kindes). Feminine: die → der (no noun ending change: der Frau). Plural: die → der (der Tiere). Proper names: Add -s directly without apostrophe: Kevins Haus, Annas Buch, Deutschlands Küche. If name ends in -s, -ß, -x, -z, use only apostrophe: Max' Auto, Felix' Fahrrad. Structure with superlatives: article + superlative + noun + der/des + genitive noun: 'Der höchste Berg der Welt', 'Das beste Buch des Jahres', 'Die schönste Stadt der Region'.

EXAMPLES

- Der Elefant ist das größte Tier der Welt. (The elephant is the biggest animal in the world.)
- Das ist Kevins Haus. (That is Kevin's house.)
- Das ist das Haus der Mutter. (That is the mother's house.)
- Der höchste Berg der Welt ist der Mount Everest. (The highest mountain in the world is Mount Everest.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may add apostrophe-s like in English. WRONG: 'Kevin's Haus', 'Anna's Buch'. CORRECT: 'Kevins Haus', 'Annas Buch' (no apostrophe with German names unless name ends in -s/-ß/-x/-z). Using wrong genitive article: WRONG: 'das größte Tier die Welt'. CORRECT: 'das größte Tier der Welt' (feminine 'Welt' requires 'der' in genitive). In colloquial speech, genitive is often replaced by 'von + Dative', but this should be avoided in formal writing: COLLOQUIAL: 'das größte Tier von der Welt'. FORMAL/CORRECT: 'das größte Tier der Welt'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Country names as proper nouns use genitive without article: 'Deutschlands Hauptstadt' (NOT 'der Deutschlands'), 'Frankreichs Küche'. Some genitive prepositions: wegen (because of), trotz (despite), während (during), statt (instead of) - though in spoken German these increasingly take dative. Fixed time expressions: 'eines Tages' (one day), 'eines Morgens' (one morning), 'eines Abends' (one evening). Genitive is declining in spoken German and often replaced by 'von + Dative' construction, especially in Southern German dialects.

Genitive vs. von structure

■ Web verified

German expresses possession using either the genitive case (einige der Leute, das Haus des Mannes) or the 'von + dative' construction (einige von den Leuten, das Haus von dem Mann). Genitive is formal and preferred in written German; 'von + dative' is more common in spoken German and considered standard in colloquial contexts. Both are grammatically correct.

COMPLETE RULE

Genitive Possession:

Article forms: *des (masc/neut), der (fem/plural)*

Nouns add -s or -es: *des Mannes, der Frau, der Kinder*

Example: *Das Auto des Lehrers (the teacher's car)*

von + Dative Construction:

Use 'von' + dative article: *von dem/der/den*

Example: *Das Auto von dem Lehrer (the car of the teacher)*

When to use each:

- WRITTEN/FORMAL: Prefer genitive
- SPOKEN/INFORMAL: Prefer von + dative
- WITH NAMES: Both acceptable (*Annas Buch / das Buch von Anna*)
- AFTER INDEFINITE QUANTIFIERS: Both acceptable (*einige der Leute / einige von den Leuten*)
- A2-B1 level: Both forms are acceptable and should be learned

Genitive articles: *des (m/n), der (f/pl)*

Dative articles after von: *dem (m/n), der (f), den (pl)*

EXAMPLES

→ *Einige von den Leuten sind zu spät gekommen. (Some of the people came too late.) [von + dative, spoken]*

→ *Einige der Leute sind zu spät gekommen. (Some of the people came too late.) [genitive, written]*

→ *Das Haus meines Vaters ist groß. (My father's house is big.) [genitive, formal]*

→ *Das Haus von meinem Vater ist groß. (The house of my father is big.) [von + dative, colloquial]*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers tend to overuse the 'von + dative' structure because it mirrors Italian 'di + article' constructions (il libro del professore / il libro di Pietro). They may avoid genitive entirely as Italian lacks this case. When attempting genitive, Italians often forget to add -s/-es endings to masculine and neuter nouns (saying 'des Mann' instead of 'des Mannes'). They may confuse genitive and dative articles since both use 'der' for feminine nouns. Italian speakers might use genitive in casual speech where native Germans would use 'von', sounding overly formal. With names, they may incorrectly add articles (saying 'das Buch des Peter' instead of 'Peters Buch').

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

With proper names not ending in s-sounds: use -s without article (Peters Auto, Annas Buch). Names ending in s-sounds use apostrophe only (Fritz' Haus). Genitive is mandatory with certain prepositions: wegen, während, trotz, statt, innerhalb, außerhalb. In modern spoken German, even genitive prepositions increasingly take dative. The expression 'von + dative' is standard (not colloquial) for phrases like 'ein Freund von mir' (a friend of mine). Genitive is becoming less common in spoken German but remains essential for formal writing and B1+ exams.

Indefinite Pronouns with Declination

■ Web verified

Indefinite pronouns (Indefinitpronomen) refer to unspecified persons or things. Key pronouns are jemand (someone), niemand (no one), keiner (none), einer (one). These pronouns must be declined according to case (nominative, accusative, dative, genitive), though in informal speech declension endings are often dropped.

COMPLETE RULE

DECLENSION TABLE FOR jemand/niemand:

Nominative: jemand / niemand

Accusative: jemanden / niemanden (or jemand/niemand in informal speech)

Dative: jemandem / niemandem (or jemand/niemand in informal speech)

Genitive: jemandes / niemandes (rare, usually replaced by von + Dative)

DECLENSION TABLE FOR einer/keiner:

Masculine Feminine Neuter Plural

Nom: einer eine eins welche (keine)

Acc: einen eine eins welche (keine)

Dat: einem einer einem welchen (keinen)

Gen: eines einer eines welcher (keiner)

USAGE RULES:

1. *jemand/niemand*: Used only for PERSONS, always singular, gender-neutral
2. *einer/keiner*: Replaces previously mentioned nouns, declined like *ein*-words
3. *keiner*: Negation of *einer* (like Italian 'nessuno')
4. In plural, *einer* becomes *welche* (some, any)
5. For uncountable things in singular, use *welche*: "Hast du Salz?" - "Ja, ich habe welches."
6. With 'von' + group: "*einer von ihnen*" (one of them), "*keiner von allen*" (none of all)
7. Declension endings -en and -em are standard but often dropped in colloquial speech

OTHER INDEFINITE PRONOUNS:

- *man* (one, people in general): only nominative, becomes *einen* (accusative), *einem* (dative)
- *etwas* (something), *nichts* (nothing): never declined, always same form
- *jeder/jede/jedes* (each, every): declined like *der/die/das*
- *alle* (all): declined, plural only for persons, can be singular (*alles*) for things

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich spreche mit niemandem über meine Probleme.* (dative case after *mit*)

I speak with no one about my problems)

→ *Niemand hat mich heute angerufen.* (nominative as subject - Nobody called me today)

→ *Hast du einen Stift? - Ja, ich habe einen. / Nein, ich habe keinen.* (*einer/keiner* replacing 'Stift' in masculine accusative)

→ *Zwei von ihnen sind sehr groß, aber keiner von allen hat eine Brille.* (*von* + dative construction with numbers - two of them are very tall, but none of all has glasses)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers often forget to decline *jemand/niemand* in dative and accusative (saying 'Ich spreche mit jemand' instead of 'Ich spreche mit jemandem'). They may confuse *einer/keiner* declension with adjective endings. Italian speakers might use *jemand* for things instead of *etwas* (influenced by Italian 'qualcuno/qualcosa' distinction). They may forget that *niemand* takes singular verb forms even though Italian 'nessuno' can take plural in some contexts. Using accusative instead of dative with *von* constructions.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

When *jemand/niemand* is followed by 'anders' (else) or by a nominalized adjective, the pronoun is usually NOT declined: '*jemand anders*' (not *jemandem anders*), '*niemand Neues*' (nobody new). Numbers (*zwei, drei, etc.*) never decline before *von*: '*zwei von ihnen*' (not '*zweien von ihnen*'). The genitive forms *jemandes/niemandes* are rarely used in spoken German; instead use *von* + Dative: '*das Buch von jemandem*' (instead of '*jemandes Buch*'). *Man* has irregular declension: *man* (nominative) → *einen* (accusative) → *einem* (dative), with no genitive form.

Negation - kein (nouns)

■ From lesson

Use 'kein' to negate nouns. It follows the same declension pattern as 'ein'

COMPLETE RULE

kein negates nouns and declines like ein/eine. Accusative masculine: keinen, neuter: kein, feminine: keine, plural: keine

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe keinen Hunger (m)*

→ *Ich habe kein Kind (n)*

→ *Ich habe keine Angst (f)*

→ *Ich habe keine Probleme (pl)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Using nicht instead of kein with nouns

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

With proper nouns or specific things, use nicht

Negation with 'kein' (nouns)

■ From lesson

'kein' is used to negate nouns and acts like the indefinite article 'ein', declining for gender and case

COMPLETE RULE

kein declines like ein: masculine nominative=kein, accusative=keinen; feminine=keine; neuter=kein; plural=keine

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe keine Angst (f)*

→ *Ich habe keinen Hunger (m)*

→ *Ich habe kein Kind (n)*

→ *Ich habe keinen Plattenspieler (m)*

→ *Ich benutze keine Digitalkamera (f)*

Superlative with nouns: der/die/das + [adjective]ste + noun

■ Web verified

When a superlative adjective precedes a noun (attributive use), it requires the definite article and takes the form 'der/die/das + adjective + -ste/-este' plus adjective declension endings. The superlative is formed by adding -st or -est (after -d, -t, -s, -ß, -sch, -x, -z) to the adjective base, then adding appropriate case endings.

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: adjective + -(e)st + adjective ending

WEAK DECLENSION (after definite article):

Masculine Nom: *der größte Fluss*

Masculine Acc: *den größten Fluss*

Masculine Dat: *dem größten Fluss*

Masculine Gen: *des größten Flusses*

Feminine Nom: *die längste Straße*

Feminine Acc: *die längste Straße*

Feminine Dat: *der längsten Straße*

Feminine Gen: *der längsten Straße*

Neuter Nom: *das höchste Gebäude*

Neuter Acc: *das höchste Gebäude*

Neuter Dat: *dem höchsten Gebäude*

Neuter Gen: *des höchsten Gebäudes*

Plural (all genders) Nom: *die besten Autos*

Plural Acc: *die besten Autos*

Plural Dat: *den besten Autos*

Plural Gen: *der besten Autos*

EXAMPLES

→ *Der Nil ist der längste Fluss Afrikas. (The Nile is the longest river in Africa.)*

→ *Das ist die schönste Stadt, die ich je gesehen habe. (That is the most beautiful city I have ever seen.)*

→ *Wir haben den teuersten Wein bestellt. (We ordered the most expensive wine.)*

→ *Der Mount Everest ist der höchste Berg der Welt. (Mount Everest is the highest mountain in the world.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may:

1. Omit the article before superlative adjectives (Italian allows 'più grande fiume' without article in some contexts)

2. Forget to add adjective declension endings after -ste (influenced by Italian invariable superlatives)

■ 3. Use 'più' (more) + adjective instead of the -ste form

4. Confuse when to use attributive vs. predicative superlative forms

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Irregular superlatives: gut→beste (not *gutste), viel→meiste (not *vielste), hoch→höchste (not *hochste), nah→nächste. After -d, -t, -s, -ß, -x, -z: add -este instead of -ste (interessant→interessanteste). Some adjectives lose -e- before -ste when ending in -el/-er (dunkel→dunkelste becomes dunkleste).

Wie geht's? / Wie geht es dir? - How are you? Greetings and Responses

■ Web verified

'Wie geht's?' is the contracted form of 'Wie geht es?' or 'Wie geht es dir/Ihnen?' meaning 'How are you?' or literally 'How goes it?'. It uses the dative case for pronouns. Unlike English where 'How are you?' is often just a greeting, in German this question typically expects a genuine answer. Germans value honesty in responses. 'Dir' is informal (for friends/family), 'Ihnen' is formal (for strangers/professional contexts).

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE FORMS AND USAGE:

QUESTION FORMS:

1. *Wie geht's?* (How's it going?) - Casual, universal
2. *Wie geht es dir?* (How are you? - informal singular)
3. *Wie geht es euch?* (How are you? - informal plural)
4. *Wie geht es Ihnen?* (How are you? - formal, singular or plural)
5. *Wie geht es [name]?* (How is [person]?)

ALTERNATIVE CASUAL FORMS:

- *Wie läuft's?* (How's it running?)
- *Was geht ab?* (What's up? - youth slang)
- *Alles klar?* (Everything okay?)
- *Na?* (Informal, no direct translation)

STANDARD RESPONSE PATTERNS:

POSITIVE RESPONSES:

- *Gut! / Gut, danke!* (Good! / Good, thanks!)

- *Sehr gut!* (Very good!)
- *Prima! / Wunderbar!* (Great! / Wonderful!)
- *Es geht mir gut.* (I'm doing well.)
- *Mir geht es sehr gut.* (I'm doing very well.)

NEUTRAL RESPONSES:

- *Es geht.* (It's going / So-so)
- *Nicht schlecht.* (Not bad.)
- *Ganz gut.* (Pretty good.)
- *Kann nicht klagen.* (Can't complain.)
- *Geht so.* (It's going so-so.)

NEGATIVE RESPONSES:

- *Nicht so gut.* (Not so good.)
- *Schlecht.* (Bad.)
- *Nicht gut.* (Not good.)
- *Es könnte besser sein.* (It could be better.)

RETURNING THE QUESTION:

- *Und dir?* (And you? - informal)
- *Und Ihnen?* (And you? - formal)
- *Und selbst?* (And yourself?)

COMPLETE EXCHANGE EXAMPLE:

A: *Hallo! Wie geht's?*

B: *Gut, danke! Und dir?*

A: *Auch gut, danke!*

FORMAL CONTEXT:

A: *Guten Tag, Frau Müller. Wie geht es Ihnen?*

B: *Danke, es geht mir sehr gut. Und Ihnen?*

A: *Mir geht es auch gut, vielen Dank.*

GRAMMAR NOTE: The construction uses DATIVE case:

- *mir* (to me)
- *dir* (to you - informal)
- *ihm/ihr* (to him/her)
- *uns* (to us)
- *euch* (to you all)
- *ihnen/Ihnen* (to them/you formal)

EXAMPLES

→ **Wie geht's?**

Sehr gut, danke! Ich habe gerade einen neuen Job bekommen. (How are you? - Very good, thanks! I just got a new job.) - Positive life update context

→ *Guten Morgen, Herr Schmidt. Wie geht es Ihnen heute? - Danke, es geht mir gut. Und Ihnen?*
(Good morning, Mr. Schmidt. How are you today? - Thanks, I'm doing well. And you?) - Formal professional greeting

→ **Na, wie geht's dir?**

Ach, nicht so gut. Ich bin erkältet. (So, how are you? - Oh, not so good. I have a cold.) - Honest negative response showing German directness

→ *Wie geht es deiner Mutter? - Danke der Nachfrage, es geht ihr viel besser!* (How is your mother? - Thanks for asking, she's doing much better!) - Asking about third person

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN SPEAKER MISTAKES:

1. MIXING FORMAL AND INFORMAL:

■ Wie geht es du?

■ ■ Wie geht es dir? (informal) OR Wie geht es Ihnen? (formal)
(Italian has 'tu/Lei' but Germans are stricter about du/Sie distinction)

■ 2. USING NOMINATIVE INSTEAD OF DATIVE:

■ Wie geht es ich?

■ Gut, danke, und du?

■ ■ Wie geht es mir? (when asking about self)

■ ■ Gut, danke, und dir? (using dative 'dir')

(Italian: 'Come stai?' uses nominative 'tu', so learners forget German needs dative)

3. LITERAL TRANSLATION FROM ITALIAN:

■ Wie stehst du? (literal from 'Come stai?')

■ ■ Wie geht es dir? OR Wie geht's?

(Can't translate word-for-word from Italian 'stare')

4. ALWAYS SAYING 'GUT' WITHOUT THINKING:

Italian: 'Come stai?' 'Bene!' (automatic)

German: Expects more honesty

Better: Vary responses - 'Es geht', 'Ganz gut', etc.

5. WRONG WORD ORDER:

■ Wie dir geht es?

■ ■ Wie geht es dir?

(Italian word order doesn't transfer)

6. FORGETTING THE ARTICLE 'ES':

■ Wie geht dir?

■ ■ Wie geht es dir?

(The 'es' is required, unlike Italian which drops subjects)

7. USING AS GREETING ONLY:

Italian: 'Come stai?' often rhetorical

German: Usually expects real answer

Don't ask if you don't have time for the response!

8. PRONUNCIATION:

■ Vee gehts? (separating words)

■ ■ Vee-GAYTS? (contracted naturally)

(The 's' is contracted from 'es', should flow together)

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

SPECIAL CASES AND REGIONAL VARIATIONS:

1. AUSTRIAN VARIATIONS:

- Wie hat's di? (Austrian dialect)
- Passt schon. (It's alright - common Austrian response)

2. SWISS GERMAN VARIATIONS:

- Wie gaht's? / Wie gohts?
 - Wiä häsches?
- (Very different from Standard German)

3. REGIONAL GERMAN GREETINGS (not direct translations):

Northern Germany: 'Moin!' (used instead of asking how are you)

Southern Germany/Bavaria: 'Grüß Gott!', 'Servus!'

4. YOUTH SLANG ALTERNATIVES:

- Was geht ab? (What's up?)
- Wie läuft's? (How's it running?)
- Alles fit? (Everything fit?)
- Alles roger? (Everything roger?)

5. WHEN 'WIE GEHT'S' IS JUST A GREETING:

In very casual contexts among close friends, 'Wie geht's?' might be used like English 'What's up?' without expecting detailed answer:

A: Wie geht's?

B: Jo! (casual 'yeah' acknowledgment)

6. BUSINESS/EMAIL CONTEXT:

Written: 'Ich hoffe, es geht Ihnen gut.' (I hope you are well.)

Not: 'Wie geht es Ihnen?' (too direct for opening email)

7. RESPONDING WITHOUT ANSWERING:

If you don't want to give details:

- Danke der Nachfrage. (Thanks for asking.)
- Muss ja. (It must, right? / I have to be okay.)

8. CULTURAL NOTE:

Germans distinguish between 'small talk' and genuine interest. In professional settings, 'Wie geht es Ihnen?' expects brief positive response. Among friends/family, expect and give honest, sometimes lengthy answers.

Indefinitpronomen

■ From lesson

Indefinite pronouns - words like 'nothing', 'something', 'one/people', 'all'

COMPLETE RULE

nichts = nothing | keine Sachen = no things | etwas = something | eine unbestimmte Sache, ein bisschen = an undefined thing, a bit | man = one, people | die Leute, eine bestimmte Gruppe = the people, a certain group | alle = all, everyone | jeder, die Gesamtheit = each one, everybody

EXAMPLES

- *Ich bringe nichts zur Party mit (z. B. kein Geschenk, ...).*
- *Ich bringe etwas zur Party mit. (Ich weiß noch nicht was.)*
- *Man bringt zu einer Party ein Geschenk mit (das ist eine Regel).*
- *Alle (hier: Gäste) haben einen Salat mitgebracht.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing 'man' (indefinite pronoun) with 'Mann' (man/husband)

Relativsätze mit 'was'

■ From lesson

Relative clauses with 'was' are used in two contexts: 1) referring to a preceding clause, 2) referring to pronouns like 'alles'.

COMPLETE RULE

'was' refers to: 1) a preceding clause - Example: *Wir duzen unsere Professoren, was komplett anders ist.*
2) pronouns - Example: *Ich mag alles, was mit Sport zu tun hat.*

EXAMPLES

- *Wir duzen unsere Professoren, was komplett anders ist.*
- *Ich mag alles, was mit Sport zu tun hat.*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using 'das' instead of 'was' when referring to a whole clause or to pronouns like 'alles'

'Das' vs 'Es' in conversational German

■ Web verified

'Es' is the neutral personal pronoun (it) and is used in impersonal constructions and as a placeholder subject. 'Das' is a demonstrative pronoun meaning 'that/this' and is used to refer to specific things, situations, or ideas already mentioned or understood in context. In spoken German, 'das' is preferred when pointing to something concrete or emphasizing, while 'es' is more neutral. 'Das' adds demonstrative force, making statements more emphatic and concrete in conversation.

COMPLETE RULE

ES uses: 1) Impersonal subject (no meaning): 'Es regnet' (It's raining), 'Es gibt' (there is/are - fixed expression). 2) Placeholder subject: 'Es ist wichtig, dass...' (It is important that...). 3) Referring to previously mentioned neuter noun: 'Wo ist das Buch? Es ist hier.' (Where is the book? It is here). 4) Formal/written German preference. DAS uses: 1) Demonstrative - pointing to specific things: 'Das ist wichtig' (That/This is important). 2) Referring to entire situations/ideas: 'Das ändert nichts' (That changes nothing). 3) In conversation for emphasis. 4) Before 'sein' when defining/identifying: 'Das ist mein Freund' (That/This is my friend). 5) As relative pronoun: 'das Buch, das...' (the book that...). CONTRACTION: 'Es' can contract to 's': 'Wie geht's?' (How goes it?). 'Das' does not contract.

EXAMPLES

- *Das ist wichtig. (That/This is important - demonstrative, emphatic)*
- *Es ist wichtig, gesund zu essen. (It is important to eat healthy - impersonal construction)*
- *Das ändert nichts. (That changes nothing - referring to situation)*
- *Es regnet heute. (It's raining today - impersonal, weather)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may overuse 'es' because Italian 'è' works similarly, missing the demonstrative nuance of 'das': saying **'Es ist wichtig'* when the context calls for emphasis with *'Das ist wichtig'*. Confusing 'das' (demonstrative/relative pronoun) with 'dass' (conjunction meaning 'that'): **'Ich denke, das er kommt'* (incorrect - should be 'dass'). Using 'das' in fixed expressions that require 'es': **'Das gibt'* (incorrect - must be 'Es gibt'). In writing, incorrectly using 'das' where formal 'es' is required.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Fixed expressions with 'es' cannot use 'das': 'es gibt' (there is/are), 'es geht um' (it's about), 'es tut mir leid' (I'm sorry), 'es kommt darauf an' (it depends). When 'es' is placeholder subject and real subject follows, 'es' disappears if sentence order changes: 'Es kommen viele Leute' → 'Viele Leute kommen' (NOT **'Viele Leute es kommen'*). In questions, 'es' often appears: 'Wie geht es dir?' In exclamations,

'das' is strongly preferred: 'Das ist ja toll!' (That's great!).

Indefinite Pronoun 'einer'

■ From lesson

The indefinite pronoun 'einer/eine/eins' replaces 'a/one' previously mentioned, and declines

COMPLETE RULE

Used to avoid repetition: instead of 'ein Garten', say 'einer'. Declines like *dieser*: Nominative: *einer/eine/eins*, Accusative: *einen/eine/eins*, Dative: *einem/einer/einem*

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe 2 Gärten, einer ist vor dem Haus (one is in front)*

→ *Wo ist ein Bancomat? - Da ist einer! (There is one!)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Not declining it properly

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

None

Indefinite pronoun 'einer/eine/eins'

■ From lesson

When referring back to a previously mentioned noun without repeating it, use 'einer' (m), 'eine' (f), 'eins' (n) meaning 'one'

COMPLETE RULE

Nominative: *einer (m), eine (f), eins (n)*. Accusative: *einen (m), eine (f), eins (n)*. Declines like *ein-words*

EXAMPLES

→ *Ich habe 2 Gärten, einer ist vor dem Haus, einer hinter dem Haus*

→ *Wo ist ein Bancomat? - Da ist einer!*

→ *Ich hatte eine Spülmaschine, aber jetzt brauche ich eine neue*

Indefinite pronouns: alle vs. jeder

■ Web verified

alle means 'all' (plural: alle Menschen = all people, alle Straßen = all streets). jeder means 'every/each' (singular: jede Person = every person). alle takes plural nouns, jeder takes singular nouns. Both decline like der/die/das.

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE DECLENSION TABLES:

JEDER (every/each) - SINGULAR ONLY:

Declines like definite article DER:

Masculine Feminine Neuter

Nom: jeder jede jedes

Acc: jeden jede jedes

Dat: jedem jeder jedem

Gen: jedes/jeden* jeder jedes/jeden*

*Genitive: -es is standard; -en used when following noun has -s/-es ending

ALLE (all) - PLURAL ONLY:

Plural (all genders)

Nom: alle

Acc: alle

Dat: allen

Gen: aller

Singular forms of ALLE (for uncountable nouns):

Masculine Feminine Neuter

Nom: aller alle alles

Acc: allen alle alles

Dat: allem aller allem

Gen: allen/alles* aller allen/alles*

*Genitive variation same as jeder

KEY DIFFERENCES:

- JEDER: Refers to EACH individual of a group (singular focus, plural meaning)
- ALLE: Refers to ALL members collectively (plural)
- JEDER: Singular verb conjugation (jeder hat)
- ALLE: Plural verb conjugation (alle haben)

USAGE:

- Jeder Mensch hat ein Gehirn (focuses on individuals)
- Alle Menschen haben ein Gehirn (focuses on collective)

EXAMPLES

- Alle Straßen sind leer. (All streets are empty.)
- Jede Person hat ein Gehirn. (Every person has a brain.)
- Alle Menschen haben ein Gehirn. (All people have a brain.)
- Jedes Kind bekommt ein Geschenk. (Every child gets a present.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

COMMON MISTAKES FOR ITALIAN SPEAKERS:

- 1. SINGULAR/PLURAL CONFUSION: Italian 'ogni' (every) and 'tutti' (all) work similarly, but Italian speakers may forget German jeder requires SINGULAR: WRONG: 'jeder Personen'. CORRECT: 'jede Person'.
- 2. VERB AGREEMENT: Italian 'tutti' takes plural verb. German JEDER takes singular despite meaning 'everyone': WRONG: 'jeder haben'. CORRECT: 'jeder hat'.
- 3. USING ALLE with SINGULAR: Italian speakers may use 'alle' with singular nouns by analogy with 'tutto'. WRONG: 'alle Person'. CORRECT: 'jede Person' OR 'alle Personen'.
- 4. GENDER AGREEMENT: Forgetting to decline JEDER by gender: WRONG: 'jeder Frau' (masculine form with feminine noun). CORRECT: 'jede Frau'.
- 5. GENITIVE ERRORS: Using -es ending with nouns already having -s: AWKWARD: 'jedes Mannes' (Mann already adds -es). BETTER: 'jeden Mannes' OR avoid genitive.
- 6. ALLES vs. ALLE: Italian 'tutto' covers both. ALLES = everything (singular, neuter), ALLE = all people/things (plural): 'Alles ist gut' (everything), 'Alle sind hier' (everyone).
- 7. ARTICLE OMISSION: Italian 'ogni persona' has no article. German can use article after JEDER (though rare): 'jede einzelne Person'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

- 1. ALLE with DEFINITE ARTICLE: When ALL precedes definite article, it remains uninflected:
 - 'all die guten Leute' (all the good people)
 - 'all meine Freunde' (all my friends)
 - 'all diese Menschen' (all these people)
- 2. ALLES (neuter singular): Used for 'everything', takes singular verb:
 - 'Alles ist vorbereitet' (Everything is prepared)
 - 'Alles Gute!' (All the best!)
- 3. JEDER in FIXED EXPRESSIONS:
 - 'jeder für sich' (every man for himself)
 - 'ohne jeden Zweifel' (without any doubt - accusative)

4. ALLE can mean 'finished/gone':

- 'Das Bier ist alle' (The beer is all gone)
- 'Mein Geld ist alle' (My money is used up)

5. JEDER can be used as pronoun (without noun):

- 'Jeder kann kommen' (Everyone can come)
- 'Das weiß jeder' (Everyone knows that)

6. BEIDE (both): Similar declension to alle, but refers to exactly two:

- 'beide Kinder' (both children)
- Declines: beide, beiden, beider

7. REGIONAL VARIATION: Southern German may use 'ein jeder' (each and every): 'ein jeder Mann'.

Possessive Articles - mein/dein

■ From lesson

Possessive articles decline like ein/kein and agree with the possessed noun

COMPLETE RULE

Possessive articles: *mein* (my), *dein* (your), *sein* (his/its), *ihr* (her/their), *unser* (our), *euer* (your pl). They take same endings as ein/kein

EXAMPLES

- *mein Bruder* (m), *meinen Bruder* (acc)
- *meine Schwester* (f)
- *mein Kind* (n)
- *Ihr Name ist Angela* (her name)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing *sein* (his) and *ihr* (her), or not declining properly

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

euer drops the -e- when adding endings: *eure* (not *euere*)

Relative pronoun was after indefinite pronouns

■ Web verified

After neuter indefinite pronouns like alles, etwas, nichts, and after substantivized adjectives (das Beste, das Schönste), or when referring to an entire clause, use the relative pronoun was (not das).

COMPLETE RULE

COMPLETE RULE FOR RELATIVE PRONOUN WAS:

WAS is used instead of regular relative pronouns (der/die/das) in these cases:

1. AFTER INDEFINITE PRONOUNS (neuter):

- alles (everything): Alles, was du sagst, ist wahr
- nichts (nothing): Nichts, was ich höre, ist neu
- etwas (something): Etwas, was mir wichtig ist
- vieles (much): Vieles, was geschehen ist
- einiges (some things): Einiges, was ich weiß
- manches (some things): Manches, was passiert
- wenig (few things): Weniges, was funktioniert

2. AFTER DEMONSTRATIVE PRONOUN DAS:

- das (that): Das, was du sagst
- dasselbe (the same): Dasselbe, was gestern passierte
- dasjenige (that which): Dasjenige, was wir brauchen

3. AFTER NEUTER SUBSTANTIVIZED ADJECTIVES (superlatives/adjectives used as nouns):

- das Beste (the best): Das Beste, was ich je gesehen habe
- das Schönste (the most beautiful): Das Schönste, was es gibt
- das Wichtigste (the most important): Das Wichtigste, was zählt
- das Erste/Letzte (the first/last): Das Erste, was ich mache

4. REFERRING TO ENTIRE PREVIOUS CLAUSE:

- Er kam zu spät, was mich ärgerte (He came late, which annoyed me)
- The 'was' refers to the whole situation, not a specific noun

WHY WAS (not der/die/das):

- These antecedents have NO CLEAR GENDER
- They are INDEFINITE (not specific nouns)
- Cannot determine gender for declension

IMPORTANT: WAS is INDECLINABLE - same form in all cases when used as relative pronoun

WITH PREPOSITIONS: Use WO-COMPOUND (not was + preposition):

- Alles, woran ich denke (Everything I'm thinking of) - NOT: was an
- Das, wofür ich kämpfe (That for which I fight) - NOT: was für
- Etwas, womit ich zufrieden bin - NOT: was mit

EXAMPLES

- *Alles, was ich brauche.* (Everything that I need.)
- *Etwas, was mir wichtig ist.* (Something that is important to me.)
- *Das Beste, was ich je gesehen habe.* (The best thing that I have ever seen.)
- *Nichts, was du sagst, ist wahr.* (Nothing that you say is true.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

COMMON MISTAKES FOR ITALIAN SPEAKERS:

- 1. USING 'CHE' EQUIVALENT: Italian uses 'che' for all relative pronouns. German requires WAS after indefinites: WRONG: 'Alles, das ich brauche'. CORRECT: 'Alles, was ich brauche'.
- 2. USING DAS WITH INDEFINITES: Italian speakers may use 'das' by analogy: WRONG: 'Nichts, das ich höre'. CORRECT: 'Nichts, was ich höre'.
- 3. GENDER CONFUSION: Trying to decline WAS like regular relative pronouns: WRONG: 'Etwas, wem ich glaube'. CORRECT: Use wo-compound: 'Etwas, woran ich glaube'.
- 4. FORGETTING WO-COMPOUNDS WITH PREPOSITIONS: Using was + preposition directly: WRONG: 'Alles, was auf ich warte'. CORRECT: 'Alles, worauf ich warte'.
- 5. MISSING WAS WITH SUPERLATIVES: Using das after substantivized adjectives: WRONG: 'Das Beste, das es gibt'. CORRECT: 'Das Beste, was es gibt'.
- 6. CLAUSE REFERENCE: Not recognizing when 'was' refers to entire clause: WRONG: 'Er kommt nicht, das mich stört'. CORRECT: 'Er kommt nicht, was mich stört'.
- 7. OMITTING RELATIVE PRONOUN: Italian sometimes omits relative pronoun. German NEVER: WRONG: 'Alles ich brauche'. CORRECT: 'Alles, was ich brauche'.
- 8. SPECIFIC NOUN MISTAKE: Using WAS with specific nouns instead of der/die/das: WRONG: 'Das Buch, was ich lese'. CORRECT: 'Das Buch, das ich lese' (Buch is specific, not indefinite).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

EXCEPTIONS AND SPECIAL CASES:

- 1. **WAS vs. WO WITH PLACES:** When 'was' would refer to a place, use WO instead:
 - Das Dorf, wo ich wohne (The village where I live)
 - NOT: Das Dorf, was ich wohne
- 2. **WELCH- AS ALTERNATIVE:** In formal/literary German, WELCH- can replace was (archaic):
 - Alles, welches ich brauche (very formal/old-fashioned)
 - Standard modern German uses WAS
- 3. **WAS IN GENITIVE CONSTRUCTIONS:** WAS cannot be used in genitive; rephrase:
 - CANNOT SAY: *Alles, was[es] Meinung wichtig ist
 - REPHRASE: Alles, dessen Meinung wichtig ist (use dessen)
 - OR AVOID: Alles, wovon die Meinung wichtig ist
- 4. **DAS + COMMA + WAS:** When DAS is demonstrative pronoun (not article), use WAS:
 - Das, was du sagst, ist richtig (That which you say is correct)

- DAS Buch, das ich lese (THE book - das is article, not pronoun)

5. WAS WITH ENTIRE CLAUSE: Always optional to add clarifying phrase:

- Er kam zu spät, was (ein Fehler war/mich ärgerte)

6. NO PREPOSITION POSSIBLE: Unlike der/die/das, WAS cannot take prepositions directly:

- NEVER: mit was, für was, an was
- ALWAYS use WO-COMPOUND: womit, wofür, woran

7. WER vs. WAS: WER for people (whoever), WAS for things:

- Wer das sagt, irrt sich (Whoever says that is wrong)
- Was er sagt, stimmt (What he says is correct)

Vergleiche: Komparativ und Superlativ – prädikativ

■ From lesson

Comparative and superlative forms of adjectives used predicatively in German

COMPLETE RULE

Komparativ: add -er to adjective (attraktiv→attraktiver, schön→schöner, bekannt→bekannter, beliebt→beliebter, groß→größer, alt→älter, teuer→teurer, hoch→höher, gern→lieber, viel→mehr, gut→besser). Superlativ: use 'am' + adjective + -sten (am attraktivsten, am schönsten, am bekanntesten, am beliebtesten, am größten, am ältesten, am teuersten, am höchsten, am liebsten, am meisten, am besten)

EXAMPLES

- Die Wohnung ist schöner.
- Diese Wohnung ist am schönsten.
- Die Miete ist höher.
- Diese Wohnung ist am teuersten.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Irregular forms: gut→besser→am besten, viel→mehr→am meisten, gern→lieber→am liebsten, hoch→höher→am höchsten

Adjektive vor Nomen ohne Artikel (=Nullartikel)

■ From lesson

Adjective endings before nouns without articles (zero article). The adjective takes the ending of the definite article.

COMPLETE RULE

Nominativ: M=der→lebendiger Dialekt, N=das→neues Leben, F=die→lange Tradition, Plural=die→alte Lieder. Akkusativ: M=den→lebendigen Dialekt, N=das→neues Leben, F=die→lange Tradition, Plural=die→alte Lieder. Dativ: M=dem→lebendigem Dialekt, N=dem→neuem Leben, F=der→langer Tradition, Plural=den→alten Liedern.

EXAMPLES

- *lebendiger Dialekt* (Nom. M)
- *neues Leben* (Nom./Akk. N)
- *lange Tradition* (Nom./Akk. F)
- *alte Lieder* (Nom./Akk. Plural)
- *lebendigen Dialekt* (Akk. M)
- *lebendigem Dialekt* (Dat. M)
- *neuem Leben* (Dat. N)
- *langer Tradition* (Dat. F)
- *alten Liedern* (Dat. Plural)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using weak endings (with definite article) instead of strong endings (without article)

Vergleiche: Komparativ und Superlativ - attributiv

■ From lesson

Comparative and superlative adjectives used attributively (before nouns) take the same endings as adjectives in their basic form. The superlative is not used with the indefinite article (ein).

COMPLETE RULE

Grundform: der hohe Berg, die kurze Grenze, das kleine Land | Komparativ: der höhere Berg, die kürzere Grenze, das kleinere Land | Superlativ: der höchste Berg, die kürzeste Grenze, das kleinste Land. Note: Adjectives in comparative and superlative have the same endings as in basic form. The superlative cannot be used with indefinite article (ein).

EXAMPLES

- *der hohe Berg* → *der höhere Berg* → *der höchste Berg*
- *die kurze Grenze* → *die kürzere Grenze* → *die kürzeste Grenze*
- *das kleine Land* → *das kleinere Land* → *das kleinste Land*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

- Using the indefinite article (ein) with the superlative form

Comparative structure: nicht so...wie

■ Web verified

Used to express inequality/inferiority in comparisons, meaning 'not as...as'. The positive (base) form of the adjective is used between 'so' and 'wie'.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: *nicht so + ADJECTIVE (positive degree) + wie + comparison object. For equality use: so + ADJECTIVE + wie. For quantity comparisons: nicht so + viel (uncountable) / viele (countable) + NOUN + wie. Standard German uses 'wie' for equality comparisons and 'als' for comparative degree (superiority). The positive degree adjective remains unchanged - no comparative ending is added.*

EXAMPLES

- *Du bist nicht so intelligent wie ich. (You're not as intelligent as me.)*
- *Es ist nicht so heiß wie im Sommer. (It's not as hot as in summer.)*
- *Ich habe nicht so viel Geld wie du. (I don't have as much money as you.)*
- *Das Auto ist nicht so schnell wie das andere. (The car is not as fast as the other one.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers may use the comparative form (e.g., 'heißer') instead of the base form with 'so...wie', influenced by Italian comparative structures. Another error is using 'als' instead of 'wie' in equality/inferiority comparisons, confusing it with superiority comparisons (schneller als).

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In non-standard/regional German, 'wie' is sometimes incorrectly used after comparatives (e.g., 'größer wie' instead of 'größer als'), but this is considered non-standard. The particle 'gleich' can replace 'so' in equality comparisons: **gleich + ADJECTIVE + wie**.

Expressing Equality (Gleichheit)

■ Web verified

To express that two things are equal, use 'so...wie' or 'genauso...wie' (just as...as). The adjective stays in positive form without any comparative ending: 'Der Hamster ist (genau)so klein wie die Maus' means they are equally small.

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: *Subject + verb + (genau)so + positive adjective + wie + comparison object. The adjective remains in its base positive form - no -er ending is added. 'So...wie' = 'as...as'. 'Genauso...wie' = 'just as...as' (emphasizes exact equivalence). 'Ebenso...wie' = 'equally as...as' (more formal, common in Northern Germany). All three constructions are grammatically correct, but 'genauso' and 'so...wie' are most universal. In short phrases, native speakers often use 'genauso' for flow; in longer comparisons, 'so' is more common. The adjective takes no declension when used predicatively after the verb. When used attributively (before nouns), normal adjective declension applies: 'ein genauso großer Hund wie' (a dog just*

as big as).

EXAMPLES

- *Der Hamster ist so klein wie die Maus. (The hamster is as small as the mouse.)*
- *Der Hamster ist genauso klein wie die Maus. (The hamster is just as small as the mouse.)*
- *Tim ist genauso groß wie Carlo. (Tim is just as tall as Carlo.)*
- *Mein Kaffee ist so heiß wie deiner. (My coffee is as hot as yours.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers influenced by Italian 'tanto...quanto' may confuse the construction. **WRONG:** Using comparative form with 'wie': 'Sie ist größer wie er'. **CORRECT:** Use positive form with 'wie': 'Sie ist so groß wie er' OR use comparative with 'als': 'Sie ist größer als er'. Never combine 'als' and 'wie' together: **WRONG:** 'als wie'. Mixing up 'als' (for inequality/comparative) and 'wie' (for equality): **WRONG:** 'Er ist so groß als sie'. **CORRECT:** 'Er ist so groß wie sie' OR 'Er ist größer als sie'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In Northern Germany and formal contexts, 'ebenso...wie' is also used but means the same as 'genauso...wie'. Native speakers often drop 'so' or 'genauso' in informal speech: 'Er ist groß wie ich' (though 'so...wie' is grammatically preferred). When comparing quantities with nouns: 'so viel...wie' (as much as) or 'so viele...wie' (as many as): 'Ich habe so viele Bücher wie du'.

Expressing Inequality (Ungleichheit)

■ Web verified

To express inequality without using comparative directly, use 'nicht so...wie' (not as...as). This replaces the Italian 'meno...di' construction which doesn't exist in standard German. Example: 'Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe' (The mouse is not as big as the giraffe).

COMPLETE RULE

Structure: Subject + verb + *nicht so* + positive adjective + *wie* + comparison object. This is the standard German equivalent of 'less...than' in English or 'meno...di' in Italian. The construction uses the positive form of the adjective (not comparative) with 'nicht so...wie'. Alternative: Use the opposite comparative with 'als': Instead of 'Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe', you can say 'Die Giraffe ist größer als die Maus' or 'Die Maus ist kleiner als die Giraffe'. While 'weniger' (less) exists in German, it is NOT used with adjectives for inferiority comparisons in standard German. 'Weniger' is used only with nouns (quantities): 'weniger Geld' (less money), 'weniger Leute' (fewer people).

EXAMPLES

- *Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe. (The mouse is not as big as the giraffe.)*
- *Die Giraffe ist nicht so klein wie die Maus. (The giraffe is not as small as the mouse.)*

→ *Das Auto ist nicht so schnell wie der Zug. (The car is not as fast as the train.)*

→ *Dieser Film ist nicht so spannend wie das Buch. (This film is not as exciting as the book.)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers directly translating 'meno...di' make this error frequently. **WRONG:** 'Die Maus ist weniger groß als die Giraffe' (literally translating Italian 'meno grande di'). **CORRECT:** 'Die Maus ist nicht so groß wie die Giraffe' OR 'Die Giraffe ist größer als die Maus'. Using 'weniger' + adjective is the most common mistake for Italian learners. While you might hear it occasionally in colloquial speech, it is not standard German and should be avoided in formal contexts. Never use 'als' with 'nicht so': **WRONG:** 'nicht so groß als'. **CORRECT:** 'nicht so groß wie'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

'Weniger' is correctly used only with non-countable nouns or quantities, never with adjectives: 'weniger Zeit' (less time), 'weniger Probleme' (fewer problems), but **NOT** 'weniger groß'. In very colloquial or dialectal German, you might hear 'weniger' + adjective, but this should be avoided by learners as it's non-standard.

Natural time expressions with 'brauchen'

■ Web verified

In German, it's more natural to express travel duration using 'brauchen' (to need/take time) rather than speed adjectives like 'langsam' (slow). For example: 'Wie lange braucht der Zug?' (How long does the train take?) and 'Der Regionalzug braucht am längsten' (The regional train takes the longest) sound more natural and native than 'Der Regionalzug ist am langsamsten' (The regional train is the slowest).

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: Subject + brauchen (conjugated) + time expression (+ länger/am längsten). The verb 'brauchen' is conjugated in present tense: ich brauche, du brauchst, er/sie/es braucht, wir brauchen, ihr braucht, sie/Sie brauchen.

Brauchen with Time Expressions - Present Tense:

ich brauche (I need/take)

du brauchst (you need/take)

er/sie/es braucht (he/she/it needs/takes)

wir brauchen (we need/take)

ihr braucht (you all need/take)

sie/Sie brauchen (they/you formal need/take)

Comparative structures with brauchen:

Positive: braucht + time (Der Zug braucht 2 Stunden)

Comparative: braucht + länger (als) (Der ICE braucht länger als der IC)

Superlative: *braucht + am längsten* (Der Regionalzug braucht am längsten)

Note: 'länger' is the comparative of 'lang' (long), not 'langsam' (slow). Use 'brauchen' for duration, reserve 'schnell/langsam' for describing speed itself.

EXAMPLES

- *Wie lange braucht der Zug?* (How long does the train take?)
- *Der Regionalzug braucht am längsten.* (The regional train takes the longest.)
- *Welcher Zug braucht am längsten?* (Which train takes the longest?)
- *Der Fernbus braucht nur 40 Minuten länger als der IC.* (The long-distance bus takes only 40 minutes longer than the IC.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers overuse 'langsam' (slow) for duration because Italian uses 'lento' (slow) or 'ci mette più tempo' (takes more time) interchangeably. They might say 'Der Zug ist am langsamsten' when 'Der Zug braucht am längsten' is more natural. Italian has 'ci vuole/servire' for time requirements, but learners don't transfer this to German 'brauchen'. Romance language pattern: Italian speakers may say 'Der Zug nimmt 2 Stunden' (using 'nehmen'='take') instead of 'Der Zug braucht 2 Stunden', following Italian 'prende 2 ore' structure. They may also forget that 'brauchen' is a regular verb and try irregular conjugations.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

For speed itself (not duration), 'schnell' and 'langsam' are still appropriate and natural: 'Der ICE ist am schnellsten' (The ICE is the fastest) refers to velocity, not duration. 'Brauchen' can also mean 'to need' (not just time): 'Ich brauche Hilfe' (I need help). In negative sentences with time, use 'nicht brauchen' + zu + infinitive: 'Du brauchst nicht zu warten' (You don't need to wait). Regional variations exist: Austrian and Swiss German may use different time expressions.

Ordinal Numbers

■ From lesson

Ordinal numbers (first, second, third...) are formed by adding -te (1-19) or -ste (20+) and decline like adjectives

COMPLETE RULE

Formation: numbers 1-19 add -te (*erste, zweite, dritte... neunzehnte*), 20+ add -ste (*zwanzigste, dreißigste*). Irregular: *erste* (not *einte*), *dritte* (not *dreite*). They decline like adjectives

EXAMPLES

- *der erste Mai* (the first of May)
- *am ersten April* (on the first of April)

→ *der zweite Stock (the second floor)*

→ *der einundzwanzigste Tag*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Not declining ordinals or using wrong endings

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

erste and dritte are irregular forms

Gegengrund nennen: Konzessive Haupt- und Nebensätze

■ From lesson

Concessive connectors refer to an ineffective counter-reason: there is a reason that speaks against doing something or that something happens, but it doesn't work - you do it anyway or it happens anyway

COMPLETE RULE

Concessive connectors express contrasts: *Nebensatz* with 'obwohl', *Hauptsätze* with 'trotzdem'/'dennoch', or 'zwar...aber', or *Präposition* 'trotz' + Genitiv

EXAMPLES

→ Lateinkenntnisse können im Studium sehr hilfreich sein. Deshalb war das 'Latinum' früher fast immer Pflicht.

→ Grund: Lateinkenntnisse sind hilfreich (Und das ist der Grund dafür, warum das 'Latinum' früher Pflicht war.)

→ Obwohl Lateinkenntnisse im Studium sehr hilfreich sein können, ist das 'Latinum' heute nur noch selten Pflicht.

→ Das 'Latinum' ist heute nur noch selten Pflicht, obwohl Lateinkenntnisse im Studium sehr hilfreich sein können.

→ Lateinkenntnisse können im Studium sehr hilfreich sein. Trotzdem ist das 'Latinum' heute nur noch selten Pflicht.

→ Lateinkenntnisse können im Studium sehr hilfreich sein. Dennoch ist das 'Latinum' heute nur noch selten Pflicht.

→ Zwar können Lateinkenntnisse im Studium sehr hilfreich sein, aber das 'Latinum' ist heute nur noch selten Pflicht.

→ Trotz der Nützlichkeit von Lateinkenntnissen ist das 'Latinum' heute nur noch selten Pflicht.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Learners may confuse word order in main clauses vs subordinate clauses with concessive connectors

Angabe: zum/zur/fürs + Nomen

■ From lesson

To express purpose or activity using nouns (mostly referring to activities), use 'zum' (= zu dem), 'zur' (= zu der), or 'fürs' (= für das) + noun.

COMPLETE RULE

zum (masc./neut.) / zur (fem.) / fürs + noun (usually activity noun)

EXAMPLES

→ Für die Mithilfe auf einem Hof erhalten die WWOOFer Verpflegung, Unterkunft und manchmal ein Taschengeld.

→ WWOOFen ist aber kein Ferienjob zum Geldverdienen.

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Confusing when to use zum vs. zur vs. fürs based on gender

dabei - having something with you

■ Web verified

'Dabei' means having something with you or on your person at the moment. It's used when asking if someone has something with them. The structure is 'etwas bei sich haben' or simply 'dabei haben'.

COMPLETE RULE

DABEI HABEN - COMPLETE USAGE:

MEANING: to have something with you/on you

STRUCTURE OPTIONS:

1. etwas dabei haben (most common)
2. etwas bei sich haben (more formal/literary)

CONJUGATION OF DABEI HABEN:

Present:

- ich habe dabei
- du hast dabei
- er/sie/es hat dabei
- wir haben dabei
- ihr habt dabei
- sie/Sie haben dabei

Perfect:

- ich habe dabeigehabt
- du hast dabeigehabt
- er/sie/es hat dabeigehabt

- wir haben dabeigehabt
- ihr habt dabeigehabt
- sie/Sie haben dabeigehabt

Past (Präteritum):

- ich hatte dabei
- du hattest dabei
- er/sie/es hatte dabei
- wir hatten dabei
- ihr hattet dabei
- sie/Sie hatten dabei

QUESTION FORMATION:

Hast du...dabei? (Do you have...with you?)

Haben Sie...dabei? (Do you have...with you? - formal)

NEGATIVE:

Ich habe kein Geld dabei. (I don't have any money with me.)

Er hat seinen Pass nicht dabei. (He doesn't have his passport with him.)

RELATED EXPRESSION - BEI SICH HABEN:

Ich habe meinen Ausweis bei mir. (I have my ID on me.)

Sie hat immer Taschentücher bei sich. (She always has tissues with her.)

OTHER DABEI MEANINGS:

- dabei sein = to be present, to be there, to be involved
- Ich bin dabei! = I'm in! Count me in!
- dabei (adverb) = while doing that, in the process

EXAMPLES

→ *Hast du deine Kreditkarte dabei? (Do you have your credit card with you?)*

→ *Ich habe leider kein Kleingeld dabei. (Unfortunately, I don't have any change with me.)*

→ *Sie hatte ihren Reisepass nicht dabei und konnte nicht einchecken. (She didn't have her passport with her and couldn't check in.)*

→ *Habt ihr eure Badesachen dabei? Wir gehen schwimmen! (Do you have your swimming things with you? We're going swimming!)*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

ITALIAN-SPEAKER ERRORS:

- 1. USING 'CON' LOGIC: *'Ich habe mit mir ein Buch' instead of 'Ich habe ein Buch dabei/bei mir'. Italian: 'Ho con me un libro' (I have with me a book) uses 'con' (with).

■ 2. WORD ORDER ERROR: *'Ich habe dabei kein Geld' instead of 'Ich habe kein Geld dabei'. Italian allows 'Ho con me nessun denaro' with different word order.

■ 3. FORGETTING DABEI: *'Hast du einen Stift?' instead of 'Hast du einen Stift dabei?' when asking about having something with you. Italian 'Hai una penna?' doesn't require locative specification.

■ 4. USING WRONG PREPOSITION: *'Ich habe mein Handy mit' instead of 'Ich habe mein Handy dabei'. Confusing 'mit' (accompaniment) with 'dabei' (on one's person).

5. OVERUSING BEI: *'Hast du bei dir einen Regenschirm?' - sounds overly formal. Natural German: 'Hast du einen Regenschirm dabei?'

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

1. DABEI SEIN (DIFFERENT MEANING):

- Ich bin dabei. = I'm in/I'm joining (participation)
- Er war gerade beim Kochen dabei. = He was in the middle of cooking
- Sind Sie beim Projekt dabei? = Are you part of the project?

2. REGIONAL VARIATIONS:

- Southern Germany/Austria prefer 'bei sich haben'
- Northern Germany prefers 'dabei haben'
- Swiss German may use 'mithaben'

3. OMISSION IN CONTEXT: When context is absolutely clear, 'dabei' can be dropped:

- 'Hast du einen Stift?' (in a meeting where it's obvious you mean 'with you')
- But safer to include it: 'Hast du einen Stift dabei?'

4. FIXED EXPRESSIONS:

- Was ist denn dabei? = What's the big deal?
- Ich war nicht dabei. = I wasn't there.
- nichts dabei haben = to have nothing with you/to see no problem

Definite article required with abstract nouns in comparisons

■ Web verified

When comparing abstract concepts, general categories, or making general statements about nationalities, cuisines, languages, etc., German requires the definite article (der/die/das), unlike English which often omits it. The article can be omitted in the second part of a comparison if the noun is understood from context.

COMPLETE RULE

USE DEFINITE ARTICLE WITH:

1. Abstract nouns in general statements:

- *Die Freiheit ist wichtig (Freedom is important)*

- Das Leben ist schön (Life is beautiful)
- Die Zeit vergeht schnell (Time passes quickly)

2. General categories/cuisines:

- Die italienische Küche ist am besten (Italian cuisine is the best)
- Die klassische Musik gefällt mir (I like classical music)

3. Nationalities in general:

- Die Deutschen lieben Bier (Germans love beer)
- Die Italiener sprechen schnell (Italians speak fast)

OMIT ARTICLE:

- With professions: Er ist Arzt (He is a doctor)
- With unmodified materials: Holz brennt (Wood burns)
- In certain fixed expressions

EXAMPLES

- Die italienische Küche ist besser als die französische Küche. (Italian cuisine is better than French cuisine.)
- Die klassische Musik ist am entspannendsten. (Classical music is the most relaxing.)
- Das Leben in Deutschland ist teuer. (Life in Germany is expensive.)
- Die Zeit ist das Wichtigste. (Time is the most important thing.)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Italian speakers may:

1. Omit the definite article in abstract comparisons (Italian often omits articles: 'cucina italiana è buona' vs 'la cucina italiana')
2. Overuse articles where German omits them (professions, materials)
3. Confuse when Italian and German article usage differs
4. Use indefinite article where definite is required for general statements

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

Article can be omitted when: 1) Talking about materials/substances in general (Holz brennt - wood burns), 2) Stating professions without adjectives (Er ist Arzt - He is a doctor), 3) With certain fixed expressions (von Beruf - by profession, mit der Post - by mail). However, if adjective is added, article returns: Er ist ein guter Arzt.

Origin expressions: 'aus' vs 'von'

■ Web verified

'Aus' indicates permanent origin or provenance from inside a place (where someone is from originally): 'Sie sind aus Belgien' (They are from Belgium - nationality/origin). 'Von' indicates movement from a location or temporary origin: 'Sie kommen von Belgien' (They are coming from Belgium - movement). For islands, use 'von' since you are ON not IN them. 'Aus' implies coming from inside; 'von' implies coming from a surface or point.

COMPLETE RULE

AUS + Dative: permanent origin, nationality, material composition. Used for: 1) Countries/cities (permanent origin): 'Ich komme aus Deutschland' (I'm from Germany - nationality). 2) Enclosed spaces you can be *INSIDE*: 'aus dem Haus gehen' (go out of the house). 3) Material: 'aus Holz' (made of wood). **VON + Dative:** 1) Movement from a location: 'Ich komme von der Arbeit' (I'm coming from work). 2) Origin from surfaces/islands: 'Ich komme von Mallorca' (I'm from Mallorca). 3) Possession/belonging: 'das Buch von Maria' (Maria's book). 4) Source/sender: 'ein Brief von dir' (a letter from you). **KOMMEN AUS** = permanent origin (nationality). **KOMMEN VON** = temporary location/movement.

EXAMPLES

- Ich komme aus Deutschland. (I'm from Germany - permanent origin/nationality)
- Ich komme von der Universität. (I'm coming from the university - movement from location)
- Sie sind aus Belgien. (They are from Belgium - nationality)
- **Ich bin gerade von Mallorca gekommen.** (I just came from Mallorca recent movement)

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

■ Italian speakers confuse 'aus' and 'von' because Italian uses 'da' for both concepts. Common errors: *'Ich komme von Deutschland' (incorrect - should be 'aus' for nationality). *'Ich bin aus der Arbeit' (incorrect - should be 'von' for movement). Using 'aus' with islands: *'Ich bin aus Teneriffa' (incorrect - should be 'von Teneriffa' since islands are surfaces). Mixing up permanent vs. temporary: using 'von' when stating nationality/hometown instead of 'aus'.

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

In colloquial spoken German, 'von' + country is increasingly accepted for origin, though 'aus' remains standard in formal contexts. Some regions and dialects show variation. When used with persons' homes, both can be acceptable: 'Ich komme von Maria' (I'm coming from Maria's place) vs. 'Ich bin bei Maria' (I'm at Maria's place). The genitive construction 'von' as possessive replacement is very common: 'von' + dative replaces genitive in speech.

Time Expressions - Days and Dates

■ From lesson

Days use 'am' (an+dem) + day. Dates use ordinal numbers with endings

COMPLETE RULE

Days: *am Montag, am Dienstag, etc.* Parts of day: *am Vormittag, am Nachmittag.* Dates: ordinal numbers (*erste, zweite, dritte, 4-19 add -te, 20+ add -ste*) + case endings

EXAMPLES

- *Am Montag habe ich Unterricht*
- *Heute ist der 9te April*
- *Ich habe am 11ten April Geburtstag*
- *Am Dienstagvormittag*

COMMON MISTAKES — Italian Speakers

Using wrong preposition or forgetting ordinal number endings

EXCEPTIONS & SPECIAL CASES

nachts (at night) has no 'am'

Time expressions - days of the week

■ From lesson

Days of the week are masculine (*der Montag, etc.*). Use 'am' + day for 'on [day]'. Add 's' to make it habitual

COMPLETE RULE

am + [day] = on [specific day]; [day]s = every [day] (habitual). Can combine with time of day: *am Dienstagvormittag*

EXAMPLES

- *Am Mittwoch arbeite ich*
On Wednesday I work
- *Dienstags habe ich Unterricht*
On Tuesdays I have class (habitual)
- *Am Sonntagmorgen - On Sunday morning*
- *Am Samstagnachmittag - On Saturday afternoon*

Wie geht's? / Wie geht es dir?

■ From lesson

EXAMPLES

→ *Wie geht's? - Gut!*

→ *Wie geht es dir? - Nicht so gut*

→ *Wie geht's? - Sehr gut, danke!*